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2 Samuel

2 Samuel - Introduction

Part 1: General Introduction

Outline of 2 Samuel

1. The early part of David's reign (1:1–10:19)
2. David becomes king of Judah (1:1–2:7)
3. David becomes king of all Israel (2:8–5:3)
4. David defeats the Jebusites and Philistines and brings the Box to Jerusalem (5:4–6:23)
5. Yahweh promises David a dynasty (7:1–7:29)
6. David helps Mephibosheth and defeats surrounding enemies (8:1–10:19)
7. The later part of David's reign (15:1–24:25)
8. David's sin with Bathsheba (11:1–12:31)
9. Amnon and Tamar; Absalom kills Amnon (13:1–14:33)
10. Absalom rebels and is killed (15:1–18:33)
11. David's kingdom restored (19:1–20:26)
12. Famine and warfare (21:1–14)
13. David's song of praise (22:1–23:7)
14. David's mighty men (23:8–39)
15. The census and the plague (24:1–25)

What is the book of 2 Samuel about?
This book is about David ruling as king over Israel. He first ruled over the tribe of Judah for seven and a half years. Then the other 11 tribes agreed to have him become their king. He ruled over all Israel for 33 years.

Throughout most of this time, David led his army to fight foreign enemies who attacked Israel. However, he struggled the most against someone in his own family. Absalom, his son, rebelled and fought against him.

The book of 2 Samuel also tells about when David sinned greatly. He made Bathsheba, the wife of Uriah the Hittite, have sexual relations with him. When she became pregnant, David arranged for Uriah to be killed in battle. David and all Israel suffered much because of David's sin. However, the writer also tells how Yahweh repeatedly showed David mercy after David repented of his sin.

What is the purpose of the book of 2 Samuel?
The book of 2 Samuel continues to tell the story of the Israelites once they had kings. It is part of a long history that also includes the preceding book of 1 Samuel and the following books of 1 Kings and 2 Kings. The entire history shows that Yahweh was not at fault for the Israelites being conquered and exiled from their land. Instead, this happened because the people disobeyed Yahweh and broke their covenant with him.

Who wrote the book of 2 Samuel?
The author or authors who wrote 2 Samuel do not identify themselves by name in the book. However, many interpreters believe that the prophets in Israel recorded the events in this book, as well as in the entire history of which it is a part, in order to demonstrate that the people had disobeyed Yahweh and to encourage them to obey Yahweh once more so that they could be restored to their land.

What title should translators use for this book?
Translators can use the traditional title 2 Samuel or Second Samuel. Translators may also consider a different title such as "The Book about King David's Reign."

Can I translate this book before 1 Samuel?
The book of 1 Samuel should be translated before 2 Samuel, since 2 Samuel continues from where 1 Samuel ends.

Part 2: Important Religious and Cultural Concepts

What covenant had its beginning in the book of 2 Samuel?
In 2 Samuel 7, Yahweh made a covenant with David. God promised to make a descendant of David rule forever over Israel. Christians believe that Jesus Christ fulfills this covenant. Jesus was a descendant of David. Jesus is the true "anointed one," the person God chose to be king forever. (See: covenant)

Part 3: Translation Issues in This Book

"And it happened"
The author often uses the phrase "And it happened" to introduce a new event in the story or a new development within an episode. To translate this phrase in its various occurrences, use a word, phrase, or other method in your language that is natural for introducing a new event or development. (See: Introduction of a New Event)

"behold"
The author and characters often use the word "behold" to focus their listeners' attention on what they are about to say. While the word literally means "look," the speakers do not want their listeners to look at

something, but to pay careful attention. For example, the author says "behold, a man came from the camp" in 1:2 in order to call the readers' attention to this new development in the story. Characters may use the equivalent expression "look," which similarly means "pay attention." For example, David says "Look" to Nathan in 7:2 to mean "Listen." (See: Metaphor)

"to this day"
In 2 Samuel 4:3, 6:8, and 7:6, and 18:18, the author uses the phrase "to this day." By that phrase, he is referring to the time at which he was writing. The translator should be aware that "to this day" refers to a time that is now in the past. He must avoid giving the impression that "to this day" means the present day of the translation's readers. The translator might decide to say "at the time when this is being written" or "at the time of this writing."

"in the eyes of"
The author and characters often speak of something being good or bad "in the eyes of" someone. This means that that person considered this to be a good or bad thing to do. For example, the author says in 3:18 that Abner went to speak to David about "all that {had been} good in the eyes of Israel and in the eyes of all of the house of Benjamin." He means that Abner went to tell David that all of the Israelite tribes, including Benjamin (Saul's tribe) considered it right to make David the next king. (See: Idiom)

"to the face of"
The expression "to the face of" can have different shades of meaning, depending on the context.

- The author and characters often use the word "face" to represent the presence of a person or group, by association with the way people can see the face of someone who is present. For example, David tells Abner in 3:13, "You will not see my face unless you bring Michal," meaning, "You will not come into my presence unless you bring Michal."
- The focus may also be on something being in front of or before a person or thing, either in space or in time. For example, David says in 3:35 that he will not eat "to the face of the going of the sun." He means that he will not eat before a certain time, sundown.
- Sometimes the idea of "in front of" has a further association. For example, the author says in 10:16 that when the Arameans gathered a large army, "Shobach, the commander of the army of Hadadezer, was to their faces." By saying that Shobach was in front of these troops, he means that Shobach was commanding them.
- The focus may also be on the relationship or interaction between people or groups, as in 2:17, where the author says that "Abner and the men of Israel were struck to the face of the servants of David." He means that they were defeated in front of David's soldiers, that is, they were defeated as they opposed David's soldiers. In other words, David's soldiers defeated them in battle. (See: Metonymy)

In other contexts, the author or a character may use the word "face," describing part of a person, in order to represent the whole person. For example, in 2 Samuel 15:14, David tells his officials that they must all flee "from the face of Absalom." He is using one part of Absalom, his "face," to mean all of him in his determination to kill David. (See: Synecdoche)

"into the hand of" or "into your hand"
The author and characters often use the word "hand" by association to represent power, capability, or control. For example, when Abner tells Ishbosheth in 3:8, "I have not delivered you into the hand of David," he means that he has not allowed David to overpower Ishbosheth and replace him as king.

The word "hand" may also represent possession or conveyance, as when the author says in 8:10 that a king sent an ambassador to David and "in his hand were vessels of silver and vessels of gold and vessels of bronze." The word "hand" may also represent agency, as when Abner remarks in 3:18 that Yahweh had said, "By the hand of David my servant, I will save my people Israel." Translation notes will help distinguish the difference between these shades of meaning when that may not be clear from the context. (See: Metonymy)

In other contexts, the author or a character may use the word "hand," describing part of a person, in order to represent the whole person. For example, in 2 Samuel 12:25, the author says that Yahweh "sent by the hand of Nathan the prophet." He is using one part of Nathan, his "hand," to mean all of him in the act of bringing a message from Yahweh, as if he were carrying that message in his hand. (See: Synecdoche)

"listen"
The author and characters often use the terms "listen" or "hear" to mean complying with what someone has said. For example, David's servants say in 12:18, "he did not listen to our voice," meaning that David was not willing to do what they were urging him to do. (See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information)

2 Samuel - Chapter 1 Introduction

name of a person representing him and associated or accompanying people
The author and characters often use the name of a person to represent that person and others who are associated with or accompanying that person. For example, in 1:1, when the author says that "David returned from striking the Amalekites," he is using David, one person who was involved in this action, to represent everyone who accompanied him. The text makes clear that David's men returned with him. So the author means that David and his men returned together to Ziklag. (See: Synecdoche)

name of nation, tribe, or city representing its people
The author and characters often use the name of a nation, tribe, or city by association to represent its people or its army. For example, in 2:28, when the author says that Joab's soldiers "did not still pursue after Israel," he is using the name of the nation of Israel to refer by association to soldiers from the tribes of Israel other than Judah. When a nation has the same name as its ancestor, this is the same thing as using the name of the ancestor by association to mean his descendants. (See: Metonymy)

"saying"
The author frequently uses the term "saying" to introduce a direct quotation. In your translation, use a natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language. It may not be necessary to represent this term explicitly. (See: Quotations and Quote Margins)

"sons of"
The author and characters often speak of "the sons of" a person to mean the nation or tribe that consists of his descendants. For example, in 7:6 Yahweh speaks of the "sons of Israel" to mean the Israelites. In 12:12, Samuel speaks of the "sons of Ammon" to mean the Ammonites. In this case, "sons" does not mean first-generation offspring but later descendants. (See: Metaphor)

"strike" and "struck"
In many places, the author says that soldiers "struck" an opposing army, city, or king as if they had only hit them. But in various contexts, he means that they either attacked, defeated, or killed those opponents. For example, when the author says in 8:1 that "David struck the Philistines, and he subdued them," he means that David attacked them in order to keep them from being a continual threat to Israel. When he says in 2:17 that "Abner and the men of Israel were struck to the face of the servants of David," he means that David's soldiers defeated Abner and the Israelite soldiers. And when he says in 2:31 that "the servants of David had struck from Benjamin and among the men of Abner 360 men," he means that they had killed those men. Consider carefully how to translate the term "struck" in each context where it does not actually mean "hit." (See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information)

travel descriptions marked for change in elevation ("went up," "went down")
In Hebrew, writers and speakers generally indicated whether people were going up to a higher elevation or going down to a lower elevation when they traveled. For example, in 2:1 David asks Yahweh, "Shall I go up into one of the cities of Judah?" David says "go up" because he is in Ziklag, near the seacoast, so he would be going up in elevation if he went to a city in the hilly territory of Judah. If your language does not mark travel for change in elevation, you can translate instances such as these simply as "went" or "go." (See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit)

2 Samuel - Chapter 1 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter continues the story from the last section of 1 Samuel about how David became king of Israel. It tells how he learned that Saul and Jonathan had died and how he composed a song to celebrate their lives and grieve their deaths.

Some translations set each line of poetry farther to the right than the rest of the text to make it easier to read. The ULT does this with the poetic song in 1:19–27.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Why is the young Amalekite's account of Saul's death different from the account in 1 Samuel 31?
In 1 Samuel 31:4, the author says that Saul died by falling on his own sword after Philistine archers wounded him badly. In this chapter, a young Amalekite man says that he killed Saul himself when Philistine chariots and horsemen, not archers, were threatening him. The reason for the difference in the accounts is that the young man is probably lying. He is not an Israelite but an Amalekite living in Israel, as he says in 1:13. He may have been working for a soldier or group of soldiers in the Israelite military camp on Mount Gilboa, or he may have been someone who followed the army at a distance, hoping to get plunder after a battle. Either way, he would not have gone into the battle with the Israelite army. He probably hid as Philistines pursued the fleeing Israelites onto Mount Gilboa, and once the battle had moved on from there, he went out to take whatever valuables he could find from the bodies of dead soldiers. (The Philistines did

not return to do that themselves until the next day, according to 1 Samuel 31:8.) He recognized Saul's body from his royal crown and armband, and he took those things for himself. He believed that David considered Saul to be his enemy and that David would reward him if he had killed Saul. (David suggests in 2 Samuel 4:10 that this was the young man's motive.) So rather than keeping the golden crown and armband for their value, he brought them to David as supposed proof that he had killed Saul. But his story is improbable. He certainly would not have been in the thick of the battle, as he claims. Moreover, Saul would not have been standing alone on the battlefield, leaning on his spear. The author says in 1 Samuel 31:6 that Saul's entire bodyguard died with him, reflecting the way that Israelite soldiers would have surrounded and defended Saul to the last man. If the Philistines had already killed his entire bodyguard, they would have killed Saul too. So the Amalekite has made up a story in the hopes that David will think he has killed Saul and reward him. As the story describes, however, this false claim only got the Amalekite himself killed. David had no way of knowing that his story was not true, and he had him executed for killing "the anointed one of Yahweh" (1:14).

Why was Saul's shield still on Mount Gilboa?
1 Samuel 31:10 says that when the Philistines found Saul dead on Mount Gilboa the day after their battle with the Israelites, they took Saul's equipment and put it in one of their idol temples as a trophy of victory. But David speaks in 2 Samuel 1:21 as if Saul's shield was still on Mount Gilboa. It is possible that the Philistines simply did not consider the shield something they should put in their temple along with Saul's armor and weapons. However, David uses a strong word for how the shield was treated. He does not say that it was simply disregarded. He says that it was "loathed." Elsewhere in the Bible, this word describes people deliberately rejecting something or someone else with a feeling of strong antipathy. So it is possible that the Philistines intentionally left Saul's shield behind as an insult to him. This would have been a symbolic action suggesting that the shield was worthless, since it had not protected Saul from their weapons. This would be a way of asserting their military superiority over the Israelites. You may have a term in your language that you can use to translate "loathed" that would convey this meaning.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

Parallelism
In the song that David composed as a memorial tribute to Saul and Jonathan (1:19–27), in many cases, a phrase means basically the same thing as the phrase before it. The second phrase emphasizes the meaning of the first phrase by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and it would be good to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation rather than combining them. However, it may be clearer in your language to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. For example, in 1:20, for "lest the daughters of the Philistines rejoice, lest the daughters of the uncircumcised triumph," you might say, "otherwise, the daughters of the Philistines would rejoice, yes, the daughters of the uncircumcised would triumph." In 1:22, for "the bow of Jonathan did not turn back, and the sword of Saul did not return empty," you might say, "the bow of Jonathan did not turn back, no, the sword of Saul did not return empty."

David's love for Jonathan
David speaks in 1:26 of the love that he and Jonathan had for each other. If your language has more than one term for "love," be sure not to use a term that describes sexual desire. Biblical Hebrew has specific language for sexual desire, and David does not use that language here. David speaks of Jonathan as his "brother," meaning that he is his dear friend. When David says that this love "was more wonderful to me than the love of women," he means that a deep, abiding friendship is better than romance. If your language has a word for friendship-love, it would be appropriate to use that word here in your translation. You could also use a word for unselfish love. If you have already translated the book of 1 Samuel, see how you translated the similar expression in 1 Samuel 18:1.

2 Samuel 1:1 (#2)

וְדָוִד שָׁשָׁב

"that David returned"

The author is using **David** to represent him and his men. See the discussion of this usage in the Introduction to 2 Samuel. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [that David and his men returned]

See: Synecdoche

2 Samuel 1:1 (#1)

וַיְהִי

"And it happened"

See the discussion of this phrase in the Introduction to 2 Samuel. The author is using it to introduce a

new development in the story. Use a word, phrase, or other method here that is natural in your language for introducing a new development.

See: Introduction of a New Event

2 Samuel 1:1 (#3)

אֶת־הָעֲמָלֵקִי

“Amalek”

Here the name of a person, **Amalek**, represents his descendants. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the Amalekites]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 1:1 (#4)

מֵהַכּוֹת אֶת־הָעֲמָלֵקִי

“from striking Amalek”

See the discussion of the term “strike” in the Introduction to 2 Samuel. Alternate translation: [from slaughtering the Amalekites]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 1:1 (#5)

יָמִים שְׁנָיִם

“two days”

The author is expressing this in the way his culture reckoned time. He does not mean that David and his men arrived in Ziklag and stayed there for two subsequent days before something further happened. He is reckoning the day of their arrival as the first of these **two days**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [that day and the next one]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 1:2 (#1)

וַיְהִי

“And it happened”

In this case, the author is using this phrase to introduce a new development in the story. Use a word, phrase, or other method here that is natural in your language for introducing a new development.

See: Introduction of a New Event

2 Samuel 1:2 (#3)

וְהִנֵּה

“that, behold”

See the discussion of the expression “behold” in the Introduction to 2 Samuel to decide how to represent it in your translation here and throughout the book.

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 1:2 (#5)

וּבְגָדָיו קְרֵעִים וַאֲדָמָה עַל־רֹאשׁוֹ

“and his clothes were torn, and dirt {was} on his head”

This was a symbolic action that showed the man was in mourning. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action. Alternate translation: [and he had torn his clothes and put dirt on his head to show that he was grieving]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 1:2 (#2)

בַּיּוֹם הַשְּׁלִישִׁי

“on the third day”

In this culture, the current day was considered the first day, the next day was considered the second day, and the day after that was considered **the third day**. So this phrase is referring to the day after the day after David returned to Ziklag. Express this in terms that your language and culture would naturally use. Alternate translation: [on the next day]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 1:2 (#6)

וַיִּפֹּל אַרְצָה וַיִּשְׁתָּחוּ

“that he fell to the ground and prostrated himself”

Be sure it is clear in your translation that this man did not fall down accidentally. He knelt down in front of David as a gesture to honor him. He then **prostrated himself** or stretched out flat on the ground to show David great honor. Alternate translation: [and he knelt on the ground in front of David, stretching himself out flat, to honor him greatly]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 1:2 (#4)

וּבְגָדָיו קְרֵעִים וַאֲדָמָה עַל־רֹאשׁוֹ

“and his clothes were torn, and dirt {was} on his head”

If your language does not use a passive form such as **were torn**, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. You could also identify this man as the one responsible for the **dirt** being on his **head**. Alternate translation: [and he had torn his clothes and put dirt on his head]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 1:3 (#1)

אַיֵּי מִזֶּה תָּבֹא

“Where from this are you coming”

David is using a common expression of his culture. The expression combines a question and an anticipated answer: “**Where** are you coming **from**?” “I am coming from **this** place.” It may be more natural in your language to translate this without reflecting the anticipated answer. Alternate translation: [Where are you coming from?]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 1:4 (#3)

נָפַל & וַיָּמֻתוּ

“had fallen and died”

The verbs **fallen** and **died** together also express a single idea. The verb **fallen** tells in what way these soldiers had **died**. Specifically, this was by being mortally wounded in battle, which caused them to fall to the ground. Alternate translation: [had died of their wounds] or [had died in battle]

See: Hendiadys

2 Samuel 1:4 (#1)

וַיֹּאמֶר אֲשֶׁר־נָס הָעָם מִן־הַמִּלְחָמָה וְגַם־הַרְבֵּה נָפַל מִן־הָעָם וַיָּמֻתוּ וְגַם שָׁאוּל וִיהוֹנָתָן בְּנוֹ מֵתוּ

“And he said that the people had fled from the battle, and also many from the people had fallen and died, and also Saul and Jonathan his son had died”

It may be more natural in your language to have a direct quotation here. Alternate translation: [And he said, “The people fled from the battle, and also many from the people fell and died, and even Saul and Jonathan his son died.”]

See: Direct and Indirect Quotations

2 Samuel 1:4 (#2)

הָעָם & מִן־הָעָם

“the people & from the people”

By **the people**, the young man means the Israelite army. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [the army ... from the army]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 1:6 (#1)

וַיֹּאמֶר הַנַּעַר ׀ הַמַּגִּיד לוֹ

“And the young man, the one declaring to him, said”

Since the author has already identified this **young man** in the previous verse, it might seem that identifying him again here in the same way would be extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you could leave it out. Alternate translation: [And the young man said]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 1:6 (#2)

נִקְרֹא נִקְרֵיתִי

“Happening to be, I happened to be”

The young man is repeating forms of the same verb in order to intensify his expression of the idea that it conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [I just happened to be]

See: Reduplication

2 Samuel 1:7 (#1)

וָאֹמַר הִנֵּנִי

“and I said, ‘Behold me”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [and I asked what I could do for him]

See: Quotes within Quotes

2 Samuel 1:7 (#2)

הִנֵּנִי

“Behold me”

The young man says he responded to Saul with the courteous expression that a person in this culture

would use to tell a superior that he had heard a summons and was ready and willing to obey. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [Yes, sir?]

See: Politeness

2 Samuel 1:8 (#1)

וַיֹּ֨אמֶר לִ֜י מִי־אָ֣תָּה ויאמר אֵלָ֗יו עֲמָלֵקִ֥י אָנֹֽכִי

“And he said to me, ‘Who {are} you?’ And I said to him, ‘I {am} an Amalekite”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [And he asked me who I was, and I told him that I was an Amalekite]

See: Quotes within Quotes

2 Samuel 1:9 (#3)

אֲחָזַ֖נִי הַשָּׁבָֽץ

“agony has seized me”

The young man claims that Saul spoke of **agony** as if it were a living thing that could have **seized** him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. This could mean: (1) that Saul is in such pain from his wounds that he is no longer capable of fighting. The **agony** would be restraining him in that sense, as if it had **seized** him and was holding him immobile. Alternate translation: [I am in too much pain to defend myself]; (2) that Saul has an overwhelming sense of pain. Alternate translation: [I am in very great agony]

See: Personification

2 Samuel 1:9 (#5)

כָּל־עוֹד֙ נַפְשִׁ֣י בִּֽי

“my life {is} still whole in me”

By **my life {is} still whole in me**, Saul means that he is badly wounded, but not mortally wounded. He will not die imminently from the wounds he currently has. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [I am badly wounded, but not wounded mortally]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 1:9 (#1)

וַיֹּ֨אמֶר אֵלַ֜י עֲמָד־נָ֣א עָלַ֗יו וּמְמָתֵ֙תְנִי֙ כִּֽי־אֲחָזַ֣נִי הַשָּׁבָ֔ץ כִּי־כָל־עוֹדִ֥י נַפְשִׁ֖י בִּֽי

“And he said to me, ‘Please stand over me and kill me, for agony has seized me, for my life {is} still whole in me”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [And he asked me please to stand over him and kill him, for agony had seized him, for his life was still whole in him]

See: Quotes within Quotes

2 Samuel 1:9 (#2)

עֲמָד־נָ֣א עָלַ֗יו וּמְמָתֵ֙תְנִי֙ כִּֽי־אֲחָזַ֣נִי הַשָּׁבָ֔ץ כִּי־כָל־עוֹד֙ נַפְשִׁ֣י בִּֽי

“Please stand over me and kill me, for agony has seized me, for my life {is} still whole in me”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Since my life is still whole in me, agony has seized me, so please stand over me and kill me]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

2 Samuel 1:9 (#4)

עֲמָד & עָלַ֗יו וּמְמָתֵ֙תְנִי֙

“stand over me and kill me”

This could mean: (1) that Saul is using a common expression of his culture to mean that he wants this young man to use violence against him. In this context, the expression **stand over me** may be equivalent to the expression “rise up against” in 22:49. Alternate translation: [attack me and kill me]; (2) that Saul actually wants the young man to **stand over** him and use all of his weight to push a sword or spear into him and kill him. Alternate translation: [stab me with all your weight and kill me]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 1:10 (#3)

לֹ֣א יִחְיֶ֔ה אַחֲרֵ֖י נִפְּלֽוֹ

“he would not live after his having fallen”

The young man does not mean that Saul had actually **fallen** to the ground. He says in 1:6 that Saul was standing up, leaning on his spear. The young man is speaking of Saul being badly defeated by the

Philistines as if Saul had fallen from a height. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the Philistines would surely kill him now that they had defeated his entire army]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 1:10 (#5)

אֶל־אֲדֹנָי

“to my lord”

Even though the young man is addressing David directly, he is speaking of him in the third person as **my master** to show respect. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a respectful form in the second person. Alternate translation: [to you, my master]

See: First, Second or Third Person

2 Samuel 1:10 (#2)

וָאֶעֱמֹד עָלָיו וָאֲמִתֶּתְהוּ

“So I stood over him and killed him”

The young man is using a common expression of his culture, **I stood over him**, to mean that he attacked Saul. See how you translated the similar expression in the previous verse. Alternate translation: [So I attacked him and killed him] or [So I stabbed him with all my weight and killed him]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 1:10 (#4)

הַנֵּזֶר ׀ אֲשֶׁר עַל־רֹאשׁוֹ וְאֶצְעָדָה אֲשֶׁר עַל־זְרֹעוֹ

“the crown that {was} on his head and the band that {was} on his arm”

A **crown** is a decorative headpiece that shows that a person is a king. In this context, the term describes a narrow band of gold encircling Saul’s helmet, not a large, ornamental headpiece with jewels. The **band on his arm** was probably a decorative item worn on the arm to show that the person was a king. If your readers would not be familiar with what these items are, in your translation you could use the name of similar things that your readers would recognize, or you could use a general expression. Alternate translation: [the royal headpiece that was on his head and the royal armband that was on his arm]

See: Translate Unknowns

2 Samuel 1:10 (#1)

וָאֶעֱמֹד עָלָיו וַאֲמִתֶּתְהוּ כִּי־יָדַעְתִּי כִּי לֹא יִחְיֶה אַחֲרֵי נָפְלֹו

“So I stood over him and killed him, for I knew that he would not live after his having fallen”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [So because I knew that he would not live after his having fallen, I stood over him and killed him]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

2 Samuel 1:11 (#1)

וַיַּחֲזֵק דָּוִד בבגדו וַיִּקְרָעֵם

“And David seized his clothes and tore them”

This was a symbolic action that showed David was feeling shock and grief. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action. Alternate translation: [And David seized his clothes and tore them to show that he was shocked and grieving]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 1:11 (#2)

וְגַם כָּל־הָאֲנָשִׁים אֲשֶׁר אִתּוֹ

“and also all of the men who {were} with him”

The author is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and all the men who were with him also seized their clothes and tore them]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 1:12 (#2)

עַם יְהוָה

“the people of Yahweh”

By **the people of Yahweh**, the author means the Israelite army. See how you translated the term “people” in 1:4. Alternate translation: [the army of Yahweh] or [the Israelite army]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 1:12 (#5)

בֶּחָרֶב

“by the sword”

The author is using the term **sword** by association to mean battle, since swords were used in battle. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in battle]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 1:12 (#3)

בֵּ֣ית יִשְׂרָאֵ֑ל

“the house of Israel”

Here, **house** means all the people descended from a particular person. It envisions them as if they were one household living together. So **the house of Israel** figuratively means all the people descended from the man named Israel (who was also known as Jacob). If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the nation of Israel]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 1:12 (#4)

נָפְל֖וּ

“they had fallen”

The author is using the term **fallen** by association to mean that they had died, since soldiers fall down when they die. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [they had died]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 1:12 (#1)

וַיִּסְפְּדוּ֩ וַיִּבְכּ֨וּ וַיָּצ֜וֹמוּ עַד־הָעֶ֗רֶב עַל־שָׁא֤וּל וְעַל־יְהוֹנָתָן֙ בְּנ֔וֹ וְעַל־עַ֥ם יְהוָ֖ה וְעַל־בֵּ֣ית יִשְׂרָאֵ֑ל כִּ֥י נָפְל֖וּ בֶּחָֽרֶב

“And they mourned and wept and fasted until the evening for Saul and for Jonathan his son and for the people of Yahweh and for the house of Israel, because they had fallen by the sword”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [And because Saul and Jonathan his son and the people of Yahweh had fallen by the sword, they mourned and wept and fasted until the evening for them and for the house of Israel]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

2 Samuel 1:13 (#2)

אִ֣ישׁ גֵּ֔ר

“a man, a foreigner”

The man is using this expression to introduce his father as a participant in his story. Your language may have its own way of introducing participants that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [a certain foreigner]

See: Introduction of New and Old Participants

2 Samuel 1:13 (#1)

אֵ֖י מִזֶּ֣ה אָתָּ֑ה

“Where from this {are} you”

David is using a common expression of his culture. See how you translated the similar expression in 1:3. Alternate translation: [Where are you from]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 1:14 (#2)

לִשְׁלֹ֥חַ יָדְךָ֖ לְשַׁחֵ֑ת

“to stretch out your hand to destroy”

David is using a common expression of his culture, **stretch out your hand**, to mean attacking or violently harming someone. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to use violence to destroy]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 1:14 (#1)

אֵ֚יךְ לֹ֣א יָרֵ֔אתָ לִשְׁלֹ֥חַ יָדְךָ֖ לְשַׁחֵ֣ת אֶת־מְשִׁ֥יחַ יְהוָֽה

“How did you not fear to stretch out your hand to destroy the anointed of Yahweh”

David is using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [You should have feared to stretch out your hand to destroy the anointed of Yahweh!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 1:14 (#3)

אֶת־מְשִׁ֥יחַ יְהוָֽה

“the anointed of Yahweh”

David is using the adjective **anointed** as a noun to mean a particular of person. Your language may use

adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase, here and in verse 16. Alternate translation: [the anointed one of Yahweh] or [the one whom Yahweh anointed]

See: Nominal Adjectives

2 Samuel 1:15 (#1)

פְּגַע & וַיַּכֵּהוּ

“attack & And he struck him”

See how you translated the term “striking” in 1:1 in light of the discussion in the Introduction to 2 Samuel. Alternate translation: [attack ... And he attacked him]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 1:15 (#2)

וַיֹּאמֶר

“and he said”

The phrase **and he said** introduces a direct quotation. In your translation, use a natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language. It may not be necessary to represent this phrase explicitly.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

2 Samuel 1:16 (#3)

דמיך עַל־רֹאשֶׁךָ

“Your blood {is} on your head”

David is using the term **blood** by association to mean “death,” since the young man he summoned shed the Amalekite’s blood when he killed him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Your death is on your head]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 1:16 (#7)

לֵאמֹר

“saying”

The term **saying** introduces a direct quotation. In your translation, use a natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language. It may not be necessary to represent this term explicitly, here and throughout your translation.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

2 Samuel 1:16 (#1)

וַיֹּאמֶר אֵלָיו דָּוִד דמיך עַל־רֹאשֶׁךָ כִּי פִיךָ עָנָה בְךָ לֵאמֹר אָנֹכִי מֹתַתִּי אֶת־מְשִׁיחַ יְהוָה

“And David said to him, “Your blood {is} on your head, for your mouth answered against you, saying, ‘I myself killed the anointed of Yahweh”

This could mean: (1) that David is speaking to the Amalekite even though he cannot hear him (since he is already dead) in order to show in a strong way how he feels about his claim that he killed Saul. He would actually be speaking to the people who can hear him, the men around him. If this would not be clear to your readers, you could translate David’s words as if he were speaking directly to those who can hear him. Alternate translation: [And David said, “His blood is on his own head, for his mouth answered against him, saying, ‘I myself killed the anointed of Yahweh]; (2) that the young man had not died yet and David was speaking to him directly. (The author’s statement in the previous verse, “and he died,” would be a description of what ultimately happened.) Alternate translation: [And David said to him as he was dying, “Your blood {is} on your head, for your mouth answered against you, saying, ‘I myself killed the anointed of Yahweh]

See: Apostrophe

2 Samuel 1:16 (#4)

דמיך עַל־רֹאשֶׁךָ

“Your blood {is} on your head”

When David says **on your head**, he is using a common expression that means that someone is morally and legally responsible for something. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You are responsible for your own death]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 1:16 (#6)

אָנֹכִי מֹתַתִּי אֶת־מְשִׁיחַ יְהוָה

“I myself killed the anointed of Yahweh”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [saying that you yourself killed the anointed of Yahweh]

See: Quotes within Quotes

2 Samuel 1:16 (#5)

פִּ֥יךָ עָנָ֖ה בְּךָ֑

“your mouth answered against you”

David is speaking of the young man’s **mouth** as if it were a living thing that could testify against him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you testified against yourself]

See: Personification

2 Samuel 1:16 (#2)

דמיך עַל־רֹאשֶׁ֔ךָ כִּֽי־פִ֥יךָ עָנָ֖ה בְּךָ֑ לֵאמֹ֗ר אָנֹכִ֤י מֹתַ֙תִּי֙ אֶת־מְשִׁ֣יחַ יְהוָ֔ה

“Your blood {is} on your head, for your mouth answered against you, saying, ‘I myself killed the anointed of Yahweh”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Since your mouth answered against you, saying, ‘I myself killed the anointed of Yahweh,’ your blood is on your head]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

2 Samuel 1:17 (#1)

וַיְקֹנֵ֣ן דָּוִ֔ד אֶת־הַקִּינָ֖ה הַזֹּ֑את

“Then David lamented this lamentation”

It might seem that this expression contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [Then David made this lamentation]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 1:18 (#2)

קֶ֖שֶׁת

“The Bow”

The Bow is the name of a song. In your translation, use the appropriate conventions of your language to indicate this.

See: Quote Markings

2 Samuel 1:18 (#1)

בְּנֵ֥י יְהוּדָ֖ה

“the sons of Judah”

See the discussion of the phrase **sons of** in the Introduction to 2 Samuel. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the people of Judah]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 1:18 (#4)

סֵ֖פֶר הַיָּשָׁ֑ר

“the Book of Jashar”

This is the title of a book. In your translation, use the appropriate conventions of your language to indicate this. You can spell the word **Jashar** the way it sounds in your language, or you could use a word or phrase from your language that expresses the meaning of this name. Alternate translation: [the Book of the Upright]

See: Copy or Borrow Words

2 Samuel 1:18 (#3)

כְּתוּבָ֖ה עַל־סֵ֥פֶר הַיָּשָׁ֑ר

“it is written in the Book of Jashar”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [one can read the words to this song in the Book of Jashar]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 1:19 (#2)

הַצְּבִ֣י יִשְׂרָאֵ֔ל & חָלָ֖ל

“The splendor of Israel {is} slain”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **splendor**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [The men who made Israel splendid lie slain]

See: Abstract Nouns

2 Samuel 1:19 (#4)

בָּמוֹתֶ֖יךָ

“your high places”

The word **your** here is singular because David is addressing the nation of Israel as if it were a single person. So use the singular form in your translation if your language marks that distinction.

See: Forms of ‘You’ — Singular

2 Samuel 1:19 (#6)

אֵ֚יךְ נָפְל֣וּ גִבּוֹרִ֔ים

“How the mighty have fallen”

David is using the adjective **mighty** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [How these mighty warriors have died]

See: Nominal Adjectives

2 Samuel 1:19 (#3)

הַצְּבִ֥י יִשְׂרָאֵ֖ל

“The splendor of Israel”

David is speaking about **Israel** in the third person even though he is addressing that nation directly. If you retain the direct address in your translation, you could translate this in the second person if that would be helpful in your language. Alternate translation: [Your splendor, O Israel]

See: First, Second or Third Person

2 Samuel 1:19 (#1)

הַצְּבִ֥י יִשְׂרָאֵ֖ל עַל־בָּמוֹתֶ֣יךָ חָלָ֑ל

“The splendor of Israel {is} slain on your high places”

David is speaking to the nation of Israel as if it were a person who could hear him. He is doing this to show in a strong way how he feels about the deaths of Saul and Jonathan. He is actually speaking to the people who can hear him, the people of Judah who will eventually learn this song. If this would not be clear to your readers, you could translate David’s words as if he were speaking directly to those who could hear him. Alternate translation: [The splendor of Israel {is} slain on its high places]

See: Apostrophe

2 Samuel 1:19 (#5)

אֵ֚יךְ נָפְל֣וּ גִבּוֹרִ֔ים

“How the mighty have fallen”

David is using the term **fallen** by association to mean “died,” since these soldiers fell down when they died. See how you translated this word in 1:12. Alternate translation: [How the mighty have died]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 1:19 (#7)

אֵ֚יךְ נָפְל֣וּ גִבּוֹרִ֔ים

“How the mighty have fallen”

David is using a phrase that expresses a strong feeling, great sorrow that the mighty warriors have died. There may be an equivalent word or phrase in your language that you can use in your translation to convey this feeling. If not, you could indicate specifically what David was feeling. Alternate translation: [I am so sad that these mighty warriors have died]

See: Exclamations

2 Samuel 1:20 (#1)

אַל־תַּגִּ֣ידוּ בְגַ֔ת אַל־תְּבַשְּׂר֥וּ בְחוּצֹ֖ת אַשְׁקְלֹ֑ון

“May they not declare {it} in Gath, may they not proclaim {it} in the streets of Ashkelon”

David is not using the pronoun **they** to refer to specific people. Use a comparable expression that would be natural in your language. Alternate translation: [May no one declare it in Gath, may no one proclaim it in the streets of Ashkelon] or [May it not be declared in Gath, may it not be proclaimed in the streets of Ashkelon]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 1:20 (#3)

בְּנ֣וֹת פְּלִשְׁתִּ֔ים

“the daughters of the Philistines”

Here the term **daughters** has the same kind of meaning as the term **sons** in 1:18. See how you decided to translate that term there. Alternate translation: [the women of Philistia]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 1:20 (#4)

בְּנ֥וֹת הָעֲרֵלִֽים

“the daughters of the uncircumcised”

David is using the adjective **uncircumcised** as a noun to mean people who have not been circumcised. Israelites used this as a term of derision to describe the Philistines as people did not worship Yahweh and did no obey his laws, such as the one requiring the circumcision of men. Your language may have a comparable term of derision that you can use in your translation. If you have already translated the book of 1 Samuel, see how you translated this term in 1 Samuel 14:6. Alternate translation: [the women among those heathen]

See: Nominal Adjectives

2 Samuel 1:20 (#2)

אַל־תַּגִּ֣ידוּ בְגַ֔ת אַל־תְּבַשְּׂרוּ֙ בְּחוּצֹ֣ת אַשְׁקְלֹ֔ון

“May they not declare {it} in Gath, may they not proclaim {it} in the streets of Ashkelon”

Following the customary practice of Hebrew poetry, David is using two phrases together that mean basically the same thing. See the discussion of this practice in the Introduction to this chapter to help you decide how you will represent such pairs of phrases in your translation.

See: Parallelism

2 Samuel 1:21 (#5)

שָׁ֣ם נִגְעַל־מָגֵ֔ן גִּבּוֹרִ֑ים

“there the shield of the mighty was loathed”

See the Introduction to this chapter for a discussion of how this may have represented a symbolic action and for a suggestion of how you might translate it.

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 1:21 (#8)

מָגֵ֥ן שָׁא֛וּל בְּלִ֥י מָשִׁ֖יחַ בַּשָּׁמֶֽן

“the shield of Saul, not anointed with oil”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [no one anoints the shield of Saul with oil anymore]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 1:21 (#1)

הָרֵ֤י בַגִּלְבֹּ֙עַ֙ אַל־טַ֣ל וְאַל־מָטָ֔ר עֲלֵיכֶ֖ם וּשְׂדֵ֣י תְרוּמֹ֑ת כִּ֣י שָׁ֣ם נִגְעַל־מָגֵ֔ן גִּבּוֹרִ֑ים מָגֵ֥ן שָׁא֛וּל בְּלִ֥י מָשִׁ֖יחַ בַּשָּׁמֶֽן

“Mountains in Gilboa, {may} not dew and {may} not rain {be} upon you, nor fields of offerings, for there the shield of the mighty was loathed, the shield of Saul, not anointed with oil”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Since the shield of the mighty was loathed there, the shield of Saul, not anointed with oil, may dew and rain not be upon you, nor fields of offerings, mountains in Gilboa]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

2 Samuel 1:21 (#2)

הָרֵ֤י בַגִּלְבֹּ֙עַ֙ אַל־טַ֣ל וְאַל־מָטָ֔ר עֲלֵיכֶ֖ם וּשְׂדֵ֣י תְרוּמֹ֑ת

“Mountains in Gilboa, {may} not dew and {may} not rain {be} upon you, nor fields of offerings”

David is speaking to the mountains of Gilboa as if they could hear him. He is doing this to show in a strong way how he feels about the deaths of Saul and Jonathan on those mountains. He is actually speaking to the people who can hear him, the people of Judah who will eventually learn this song. If this would not be clear to your readers, you could translate his words as if he were speaking directly to people who could hear him. Alternate translation: [May there be no dew or rain, nor fields of offerings, upon the mountains in Gilboa]

See: Apostrophe

2 Samuel 1:21 (#3)

וּשְׂדֵ֣י תְרוּמֹ֑ת

“nor fields of offerings”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and may fields of offerings not be upon you]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 1:21 (#4)

וּשְׂדֵ֣י תְרוּמֹ֑ת

“nor fields of offerings”

David is using this possessive form to mean fields that produce only enough crops for people to use as offerings. Offerings were typically only a small percentage of an overall crop. So David is wishing for so little rain and dew that the fields will not produce even a fraction of their usual amount. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [nor fields producing even enough crops for small offerings]

See: Possession

2 Samuel 1:21 (#6)

נִגְעַל־מָגֵ֥ן גִּבּוֹרִ֑ים

“the shield of the mighty was loathed”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation:

[people treated the shield of the mighty disrespectfully]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 1:21 (#7)

גִּבּוֹרִֽים

“the mighty”

David is using the adjective **mighty** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [a mighty warrior]

See: Nominal Adjectives

2 Samuel 1:22 (#2)

מִדַּ֣ם חֲלָלִ֔ים מֵחֵ֖לֶב גִּבּוֹרִֽים

“From the blood of the slain, from the fat of the mighty”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. He is using a common image of his culture, but in an abbreviated form. The image appears in its full form in Deuteronomy 32:42, “I will make my arrows drunk with blood, and my sword will devour flesh.” You can supply the omitted words from the cultural context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [From drinking the blood of the slain, from devouring the fat of the mighty]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 1:22 (#4)

חֲלָלִ֔ים & גִּבּוֹרִֽים

“the slain & the mighty”

David is using the adjectives **slain** and **mighty** as nouns to mean certain kinds of people. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate these adjectives with equivalent phrases. Alternate translation: [slain soldiers ... mighty warriors]

See: Nominal Adjectives

2 Samuel 1:22 (#5)

קֶ֣שֶׁת יְהוֹנָתָ֔ן לֹ֥א נָשֹׁ֖וג אָחֹֽור

“the bow of Jonathan did not turn itself back”

David is using the term **bow** by association to mean the arrows that Jonathan shot from his bow. You may choose to use the arrows to represent this image in your translation. Alternate translation: [the arrows of Jonathan did not turn themselves back]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 1:22 (#1)

מִדַּ֣ם חֲלָלִ֔ים מֵחֵ֖לֶב גִּבּוֹרִ֑ים קֶ֣שֶׁת יְהוֹנָתָ֔ן לֹ֥א נָשֹׁ֖וג אָחֹ֑וֹר
וְחֶ֥רֶב שָׁא֛וּל לֹ֥א תָשׁ֖וּב רֵיקָֽם

“From the blood of the slain, from the fat of the mighty, the bow of Jonathan did not turn itself back, and the sword of Saul did not return empty”

David is speaking of **the bow of Jonathan** as if it had been a person who could have been sent to fulfill a task but who might have decided to **turn itself back** and not complete it. David is speaking similarly of **the sword of Saul** as if it had been a person who could have been sent to get something but who might have returned with **empty** hands, that is, without it. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [When Jonathan shot arrows at enemy soldiers, the arrows pierced them so that they bled and died. When Saul stabbed enemy soldiers, his sword cut them so deeply that their fat came out and they died]

See: Personification

2 Samuel 1:22 (#3)

מִדַּ֣ם חֲלָלִ֔ים מֵחֵ֖לֶב גִּבּוֹרִֽים

“From the blood of the slain, from the fat of the mighty”

David is speaking as if the bow and sword were living things that could drink blood and consume fat. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [From slaying soldiers by piercing them so that they bled, from stabbing the mighty so deeply that their fat came out]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 1:23 (#1)

שָׁא֤וּל וְיהוֹנָתָן֙ הַנֶּאֱהָבִ֣ים וְהַנְּעִימִ֔ם בְּחַיֵּיהֶ֖ם וּבְמוֹתָ֣ם לֹ֣א נִפְרָ֑דוּ

“Saul and Jonathan {were} being loved and delightful in their lives, and in their death they were not separated”

If your language would not use the passive forms **were being loved** and **were not separated**, you could express these ideas in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [While Saul and Jonathan were alive, people loved

them and delighted in them, and when they died, they were together]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 1:23 (#2)

מִנְּשָׁרִים קַלּוּ מֵאֲרָיוֹת גָּבֵרוּ

“They were swifter than eagles, they were mightier than lions”

David is making an overstatement for emphasis. If it would be clearer in your language, you could express the emphasis in a different way. Alternate translation: [They were swift like eagles; they were mighty like lions]

See: Hyperbole

2 Samuel 1:24 (#2)

בְּנוֹת יִשְׂרָאֵל

“Daughters of Israel”

See how you translated this expression in 1:20. Alternate translation: [Women of Israel]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 1:24 (#6)

שָׁנִי

“in} scarlet”

The term **scarlet** refers to a bright red color. In this culture, people had to use an expensive dye to make clothes this color. So having scarlet clothing represented prosperity and status. If your readers would not be familiar with what scarlet is, in your translation you could use a general expression. Alternate translation: [in expensive clothing]

See: Translate Unknowns

2 Samuel 1:24 (#3)

הַמַּלְבִּשְׁכֶם שָׁנִי עִם־עֲדָנִים הַמַּעֲלֶה עֲדִי זָהָב עַל לְבוּשְׁכֶן

“the one having clothed you {in} scarlet with delights, the one having put an ornament of gold on your clothing”

Saul had not directly **clothed** the Israelite women in scarlet, and he had not directly **put** gold ornaments on their clothing. David is illustrating the prosperity that Saul brought to Israel by ensuring its security and by plundering its enemies. The UST models one way to express this meaning.

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 1:24 (#4)

שָׁנִי

“in} scarlet”

David is using the term **scarlet** by association to mean clothing that was scarlet in color. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in scarlet-colored clothing]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 1:24 (#5)

שָׁנִי עִם־עֲדָנִים

“in} scarlet with delights”

This expression conveys a single idea by using two phrases connected with **with**. The phrase **in delights** tells in what way Saul clothed the women **in scarlet**. Specifically, the clothing brought delight to the ones who wore it. Alternate translation: [delightfully in scarlet]

See: Hendiadys

2 Samuel 1:24 (#1)

בְּנוֹת יִשְׂרָאֵל אֶל־שָׁאוּל בְּכֶיָנָה הַמַּלְבִּשְׁכֶם שָׁנִי עִם־עֲדָנִים הַמַּעֲלֶה עֲדִי זָהָב עַל לְבוּשְׁכֶן

“Daughters of Israel, weep for Saul, the one having clothed you {in} scarlet with delights, the one having put an ornament of gold on your clothing”

David is speaking to the women of Israel as if they could hear him. He is doing this to show in a strong way how he feels about Saul’s death. He is actually speaking to the people who can hear him, the people of Judah who will eventually learn this song. If this would not be clear to your readers, you could translate this as if he were speaking directly to those who could hear him. Alternate translation: [The daughters of Israel should weep for Saul, the one having clothed them in scarlet with delights, the one having put an ornament of gold on their clothing]

See: Apostrophe

2 Samuel 1:25 (#2)

עַל־בָּמוֹתֶיךָ

“on your high places”

As in 1:19, the word **your** refers to the nation of Israel as if it were a single person. See how you translated this expression there. Alternate translation: [on one of the high places of Israel]

See: Apostrophe

2 Samuel 1:25 (#1)

אֵ֣יךְ נָפְל֔וּ גִּבֹּרִ֖ים

“How the mighty have fallen”

See how you translated this expression in 1:19. Alternate translation: [I am so sad that these mighty warriors have died]

See: Exclamations

2 Samuel 1:26 (#2)

אָחִ֤י יְהוֹנָתָן֙

“my brother Jonathan”

David is speaking as if Jonathan were his actual brother, even though he was not. David is using this expression to emphasize that Jonathan was as dear to him as a brother would have been. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my dear friend Jonathan]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 1:26 (#1)

לִ֣י עָלֶ֔יךָ

“to me concerning you”

David is speaking as if he were in a **narrow** (tightly confined) space in which he did not have much freedom of movement. In such a situation, a person would feel distress, and that feeling is what David is expressing through this image. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I am very distressed about you]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 1:26 (#3)

נָעַ֥מְתָּ אַהֲבָתְךָ֖ לִ֑י מֵאַהֲבַ֥ת נָשִֽׁים

“Your love was more wonderful to me than the love of women”

David is saying that his bond of friendship with Jonathan meant more to him than any romantic relationship with a woman. See the discussion of this statement in the Introduction to this chapter.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 1:27 (#1)

אֵ֣יךְ נָפְל֔וּ גִּבּוֹרִ֖ים

“How the mighty have fallen”

See how you translated this expression in 1:19. Alternate translation: [I am so sad that these mighty warriors have died]

See: Exclamations

2 Samuel 1:27 (#2)

וַיֹּאבְד֖וּ כְּלֵ֥י מִלְחָמָֽה

“and the weapons of war have perished”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and how the weapons of war have perished]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 1:27 (#3)

וַיֹּאבְד֖וּ כְּלֵ֥י מִלְחָמָֽה

“and the weapons of war have perished”

David is using these **weapons** by association to mean Saul and Jonathan who used them so skillfully, as he describes in 1:22. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and how these men who used weapons of war so skillfully have perished]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 1:27 (#4)

וַיֹּאבְד֖וּ כְּלֵ֥י מִלְחָמָֽה

“and the weapons of war have perished”

David is using a phrase that expresses a strong feeling, great sorrow that Saul and Jonathan, who used weapons skillfully, have died. There may be an equivalent word or phrase in your language that you can use in your translation to convey this feeling. If not, you could indicate specifically what David was feeling. Alternate translation: [yes, I am so sad that these men who used weapons of war so skillfully have perished]

See: Exclamations

2 Samuel - Chapter 2 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter continues the story of how David became king of Israel. It tells how he returned to live in the city of Hebron in the territory of the tribe of Judah. There

2 Samuel 2:1 (#2)

the leaders of that tribe anointed him to be the king of Judah. This chapter also tells how Abner, who had been Saul's commander, installed Saul's son Ishbosheth as a rival king in the city of Mahanaim on the other side of the Jordan River. It tells how Abner reconquered the territory that the Israelites had lost to the Philistines and then led a group of soldiers to challenge David's rule. But soldiers loyal to David, under the command of his nephew Joab, defeated Abner's soldiers and drove them away.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

For which "two years" did Ishbosheth reign?
The author says in 2:10 that Ishbosheth reigned for two years after the death of his father Saul. He says in 2:11 that David "was king in Hebron over the house of Judah" for seven years and six months, also starting shortly after the death of Saul. However, it appears from 5:1 that the other tribes of Israel came and anointed David as their king shortly after the death of Ishbosheth. So what accounts for the difference of five and a half years? The explanation may be in what the author says in 2:9, that Abner, by steadily reconquering territory from the Philistines, made Ishbosheth "rule over Gilead and over the Ashurite and over Jezreel and over Ephraim and over Benjamin and over Israel, all of it." The statement that Ishbosheth was 40 years old "when he became king over Israel, and he reigned two years" would be dating the beginning of his reign from the time when Abner had reconquered all of Israel's territory from the Philistines. So the other five and a half years represent the time it took for Abner to complete this reconquest.

Why did Joab's soldiers stop when they got to Asahel's body?
In 2:23, the author says that after Abner killed Asahel, when any of Joab's soldiers came to the place where Asahel's body was lying, they stopped pursuing Abner's soldiers and just stood there. There are several reasons why they may have done this. One possibility is that they wanted to protect Asahel's body from being mistreated (as Saul said in 1 Samuel 31:4 that he was concerned might happen to his body). Another possibility is that they stopped as an act of mourning, as an expression of grief and respect for Asahel. A further possibility is that seeing that Asahel had died in this way upset them so much that they were not able to continue pursuing Abner's soldiers. However, as the author does not say specifically why the soldiers stopped, we recommend that you do not indicate anything about this in the text of your translation.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

A standard way of describing a king's reign
The statement in 2:10, "Ishbosheth, the son of Saul, was a son of 40 years when he became king over Israel, and he reigned two years," is the first instance in this book of a standard description that occurs repeatedly in this history of Israel that extends through 1–2 Samuel and 1–2 Kings. At the start of the account of each king's reign, the history tells how old that man was when he became king and for how long he reigned. In your translation, be sure to translate this description consistently throughout these books so that your readers will recognize how the history is using it. If you have already translated the book of 1 Samuel, see how you translated the similar description in 1 Samuel 13:1.

The meaning of "play" in 2:14
In 2:14, Abner says to Joab, "May the young men now arise and play to our faces." Abner could be suggesting to Joab that some of their soldiers engage in single combat in order to determine the victor of the conflict between them. Abner may have felt that it would be wise for both sides not to suffer many casualties fighting each other with full armies when they were still threatened by the Philistines. The term "play" would denote the war-play of single combat. Another possibility is that Abner wants a battle to decide whether David or Ishbosheth would rule over Judah, but he recognizes how both armies have cautiously taken up defensive positions. So he is suggesting an initial skirmish that he is confident will lead to a full battle. The word "play" would describe the fighting as a spectacle that would incite the soldiers of each army to attack their opponents, in much the same way that joining together in a war cry would arouse soldiers to fight. A note to 2:14 suggests ways of representing each of these possible meanings.

2 Samuel 2:1 (#2)

הַאֶעֱלֶה

"Shall I go up"

See the discussion in the Introduction to 2 Samuel of how Hebrew speakers and writers marked descriptions of travel for change in elevation. David says **go up** because he is in Ziklag, near the seacoast, so he would be going up in elevation if he went to a city in the territory of Judah, which was hilly. Alternate translation: [Shall I go]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 2:1 (#3)

הַאֶעֱלֶה

“Shall I go up”

See the discussion in the Introduction to 2 Samuel of how the ULT represents the Hebrew verb form for instruction or obligation. Alternate translation: [Should I go]

See: Irregular Use of Tenses

2 Samuel 2:1 (#1)

וַיְהִי

“And it happened”

The author is using this expression to introduce a new event in the story. Use a word, phrase, or other method here that is natural in your language for introducing a new event.

See: Introduction of a New Event

2 Samuel 2:1 (#4)

חֶבְרֹנָה

“To Hebron”

Yahweh is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [Go to Hebron]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 2:2 (#1)

וְגַם שְׁתֵּתֵי נָשָׁיו

“and also the two of his wives”

The author is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and the two of his wives also went up there]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 2:2 (#2)

אֵשֶׁת נָבָל

“the wife of Nabal”

Your language may have its own term or expression for this relationship, since Nabal was now dead and Abigail was no longer his legal **wife**. Alternate translation: [the widow of Nabal]

See: Kinship

2 Samuel 2:3 (#1)

אִישׁ וּבֵיתוֹ

“a man and his house”

The author is using the term **house** by association to mean the people who lived in the same house with a man. He means the people in that man’s household. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [each man with his family]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 2:3 (#2)

בְּעָרֵי חֶבְרוֹן

“in the cities of Hebron”

The author is using the plural form **cities** in a context where the singular term “city” would suffice, since Hebron was a single city. This suggests that he is using the plural form to refer to Hebron and its surrounding villages. Your language may use plural forms in the same way. If not, you could express the meaning in another way. Alternate translation: [in and around the city of Hebron]

See: Unusual Uses of the Plural

2 Samuel 2:4 (#1)

בֵּית יְהוּדָה

“the house of Judah”

Here, **house** represents all the people descended from a particular person. It envisions them as if they were one household living together. So **the house of Judah** figuratively means all the people descended from Judah, one of the sons of Jacob or Israel. Alternate translation: [the people of the tribe of Judah]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 2:4 (#2)

וַיַּגִּדוּ לְדָוִד לֵאמֹר

“And they declared to David, saying”

The author is not using the pronoun **they** to refer to specific people. Use a comparable expression that would be natural in your language. Alternate translation: [And David was told]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 2:5 (#1)

אַנְשֵׁי יָבֵישׁ גִּלְעָד

“the men of Jabesh Gilead”

Here the masculine term **men** has a generic sense that includes both men and women. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use language in your translation that is clearly inclusive of both men and women. Alternate translation: [the people of Jabesh Gilead]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

2 Samuel 2:5 (#3)

בְּרוּכִים אַתֶּם לַיהוָֹה

“Blessed {are} you by Yahweh”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [May Yahweh bless you]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 2:5 (#2)

וַיֹּאמֶר אֲלֵיהֶם

“and he said to them”

The author is using the term **he said** by association to mean that David said this through the messengers he sent. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and they said to them on his behalf]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 2:5 (#4)

אַתֶּם

“you”

The words **you** and **your** are plural here because David is addressing all the people of Jabesh Gilead. So use the plural form in your translation if your language marks that distinction, here and through verse 7.

See: Forms of ‘You’ — Singular

2 Samuel 2:5 (#5)

עֲשִׂיתֶם הַחֶסֶד הַזֶּה עִם־אֲדֹנֵיכֶם עִם־שָׁאוּל וַתִּקְבְּרוּ אֹתוֹ

“you have done this kindness with your master, with Saul, and have buried him”

This expression conveys a single idea by using two phrases connected with **and**. The phrase **have buried him** tells in what way the people **have done this kindness** with Saul. Alternate translation: [you have done this kindness with your master, with Saul, by burying him]

See: Hendiadys

2 Samuel 2:6 (#2)

יַעַשׂ־יְהוָֹה עִמָּכֶם חֶסֶד וֶאֱמֶת

“may Yahweh do kindness and faithfulness with you”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **kindness** and **faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [may Yahweh treat you kindly and be faithful to you]

See: Abstract Nouns

2 Samuel 2:6 (#1)

וְעַתָּה

“And now”

And now was an expression that speakers in this culture commonly used to introduce their main topic. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. You could also use plain language. The UST models one way to do that.

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

2 Samuel 2:6 (#3)

וְגַם אָנֹכִי אֶעֱשֶׂה אִתְּכֶם הַטּוֹבָה הַזֹּאת

“And I myself will also do this good with you”

David is using the adjective **good** as a noun to mean a certain kind of action. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [And I myself will also do good things for you]

See: Nominal Adjectives

2 Samuel 2:7 (#1)

תֶּחֱזַקְנָה יְדֵיכֶם וִהְיוּ לִבְנֵי־חַיִל כִּי־מֵת אֲדֹנֵיכֶם שָׁאוּל וְגַם־אֹתִי מָשְׁחוּ בֵּית־יְהוּדָה לְמֶלֶךְ עֲלֵיהֶם

“may your hands be strong, and be sons of valor, for your master Saul has died, and also the house of Judah has anointed me as king over them”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second

phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [since your master Saul has died, and also the house of Judah has anointed me as king over them, may your hands be strong, and be sons of valor]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

2 Samuel 2:7 (#3)

וְהָיוּ֙ לִבְנֵי־חַ֔יִל

“and be sons of valor”

In certain contexts, biblical authors and characters use the expression **sons of** to describe people who have a certain quality. In this case, **sons of valor** describes warriors who have the quality of valor, which is courage in dangerous situations. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an equivalent expression from your language or state the meaning plainly. If you have already translated the book of 1 Samuel, see how you translated this expression in 1 Samuel 18:17. Alternate translation: [valiant warriors]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 2:7 (#4)

בֵּית־יְהוּדָ֑ה

“the house of Judah”

See how you translated this expression in 2:4. Alternate translation: [the people of the tribe of Judah]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 2:7 (#2)

תֶּחֱזַ֣קְנָה יְדֵיכֶ֗ם

“may your hands be strong”

David is using one part of the people of Jabesh Gilead, their **hands**, to mean all of them in the act of being courageous. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [be courageous]

See: Synecdoche

2 Samuel 2:8 (#1)

וְאַבְנֵ֣ר בֶּן־נֵ֗ר שַׂר־צְבָ֛א אֲשֶׁ֥ר לְשָׁא֖וּל

“But Abner, the son of Ner, the commander of the army that {was} to Saul”

The author is reintroducing Abner as a participant in the story. He was first introduced in 1 Samuel 14:50 Your language may have its own way of reintroducing participants that you can use in your translation.

See: Introduction of New and Old Participants

2 Samuel 2:9 (#1)

וַיַּמְלִכֵ֖הוּ

“And he made him rule”

The pronoun **he** refers to Abner, while the pronoun **him** refers to Ishbosheth. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [And Abner made Ishbosheth rule]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 2:9 (#3)

כֻּלֹּ֑ה

“all of it”

The author is making a generalization for emphasis. If it would be clearer in your language, you could express the emphasis in a different way. Alternate translation: [all of it except the tribe of Judah]

See: Hyperbole

2 Samuel 2:9 (#2)

וְאֶל־הָאֲשׁוּרִ֥י

“and over the Ashurite”

The author is not referring to a specific Ashurite. He means the Ashurites in general. It may be more natural in your language to express this meaning by using a plural form. Alternate translation: [and over the Ashurites]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

2 Samuel 2:10 (#4)

הָיָ֖ו אַחֲרֵ֥י דָּוִֽד

“were behind David”

The author is speaking as if the people of Judah had positioned themselves physically **behind** David. He means that they were loyal to him as their king. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [were loyal to David as their king]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 2:10 (#2)

בֶּן־אַרְבָּעִ֥ים שָׁנָ֖ה

“was} a son of 40 years”

In this culture, to say how old a man was, speakers would say that he was **a son of** a certain number of **years**. In your translation, express this in the way your language and culture say how old someone is. Alternate translation: [was 40 years of age]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 2:10 (#3)

בֵּ֣ית יְהוּדָ֑ה

“the house of Judah”

See how you translated this expression in 2:4. Alternate translation: [the people of the tribe of Judah]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 2:10 (#1)

בֶּן־אַרְבָּעִ֣ים שָׁנָ֗ה אִישׁ־בֹּ֙שֶׁת֙ בֶּן־שָׁא֣וּל בְּמָלְכ֔וֹ עַל־יִשְׂרָאֵ֖ל וּשְׁתַּ֥יִם שָׁנִ֖ים מָלָ֑ךְ

“Ish Bosheth, the son of Saul, {was} a son of 40 years when he became king over Israel, and he reigned two years”

The author is using this statement formally to introduce Ishbosheth as a participant in the story. Your language may have its own way of introducing participants that you can use in your translation. See the discussion in the Introduction to this chapter about the form of this statement, which marks the reigns of kings throughout the books of 1 and 2 Samuel and 1 and 2 Kings.

See: Introduction of New and Old Participants

2 Samuel 2:11 (#1)

וַיִּהְי֣וּ מִסְפַּ֔ר הַיָּמִ֕ים

“And the number of the days”

The author is using the phrase **the number of the days** by association to mean the length of time, since time is made up of days. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [And the length of time]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 2:12 (#1)

וַיֵּצֵא֙ אַבְנֵ֣ר בֶּן־נֵ֔ר

“Now Abner, the son of Ner & went out”

The author is introducing a new event in the story. Use a word, phrase, or other method here that is natural in your language for introducing a new event.

See: Introduction of a New Event

2 Samuel 2:13 (#1)

וְיוֹאָ֣ב בֶּן־צְרוּיָ֔ה

“And Joab, the son of Zeruiah”

Here the author is introducing Joab as a new participant in the story. Your language may have its own way of introducing new participants that you can use in your translation.

See: Introduction of New and Old Participants

2 Samuel 2:13 (#2)

צְרוּיָ֔ה

“Zeruiah”

The word **Zeruiah** is the name of a woman, David’s older sister.

See: How to Translate Names

2 Samuel 2:13 (#3)

אֵ֚אֶלֶּה עַל־הַבְּרֵכָ֣ה מִזֶּ֔ה וְאֵ֖אֶלֶּה עַל־הַבְּרֵכָ֑ה מִזֶּֽה

“these by the pool on this {side} and these by the pool on that {side”

The author is using a common expression of his culture to mean that the two groups were on opposite sides of the pool from each other. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [on opposite sides of the pool]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 2:14 (#2)

וְיְשַׂחֲקוּ֙

“and play”

See the discussion of the possible meanings here of the term **play** in the Introduction to this chapter. Alternate translation: [and engage in single combat] or [and start the fighting]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 2:14 (#1)

יָקֻ֣מוּ נָ֔א הַנְּעָרִ֖ים

“May the young men now arise”

While these young men would have to **arise** from their seated position, Abner could be using the term here to suggest that they take action. That is one frequent meaning of the term. Alternate translation: [May the young men now take action]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 2:14 (#3)

לְפָנֵינוּ

“to our faces”

See the discussion of the term **face** in the Introduction to 2 Samuel. Alternate translation: [in front of us]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 2:15 (#1)

וּשְׁנֵים עָשָׂר מֵעַבְדֵי דָוִד

“and 12 from the servants of David”

The author is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and they fought against 12 from the servants of David]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 2:16 (#4)

וַיִּקְרָאוּ לַמָּקוֹם הַהוּא

“So one called that place”

The author is not using the pronoun **one** to refer to a specific person. Use a comparable expression that would be natural in your language. Alternate translation: [So that place was called]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 2:16 (#1)

בְּרֹאשׁ

“by the head”

The author is using the term **head** by association to mean the hair on the head. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [by the hair]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 2:16 (#2)

וְחַרְבוֹ בְּצִדֵּד רֵעֵהוּ

“and his sword in the side of his fellow”

The author is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and thrust his sword in the side of his fellow]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 2:16 (#3)

וַיִּפְּלוּ

“and they fell”

The author is using the term **fell** by association to mean that they died, since they fell down when they died. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and they died]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 2:16 (#5)

חֶלְקַת הַצֻּרִים

“Helkath Hazzurim”

As the author indicates, **Helkath Hazzurim** is the name of a place. In your translation, you could spell it the way it sounds in your language. Alternatively, you could use a word or phrase from your language that expresses the meaning of this name. However, the exact meaning is uncertain. One possible meaning is “The Field of the Sides,” which would be an allusion to the way each soldier stabbed his opponent in the side. Another possible meaning is “The Field of the Swords” or “The Field of the Daggers,” which would be an allusion to the weapons that the soldiers used. If a translation of the Bible exists in your region and it suggests one of these meanings, you may wish to suggest the same meaning in your translation.

See: Copy or Borrow Words

2 Samuel 2:17 (#2)

וַיִּנָּגֶף & לִפְנֵי עַבְדֵי דָוִד

“And & were struck to the face of the servants of David”

The author is using the term **face** by association to mean that Abner and the men of Israel were in front of the servants of David. The expression indicates agency. It means that David’s soldiers struck Abner and his soldiers as they engaged them in battle. See the discussion of this phrase in the Introduction to 2

Samuel. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [were struck by the servants of David] or [were struck as they opposed the servants of David]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 2:17 (#1)

וַיִּנָּגֶף אַבְנֵר וְאַנְשֵׁי יִשְׂרָאֵל לִפְנֵי עַבְדֵי דָוִד

“And Abner and the men of Israel were struck to the face of the servants of David”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [And the servants of David struck Abner and the men of Israel to their faces]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 2:17 (#3)

וַיִּנָּגֶף & לִפְנֵי עַבְדֵי דָוִד

“And & were struck to the face of the servants of David”

By **were struck**, the author means that Abner and the men of Israel “were defeated” in battle. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. See the discussion of the term “struck” in the Introduction to 2 Samuel. Alternate translation: [were defeated to the face of the servants of David] or [were defeated by the servants of David]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 2:18 (#1)

וַיְהִיּוּ־שָׁם שְׁלֹשָׁה בְּנֵי צְרוּיָה יוֹאָב וַאֲבִישַׁי וַעֲשָׂהאֵל וַעֲשָׂהאֵל קַל בְּרַגְלָיו כְּאַחַד הַצְּבָיִם אֲשֶׁר בַּשָּׂדֶה

“Now the three sons of Zeruiah were there, Joab and Abishai and Asahel. And Asahel {was} light on his feet, like one of the gazelles that {are} in the field”

Here the author is introducing Asahel as a new participant in the story. Your language may have its own way of introducing new participants that you can use in your translation.

See: Introduction of New and Old Participants

2 Samuel 2:18 (#3)

הַצְּבָיִם

“the gazelles”

The word **gazelles** describes small, fast-running, deer-like animals. If your readers would not be familiar with what a gazelle is, in your translation you could use the name of a similar animal that your readers would recognize, or you could use a general expression. Alternate translation: [the fast deer] or [the swift-running wild animals]

See: Translate Unknowns

2 Samuel 2:18 (#2)

וַעֲשָׂהאֵל קַל בְּרַגְלָיו

“And Asahel {was} light on his feet”

The author is using a common expression of his culture, **light on his feet**, to mean that Asahel was very fast when he ran. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. You could also use plain language, as the UST does. Alternate translation: [And Asahel was swift of foot]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 2:19 (#1)

עַל־הַיָּמִין וְעַל־הַשְּׂמֹאול מֵאַחֲרֵי אַבְנֵר

“to the right or to the left from after Abner”

The author is speaking of two extremes, right and left, in order to mean them and everything in between. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in any direction except after Abner]

See: Merism

2 Samuel 2:21 (#1)

עַל־יְמִינְךָ אוֹ עַל־שְׂמֹאלֶךָ

“to your right or to your left”

See how you translated the similar expression in 2:19. Alternate translation: [in some other direction] or [in pursuit of someone else]

See: Merism

2 Samuel 2:22 (#3)

וְאֵיךְ אֶשָּׂא פָנַי אֶל־יוֹאָב אָחִיךָ

“Then how would I lift my face to Joab your brother”

Abner failing to **lift** his **face** to look at Joab directly would be a symbolic action that would express shame for killing Asahel, a younger, less experienced warrior.

If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action. Alternate translation: [Then I would be too ashamed to look your brother Joab in the face]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 2:22 (#1)

לָֽמָּה אַכֶּכָּהּ֙ אַ֣רְצָה וְאֵידְךָ֔ אֶשָּׂ֖א פָּנַ֑י אֶל־יוֹאָ֖ב אָחִֽיךָ

“Why should I strike you to the ground? Then how would I lift my face to Joab your brother”

Abner is using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Do not make me strike you to the ground! Then I would not be able to lift my face to Joab, your brother.]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 2:22 (#2)

לָֽמָּה אַכֶּכָּהּ֙ אַ֣רְצָה

“Why should I strike you to the ground”

By **strike you to the ground**, Abner means kill Asahel, causing him to fall to the ground dead. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Why should I kill you, so that you fall to the ground dead]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 2:23 (#1)

תחתו

“under him”

The author is using a common expression of his culture to mean that Asahel died right in the place where Abner killed him, that is, on the ground that was **under him** at that time. The author is not saying that Abner stood over Asahel as he was dying. Be sure that this is clear for your readers. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [on the spot]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 2:23 (#2)

כָּל־הַבָּבֵֽא

“every one coming”

The author is making a generalization for emphasis, since the next verse shows that **every** did not include Joab and Abishai. If it would be clearer in your language, you could express the emphasis in a different way. Alternate translation: [whenever soldiers came]

See: Hyperbole

2 Samuel 2:23 (#3)

אֲשֶׁר־נָ֥פַל שָׁ֖ם עֲשָׂהאֵ֑ל

“where Asahel fell there”

It might seem that this expression contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [where Asahel fell]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 2:23 (#4)

וַיַּֽעַמְד֖וּ

“that they stood”

See the discussion in the Introduction to the chapter of why the soldiers who came to this place may have **stood** still there.

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 2:24 (#2)

וְהַשֶּׁ֖מֶשׁ בָּ֑אָה

“and the sun was coming in”

The author is using a common expression of his culture to mean that the sun was setting. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and the sun was setting]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 2:24 (#1)

וְהַשֶּׁ֖מֶשׁ בָּ֑אָה וְהֵ֣מָּה בָ֔אוּ עַד־גִּבְעַ֖ת אַמָּֽה

“and the sun was coming in, and they themselves came to the hill of Ammah”

The words that the ULT translates as **and ... and** indicate that Joab and Abishai **came to the hill of Ammah** at the same time as when **the sun was coming in**. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could describe the time relationship more explicitly. Alternate translation: [while the sun was going down, they came to the hill of Ammah]

See: Connect — Simultaneous Time Relationship

2 Samuel 2:24 (#3)

אֲשֶׁר֙ עַל־פְּנֵ֣י גִּ֔יאַ

“which {is} on the face of Giah”

The author is using the term **face** by association to mean that the hill of Ammah was opposite or facing the place called Giah. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [which is opposite Giah]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 2:24 (#4)

דֶּ֖רֶךְ מִדְבַּ֥ר גִּבְעֽוֹן

“the way of the wilderness of Gibeon”

The author is using this possessive form to mean the road that lead to the wilderness of Gibeon. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [on the road that leads to the wilderness of Gibeon]

See: Possession

2 Samuel 2:25 (#1)

בְּנֵ֣י־בִנְיָמִ֔ן

“the sons of Benjamin”

See how you translated the similar expression in 1:18. Alternate translation: [the soldiers from the tribe of Benjamin]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 2:25 (#2)

אַחֲרֵ֖י אַבְנֵֽר

“behind Abner”

The author is speaking as if these soldiers had positioned themselves physically **behind** Abner. He means that they were following Abner as their leader. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [with Abner leading them] or [under the command of Abner]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 2:25 (#3)

עַ֚ל רֹ֣אשׁ־גִּבְעָ֔ה אֶחָֽת

“on the head of one hill”

The author is speaking of this **hill** as if it were a living thing that could have had a **head**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. You could also use plain language, as the UST does. Alternate translation: [on the crown of a hill]

See: Personification

2 Samuel 2:26 (#1)

וַיֹּ֤אמֶר

“and said”

The expression **and said** introduces a direct quotation. In your translation, use a natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language. It may not be necessary to represent this expression explicitly.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

2 Samuel 2:26 (#4)

בָּאַחֲרוֹנָ֑ה

“at the last”

Abner is using the adjective **last** as a noun to mean a certain time. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [in the end]

See: Nominal Adjectives

2 Samuel 2:26 (#6)

אֲחֵיהֶֽם

“their brothers”

Abner is speaking as if his soldiers were the actual **brothers** of Joab’s soldiers. He means they were fellow Israelites. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [their fellow Israelites]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 2:26 (#2)

הֲלָנֶ֤צַח תֹּֽאכַל֙ חֶ֔רֶב וְלֹ֣א יָדַ֔עְתָּה כִּי־מָ֖רָה תִּהְיֶ֑ה בָּאַחֲרוֹנָ֗ה וְעַד־מָתַי֙ לֹ֣א־תֹאמַ֔ר לָעָ֖ם לְשׁ֥וּב מֵאַחֲרֵ֖י אֲחֵיהֶֽם

“Shall the sword devour forever? Do you not know that it will be bitter at the last? So until when will you not say to the people to turn from after their brothers”

Abner is using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [The sword should not devour forever! You must know

that it will be bitter at the last! You should say to the people right away to turn from after their brothers!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 2:26 (#3)

הֲלָנֶ֣צַח תֹּאכַ֣ל חָ֔רֶב

“Shall the sword devour forever”

Abner is speaking of a **sword** as if it were a living thing that could **devour** something. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Are we going to keep killing each other?] or [We should not keep killing each other!]

See: Personification

2 Samuel 2:26 (#5)

לָעָֽם

“to the people”

See how you translated the term **people** in 1:4. Alternate translation: [to your soldiers]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 2:27 (#1)

חַ֥י הָאֱלֹהִ֖ים

“The life of God”

Following the custom of his culture, Joab is swearing an oath by guaranteeing it by something he holds sacred, **The life of God**. Use a natural way in your language to express an oath.

See: Oath Formulas

2 Samuel 2:27 (#2)

לוּלֵ֣א דִבַּ֔רְתָּ כִּֽי־אָ֖ז מֵהַבֹּ֑קֶר נַעֲלָ֥ה הָעָ֖ם

“if you had not spoken, that then from the morning the people would have taken itself up”

Joab is not actually saying that a second event is not going to take place because a first event has not taken place. He does not mean, “If you had not spoken, the people would have taken itself up, but since you have spoken, they are not going to do that.” Instead, he means that this second event would have taken place whether or not the first event had taken place. He is assuring Abner that he too recognizes how destructive war is, and so he would have called off the attack very soon. Be sure that this is clear in your translation. Alternate translation: [even if you had not spoken, by morning the people would still have taken itself up]

See: Connect — Hypothetical Conditions

2 Samuel 2:27 (#4)

אָחִֽיו

“his brother”

See how you translated the similar expression in 2:26. Alternate translation: [his fellow Israelite]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 2:27 (#3)

נַעֲלָ֥ה

“would have taken itself up”

Joab is using a common expression of his culture to mean that his soldiers would have stopped pursuing Abner’s men. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [would have given up its pursuit]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 2:28 (#1)

יִשְׂרָאֵ֑ל

“Israel”

The author is using the name of a nation by association to represent its army. See the discussion of this in the Introduction to 2 Samuel. Alternate translation: [the Israelite soldiers]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 2:31 (#2)

מִבִּנְיָמִ֔ן

“from Benjamin”

The author is using the name of a person by association to represent his descendants, the tribe of Benjamin. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [among the Benjaminites]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 2:31 (#1)

הִכּוּ֙ מִבִּנְיָמִ֔ן וּבְאַנְשֵׁ֖י אַבְנֵ֑ר שְׁלֹ֣שׁ־מֵא֔וֹת וְשִׁשִּׁ֖ים אִ֥ישׁ מֵֽתוּ

“had struck from Benjamin and among the men of Abner 360 men, they had died”

The author seems to add they had died in order to clarify that here the term struck means “killed.” If this seems like extra information that would not be natural

to express in your language, you could shorten it. See the discussion of the term “struck” in the Introduction to 2 Samuel. Alternate translation: [had killed 360 men from Benjamin and among the men of Abner]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 2:32 (#1)

וַיִּשְׂאוּ֙ אֶת־עֲשָׂהאֵ֔ל וַיִּקְבְּרֻ֖הוּ בְּקֶ֣בֶר אָבִ֑יו

“And they took up Asahel, and they buried him in the tomb of his father”

The author is not using the pronoun **they** to refer to specific people. Use a comparable expression that would be natural in your language. Alternate translation: [And Asahel was carried off the battlefield and buried in the tomb of his father]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 2:32 (#3)

וַיֵּאָ֥ר לָהֶ֛ם בְּחֶבְר֖וֹן

“and it became light for them at Hebron”

The author is using the term **it became light** by association to mean that the sky had begun to become light when they reached Hebron. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and they reached Hebron in the early morning]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 2:32 (#2)

וַיִּשְׂאוּ֙ אֶת־עֲשָׂהאֵ֔ל וַיִּקְבְּרֻ֖הוּ בְּקֶ֣בֶר אָבִ֑יו

“And they took up Asahel, and they buried him in the tomb of his father”

Ordinarily, soldiers were buried on the battlefield where they had died, so carrying Asahel’s body more than fifteen kilometers (more than ten miles) to his family tomb in Bethlehem was a symbolic action that showed special honor to him as a great warrior and as the brother of the commanding general, Joab. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action. Alternate translation: [And they respectfully took up Asahel, and they buried him with great honor in the tomb of his father]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel - Chapter 3 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter continues the story of how David became king of Israel. It first lists briefly the sons who were born to David in Hebron while he was still the king only of the tribe of Judah. It then describes how Abner, who had been Saul’s general, turned against Ishbosheth and offered to make David the king of all the Israelite tribes. Abner fulfilled David’s condition of returning his wife Michal to him. But when Abner came to meet with David, David’s general Joab treacherously murdered him. The chapter concludes by describing how David cursed Joab for doing this, how he gave Abner an honorable burial, and how he composed a song to grieve Abner’s death.

Some translations set each line of poetry farther to the right than the rest of the text to make it easier to read. The ULT does this with the poetic song in 3:33–34.

You may choose to present the list of David’s sons in 3:2–5 the way a list would appear in your culture. For example, you might put the title and concluding summary on separate lines and the names of each son on a separate line, like this:

Now sons were born to David in Hebron. And his firstborn was Amnon, to Ahinoam the Jezreelite. And his second was Kileab, to Abigail, the wife of Nabal the Carmelite. And the third was Absalom, the son of Maacah, the daughter of Talmai, the king of Geshur. And the fourth was Adonijah, the son of Haggith. And the fifth was Shephatiah, the son of Abital. And the sixth was Ithream, to Eglah, the wife of David. These were born to David in Hebron.

There are many similar lists later in the historical books of the Bible. Decide as a team how you will present them.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Did Abner have sexual relations with Rizpah?

In 3:7, Ishbosheth accuses Abner of having sexual relations with Rizpah, who had been the concubine of his father Saul. In this culture, it was the duty of a son who succeeded his father as king to protect and care for the women who had been his father’s wives and concubines. If someone else married or had sexual relations with one of these women, that was an implicit assertion of a claim to the throne, as 1 Kings 2:22 illustrates. Since the author says in the previous verse that Abner “was strengthening himself” (becoming powerful) within Ishbosheth’s kingdom, it is possible that he was taking royal prerogatives for himself. However, it is not entirely clear from the text whether

Abner actually did have sexual relations with Rizpah or whether Ishbosheth only suspected him of this. When Abner replies in 3:8, "Yet today you charge against me the iniquity of a woman!" he could either be insisting that he had not done this or that Ishbosheth should not consider that he had done anything disloyal even though he had done this. The author may mean to leave this uncertain, and so we recommend that you do the same in your translation.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

"cut" a covenant
In 3:12, Abner sends messengers to David to say on his behalf, "Cut your covenant with me." The expression "cut" a "covenant" means "make a covenant." The word "cut" is used because in some covenant ceremonies, the participants would cut up animals and then walk between the pieces. This was to indicate, "If I break this covenant, may I be destroyed in this same way." It is not necessary to understand this background to covenant ceremonies in order to understand the action in this chapter, so you do not have to use the term "cut" in your translation. You could simply say "make," or you could use an expression from your own language and culture.

Paltiel
In 3:15, the author uses the name Paltiel for the man to whom Saul gave Michal as a wife when he took her away from David. In 1 Samuel 25:44, the author calls this man Palti. From ancient times, Jewish interpreters have stated that in 2 Samuel 3:15, the author adds the term "el," which means "God," to the end of Palti's name to show that he was a godly man who did not have sexual relations with Michal, since he knew that she was actually David's wife. While the biblical text does not state this explicitly, it is a reasonable explanation of why the author gives this man's name in two different forms. It receives some support, as Jewish tradition also states, from the fact that the place where Paltiel turned back from following Michal became known as Bahurim. That word means "youths," suggesting that Paltiel and Michal had been like unmarried youths in their relationship with each other, or in other words, that they had not had sexual relations. Otherwise, according to Deuteronomy 24:4, it would not have been lawful for David to take Michal back as his wife. Whatever the reason, we recommend that you present this man's name in two different forms in these places in your translation, since that is what the author does.

2 Samuel 3:1 (#1)

וַתְּהִי הַמִּלְחָמָה אֶרֶכָּה בֵּין בֵּית שָׁאוּל וּבֵין בֵּית דָּוִד

"And the war was long between the house of Saul and between the house of David"

The author is using this clause to describe something that was ongoing. This provides the background for other events he will describe that began to happen during this time. Connect this clause to the story in a way that makes it clear in your language that this clause is describing something that was ongoing in the background. Alternate translation: [For a long time after that there was war between the house of Saul and between the house of David.]

See: Connect — Background Information

2 Samuel 3:1 (#2)

וַתְּהִי הַמִּלְחָמָה אֶרֶכָּה בֵּין בֵּית שָׁאוּל וּבֵין בֵּית דָּוִד

"And the war was long between the house of Saul and between the house of David"

In this context, the term **house** refers to the family line of a king, which might include several descendants who were his successors as king. Your language may use this term in the same way, or it may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. You could also use plain language, as the UST does. Alternate translation: [the royal house of Saul ... the royal house of David] or [the dynasty of Saul ... the dynasty of David]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 3:1 (#3)

וְדָוִד הֹלֵךְ וְחָזֵק וּבֵית שָׁאוּל הֹלְכִים וְדַלִּים

"And David was going and strong, but the house of Saul were going and weak"

The phrases **going and strong** and **going and weak** express single ideas. The word **going** indicates that the strength and weakness grew greater over time. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express these meanings in a different way. Alternate translation: [And David kept getting stronger, but the house of Saul kept getting weaker]

See: Hendiadys

2 Samuel 3:1 (#4)

וְדָוִד הֹלֵךְ וְחָזֵק וּבֵית שָׁאוּל הֹלְכִים וְדַלִּים

"And David was going and strong, but the house of Saul were going and weak"

The author is using **David** to represent David and all those who supported him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression

from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And David and his supporters kept getting stronger]

See: Synecdoche

2 Samuel 3:2 (#2)

וילדו לְדָוִד בָּנִים בְּחֶבְרוֹן

“Now sons were born to David in Hebron”

The expression **were born** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Now David’s wives bore him sons]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 3:2 (#1)

וילדו לְדָוִד בָּנִים בְּחֶבְרוֹן

“Now sons were born to David in Hebron”

The author is providing background information to help readers understand what happens later in the story. Three of these sons, **Amnon**, Absalom, and Adonijah, will figure prominently in the narrative. In your translation, introduce this information in a way that would be natural in your own language and culture.

See: Background Information

2 Samuel 3:2 (#3)

וַיְהִי בְכוֹרוֹ

“And his firstborn was”

Your language may have its own term or expression for this relationship. Alternate translation: [And his eldest]

See: Kinship

2 Samuel 3:2 (#4)

לַאֲחִינֹעַם הַיִּזְרְעֵאלִת

“to Ahinoam the Jezreelitess”

The author is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [who was born to Ahinoam the Jezreelitess] or [whose mother was Ahinoam the Jezreelitess]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 3:3 (#1)

וּמִשְׁנֵהוּ & וְהַשְּׁלִשִׁי

“And his second & And the third”

The author is using the adjectives **second** and **third** as nouns to mean certain people. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate these adjectives with equivalent phrases, here and in verses 4 and 5. Alternate translation: [And his second son … And his third son]

See: Nominal Adjectives

2 Samuel 3:3 (#3)

אֵשֶׁת

“the wife of”

See how you translated the similar expression in 2:2. Alternate translation: [the widow of]

See: Kinship

2 Samuel 3:3 (#2)

וּמִשְׁנֵהוּ & וְהַשְּׁלִשִׁי

“And his second & And the third”

Your language may have its own way of showing that someone or something is first, second, third, or fourth in a series. If so, you can use it here and in verses 4 and 5. Alternate translation: [And son number two … And son number three] or [And his next son … And his next son]

See: Ordinal Numbers

2 Samuel 3:5 (#1)

אֵשֶׁת דָּוִד

“the wife of David”

The author expects his readers to understand that this phrase applies to all of the women he lists here, not just to **Eglah**. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. (The author explains in 5:13 that David had concubines in addition to wives. These sons of his wives had rights of inheritance, and so they competed to succeed David as king, as much of the later story relates.) Alternate translation: [All of these women were David’s wives]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 3:5 (#2)

אֵלֶּה יֻלְּדוּ לְדָוִד

“These were born to David”

The expression **were born** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [David's wives bore them to him] or [They bore them to him]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 3:5 (#3)

אֵ֣לֶּה יֻלְּדוּ־ לְדָוִ֗ד בְּחֶבְרוֹן

"These were born to David in Hebron"

Since this statement duplicates information that is already in verse 2, it might seem like extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you might leave it out. However, see the discussion in the Introduction to this chapter of how this statement provides a summary conclusion to the list and of how you might present the whole list in a way that is natural in your language and culture.

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 3:6 (#1)

וַיְהִ֗י

"And it happened"

The author is using the word translated **And it happened** to introduce a new event in the story. Use a word, phrase, or other method in your language that is natural for introducing a new event. Alternate translation: [During this time] or [Meanwhile]

See: Introduction of a New Event

2 Samuel 3:6 (#2)

בֵּ֣ית שָׁא֔וּל & בֵּ֖ית דָּוִֽד

"the house of Saul & the house of David"

See how you translated these expressions in 3:1.

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 3:7 (#3)

מַדּ֣וּעַ בָּ֔אתָה אֶל־פִּילֶ֖גֶשׁ אָבִֽי

"Why have you gone in to the concubine of my father"

Ishbosheth is using the question form to rebuke Abner. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [You should not have gone in to the concubine of my father!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 3:7 (#1)

וּלְשָׁא֖וּל פִּלֶ֣גֶשׁ וּשְׁמָ֑הּ רִצְפָּ֥ה בַת־אַיָּ֖ה

"And a concubine {was} to Saul, and her name {was} Rizpah, the daughter of Aiah"

Here the author is introducing Rizpah as a new participant in the story. Your language may have its own way of introducing new participants that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [Saul had a concubine named Rizpah who was the daughter of Aiah]

See: Introduction of New and Old Participants

2 Samuel 3:7 (#4)

בָּ֖אתָה אֶל

"have you gone in to"

Ishbosheth is referring to sexual relations in a polite way by using the phrase **gone in to**. Depending on what is appropriate in your language, you could use a polite way of referring to this or you could state this plainly. Alternate translation: [slept with]

See: Euphemism

2 Samuel 3:7 (#2)

וַיֹּ֥אמֶר אֶל־אַבְנֵֽר

"And he said to Abner"

The pronoun **he** refers to Ishbosheth. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Then Ishbosheth said to Abner]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 3:8 (#1)

וַיִּחַר־ לְאַבְנֵ֖ר מְאֹ֑ד

"And it burned greatly to Abner"

The author is describing Abner becoming extremely angry by association with the way a person's skin may become hot when he is angry. Your culture may also associate anger with heat, and if so, you could use its characteristic expression in your translation. You could also use plain language. Alternate translation: [And Abner became steaming mad] or [And Abner became extremely angry]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 3:8 (#2)

דִּבְרֵי אִישׁ־בֹּשֶׁת

“the words of Ish Bosheth”

The author is using the term **words** to represent what Ishbosheth said by using words. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [what Ishbosheth had said to him]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 3:8 (#7)

וְלֹא הִמְצִיתִתַּךְ בְּיַד־דָּוִד

“and I have not delivered you into the hand of David”

Here, **hand** represents the capability of a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and I have not delivered you into David’s power] or [and I have not allowed David to overpower you]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 3:8 (#3)

הֲרֹאׁשׁ כֶּלֶב אָנֹכִי֙ אֲשֶׁ֣ר לִיהוּדָ֔הּ

“Am} I the head of a dog that {is} to Judah”

Abner is using one part of a dog, his **head**, to mean an entire dog. He may be doing this to make his statement more elaborate and emphatic. Your language may have its own way of doing this. Alternate translation: [Am I some kind of dog that is to Judah]

See: Synecdoche

2 Samuel 3:8 (#5)

הֲרֹאׁשׁ כֶּלֶב אָנֹכִי֙ אֲשֶׁ֣ר לִיהוּדָ֔הּ

“Am} I the head of a dog that {is} to Judah”

In this culture, people considered wild dogs dirty and regarded them with contempt. Abner is suggesting that the Judeans are contemptible for not supporting Saul’s son as their next king. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [I am not some contemptible Judean!]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 3:8 (#8)

וַתִּפְקְקֵ֥ד עָלַ֛י עֲוֹ֥ן הָאִשָּׁ֖ה

“Yet & you charge against me the iniquity of a woman”

Abner is using this possessive form to mean iniquity committed against a woman. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [you charge me with committing iniquity against a woman]

See: Possession

2 Samuel 3:8 (#4)

הֲרֹאׁשׁ כֶּלֶב אָנֹכִי֙ אֲשֶׁ֣ר לִיהוּדָ֔הּ

“Am} I the head of a dog that {is} to Judah”

Abner is using the question form to express anger and deny that he is worthless. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for those purposes, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [I am not the head of a dog that is to Judah!] or [I am not some kind of dog that is to Judah!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 3:8 (#6)

הַיּ֨וֹם אֲנִ֜י עֹשֶׂ֣ה חֶ֗סֶד עִם־בֵּ֤ית ׀ שָׁא֙וּל אָבִ֣יךָ אֶל־אֶחָ֔יו וְאֶל־מְרֵעֵ֖הוּ

“Today I am doing kindness with the house of Saul your father, to his brothers, and to his friends”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **kindness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [I am treating your father Saul’s descendants, brothers, and friends kindly] or [I am remaining loyal to the house of Saul your father, to his brothers, and to his friends]

See: Abstract Nouns

2 Samuel 3:8 (#9)

וַתִּפְקְקֵ֥ד עָלַ֛י עֲוֹ֥ן הָאִשָּׁ֖ה

“Yet & you charge against me the iniquity of a woman”

See the discussion in the Introduction to this chapter of how, if Abner had actually had sexual relations with Rizpah, that would have been a symbolic action asserting a claim to be the king.

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 3:9 (#1)

Abner swears in this verse that he is going to do something, but he does not describe until the next verse what he is going to do. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could create a verse bridge for

verses 9–10 and have Abner first describe what he is going to do and then swear that he will do it. (That would not change the meaning, only the order of the information.) The UST models one way to do that.

See: Verse Bridges

2 Samuel 3:9 (#4)

כֹּה־יַעֲשֶׂה אֱלֹהִים לְאַבְנֵר וְכֹה יֹסִיף לוֹ

“Thus may God do to Abner, and thus may he add to him”

When Abner says **thus may he add**, he is using a common expression of his culture. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Thus may God do to Abner, and may he do even worse]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 3:9 (#2)

כֹּה־יַעֲשֶׂה אֱלֹהִים לְאַבְנֵר וְכֹה יֹסִיף לוֹ כִּי כַאֲשֶׁר נִשְׁבַּע יְהוָה לְדָוִד כִּי־כֵן אֶעֱשֶׂה־לּוֹ

“Thus may God do to Abner, and thus may he add to him, if, according to what Yahweh has sworn to David, that thus I will do for him”

Following the custom of his culture, Abner is using a conditional statement to swear an oath. What he states as a condition (“if”) is what he is swearing to do. Use a natural way in your language to express an oath. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could put the condition before the consequence. Alternate translation: [I swear that I will do for David according to what Yahweh has sworn to him, and if I do not, then may God do thus to Abner, and thus may he add to him]

See: Oath Formulas

2 Samuel 3:9 (#3)

כֹּה־יַעֲשֶׂה אֱלֹהִים לְאַבְנֵר וְכֹה יֹסִיף לוֹ כִּי כַאֲשֶׁר נִשְׁבַּע יְהוָה לְדָוִד כִּי־כֵן אֶעֱשֶׂה־לּוֹ

“Thus may God do to Abner, and thus may he add to him, if, according to what Yahweh has sworn to David, that thus I will do for him”

Because he is swearing an oath, Abner is speaking about himself solemnly in the third person. If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this in the first person. Alternate translation: [Thus may God do to me, Abner, and thus may he add to me]

See: First, Second or Third Person

2 Samuel 3:9 (#5)

כֹּה־יַעֲשֶׂה אֱלֹהִים לְאַבְנֵר וְכֹה יֹסִיף לוֹ

“Thus may God do to Abner, and thus may he add to him”

The word **Thus**: (1) could refer to what Abner describes in the next verse. Abner could be saying that if he does not take away the privileged position of Saul’s family, then he wants God to take away his privileged position as a powerful leader. The UST models one way to express that meaning. (2) could be a general expression introducing the entire statement as a reference to severe punishment. Alternate translation: [May God punish me, Abner, very severely]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 3:10 (#3)

לְהַעֲבִיר הַמַּמְלָכָה מִבֵּית שָׁאוּל

“to cause the kingdom to pass over from the house of Saul”

Here, Abner is speaking as if the **kingdom** might physically **pass over** from one location to another. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to cause the descendants of Saul no longer to rule as kings]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 3:10 (#4)

וּלְהָקִים אֶת־כִּסֵּא דָוִד

“and to raise up the throne of David”

Abner is speaking as if he would physically **raise up** the **throne** of David to a high position above Israel and Judah. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express his meaning using an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and to establish the rule of David]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 3:10 (#5)

עַל־יִשְׂרָאֵל וְעַל־יְהוּדָה מִדָּן וְעַד־בְּאֵר שָׁבַע

“over Israel and over Judah, from Dan and to Beersheba”

Abner is referring to all of the Israelite territory by naming two extremes, **Dan** (a city in the far north) and **Beersheba** (a city in the far south). If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [over the entire territory of Israel and Judah]

See: Merism

2 Samuel 3:10 (#1)

לְהַעֲבִיר הַמַּמְלָכָה מִבֵּית שָׁאוּל

“to cause the kingdom to pass over from the house of Saul”

See how you translated the similar expression in 1:12. Alternate translation: [to cause the kingdom to pass over from the descendants of Saul]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 3:10 (#2)

לְהַעֲבִיר הַמַּמְלָכָה מִבֵּית שָׁאוּל

“to cause the kingdom to pass over from the house of Saul”

Abner is using the term **kingdom** to mean a king’s rule over the Israelites, not the Israelites themselves over whom he would rule. Alternate translation: [to cause the kingship to pass over from the descendants of Saul]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 3:11 (#1)

וְלֹא־יָכֹל

“And he was not able”

The pronoun **he** refers to Ishbosheth. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [And Ishbosheth was not able]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 3:11 (#2)

עוֹד לְהָשִׁיב & דָּבָר

“to return a further word”

The author is using the term **word** to represent what Ishbosheth might have said by using words. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to say anything further]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 3:12 (#6)

יָדִי עִמָּךְ

“my hand {will be} with you”

In telling David he will be **with** him, Abner is using a common expression of his culture to mean that he will help him. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will support you]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 3:12 (#2)

לְמִי־הָאָרֶץ

“To whom {is} the land”

Abner is using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Abner could mean: (1) that he, not Ishbosheth, actually controls the **land**, so if David makes a covenant **with** him, he can deliver **all of Israel** to David. Alternate translation: [The land is under my control!]; (2) that since Yahweh promised David the kingship, Abner will help him become the king of all of Israel on that basis. Alternate translation: [You are the rightful king of the land!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 3:12 (#5)

יָדִי עִמָּךְ

“my hand {will be} with you”

Abner is using his **hand** to represent himself in the act of accompanying and assisting David. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will be with you]

See: Synecdoche

2 Samuel 3:12 (#1)

לֵאמֹר לְמִי־הָאָרֶץ לֵאמֹר כָּרְתָה בְרִיתְךָ אִתִּי

“saying, “To whom {is} the land?” saying, “Cut your covenant with me”

The term **saying** introduces a direct quotation. In your translation, use a natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language. It may not be necessary to represent this term explicitly. Alternate translation: [saying, “To whom {is} the land? Cut your covenant with me]

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

2 Samuel 3:12 (#4)

וְהִנֵּה

“and behold”

See how you translated the similar expression in 1:12.

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 3:12 (#7)

לְהָסֵב אֵלֶיךָ אֶת־כָּל־יִשְׂרָאֵל

“to make all of Israel turn to you”

Here, Abner is speaking as if he would physically make the Israelites **turn** in a different direction. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to make all the Israelites accept you as their king]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 3:12 (#3)

כָּרְתָה בְרִיתְךָ אִתִּי

“Cut your covenant with me”

Abner is using **Cut your covenant** as a common expression of his culture to mean “make your covenant.” If this phrase would not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Make a covenant with me]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 3:13 (#4)

לֹא־תִרְאֶה אֶת־פָּנַי כִּכְי ׀ אִם־לִפְנֵי הֶבִיאֲךָ אֶת מִיכַל

“You shall not see my face unless you bring Michal & to my face”

If it would appear in your language that David was making a statement and then contradicting it, you could reword this as a positive statement. Alternate translation: [You will only see my face if you bring Michal]

See: Connect — Exception Clauses

2 Samuel 3:13 (#2)

אֲנִי֙ אֶכְרֹ֣ת אִתְּךָ֔ בְּרִ֖ית

“I, I will cut a covenant with you”

David is stating the pronoun **I** separately, even though the verb translated as **I will cut** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that he is making a commitment to Abner. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [I agree to cut a covenant with you]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 3:13 (#5)

לֹא־תִרְאֶה אֶת־פָּנַי & בְּבֹאֲךָ לִרְאוֹת אֶת־פָּנָי

“You shall not see my face & when you come to see my face”

Here, **face** represents personal presence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [You will not come into my presence ... when you come into my presence]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 3:13 (#1)

וַיֹּ֖אמֶר

“And he said”

The pronoun **he** refers to David. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Then David said]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 3:13 (#6)

לִפְנַי

“to my face”

David is using **face** to represent his whole person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [back to me]

See: Synecdoche

2 Samuel 3:13 (#3)

אַ֣חַד דָּבָ֣ר אֶחָ֣ד אָנֹכִי֮ שֹׁאֵ֣ל מֵאִתְּךָ֒ לֵאמֹ֗ר לֹא־תִרְאֶ֤ה אֶת־פָּנַי֙ כִּכְי ׀ אִם־לִפְנֵי֙ הֶבִיאֲךָ֣ אֶת מִיכַ֔ל בַּת־שָׁא֖וּל בְּבֹאֲךָ֑ לִרְאוֹת֙ אֶת־פָּנָ֔י

“Only one thing I am asking from you, saying, ‘You shall not see my face unless you bring Michal, the daughter of Saul, to my face when you come to see my face”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [Only one thing I am asking from you. You will not see my face unless you bring Michal, the daughter of Saul, to my face when you come to see my face.]

See: Quotes within Quotes

2 Samuel 3:15 (#2)

פַּלְטִיאֵל בֶּן־לוּשׁ

“Paltiel, the son of Laish”

Here the author is introducing Paltiel as a new participant in the story. Your language may have its own way of introducing new participants that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [a man named Paltiel who was the son of Laish]

See: Introduction of New and Old Participants

2 Samuel 3:15 (#3)

פַּלְטִיאֵל

“Paltiel”

See the discussion in the Introduction to this chapter of why this man is called **Paltiel** here but Palti when he first appears in the story in 1 Samuel 25:44. We recommend that you use these two different versions of his name in these places in your translation.

See: How to Translate Names

2 Samuel 3:15 (#1)

אִישָׁהּ

“her} husband”

Since David refers to Michal as “my wife” in the previous verse, it may not be appropriate in your language and culture to describe Paltiel as **{her} husband** here. If that is the case, you can use a different expression. Alternate translation: [the man to whom her father Saul had given her]

See: Kinship

2 Samuel 3:16 (#1)

אִישָׁהּ

“her husband”

See how you translated the similar expression in 3:15.

See: Kinship

2 Samuel 3:16 (#2)

הָלוֹךְ וּבָכָה

“going and weeping”

The phrase **going and weeping** expresses a single idea. The word **weeping** tells in what way Paltiel was **going**. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning in a different way. Alternate translation: [going tearfully]

See: Hendiadys

2 Samuel 3:16 (#3)

לֵךְ שׁוּב

“Go, return”

Abner could be using the term **Go** to tell Paltiel: (1) that he must now **return**. **Bahurim** was near the border of Judah, and Abner did not want Paltiel to enter the territory that David was ruling. Alternate translation: [It is time for you to return]; (2) that Paltiel must leave that place, where Michal was, and return to his home without her. Alternate translation: [Leave here and return home]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 3:17 (#3)

גַּם־תְּמוֹלֹל גַּם־שִׁלְשֹׁם

“Both yesterday and the third day”

Abner is using **Both yesterday and the third day** as a common expression of his culture to mean the way things had been previously. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [In the past]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 3:17 (#1)

וּדְבַר־אַבְנֵר הָיָה עִם־זִקְנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל

“Now the word of Abner had been with the elders of Israel”

The author is providing background information to help readers understand what happens next in the story. In your translation, introduce this information in a way that would be natural in your own language and culture. Alternate translation: [Meanwhile, Abner had been speaking with the elders of Israel]

See: Background Information

2 Samuel 3:17 (#2)

וּדְבַר־אַבְנֵר הָיָה עִם־זִקְנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל

“Now the word of Abner had been with the elders of Israel”

The author is using the term **word** to represent what Abner said by using words. If it would be clearer in

your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Now Abner had sent a message to the elders of Israel]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 3:18 (#1)

וְעַתָּה

“And now”

See how you translated the similar expression in 2:6.

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 3:18 (#2)

עֲשׂוּ כִּי־יְהוָה אָמַר אֶל־דָּוִד לֵאמֹר בְּיַד ׀ דָּוִד עַבְדִּי הוֹשִׁיעַ אֶת־עַמִּי יִשְׂרָאֵל מִיַּד פְּלִשְׁתִּים וּמִיַּד כָּל־אוֹיְבֵיהֶם

“do {it}, for Yahweh spoke about David, saying, ‘By the hand of David my servant, I will save my people Israel from the hand of the Philistines and from the hand of all of their enemies”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [since Yahweh spoke about David, saying, ‘By the hand of David my servant, I will save my people Israel from the hand of the Philistines and from the hand of all of their enemies,’ do it]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

2 Samuel 3:18 (#3)

לֵאמֹר בְּיַד ׀ דָּוִד עַבְדִּי הוֹשִׁיעַ אֶת־עַמִּי יִשְׂרָאֵל מִיַּד פְּלִשְׁתִּים וּמִיַּד כָּל־אוֹיְבֵיהֶם

“saying, ‘By the hand of David my servant, I will save my people Israel from the hand of the Philistines and from the hand of all of their enemies”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [saying that by the hand of David his servant he would save his people Israel from the hand of the Philistines and from the hand of all of their enemies]

See: Quotes within Quotes

2 Samuel 3:18 (#4)

בְּיַד ׀ דָּוִד עַבְדִּי

“By the hand of David my servant”

Here, **hand** represents the actions of a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Through the actions of David my servant]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 3:18 (#5)

מִיַּד פְּלִשְׁתִּים וּמִיַּד כָּל־אוֹיְבֵיהֶם

“from the hand of the Philistines and from the hand of all of their enemies”

Here, **hand** represents the power or control of a group. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from the power of the Philistines and from the power of all of their enemies] or [from the control of the Philistines and from the control of all of their enemies]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 3:19 (#3)

יִשְׂרָאֵל

“Israel”

Here, **Israel** represents the people of Israel. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the Israelites]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 3:19 (#4)

כָּל־בֵּית בִּנְיָמִן

“all of the house of Benjamin”

See how you translated the similar expression in 1:12. Alternate translation: [the whole tribe of Benjamin]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 3:19 (#1)

בְּאָזְנֵי בִנְיָמִין & בְּאָזְנֵי דָּוִד

“in the ears of Benjamin & in the ears of David”

The author is using the term **ears** to mean hearing. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in the hearing of Benjamin ... in the hearing of David] or [to Benjamin in person ... to David in person]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 3:19 (#2)

אֵת כָּל־אֲשֶׁר־טוֹב בְּעֵינֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל וּבְעֵינֵי כָּל־בֵּית בִּנְיָמִן

“all that {had been} good in the eyes of Israel and in the eyes of all of the house of Benjamin”

See the discussion of the phrase **good in the eyes of** in the Introduction to this chapter. Alternate translation: [everything that Israel and the house of Benjamin had decided was the right thing to do]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 3:20 (#1)

וְאִתּוֹ עֶשְׂרִים אֲנָשִׁים

“and with him {were} 20 men”

Bringing a round and significant number of men with him was a symbolic action by which Abner showed respect for David. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action. Alternate translation: [and he brought 20 men with him to show respect for David]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 3:21 (#1)

אָקוּמָה

“Let me arise”

See how you translated the similar expression in 2:14. Alternate translation: [Let me take action]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 3:21 (#3)

אֶת־כָּל־יִשְׂרָאֵל

“all of Israel”

Abner says **all of Israel** as an generalization for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [leaders from throughout Israel]

See: Hyperbole

2 Samuel 3:21 (#6)

בְּשָׁלוֹם

“in peace”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **peace**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [peacefully]

See: Abstract Nouns

2 Samuel 3:21 (#2)

אֶל־אֲדֹנִי הַמֶּלֶךְ

“to my lord the king”

Even though Abner is addressing David directly, he is speaking of him in the third person as **my lord the king** to show respect. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a respectful form in the second person. Alternate translation: [to you, my lord the king]

See: First, Second or Third Person

2 Samuel 3:21 (#4)

וְיִכְרְתוּ אִתְּךָ בְּרִית

“so they may cut a covenant with you”

See how you translated the similar expression in 3:12. Alternate translation: [so they may make a covenant with you]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 3:21 (#5)

תְּאַוֶּה נַפְשֶׁךָ

“your soul desires”

Abner is using David’s **soul** to represent all of him as a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you desire]

See: Synecdoche

2 Samuel 3:22 (#2)

וְאַבְנֵר אֵינֶנּוּ עִם־דָּוִד בְּחֶבְרוֹן כִּי שִׁלְּחוֹ וַיֵּלֶךְ בְּשָׁלוֹם

“But Abner, he {was} not with David in Hebron, for he had sent him & and he had gone in peace”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [But since David had sent Abner away and he had gone in peace, he was not with David in Hebron]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

2 Samuel 3:22 (#1)

עַבְדֵי דָוִד וְיוֹאָב

“the servants of David and Joab”

The author is using this possessive form to mean not people who served both David and Joab but people who served David, including Joab. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Joab and other servants of David]

See: Possession

2 Samuel 3:23 (#1)

וַיַּגִּדוּ לְיוֹאָב לֵאמֹר

“and they declared to Joab, saying”

Here the author is using the pronoun **they** in a general sense, not to refer to specific people. Use an expression for this that would be natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and Joab was told]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 3:24 (#1)

מֶה עָשִׂיתָה

“What have you done”

Joab is using the question form to challenge David for letting Abner go. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [You have done something that you should not have done!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 3:24 (#3)

וַיֵּלֶךְ הָלוֹךְ

“and going, he has gone”

Joab is repeating forms of the verb “go” in order to intensify his expression of the idea that it conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [and he has completely gone]

See: Reduplication

2 Samuel 3:24 (#2)

לָמָּה־זֶּה שִׁלַּחְתּוֹ וַיֵּלֶךְ הָלוֹךְ

“Why {is} this, you have sent him away, and going, he has gone”

Joab is using the question form to express his strong disapproval of David letting Abner go. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [There was no good reason to send him away, so that going, he has gone!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 3:25 (#1)

וְלָדַעַת אֶת־מוֹצָאֲךָ וְאֶת־מבואך

“and to know your going out and your coming in”

Joab is speaking of the first and last actions of a military campaign, **going out** and **coming in**, in order to mean military activities as a whole. If you have already translated the book of 1 Samuel, see how you translated the same expression in 1 Samuel 29:6. Alternate translation: [and to find out about how you conduct your military campaigns]

See: Merism

2 Samuel 3:25 (#2)

וְלָדַעַת אֵת כָּל־אֲשֶׁר אַתָּה עֹשֶׂה

“and to know all that you are doing”

Joab speaks in the present tense to David of things **you are doing** in order to describe actions that David has not yet done but that Joab believes he is planning to do. Use the verb form in your language that is natural for referring to planned future actions. Alternate translation: [and to find out everything that you are planning to do]

See: Irregular Use of Tenses

2 Samuel 3:27 (#4)

וַיַּכֵּהוּ שָׁם֩ הַחֹמֶשׁ וַיָּ֨מָת בְּדַם עֲשָׂה־אֵ֜ל אָחִיו

“And he struck him there {in} the stomach, and he died, for the blood of Asahel his brother”

The pronoun **he** refers to Joab, while the pronoun **him** refers to Abner. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [And for the blood of Asahel his brother, Joab struck Abner there in the stomach, and Abner died]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 3:27 (#1)

תּוֹךְ הַשַּׁעַר

“the middle of the gate”

The author assumes that his readers will know that by **the middle of the gate**, he is referring to an area within the city wall between the openings that led out of the city and into the city. You could indicate this

explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. The UST models one way to do that.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 3:27 (#3)

וַיַּכֵּהוּ שָׁם֙ הַחֹ֣מֶשׁ וַיָּ֔מָת בְּדַ֖ם עֲשָׂה־אֵ֥ל אָחִֽיו

“And he struck him there {in} the stomach, and he died, for the blood of Asahel his brother”

If it would be more natural in your language, you may want to put the information about why Joab killed Abner before the information about how he did it. Alternate translation: [And for the blood of Asahel his brother, he struck him there in the stomach, and he died]

See: Information Structure

2 Samuel 3:27 (#5)

בְּדַ֖ם עֲשָׂה־אֵ֥ל אָחִֽיו

“for the blood of Asahel his brother”

Here, **blood** represents the killing of Asahel for which Joab wanted to take revenge. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [to avenge the death of Asahel his brother]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 3:27 (#2)

בַּשָּׁלְוִֽי

“in quiet”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **quiet**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [quietly]

See: Abstract Nouns

2 Samuel 3:28 (#2)

מִדְּמֵ֥י אַבְנֵֽר

“from the blood of Abner”

Here, **blood** represents the killing of Abner. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [regarding the death of Abner]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 3:28 (#1)

וּמַמְלַכְתִּ֔י

“and my kingdom”

The implication is that David is referring not just to his current reign but to the continuing rule of his descendants. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and my royal dynasty]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 3:28 (#3)

מִדְּמֵ֥י אַבְנֵֽר

“from the blood of Abner”

The word **blood** is plural here because it refers to blood shed by violence. Your language may use the plural form of its word for blood to mean the same thing. If not, you could express the meaning in another way. Alternate translation: [of the bloodshed against Abner]

See: Unusual Uses of the Plural

2 Samuel 3:29 (#8)

וְנֹפֵ֥ל בַּחֶ֖רֶב

“or one falling by the sword”

See how you translated the similar expression in 1:12. Alternate translation: [or one dying in battle]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 3:29 (#2)

יְחֻלֻּ֞ו עַל־רֹ֣אשׁ יוֹאָ֗ב וְאֶ֛ל כָּל־בֵּ֥ית אָבִ֖יו

“May it writhe on the head of Joab and to all of the house of his father”

David is using the same common expression here that he used in 1:16, about blood being on someone’s **head**, to mean that a person was morally and legally responsible for something and would be punished for it. Here he uses a more vivid form of the expression and wishes that the blood of Abner would **writhe** on Joab’s head. This represents the sufferings of Joab and his extended family that David describes in the rest of the verse. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [May Joab and all of the house of his father painfully bear the responsibility for it]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 3:29 (#1)

יְחֻלֻּ֞ו עַל־רֹ֣אשׁ יוֹאָ֗ב וְאֶ֛ל כָּל־בֵּ֥ית אָבִ֖יו

“May it writhe on the head of Joab and to all of the house of his father”

The word as **it** refers back to “the blood of Abner” in the previous verse. If you translated “blood” with a plural form there, it may be natural for you to use a plural pronoun here. You could also state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [May Abner’s blood writhe on the head of Joab and to all of the house of his father]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 3:29 (#3)

בְּבֵ֣ית אָבִ֑יו

“the house of his father”

The expression **the house of his father** refers to Joab’s extended family and descendants. Your language may have its own term or expression for such a group of related people. Alternate translation: [his extended family]

See: Kinship

2 Samuel 3:29 (#4)

וְאַל־יִכָּרֵ֤ת מִבֵּית֙ יוֹאָ֔ב

“and may not be cut off from the house of Joab”

The expression **be cut off** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and may not be missing from the house of Joab] or [may there always be in the house of Joab]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 3:29 (#6)

וּמְצֹרָ֑ע

“or one stricken with leprosy”

The expression **stricken with leprosy** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [or a leper]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 3:29 (#7)

וּמַחֲזִ֣יק בַּפֶּ֔לֶךְ

“or one holding onto a staff”

This expression could describe: (1) a person who, because of injury or illness, needs to use a staff to support himself when standing or walking. Alternate translation: [or a lame person]; (2) a man who, because of injury or weakness, cannot do strenuous work or fight in battles and so must do domestic work such as using a distaff (spindle) to wind wool into thread. Alternate translation: [or a weak man]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 3:29 (#9)

וְחַסַר־לָ֖חֶם

“or a destitute of bread”

David is using the adjective **destitute** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [or someone who lacks bread]

See: Nominal Adjectives

2 Samuel 3:29 (#10)

וְחַסַר־לָ֖חֶם

“or a destitute of bread”

David is using **bread** to represent all food or basic necessities. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [or someone who lacks food] or [someone who is desperately poor]

See: Synecdoche

2 Samuel 3:29 (#5)

מִבֵּ֣ית יוֹאָ֔ב

“from the house of Joab”

See how you translated the similar expression in 1:12. Alternate translation: [among the descendants of Joab]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 3:30 (#1)

וְיוֹאָב֙ וַאֲבִישַׁ֣י אָחִ֔יו הָרְג֖וּ לְאַבְנֵ֑ר עַל֙ אֲשֶׁ֣ר הֵמִ֣ית אֶת־עֲשָׂהאֵ֔ל אֲחִיהֶ֖ם בְּגִבְעֹ֥ון בַּמִּלְחָמָֽה

“Now Joab and Abishai his brother had murdered Abner because he had killed Asahel their brother at Gibeon in the battle”

The author is providing background information to help readers understand why David so greatly disap-

proved of what Joab had done. The author is contrasting the way Abner **killed** Asahel in battle (as he described in 2:23) with the way Joab and Abishai **murdered** Abner treacherously under peaceful conditions. If your language has different words for killing and murdering, it would be appropriate to use them here in your translation to show this contrast.

See: Background Information

2 Samuel 3:31 (#5)

הַמִּטָּה

“the bier”

A **bier** is a kind of platform or frame used to carry a dead body to burial. If your readers would not be familiar with what a bier is, you could use the name of a similar thing that your readers would recognize, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [the stretcher carrying Abner’s body]

See: Translate Unknowns

2 Samuel 3:31 (#1)

הָעָם

“the people”

See how you translated the similar expression in 1:4. Alternate translation: [the soldiers]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 3:31 (#2)

קִרְעוּ בִגְדֵיכֶם וְחִגְרוּ שַׂקִּים

“Tear your clothes and put on sackcloth”

Tearing one’s **clothes** and wearing **sackcloth** were symbolic actions that showed intense grief and mourning in ancient Israelite culture. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of these actions in the text or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [show your grief by tearing your clothes and wearing rough cloth]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 3:31 (#3)

וְסִפְדוּ לִפְנֵי אַבְנֵר

“and mourn to the face of Abner”

Here David speaks of **Abner** to mean Abner’s body. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and walk in procession as mourners ahead of Abner’s body]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 3:31 (#4)

וְהַמֶּלֶךְ דָּוִד הֹלֵךְ אַחֲרֵי הַמִּטָּה

“And King David was walking behind the bier”

Here, **walking behind the bier** was a symbolic action by which David showed public respect for Abner and demonstrated that he had not been responsible for Abner’s death. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [King David himself followed the funeral procession to show his respect]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 3:32 (#2)

וַיִּשָּׂא הַמֶּלֶךְ אֶת־קוֹלוֹ וַיֵּבְךְּ

“And the king lifted up his voice and wept”

The phrase **lifted up his voice and wept** expresses a single idea. The words **lifted up his voice** describe in what way David **wept**. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning in a different way. Alternate translation: [And the king wept loudly]

See: Hendiadys

2 Samuel 3:32 (#1)

וַיִּשָּׂא הַמֶּלֶךְ אֶת־קוֹלוֹ וַיֵּבְךְּ

“And the king lifted up his voice and wept”

Here, the author is speaking as if **voice** were an object that could be lifted up. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And the king raised the volume of his voice and wept]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 3:33 (#2)

הַכְּמוֹת נָבָל יָמוּת אַבְנֵר

“Should Abner have died like the death of a fool”

The implication is that Abner died in an unjust and dishonorable way, as if he were a criminal deserving death, when in fact he was not. You could indicate this if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Abner should not have been executed as if he had been a wicked person!]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 3:33 (#1)

הַכְּמוֹת נָבָל יָמוּת אַבְנֵר

“Should Abner have died like the death of a fool”

David is using the question form to emphasize how wrong it was for Abner to have died the way he did. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Abner should not have died like the death of a fool!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 3:34 (#5)

בְּנֵי־עַוְלָה

“sons of wickedness”

See how you translated the similar expression in 2:7. Alternate translation: [wicked men]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 3:34 (#1)

יָדֶיךָ לֹא־אֲסֻרוֹת וְרַגְלֶיךָ לֹא־לְנְחֻשְׁתַּיִם הֻגָּשׁוּ כִּנְפֹל לִפְנֵי בְּנֵי־עַוְלָה נָפָלְתָּ

“Your hands were not bound, and your feet were not put in shackles. As falling to the face of sons of wickedness, you have fallen”

David is speaking to Abner, who is dead and cannot hear him. He is doing this to communicate to the people listening to him that he feels very strongly about how Abner was treacherously murdered. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate these words as if he were speaking directly to the people about Abner. Alternate translation: [His hands were not bound, and his feet were not put in shackles. He died like someone murdered by wicked men]

See: Apostrophe

2 Samuel 3:34 (#2)

יָדֶיךָ לֹא־אֲסֻרוֹת וְרַגְלֶיךָ לֹא־לְנְחֻשְׁתַּיִם הֻגָּשׁוּ

“Your hands were not bound, and your feet were not put in shackles”

Here, bound **hands** and shackled **feet** represent being held as a prisoner. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [You were not being held as a prisoner because you had been convicted of a crime]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 3:34 (#3)

כִּנְפֹל לִפְנֵי בְּנֵי־עַוְלָה נָפָלְתָּ

“As falling to the face of sons of wickedness, you have fallen”

See how you translated the expression similar to **falling** and **fallen** in 1:12. Alternate translation: [As dying to the face of sons of wickedness, you have died]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 3:34 (#4)

כִּנְפֹל לִפְנֵי בְּנֵי־עַוְלָה נָפָלְתָּ

“As falling to the face of sons of wickedness, you have fallen”

See how you translated the expression similar to **to the face of** in 2:17. Alternate translation: [As dying at the hands of sons of wickedness, you have died] or [You died because sons of wickedness killed you]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 3:34 (#6)

וַיֹּסְפוּ & לִבְכּוֹת עָלָיו

“And & added to weep for him”

This could mean: (1) Alternate translation: [wept for him even more]; (2) Alternate translation: [wept for him again]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 3:35 (#2)

וַיָּבֹאוּ כָל־הָעָם

“Then all of the people came”

The author says **all of the people** as a generalization for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [Then the others in attendance came with concern]

See: Hyperbole

2 Samuel 3:35 (#4)

כֹּה יַעֲשֶׂה־לִּי אֱלֹהִים וְכֹה יֹסִיף כִּי אִם־לִפְנֵי בוֹא־הַשֶּׁמֶשׁ אֶטְעַם־לֶחֶם אוֹ כָל־מְאוּמָה

“Thus may God do to me, and thus may he add, that if to the face of the coming in of the sun I taste bread or any of a thing”

See how you translated the similar expression in 3:9. Alternate translation: [If I taste bread or any of a thing

to the face of the coming in of the sun, then may God do thus to me, and thus may he add]

See: Oath Formulas

2 Samuel 3:35 (#9)

לִפְנֵי בוֹא־הַשֶּׁמֶשׁ

“to the face of the coming in of the sun”

David is using **the coming in of the sun** as a common expression of his culture to mean “sunset.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [before the sun goes down] or [before sunset]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 3:35 (#3)

לֶחֶם

“bread”

The author is using **bread** to represent food in general. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [food] or [a meal]

See: Synecdoche

2 Samuel 3:35 (#7)

אִם־לִפְנֵי בוֹא־הַשֶּׁמֶשׁ אֶטְעַם־לֶחֶם אוֹ כָל־מְאוּמָה

“if to the face of the coming in of the sun I taste bread or any of a thing”

David not eating bread or anything else until sunset, not even a small taste, was a symbolic action that showed deep mourning and grief in ancient Israelite culture. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [if I fail to show proper morning by even tasting any food before sunset]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 3:35 (#8)

לִפְנֵי בוֹא־הַשֶּׁמֶשׁ

“to the face of the coming in of the sun”

Here, **face** represents “before.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [before the coming in of the sun]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 3:35 (#1)

וַיָּבֹאוּ כָל־הָעָם לְהַבְרוֹת אֶת־דָּוִד לֶחֶם בְּעוֹד הַיּוֹם

“Then all of the people came to make David eat bread while {it was} still day”

If it would be more natural in your language, you may want to put the information about when this happened before the information about the people coming to David. Alternate translation: [Then, while it was still day, all of the people came to make David eat bread]

See: Information Structure

2 Samuel 3:35 (#5)

כֹּה יַעֲשֶׂה־לִּי אֱלֹהִים וְכֹה יֹסִיף

“Thus may God do to me, and thus may he add”

See how you translated the similar expression in 3:9. Alternate translation: [Thus may God do to me, and may he do even worse]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 3:35 (#6)

כֹּה יַעֲשֶׂה־לִּי אֱלֹהִים וְכֹה יֹסִיף

“Thus may God do to me, and thus may he add”

The word **Thus**: (1) could refer to the way Abner died a violent death. Alternate translation: [May God make me suffer a violent death, as Abner did, and even worse]; (2) could be a general expression introducing the entire statement as a reference to severe punishment. Alternate translation: [May God punish me very severely]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 3:36 (#1)

וְכָל־הָעָם הִכִּירוּ

“And all of the people noticed”

See how you translated the similar expression in 3:35. Alternate translation: [And the others in attendance noticed]

See: Hyperbole

2 Samuel 3:36 (#2)

וַיִּיטַב בְּעֵינֵיהֶם

“and it was good in their eyes”

See how you translated the similar expression in 3:19. Alternate translation: [and they felt that he had done the right thing]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 3:36 (#3)

כְּכֹלֹ֣ אֲשֶׁ֣ר עָשָׂ֣ה הַמֶּ֣לֶךְ בְּעֵינֵ֖י כָּל־הָעָֽם טֽוֹב

“as everything that the king did was good in the eyes of all of the people”

The author says **everything that the king did was good in the eyes of all of the people** as a generalization for emphasis. If it would be clearer in your language, you could express the emphasis in a different way. Alternate translation: [just as the people of Judah generally felt that David, their king, was doing the right things]

See: Hyperbole

2 Samuel 3:38 (#1)

הֲלֹ֥וֹא תֵדְע֖וּ כִּי־שַׂ֣ר וְגָד֑וֹל נָפַ֥ל הַיּ֛וֹם הַזֶּ֖ה בְּיִשְׂרָאֵֽל

“Do you not know that a commander and great has fallen this day in Israel”

David is using the question form for emphasis when he makes a strong statement that his people should recognize Abner’s importance. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [You must appreciate that a commander and great has fallen this day in Israel!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 3:38 (#3)

נָפַ֥ל

“has fallen”

See how you translated the similar expression in 1:12. Alternate translation: [has died]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 3:38 (#4)

הַיּ֛וֹם הַזֶּ֖ה

“this day”

David is using the term **this day** to refer to a specific time. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [at this time]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 3:38 (#2)

שַׂ֣ר וְגָד֑וֹל

“a commander and great”

See how you translated the similar expression in 3:1. Alternate translation: [a great commander]

See: Hendiadys

2 Samuel 3:39 (#1)

וּמְשׁ֣וּחַ מֶ֔לֶךְ

“though anointed king”

The expression **anointed** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [even though Yahweh has anointed me to be the king]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel - Chapter 4 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter continues the story of how David became king of Israel. It describes how two of Ishbosheth’s military commanders, Recab and Baanah, murdered him and brought his head to David at Hebron. They thought that David would reward them for killing Saul’s son, since Saul had tried to kill David. But David instead executed them for committing this murder. This made it clear that David had never wanted to hurt Saul’s family. (David had sworn to Saul in 1 Samuel 24:22 that he would not kill his descendants.)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Why does the author describe the Beerothites fleeing to Gittaim?

In 4:3, the author relates that the Beerothites (that is, the inhabitants of the Gibeonite city of Beeroth) had fled to another city called Gittaim. (The location of that city is now uncertain.) The author provides this as background information to help readers understand what happens next in the story. However, it is not clear why this information is significant. Here is one possibility. In 21:1–2, the author describes how Saul tried to destroy the Gibeonites and seize their land and cities, even though the Israelites had sworn never to harm them. It is possible that the author is describing how some of the Beerothites fled from Saul

to Gittaim. If that is what he is describing, then it may be that the man named Rimmon, whom he mentions in the previous verse, and his family were survivors of Saul's attempted massacre. His sons Baanah and Recab might later have found their way into the service of Ishbosheth as military commanders, but they might still have wanted to get revenge against Saul for killing so many members of their people group. This could be why they murdered his son Ishbosheth. However, the biblical text does not say this specifically, so we recommend that you do not suggest in your translation why the author is providing this background information.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

Why does the author call Baanah and Recab "sons of Benjamin"?
In 4:2, the author introduces two men, Baanah and Recab, whom he says were "from the sons of Benjamin." That phrase would ordinarily indicate that they were descendants of Benjamin, as in the case of the phrase "the sons of Judah" in 1:18. However, as the author states, Baanah and Recab were actually the sons of a Beerothite man named Rimmon. Beeroth was one of four cities in which Gibeonites, members of a different people group, lived among the Israelites. So it is possible that Baanah and Recab were Gibeonites, not Israelites. However, as the author explains, Beeroth was considered to be part of the territory of the tribe of Benjamin, and so the Gibeonite inhabitants of that city were considered to be members of that tribe. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could state this meaning plainly. A note to 4:2 suggests one way to do that.

2 Samuel 4:1 (#1)

וַיִּרְפּוּ יָדָיו

"and his hands dropped"

The author is reporting that Ishbosheth's **hands dropped** in order to indicate that he lost his strength and courage. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and he became weak with fear]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 4:1 (#2)

וְכָל־יִשְׂרָאֵל

"and all of Israel"

See how you translated the similar expression in 2:28. Alternate translation: [and all the people of Israel]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 4:1 (#3)

נִבְהָלוּ

"was terrified"

The expression **was terrified** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [became very afraid]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 4:2 (#3)

כִּֽי־גַם־בְּאֵרוֹת תֵּחָשֵׁב עַל־בִּנְיָמִן

"for Beeroth is also reckoned to Benjamin"

The expression **is reckoned** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [for people also reckon Beeroth to Benjamin]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 4:2 (#1)

וּשְׁנֵי אֲנָשִׁים שָׂרֵי־גְדוּדִים הָיְיוּ בֶּן־שָׁאוּל שֵׁם הָאֶחָד בַּעֲנָה וְשֵׁם הַשֵּׁנִי רֵכָב בְּנֵי רִמּוֹן הַבְּאֵרֹתִי מִבְּנֵי בִנְיָמִן

"Now two men, commanders of troops, were {to} the son of Saul. The name of the one {was} Baanah, and the name of the second {was} Rechab, sons of Rimmon the Beerothite, from the sons of Benjamin"

Here the author is introducing **Baanah and Rechab** as new participants in the story. Your language may have its own way of introducing new participants that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [Among Ishbosheth's officers were two men named Baanah and Rechab. They were sons of Rimmon from the town of Beeroth in the territory of Benjamin]

See: Introduction of New and Old Participants

2 Samuel 4:2 (#2)

בְּנֵי רִמּוֹן הַבְּאֵרֹתִי מִבְּנֵי בִנְיָמִן כִּֽי גַם־בְּאֵרוֹת תֵּחָשֵׁב עַל־בִּנְיָמִן

"sons of Rimmon the Beerothite, from the sons of Benjamin, for Beeroth is also reckoned to Benjamin"

See the discussion of this statement in the Introduction to this chapter. Alternate translation: [While they were the sons of Rimmon the Beerothite, since the city of Beeroth is within the territory of the tribe of Benjamin, they were considered to be members of the tribe of Benjamin]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 4:3 (#2)

עַ֖ד הַיּ֥וֹם הַזֶּֽה

“to this day”

See the discussion of this phrase in the Introduction to 2 Samuel. The author is using this phrase to refer to the time when he was writing. In your translation, make clear that the phrase refers to a time that is already past. Avoid giving the impression the phrase means “to the present day.” Alternate translation: [right up to the time of this writing]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 4:3 (#1)

וַיִּבְרְח֥וּ הַבְּאֵר֖וֹתִים גִּתָּ֑יְמָה וַיָּג֣וּרוּ־שָׁ֔ם גָּרִ֖ים עַ֥ד הַיּ֥וֹם הַזֶּֽה

“But the Beerothites had fled to Gittaim, and they have been sojourning there to this day”

The author is providing background information to help readers understand what happens next in the story. In your translation, introduce this information in a way that would be natural in your own language and culture. See the discussion in the Introduction to this chapter of why the author may provide this information.

See: Background Information

2 Samuel 4:4 (#2)

בְּבֹ֗א שְׁמַעַת֙ שָׁא֣וּל וִיהוֹנָתָ֔ן מִיִּזְרְעֶ֖אל

“when the report of Saul and Jonathan came from Jezreel”

The author is speaking of **the report** as if it were a living thing that could have come from a place. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [when people came from Jezreel and reported about Saul and Jonathan]

See: Personification

2 Samuel 4:4 (#1)

בֶּן־חָמֵ֤שׁ שָׁנִים֙ הָיָ֔ה

“He was a son of five years”

See how you translated the similar expression in 2:10. Alternate translation: [He was five years of age]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 4:5 (#1)

שֹׁכַ֥ב אֵ֖ת מִשְׁכַּ֣ב הַצָּהֳרָֽיִם

“was lying {on} the bed of noon”

The phrase **bed of noon** describes a special bed or couch on which someone would rest or sleep during the midday rest period that was common in this region where the middle of the day would be very hot. If your readers would not be familiar with this custom, you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [was resting during the heat of midday] or [was taking his midday nap]

See: Translate Unknowns

2 Samuel 4:6 (#1)

וְ֠הִנֵּה בָּ֣אוּ עַד־תּ֨וֹךְ הַבַּ֜יִת לֹקְחֵ֣י חִטִּ֗ים וַיַּכֶּ֙הוּ֙ אֶל־הַחֹ֣מֶשׁ וְרֵכָ֔ב וּבַעֲנָ֥ה אָחִ֖יו נִמְלָֽטוּ

“And behold, they came to the midst of the house, takers of wheat, and they struck him in the stomach. And Rechab and Baanah his brother escaped”

Following the conventions of Hebrew storytelling, the author gives a general summary of these events in this verse and then describes them in more specific detail in the next verse. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could create a verse bridge for verses 6–7 and relate these events only once. The UST models one way to do that.

See: Verse Bridges

2 Samuel 4:6 (#2)

וְ֠הִנֵּה

“And behold”

See how you translated the similar expression in 1:12. Alternate translation: [Then suddenly]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 4:8 (#2)

אֶת־נַפְשֶׁ֔ךָ

“your life”

By saying that Saul sought David’s **life**, Rechab and Baanah mean that Saul sought to take his life, that is, to kill him. If it would be helpful in your language, you

could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [to murder you]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 4:8 (#5)

וּמִזַּרְעוֹ

“and against his seed”

The speaker is speaking here of descendants as if they were **seed**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and against his descendants]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 4:8 (#1)

אֹיִבְךָ֙ אֲשֶׁ֣ר בִּקֵּ֔שׁ אֶת־נַפְשֶׁ֖ךָ

“your enemy who sought your life”

Rechab and Baanah are using this phrase to describe Saul, not Ishbosheth. You may be able to use punctuation or some other convention of your language to make this clear.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 4:8 (#3)

לַאדֹנִ֤י הַמֶּ֙לֶךְ֙

“to my lord the king”

One of the sons of Rimmon is addressing David, so he calls him **my** lord, but since he is speaking on behalf of both of them, it may be more natural in your language to use a plural pronoun. Alternate translation: [to our lord the king]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 4:8 (#4)

לַאדֹנִ֤י הַמֶּ֙לֶךְ֙

“to my lord the king”

Even though the sons of Rimmon are addressing David directly, one of them is speaking of him in the third person as **my lord the king** to show respect. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a respectful form in the second person. Alternate translation: [to you, my lord the king] or [to you, our lord the king]

See: First, Second or Third Person

2 Samuel 4:9 (#2)

חַי־יְהוָ֔ה אֲשֶׁר־פָּדָ֖ה אֶת־נַפְשִׁ֑י מִכָּל־צָרָֽה

“The life of Yahweh, who rescued my life from every distress”

Following the custom of his culture, David is swearing an oath by guaranteeing it by something he holds sacred. David is using this oath to swear that what he says in the next verse is true. Use a natural way in your language to express an oath.

See: Oath Formulas

2 Samuel 4:9 (#1)

וַיַּ֨עַן דָּוִ֜ד אֶת־רֵכָ֣ב ׀ וְאֶת־בַּעֲנָ֣ה אֲחִ֗יו בְּנֵי֙ רִמּ֣וֹן הַבְּאֵרֹתִ֔י וַיֹּ֥אמֶר לָהֶ֖ם

“But David answered Rechab and Baanah his brother, the sons of Rimmon the Beerothite, and he said to them”

The expression **and he said to them** introduces a direct quotation. In your translation, use a natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language. It may not be necessary to represent this expression explicitly. Alternate translation: [But David responded to Rechab and Baanah his brother, the sons of Rimmon the Beerothite]

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

2 Samuel 4:10 (#3)

וָאֹחֲזָ֥ה בּ֛וֹ וָאֶהֳרְגֵ֖הוּ

“that I seized him, and I killed him”

See how you translated the similar expression in 1:15. Alternate translation: [that I had one of my soldiers seize him and kill him]

See: Synecdoche

2 Samuel 4:10 (#2)

וְהוּא־הָיָ֤ה כִמְבַשֵּׂר֙ בְּעֵינָ֔יו

“and in his eyes he was like a bringer of {good} news”

See how you translated the similar expression in 3:19. Alternate translation: [and he thought that he was bringing good news]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 4:10 (#4)

אֲשֶׁ֥ר לְתִתִּי־לֹ֖ו בְּשׂרָֽה

“to & which {was} me giving him a reward for good news”

In this figure of speech, David actually means to communicate the opposite of the literal meaning of his words. (By saying that he gave him **a reward for good news**, he means that he killed the messenger for bringing what the messenger wrongly thought was good news.) If a speaker of your language would not say the opposite of what he meant, you could translate the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [which was how I punished him for telling me that he had killed Saul as if that had been good news]

See: Irony

2 Samuel 4:10 (#1)

הַמַּגִּיד֤ לִֽי לֵאמֹר֙ הִנֵּה־מֵ֣ת שָׁא֔וּל

“the one declaring & me, saying, ‘Behold, Saul is dead”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [the one who declared to me that Saul was dead]

See: Quotes within Quotes

2 Samuel 4:11 (#3)

וְעַתָּ֕ה

“And now”

And now was an expression that speakers in this culture commonly used to introduce their main topic. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. You could also use plain language. See how you translated the similar expression in 2:6.

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

2 Samuel 4:11 (#4)

הֲלֹ֗וא אֲבַקֵּ֛שׁ אֶת־דָּמוֹ֙ מִיֶּדְכֶ֔ם וּבִעַרְתִּ֥י אֶתְכֶ֖ם מִן־הָאָֽרֶץ

“shall I not seek his blood from your hand and consume you from the earth”

David is using the question form to emphasize that he will certainly punish Rechab and Baanah for killing Ishbosheth. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [I should certainly seek his blood from your hand and consume you from the earth!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 4:11 (#6)

וּבִעַרְתִּ֥י אֶתְכֶ֖ם מִן־הָאָֽרֶץ

“and consume you from the earth”

Here, David is speaking as if he would **consume** the murderers as fire consumes something completely. This image emphasizes total destruction. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and completely destroy you]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 4:11 (#2)

אַ֗ף

“How much more”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [How much more would I punish rather than reward]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 4:11 (#5)

הֲלֹ֗וא אֲבַקֵּ֛שׁ אֶת־דָּמוֹ֙ מִיֶּדְכֶ֔ם

“shall I not seek his blood from your hand”

David is using **seek his blood from your hand** as a common expression of his culture to mean “punish you for killing him.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [should I not punish you for killing him]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 4:11 (#1)

אַ֗ף

“How much more”

David is using this expression to convey a strong feeling, his conviction that the crime of Rechab and Baanah is much greater than the crime of the person who told him that Saul was dead. There may be an equivalent word or phrase in your language that you can use in your translation to convey this feeling.

See: Exclamations

2 Samuel 4:12 (#1)

וַיִּתְלֻם֙ עַל־הַבְּרֵכָ֣ה בְּחֶבְרֹ֔ון & בְּחֶבְרֹֽון

“and they hung {them} beside the pool in Hebron & in Hebron”

This could mean: (1) that David’s soldiers hung up the **hands** and **feet** of Rechab and Baanah beside the pool. This would have been a symbolic action, exposing to disgrace in a public location the hands that these men had used to murder Ishbosheth and the feet that they had used to flee with his head. By this action, David would have been repudiating their deed and warning others against doing anything similar. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action. Alternate translation: [and they hung their murderous hands and fugitive feet in disgrace beside the pool in Hebron]; (2) that David’s soldiers hung the bodies of Rechab and Baanah beside the pool. This too would have disgraced them as murderers, repudiated their deed, and warned others. However, it would have been a violation of Deuteronomy 21:23, which required the Israelites to bury the body of an executed person on the same day on which he was executed. So this is less likely. Alternate translation: [and they hung their bodies in disgrace beside the pool in Hebron]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel - Chapter 5 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter concludes the story of how David became king of Israel, and it begins the story of what David did as the king of Israel. 5:1–3 The leaders of the Israelite tribes come and anoint David as their king 5:4–5 The author formally reintroduces David as a character in the story in his new role 5:6–10 David captures the fortress in Jerusalem and makes that city his capital 5:11–12 Hiram, the king of Tyre, builds a palace for David 5:13–16 The author lists the further sons David had in Jerusalem 5:17–25 David defeats the invading Philistines

If you chose to present the list of David’s sons in 3:2–5 the way a list would appear in your culture, you should present the list in 5:13–16 in the same way. For example, you might put the title on a separate line and the names of three or four sons on the following lines, like this: And these are the names of the ones born to him in Jerusalem: Shammua and Shobab and Nathan and Solomon and Ibhar and Elishua and Nepheg and Japhia and Elishama and Eliada and Eliphelet.

2 Samuel 5:1 (#1)

כָּל־שִׁבְטֵ֥י יִשְׂרָאֵ֖ל

“all of the tribes of Israel”

The author is speaking of a whole, **all of the tribes of Israel**, to mean a part of that whole, representatives of the tribes who came to David. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [representatives of all of the tribes of Israel]

See: Synecdoche

2 Samuel 5:1 (#3)

עַצְמְךָ֥ וּבְשָׂרְךָ֖ אֲנָֽחְנוּ

“we {are} your bone and your flesh”

Here, **we are your bone and your flesh** was a common expression that the tribal representatives were using to affirm to David that they were related by descent from a common ancestor. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [we are your blood relatives]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 5:1 (#2)

הִנֵּ֥נוּ

“Behold us”

The tribal representatives are using the courteous expression that people in this culture would use to tell a superior that they were ready and willing to obey his orders. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. See how you translated the similar expression in 1:7.

See: Politeness

2 Samuel 5:2 (#3)

אֶת־יִשְׂרָאֵֽל

“Israel”

Here the term **Israel** represents the Israelite soldiers whom David commanded. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the Israelite soldiers]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 5:2 (#1)

גַּם־אֶתְמוֹל גַּם־שִׁלְשׁוֹם

“Both yesterday and the third day”

See how you translated the similar expression in 3:7. Alternate translation: [In the past]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 5:2 (#4)

אַתָּה הייתה & אַתָּה תִרְעֶה & וְאַתָּה תִּהְיֶה

“you, you were & You, you will shepherd & and you, you will become”

The Israelite leaders are stating the pronoun **you** separately, even though the verb translated as **you were** already includes this meaning. They are doing that to emphasize David’s personal role in leading the Israelite army. When Yahweh spoke to David as they describe, he was stating the pronoun **you** separately in both of these instances, even though the verbs translated as **you will shepherd** and **you will become** already included this meaning, to emphasize that he was making promises to David. If speakers of your language would use explicit pronouns for these same purposes, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meanings here. Alternate translation: [you personally were … I promise that you will shepherd … and I promise that you will become]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 5:2 (#5)

וַיֹּ֣אמֶר יְהוָ֗ה לְךָ֤ אַתָּה֙ תִּרְעֶ֣ה אֶת־עַמִּ֔י אֶת־יִשְׂרָאֵ֖ל וְאַתָּ֣ה תִּהְיֶ֑ה לְנָגִ֖יד עַל־יִשְׂרָאֵֽל

“And Yahweh said to you, ‘You, you will shepherd my people Israel, and you, you will become the ruler over Israel”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [And they reminded David that Yahweh had told him that he would shepherd the people of Israel and become their ruler]

See: Quotes within Quotes

2 Samuel 5:2 (#2)

מוציא והמבי אֶת־יִשְׂרָאֵל

“the one bringing out and bringing in Israel”

See how you translated the similar expression in 3:25. Alternate translation: [the one leading Israel on military campaigns]

See: Merism

2 Samuel 5:2 (#6)

אַתָּה תִרְעֶה אֶת־עַמִּי אֶת־יִשְׂרָאֵל וְאַתָּה תִּהְיֶה לְנָגִיד עַל־יִשְׂרָאֵל

“You, you will shepherd my people Israel, and you, you will become the ruler over Israel”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and it would be good to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation rather than combining them. It may be clearer in your language to connect the phrases with a word other than **and** in order to show that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [You yourself will shepherd my people Israel, indeed, you yourself will become the ruler over Israel]

See: Parallelism

2 Samuel 5:2 (#7)

אַתָּה תִרְעֶה אֶת־עַמִּי אֶת־יִשְׂרָאֵל

“You, you will shepherd my people Israel”

Yahweh is speaking here as if David would actually **shepherd** the people of Israel as though they were sheep. This image compares the way a shepherd cares for and guides his sheep to the way a king should care for and lead his people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You yourself will care for and guide my people Israel]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 5:3 (#1)

וַיִּכְרֹ֨ת לָהֶ֤ם׀ הַמֶּ֙לֶךְ דָּוִ֔ד בְּרִ֖ית

“and King David cut for them a covenant”

See how you translated the similar expression in 3:12. Alternate translation: [and King David made a covenant with them]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 5:3 (#2)

לִפְנֵי֙ יְהוָ֔ה

“to the face of Yahweh”

See how you translated the similar expression in 3:13. Alternate translation: [in the presence of Yahweh]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 5:4 (#1)

בֶּן־שְׁלֹשִׁים שָׁנָה דָּוִד בְּמָלְכֹו אַרְבָּעִים שָׁנָה מָלָךְ

“David {was} a son of 30 years when he became king. He reigned 40 years”

Here the author is reintroducing **David** as a participant in the story in his new role as king over all Israel. Your language may have its own way of reintroducing participants in new roles that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [Now David was 30 years old when he began to reign as king, and he ruled for 40 years]

See: Introduction of New and Old Participants

2 Samuel 5:4 (#2)

בֶּן־שְׁלֹשִׁים שָׁנָה דָּוִד

“David {was} a son of 30 years”

See how you translated the similar expression in 2:10. Alternate translation: [David was 30 years old]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 5:6 (#2)

הֶסִירְךָ֣ הַעִוְרִ֔ים וְהַפִּסְחִ֖יםלֵ

“the blind and the lame will turn you away”

The Jebusites say **the blind and the lame will turn you away** as an extreme statement for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [our least capable soldiers will be able to keep you from capturing our city]

See: Hyperbole

2 Samuel 5:6 (#3)

הַעִוְרִ֔ים וְהַפִּסְחִ֖יםלֵ

“the blind and the lame”

The Jebusites are using the adjectives **blind** and **lame** as nouns to mean people who cannot see and people who cannot walk well. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate these adjectives with equivalent phrases. Alternate translation: [people who are blind and people who cannot walk well]

See: Nominal Adjectives

2 Samuel 5:6 (#4)

לֵאמֹ֥רלֵ

“saying”

In this instance, the author is using the term **saying** to introduce what the Jebusites were thinking or saying to themselves. They did not say this out loud to David. In your translation, use a natural way of introducing what people said to themselves or thought. Alternate translation: [thinking to themselves]

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

2 Samuel 5:6 (#1)

אֶל־הַיְבוּסִי יוֹשֵׁ֣ב הָאָ֔רֶץ וַיֹּ֥אמֶר לְדָוִ֖דלֵ

“to the Jebusite, the dweller of the land. And he spoke to David”

The author is not referring to a specific **Jebusites**. He means the Jebusites who lived in this fortified area in Jerusalem. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use expressions that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [to the Jebusites, the inhabitants of that area. And they spoke to David]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

2 Samuel 5:7 (#1)

הִ֥יא עִיר־דָּוִֽדלֵ

“It {is} the City of David”

The author is providing background information to explain to readers that the fortified area that he calls **Zion** is the same area that they know as **the City of David**. In your translation, present this information in a way that would be natural in your own language and culture.

See: Background Information

2 Samuel 5:8 (#3)

שנאו נֶ֥פֶשׁ דָּוִ֖דלֵ

“hated by the soul of David”

The expression **hated by the soul of David** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [whom David’s soul hates]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 5:8 (#9)

הַבָּ֔יִת

“the house”

In this saying, **the house** means the palace where the king lived. You could clarify this if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [the palace]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 5:8 (#1)

יְבֻסִי

“the Jebusite”

David is not referring to a specific **Jebusite**. He means all of the Jebusites who are living in this fortified area of Jerusalem and fighting to keep him out of it. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [these Jebusites]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

2 Samuel 5:8 (#7)

עִוֵּר וּפִסֵּחַ

“The blind and the lame”

The people using this popular saying are not referring to a specific **blind** or **lame** person. They mean blind and lame people in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [A blind person or a lame person]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

2 Samuel 5:8 (#8)

יֹאמְרוּ

“they say”

Here the author is using the pronoun **they** in a general sense, not to refer to specific people. Use an expression for this that would be natural in your language. Alternate translation: [it came to be said] or [it became a saying]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 5:8 (#2)

וְאֶת־הַפִּסְחִים וְאֶת־הָעִוְרִים

“the lame and the blind”

David is using the adjectives **lame** and **blind** as nouns to mean people who cannot walk well and people who cannot see. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate these adjectives with equivalent phrases. Alternate translation: [people who cannot walk well and people who cannot see]

See: Nominal Adjectives

2 Samuel 5:8 (#5)

שנאו נֶפֶשׁ דָּוִד

“hated by the soul of David”

In giving an official command to his soldiers, David is speaking about himself formally in the third person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in the first person. Alternate translation: [whom I hate]

See: First, Second or Third Person

2 Samuel 5:8 (#4)

שנאו נֶפֶשׁ דָּוִד

“hated by the soul of David”

David is using **the soul of David** to represent David himself. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [whom David hates]

See: Synecdoche

2 Samuel 5:8 (#6)

עַל־כֵּן יֹאמְרוּ עִוֵּר וּפִסֵּחַ לֹא יָבוֹא אֶל־הַבָּיִת

“Therefore they say, “The blind and the lame shall not come into the house”

The author is providing the background information that David’s statement that he hated the lame and the blind was the origin of the popular saying that he quotes. In your translation, introduce this information in a way that would be natural in your own language and culture.

See: Background Information

2 Samuel 5:9 (#1)

הַמִּלּוֹא

“the Millo”

The word **Millo** is the name of a place. (It was likely a raised platform or landfill that formed part of Jerusalem’s fortifications.)

See: How to Translate Names

2 Samuel 5:10 (#1)

וַיֵּלֶךְ דָּוִד הָלוֹךְ וְגָדֵל וַיהוָה אֱלֹהֵי צְבָאוֹת עִמּוֹ

“And David went, going and becoming great, for Yahweh, the God of Armies, {was} with him”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [And since Yahweh, the God of Armies, was with him, David went, going and becoming great]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

2 Samuel 5:10 (#3)

עִמּוֹ

“was} with him”

See how you translated the similar expression in 3:12. Alternate translation: [was helping him]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 5:10 (#2)

וַיֵּ֣לֶךְ דָּוִ֗ד הָלֹ֥וךְ וְגָדֹֽול

“And David went, going and becoming great”

The author is using **went, going and becoming great** as a common expression of his culture to mean “kept becoming greater and greater.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And David kept becoming greater and greater]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 5:11 (#1)

וַעֲצֵי֙ אֲרָזִ֔ים

“and trees of cedar”

The author is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and he also sent trees of cedar]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 5:11 (#2)

וַיִּבְנוּ

“And they built”

The pronoun **they** refers to the woodworkers and stonemasons whom Hiram sent. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [And Hiram’s craftsmen built]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 5:12 (#1)

נִשָּׂ֥א מַמְלַכְתֹּ֖ו

“he had lifted up his kingdom”

Here the author is speaking of David’s **kingdom** as if it had been an object that could have been lifted up physically. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he had made his kingdom prosperous and strong]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 5:13 (#1)

וַיִּוָּלְד֥וּ עֹ֛וד לְדָוִ֖ד בָּנִ֣ים וּבָנֹ֑ות

“And again sons and daughters were born to David”

The expression **were born** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [And they bore more sons and daughters to David]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 5:14 (#1)

הַיִּלּ֥וֹדִ֖ים לֹֽו

“the ones born to him”

The expression **born** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the sons he had]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 5:17 (#1)

מָשְׁח֥וּ אֶת־דָּוִ֖ד

“they had anointed David”

Here the author is using the pronoun **they** in a general sense, not to refer to specific people. Use an expression for this that would be natural in your language. Alternate translation: [David had been anointed] or [the leaders of the Israelites had anointed David]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 5:17 (#2)

וַיַּעֲל֥וּ כָל־פְּלִשְׁתִּ֖ים & וַיֵּ֣רֶד

“and all of the Philistines went up & and he went down”

See how you translated the similar expression in 2:1. Alternate translation: [and all of the Philistines went ... and he went]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 5:19 (#1)

הַאֶֽעֱלֶה֙ אֶל־פְּלִשְׁתִּ֔ים & עֲלֵֽה

“Shall I go up to the Philistines & Go up”

In keeping with what is usual in this language and culture, David and Yahweh are marking travel for change in elevation. If these expressions contain extra information that would not be natural to express in your language, you could shorten them. Alternate translation: [Shall I attack the Philistines ... Attack them]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 5:19 (#2)

בְּיָדֶ֑ךָ & בְּיָדֶ֖ךָ

“into my hand & into your hand”

See how you translated the similar expression in 3:8. Alternate translation: [into my power ... into your power]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 5:19 (#3)

עֲלֵ֔ה כִּ֥י־נָתֹ֛ן אֶתֵּ֥ן אֶת־הַפְּלִשְׁתִּ֖ים בְּיָדֶֽךָ

“Go up, for giving, I will give the Philistines into your hand”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Since giving, I will give the Philistines into your hand, go up]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

2 Samuel 5:19 (#4)

נָתֹ֛ן אֶתֵּ֥ן

“giving, I will give”

Yahweh is repeating forms of the verb **give** in order to intensify his expression of the idea that it conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [I will certainly give]

See: Reduplication

2 Samuel 5:20 (#1)

וַיַּכֵּ֥ם & דָּוִ֖ד

“and David struck them”

See the discussion of the term “struck” in the Introduction to 2 Samuel. The meaning of that term here and in verses 24 and 25 is “defeated.” Alternate translation: [and David defeated them]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 5:20 (#2)

לְפָנָ֑י

“to my face”

Here, **face** represents opposing or being in front. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [who were in front of me] or [who were opposing me]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 5:20 (#4)

קָרָ֗א שֵׁם־הַמָּקוֹם֙ הַה֔וּא

“he called the name of that place”

It might seem that the expression **called the name of** contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [he called that place]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 5:20 (#5)

בְּבַעַל־פְּרָצִ֖ים

“to} Baal Perazim”

The name **Baal Perazim** means “the Lord of Breakthroughs.” If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain this in the text of your translation or in a footnote.

See: How to Translate Names

2 Samuel 5:20 (#3)

כְּפֶ֥רֶץ מָ֖יִם

“like the breach of waters”

The point of this comparison is that just as a **breach of waters** is powerful and overwhelming, so was Yahweh’s defeat of David’s enemies. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [as powerfully as a rushing flood]

See: Simile

2 Samuel 5:21 (#2)

וַיִּשָּׂאֵם דָּוִד וַאֲנָשָׁיו

“and David and his men took them away”

Taking away the Philistines’ idols was a symbolic action that illustrated the character of David’s victory over the Philistines and their gods. The Philistines had brought these idols into battle with them in the hopes that the gods they represented would help them defeat David and the Israelites. Instead, the gods themselves were shown to be helpless. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [and David and his men carried off their idols to show how weak and helpless the Philistine gods were compared to Yahweh]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 5:21 (#1)

וַיַּעַזְבוּ

“And they abandoned”

The pronoun **they** refers to the Philistines who were fleeing from David’s army. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [And the Philistines abandoned]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 5:22 (#1)

וַיֹּסְפוּ עוֹד פְּלִשְׁתִּים לַעֲלוֹת

“And the Philistines resumed again to go up”

In keeping with what is usual for his language and culture, the author is marking travel for change in elevation. He is also saying **resumed again**. If these expressions contain extra information that would not be natural to express in your language, you could shorten them. Alternate translation: [And the Philistines invaded again]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 5:23 (#1)

וַיֹּאמֶר

“and he said”

The pronoun **he** refers to Yahweh. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [and Yahweh said]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 5:23 (#2)

לֹא תַעֲלֶה

“You shall not go up”

While David would have had to move to a higher elevation in order to engage the Philistines, in this context, by telling him not to **go up**, Yahweh means that he should not make a direct, frontal attack. If this phrase would not have that meaning in your language in this context, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Do not make a frontal attack]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 5:24 (#2)

בְּמַחֲנֵה פְּלִשְׁתִּים

“the camp of the Philistines”

Here, **camp** represents the army that has camped in a place. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the army of the Philistines]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 5:24 (#1)

לְפָנֶיךָ

“to your face”

Here, **face** represents what is ahead of a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in advance of you]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 5:25 (#1)

מִגֶּבַע

“from Geba”

The Septuagint (an ancient Greek translation of the Hebrew Bible) and the parallel passage in 1 Chroni-

cles 14:16 read “Gibeon” instead of **Geba**. That may have been the original reading, particularly since the location of Gibeon suits the account of this battle better than the location of Geba. At one point in the process of transmission, scribes may have left out the additional letters that would have spelled “Gibeon” rather than “Geba,” either accidentally or as a way of abbreviating. If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to use the reading that it uses. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to use the reading of the ULT.

See: Textual Variants

2 Samuel - Chapter 6 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter continues the story of what David did as the king of Israel. It describes how he brought the Box of Yahweh to Jerusalem and placed it in an honored location in the fortress where he lived, the City of David.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Why did David offer sacrifices after the people carrying the Box had taken six steps?

The author relates in 6:13 that David had the people who were carrying the Box of Yahweh stop after taking six steps so that he could offer sacrifices. Some interpreters believe that this was a symbolic action that alluded to the commandment to work for six days and then observe a day of rest and worship. The parallel passage in 1 Chronicles 15:2–14 tells how David specifically said how important it was for the Israelites to obey Yahweh’s instructions in the law. So this action could have been a symbolic affirmation of that. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action. However, since this interpretation is not entirely certain, you may wish to describe it in general terms. You might say, for example, that “when the lifters of the Box of Yahweh had stepped six steps, David had them pause reverently, and he worshiped Yahweh by sacrificing an ox and a fatling.”

2 Samuel 6:1 (#1)

בָּחוּר

“the chosen”

The author is using the adjective **chosen** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the select warriors] or [the elite troops]

See: Nominal Adjectives

2 Samuel 6:2 (#1)

וַיָּ֣קָם & דָּוִ֔ד

“And David arose”

See how you translated the similar expression in 2:14. Alternate translation: [And David took action]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 6:2 (#3)

לְהַעֲלֹ֖ות

“to bring up”

In keeping with what is usual for his language and culture, the author is marking travel for change in elevation. If this expression contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [to bring]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 6:2 (#4)

אֲשֶׁר־נִקְרָ֥א שֵׁ֛שֶׁם

“whose name is called”

The expression **whose name is called** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [which people call]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 6:2 (#2)

מִבַּעֲלֵ֣י יְהוּדָ֑ה

“from Baalah of Judah”

The parallel passage in 1 Chronicles 13:6 explains that **Baalah** was another name for Kiriath Jearim. That was where the Box had remained since the Philistines returned it after capturing it, according to 1 Samuel 7:2. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain this in the text of your translation or in a footnote.

See: How to Translate Names

2 Samuel 6:3 (#1)

אֲשֶׁ֣ר בַּגִּבְעָ֔ה

“which {was} on the hill”

The author assumes that his readers will know that by **on the hill**, he means a certain hill within the city of Baalah, that is, Kiriath Jearim. Since modern readers would not recognize the identity of this hill, it may be more natural to speak of it in general terms. If you have already translated the book of 1 Samuel, see how you translated the similar expression in 1 Samuel 7:1. Alternate translation: [which was on a hill]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 6:3 (#2)

אֶת־הָעֲגָלָה חֲדָשָׁה

“the new cart”

The author is speaking of the **new cart** to mean the oxen that were pulling the cart. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the oxen that were pulling the new cart]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 6:4 (#3)

לִפְנֵי

“to the face of”

Here, **to the face of** represents “in front of.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in front of]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 6:4 (#1)

וַיִּשָּׂאֻהוּ מִבֵּית אֲבִינָדָב אֲשֶׁר בַּגִּבְעָה

“And they bore it from the house of Abinadab, which {was} on the hill”

The Septuagint (an ancient Greek translation of the Hebrew Bible) and the parallel passage in 1 Chronicles do not have this sentence, which seems to have been repeated accidentally from the previous verse. Without it, the text of verses 3–4 would sensibly read, “And Uzzah and Ahio, the sons of Abinadab, were leading the new cart with the Box of God” (that is, the new cart that had the Box of God on it). Many versions of the Bible do not include this sentence. If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to omit the sentence if it does.

See: Textual Variants

2 Samuel 6:4 (#4)

הָאָרוֹן

“the Box”

Here, **the Box** represents the oxen that were pulling the cart that was carrying the Box. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the oxen that were pulling the cart that was carrying the Box]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 6:4 (#2)

וְאַחְיוֹ הֹלֵךְ לִפְנֵי הָאָרוֹן

“and Ahio was walking to the face of the Box”

The author assumes that his readers will know that Ahio and Uzzah were following the custom of this culture for steadying a load on a cart that animals were pulling. One person would walk ahead of the cart, leading and guiding the animals, while another person would walk next to the cart to make sure that the load did not fall off. By saying that **Ahio was walking to the face of the Box**, he also means that Uzzah was walking alongside the cart that was carrying it, as the story itself indicates in 6:6. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. The UST models one way to do that.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 6:5 (#1)

וְכָל־בֵּית יִשְׂרָאֵל

“and all of the house of Israel”

See how you translated the similar expression in 1:12. Alternate translation: [and all of the people of Israel]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 6:5 (#2)

וְכָל־בֵּית יִשְׂרָאֵל

“and all of the house of Israel”

The author says **and all of the house of Israel** as a generalization for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [and people from throughout Israel]

See: Hyperbole

2 Samuel 6:5 (#3)

לִפְנֵי יְהוָה

“to the face of Yahweh”

Here, **face** represents "presence." If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. See how you translated the similar expression in 3:13. Alternate translation: [in the presence of Yahweh]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 6:5 (#5)

וּבְתֻפִּ֔ים

"and with tambourines"

A **tambourine** is a kind of hand-held drum with metal discs around its frame that jingle when people shake or strike the drum. If your readers would not be familiar with what a tambourine is, you could use the name of a similar instrument that your readers would recognize, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [and with hand drums] or [and with jingling drums]

See: Translate Unknowns

2 Samuel 6:5 (#6)

וּבִמְנַעֲנָעִֽים

"and with sistrums"

A **sistrum** is a kind of musical instrument consisting of a handle and a U-shaped metal frame with loose metal crossbars that jingle when people shake the frame. If your readers would not be familiar with what a sistrum is, you could use the name of a similar instrument that your readers would recognize, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [and with rattles] or [and with shaking instruments]

See: Translate Unknowns

2 Samuel 6:5 (#4)

בְּכֹ֖ל עֲצֵ֣י בְרוֹשִׁ֑ים

"with all woods of cypress"

The expression **all woods of cypress** means various musical instruments made from cypress wood. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [with various musical instruments made from cypress wood]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 6:5 (#7)

וּבְצֶלְצָלִֽים

"and with cymbals"

A **cymbal** is a kind of musical instrument made of two metal discs that people strike together to make a loud, ringing sound. If your readers would not be familiar with what a cymbal is, you could use the name of a similar instrument that your readers would recognize, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [and with clashing metal discs] or [and with metal percussion instruments]

See: Translate Unknowns

2 Samuel 6:6 (#1)

נָכֹ֑ון

"Nacon"

The word **Nacon** is the name of the place where this threshing floor was located.

See: How to Translate Names

2 Samuel 6:6 (#2)

וַיִּשְׁלַ֤ח עֻזָּא֙ אֶל־אֲרֹ֣ון הָאֱלֹהִ֔ים וַיֹּֽאחֶז־בֹּ֖ו כִּֽי־שָׁמְט֥וּ הַבָּקָֽר

"and Uzzah reached out to the Box of God and held it, for the oxen stumbled"

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [and because the oxen stumbled, Uzzah reached out to the Box of God and held it]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

2 Samuel 6:7 (#1)

וַיִּֽחַר־אַ֣ף יְהוָ֔ה

"And the nose of Yahweh burned"

The author is describing Yahweh becoming extremely angry by alluding to the way a person's **nose** may become hot and red when he is angry. Your culture may also associate anger with heat or with a particular part of the body, and if so, you could use its characteristic expression in your translation. You could also use plain language. See how you translated the similar expression in 3:8. Alternate translation: [And Yahweh blazed with fury] or [And Yahweh became extremely angry]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 6:7 (#2)

וַיַּכֵּ֥הוּ & הָאֱלֹהִ֖ים

"and God struck him"

See how you translated the similar expression in 1:1. Alternate translation: [and God killed him]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 6:8 (#2)

וַיִּיָּחַר לְדָוִד

“And it burned to David”

See how you translated the similar expression in 3:8. Alternate translation: [And David became angry]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 6:8 (#4)

פֶּרֶץ עֻזָּה

“Perez Uzzah”

The name **Perez Uzzah** means “Outbreak against Uzzah.” If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain this in the text of your translation or in a footnote.

See: How to Translate Names

2 Samuel 6:8 (#5)

עַד הַיּוֹם הַזֶּה

“to this day”

The author is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and that is still its name to this day]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 6:8 (#1)

וַיִּיָּחַר לְדָוִד עַל־אֲשֶׁר פָּרַץ יְהוָה פֶּרֶץ בְּעֻזָּה

“And it burned to David because Yahweh had broken out an outbreak against Uzzah”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [And because Yahweh had broken out an outbreak against Uzzah, it burned to David]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

2 Samuel 6:8 (#6)

עַד הַיּוֹם הַזֶּה

“to this day”

See how you translated the similar expression in 4:3. Alternate translation: [as of the time of this writing]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 6:8 (#3)

פָּרַץ יְהוָה פֶּרֶץ

“Yahweh had broken out an outbreak”

It might seem that the expression **Yahweh had broken out an outbreak** contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [Yahweh had broken out]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 6:9 (#1)

אֵאֵיךְ יָבוֹא אֵלַי אֲרוֹן יְהוָה

“How shall the Box of Yahweh come to me”

David is using the question form to express his concern about trying bring the Box of Yahweh to where he lives. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [I should not dare to try to bring the Box of Yahweh to me!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 6:10 (#1)

עֹבֵד־אֱדֹם הַגִּתִּי

“Obed Edom the Gittite”

Here the author is introducing **Obed Edom** as a new participant in the story. Your language may have its own way of introducing new participants that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [a certain man named Obed Edom who came from Gath]

See: Introduction of New and Old Participants

2 Samuel 6:11 (#1)

וְאֶת־כָּל־בֵּיתוֹ

“and all of his house”

The author is using the term **house** by association to mean the people who lived in the same house with a man. He means the people in that man’s household. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. See how you translated the

similar expression in 2:3. Alternate translation: [and his entire household]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 6:12 (#1)

וַיֻּגַּד

“And it was declared”

The expression **it was declared** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [And someone declared]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 6:12 (#3)

בְּשִׂמְחָה

“with joy”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **joy**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [joyfully]

See: Abstract Nouns

2 Samuel 6:12 (#2)

וַיַּעַל֙

“and he brought up”

See how you translated the similar expression in 2:1. Alternate translation: [and he brought]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 6:13 (#2)

שִׁשָּׁה צְעָדִים & צָעֲדוּ

“had stepped six steps”

It might seem that the expression **stepped six steps** contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [had taken six steps]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 6:13 (#1)

כִּֽי צָעֲדוּ נֹשְׂאֵי אֲרוֹן־יְהוָה שִׁשָּׁה צְעָדִים וַיִּזְבַּח שׁוֹר וּמְרִיא

“when the carriers of the Box of Yahweh had stepped six steps, that he sacrificed an ox and a fatling”

See the discussion in the Introduction to this chapter of how having the **lifters of the Box** pause after taking **six steps** could have been a symbolic action.

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 6:14 (#3)

וְדָוִד חָגוּר אֵפוֹד בָּד

“And David was girded {with} an ephod of linen”

Wearing **an ephod of linen** was a symbolic action by which David showed he was humbling himself before Yahweh. He was dressing like an ordinary worshiper rather than wearing his royal robes. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [And David had humbly dressed himself in a simple linen garment]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 6:14 (#2)

וְדָוִד חָגוּר אֵפוֹד בָּד

“And David was girded {with} an ephod of linen”

The expression **was girded** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [And David was wearing an ephod of linen]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 6:14 (#1)

לִפְנֵי יְהוָֽה

“to the face of Yahweh”

Here, **face** represents “presence.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in the presence of Yahweh]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 6:15 (#4)

שׁוֹפָר

“the shofar”

The author is not referring to a specific **shofar**. He means shofars in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [shofars]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

2 Samuel 6:15 (#1)

וְכָל־בֵּ֖ית יִשְׂרָאֵ֑ל

“and all of the house of Israel”

See how you translated the similar expression in 1:12. Alternate translation: [and all of the people of Israel]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 6:15 (#2)

וְכָל־בֵּ֖ית יִשְׂרָאֵ֑ל

“and all of the house of Israel”

See how you translated the similar expression in 6:5. Alternate translation: [and people from throughout Israel]

See: Hyperbole

2 Samuel 6:15 (#3)

מַעֲלִ֥ים אֶת־אֲרֹ֖ון יְהוָֽה

“were bringing up the Box of Yahweh”

When the author says **bringing up**, the implication is that David and the Israelites were bringing the Box of Yahweh up the mountain into Jerusalem. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [were bringing the Box of Yahweh up the mountain into Jerusalem]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 6:16 (#1)

וּמִיכַ֣ל בַּת־שָׁא֗וּל

“But Michal, the daughter of Saul”

Here the author is reintroducing Michal into the story as **the daughter of Saul** to remind readers of who she was and to hint at why she might disapprove of David’s actions. If your language has its own way of reintroducing participants with characterizing information, you could use it here in your translation. Alternate translation: [But David’s wife Michal, who was Saul’s daughter]

See: Introduction of New and Old Participants

2 Samuel 6:16 (#2)

וַתִּתְּבֶ֥ז לֹ֖ו בְּלִבָּֽהּ

“and she despised him in her heart”

Here the **heart** represents the feelings. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and she felt great disdain toward him]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 6:18 (#2)

וַיְבָ֥רֶךְ אֶת־הָעָ֖ם בְּשֵׁ֣ם יְהוָ֑ה צְבָאֹֽות

“and he blessed the people in the name of Yahweh of Armies”

To bless people **in the name of Yahweh** was to name Yahweh as the one whom one hoped and believed would bless those people. (The poetic parallel in Psalm 129:8 indicates this. It says, “May the blessing of Yahweh be on you; we bless you in the name of Yahweh.”) Alternate translation: [and he called upon Yahweh of Armies to bless the people]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 6:18 (#1)

הָעֹולָ֖ה

“the burnt offering”

The author is not referring to a specific **burnt offering**. He means burnt offerings in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the burnt offerings]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

2 Samuel 6:19 (#1)

לְכָל־הָעָ֣ם לְכָל־הֲמֹ֣ון יִשְׂרָאֵ֔ל׃

“to all of the people, to all of the multitude of Israel”

The expressions **all of the people** and **all of the multitude of Israel** mean similar things. The author is using the two expressions together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [to all of the Israelites who had gathered there]

See: Doublet

2 Samuel 6:19 (#2)

לְאִ֥ישׁ & אִ֖ישׁ לְבֵיתֹֽו

“to a man & a man to his house”

In these cases, the masculine term **man** has a generic sense that includes both men and women. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use language in your translation that is clearly inclusive of both men

and women. Alternate translation: [to each one ... each one back to his or her home]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

2 Samuel 6:20 (#3)

מַה־נִּכְבַּד הַיּוֹם מֶלֶךְ יִשְׂרָאֵל

“How the king of Israel honored himself today”

In this figure of speech, Michal actually means to communicate the opposite of the literal meaning of her words. If a speaker of your language would not do that, you could translate the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [How the king of Israel disgraced himself today]

See: Irony

2 Samuel 6:20 (#5)

כְּהִגָּלוֹת נִגְלוֹת אַחַד הָרֵקִים

“as uncovering himself, one of the worthless uncovers himself”

Michal is repeating forms of the verb “uncover” in order to intensify her expression of the idea that it conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. Alternate translation: [as one of the worthless shamelessly uncovers himself]

See: Reduplication

2 Samuel 6:20 (#1)

אֶת־בֵּיתָהּ

“his house”

The author is using the term **house** to mean the people who lived in the same house with a man. He means the people in that man’s household. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. See how you translated the similar expression in 2:3. Alternate translation: [his household]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 6:20 (#2)

מַה־נִּכְבַּד הַיּוֹם מֶלֶךְ יִשְׂרָאֵל אֲשֶׁשֶׁר נִגְלָה הַיּוֹם לְעֵינֵי אַמְהוֹת עֲבָדָיו כְּהִגָּלוֹת נִגְלוֹת אַחַד הָרֵקִים

“How the king of Israel honored himself today, who uncovered himself today to the eyes of the female servants of his servants, as uncovering himself, one of the worthless uncovers himself”

Even though Michal is addressing David directly, she is speaking of him in the third person mockingly as **the king of Israel**, as if she were showing respect. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a respectful form in the second person, even though that would still represent mockery on the part of Michal. Alternate translation: [How you, the king of Israel, honored yourself today by uncovering yourself today to the eyes of the female servants of your servants]

See: First, Second or Third Person

2 Samuel 6:20 (#4)

לְעֵינֵי

“to the eyes of”

Here, **eyes** represent seeing. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in the sight of]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 6:20 (#6)

אַחַד הָרֵקִים

“one of the worthless”

Michal is using the adjective **worthless** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [a worthless person]

See: Nominal Adjectives

2 Samuel 6:21 (#1)

לִפְנֵי יְהוָה & לִפְנֵי יְהוָה

“To the face of Yahweh & to the face of Yahweh”

Here, **face** represents “presence.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [In the presence of Yahweh ... in the presence of Yahweh]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 6:21 (#2)

בֵּיתוֹ

“his house”

The author is using the term **house** to mean all the people descended from a particular person. It envisions them as if they were one household living together. Alternate translation: [his descendants]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 6:21 (#3)

עַל־עַ֣ם יְהוָ֔ה עַל־יִשְׂרָאֵ֑ל

“over the people of Yahweh, over Israel”

The terms **over the people of Yahweh** and **over Israel** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [over his people Israel]

See: Doublet

2 Samuel 6:22 (#1)

בְּעֵינָֽי

“in my eyes”

David is using the expression **in the eyes of** to mean “in the judgment of” or “in the opinion of.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in my own regard]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 6:22 (#2)

וְעִם־הָאֲמָהוֹת֙ אֲשֶׁ֣ר אָמַ֔רְתָּ עִמָּ֖ם אִכָּבֵדָֽה

“But with the female servants {about} whom you spoke, with them, I will be honored”

The expression **I will be honored** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [But the female servants about whom you spoke will honor me]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel - Chapter 7 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter continues the story of what David did as the king of Israel. It describes how he wanted to build a temple (a “house”) for Yahweh, but Yahweh told him that he would build a dynasty (a “house”) for David by having his descendants succeed him as king.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

Multiple levels of quotation in Yahweh’s message to Nathan in 7:5–16

Yahweh speaks a message to the prophet Nathan in verses 5–16. Within this message, there are second-level, third-level, and fourth-level quotations. In other words, the entire message is something that Yahweh said and that the author is quoting, so it is a first-level quotation. But within it, Yahweh tells Nathan what he should say, so that is a quotation within a quotation, or a second-level quotation. Yahweh tells Nathan that he should tell David that Yahweh says something, and that is a third-level quotation. Within it, there is a further direct quotation, which is a fourth-level one. Your language may use quotation marks or some other punctuation or convention to indicate various levels of quotation. The ULT models one way to do that. You could also translate the whole message in such a way that there are not quotations within quotations. The UST models one way to do that.

David referring to himself in the third person in 7:19–29

As David responds to the message that Yahweh sent him through the prophet Nathan, he often speaks of himself in the third person as **your servant** to show humility. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a humble form in the first person throughout these verses.

2 Samuel 7:1 (#1)

וַיְהִ֔י

“And it happened”

The author is using the words **And it happened** to introduce a new event in the story. Use a word, phrase, or other method in your language that is natural for introducing a new event.

See: Introduction of a New Event

2 Samuel 7:1 (#2)

וַיהוָ֣ה הֵנִ֤יחַ־לוֹ֙ מִסָּבִ֔יב מִכָּל־אֹיְבָֽיו

“and Yahweh gave rest to him from all around, from all of his enemies”

The author is using a common expression of his culture when he says that Yahweh **gave rest** to David. He means that Yahweh made it so none of the enemy nations around him were at war with him. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and Yahweh had made it so that he was not at war with any of the enemy nations around him]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 7:2 (#2)

בְּבֵ֣ית אֲרָזִ֔ים

“in a house of cedars”

Here, **cedars** represent cedar wood. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in a house built of cedar wood]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 7:2 (#3)

בְּתוֹךְ֙ הַיְרִיעָ֔ה

“in the midst of a curtain”

Israelites characteristically referred to the individual pieces of cloth that they sewed together to make tents as “curtains,” and they referred to an entire tent made from such pieces as a **curtain**. It may be more natural in your language to use a plural form here. Alternate translation: [in the midst of tent-curtains] or [in a tent]

See: Unusual Uses of the Plural

2 Samuel 7:2 (#1)

רְאֵ֣ה

“See”

David is using the term **See** to focus Nathan’s attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [Listen]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 7:2 (#4)

וַאֲרוֹן֙ הָאֱלֹהִ֔ים יֹשֵׁ֖שֶׁב בְּתוֹךְ֙ הַיְרִיעָ֔ה

“but the Box of God is dwelling in the midst of a curtain”

The implication is that David wanted to build a splendid temple for Yahweh and put the Box in it. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [but the Box of God is dwelling in the midst of a curtain. I want to build a splendid temple for Yahweh and put the Box in it]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 7:3 (#3)

לֵ֖ךְ עֲשֵׂ֑ה

“go, do”

Nathan is not telling David to **go** somewhere. He is saying **go** to mean that David should take action. (The meaning is similar to that of the term “arise” in 3:21.) Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. You could also use plain language. Alternate translation: [go ahead and do] or [take action and do]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 7:3 (#1)

כֹּ֚ל אֲשֶׁ֣ר בְּלִבְבְּךָ֔ לֵ֖ךְ עֲשֵׂ֑ה כִּ֥י יְהוָ֖ה עִמָּֽךְ

“All that {is} in your heart, go, do, for Yahweh {is} with you”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Since Yahweh is with you, go, do all that is in your heart]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

2 Samuel 7:3 (#2)

כֹּ֚ל אֲשֶׁ֣ר בְּלִבְבְּךָ֔

“All that {is} in your heart”

Here, the **heart** represents a person’s desires. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [All that you desire to do]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 7:3 (#4)

יְהוָ֖ה עִמָּֽךְ

“Yahweh {is} with you”

See how you translated the similar expression in 3:12. Alternate translation: [Yahweh will help you]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 7:4 (#1)

וַיְהִ֥י

“But it happened”

The author is using the words **But it happened** to introduce a new development in this episode. Use a word, phrase, or other method in your language that is natural for introducing a new development.

See: Introduction of a New Event

2 Samuel 7:4 (#2)

וַיְהִי֙ דְּבַר־יְהוָ֔ה אֶל־נָתָ֖ן

“that the word of Yahweh was to Nathan”

When the author says that **the word of Yahweh was to Nathan**, he is using a common expression to mean that Yahweh spoke a message to Nathan. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [that Yahweh spoke a message to Nathan]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 7:5 (#1)

לֵ֣ךְ וְאָמַרְתָּ֔ אֶל־עַבְדִּ֖י אֶל־דָּוִ֑ד כֹּ֣ה אָמַ֔ר יְהוָ֗ה הַאַתָּ֤ה תִבְנֶה־לִּי֙ בַּ֔יִת לְשִׁבְתִּֽי

“Go, and you shall say to my servant, to David, ‘Thus says Yahweh, “You, will you build for me a house for my dwelling”

See the discussion in the Introduction to this chapter of how you might use punctuation or some other convention of your language to indicate the second-level, third-level, and fourth-level quotations in Yahweh’s message to Nathan in verses 5–16. That discussion also suggests that, alternatively, you could translate these verses in such a way that there are not quotations within quotations. The UST models one way to do that.

See: Quote Markings

2 Samuel 7:5 (#2)

הַאַתָּ֤ה תִבְנֶה־לִּי֙ בַּ֔יִת לְשִׁבְתִּֽי

“You, will you build for me a house for my dwelling”

Yahweh is using the question form for emphasis, to tell David that he will not build a house for him to dwell in. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [You shall not build for me a house for my dwelling.]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 7:5 (#3)

הַאַתָּ֤ה תִבְנֶה־לִּי֙ בַּ֔יִת לְשִׁבְתִּֽי

“You, will you build for me a house for my dwelling”

Yahweh is stating the pronoun **you** separately, even though the verb translated as **will you build** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that David is wanting to do something that he has never asked the Israelites to do for him. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [No, you shall not build a house for my dwelling]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 7:5 (#4)

בַּ֔יִת לְשִׁבְתִּֽי

“a house for my dwelling”

Yahweh is speaking here as if David wants to build him a physical **house** as his **dwelling**. He is actually speaking of a temple where he would be present with his people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [a temple where I will be present]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 7:6 (#3)

לְיוֹם֙ הַעֲלֹתִ֣י

“from the day of my bringing up”

Yahweh is using the term **day** to refer to a specific time. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [since the time when I brought up]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 7:6 (#5)

אֶת־בְּנֵ֥י יִשְׂרָאֵ֖ל

“the sons of Israel”

Here, **sons** means all the people descended from a particular person. It envisions them as if they were one household living together. So **the sons of Israel** figuratively means all the people descended from the patriarch Jacob, who was also known as Israel. Alternate translation: [the people of Israel]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 7:6 (#1)

כִּ֣י

“For”

Here the word **For** provides not a reason but an explanation. Alternate translation: [After all]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

2 Samuel 7:6 (#2)

בְּבַיִת

“in a house”

Here, Yahweh is speaking as if a temple were actually a physical **house** in which he might live. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [a temple]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 7:6 (#6)

וְעַד הַיּוֹם הַזֶּה

“and to this day”

See how you translated the similar expression in 4:3. Alternate translation: [up to this time]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 7:6 (#7)

בְּאֹהֶל וּבְמִשְׁכָּן

“in a tent and in a dwelling”

The phrase **in a tent and in a dwelling** expresses a single idea. The word **dwelling** describes the purpose of the **tent**. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning in a different way. Alternate translation: [in a tent for my dwelling]

See: Hendiadys

2 Samuel 7:6 (#4)

הַעֲלֹתִי

“my bringing up”

In keeping with what is usual for this language and culture, Yahweh is marking travel for change in elevation. If this expression contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [my bringing]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 7:7 (#2)

הֲדָבָר דִּבַּרְתִּי אֶת

“did I speak a word with”

Yahweh is using the term **word** to represent what he might have said by using words. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [did I give a command to]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 7:7 (#3)

אַחַד שִׁבְטֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל

“one of the scepters of Israel”

Here, **scepters** represents “leaders,” since leaders held scepters as an emblem of their office. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [any of the leaders of Israel]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 7:7 (#5)

בֵּבַיִת אֲרָזִים

“a house of cedars”

See how you translated the similar expression in 7:2. Alternate translation: [a temple built from cedar wood]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 7:7 (#4)

לִרְעוֹת

“to shepherd”

Here, Yahweh is speaking as if each of these leaders was a **shepherd** and as if his **people Israel** were sheep. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to guide]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 7:7 (#1)

הֲדָבָר דִּבַּרְתִּי אֶת־אַחַד שִׁבְטֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל אֲשֶׁר צִוִּיתִי לִרְעוֹת
אֶת־עַמִּי אֶת־יִשְׂרָאֵל לֵאמֹר לָמָּה לֹא־בְנִיתֶם לִי בֵּבַיִת אֲרָזִים

“did I speak a word with one of the scepters of Israel whom I commanded to shepherd my people Israel, saying, ‘Why have you not built for me a house of cedars”

Yahweh is using the question form to emphasize that he never asked any of Israel’s leaders to build him a house. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate

translation: [I did not speak a word with one of the scepters of Israel whom I commanded to shepherd my people Israel, saying, 'Why have you not built for me a house of cedars'!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 7:8 (#4)

עַל־עַמִּי עַל־יִשְׂרָאֵל

"over my people, over Israel"

The terms **over my people** and **over Israel** mean similar things. Yahweh is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [over my people Israel]

See: Doublet

2 Samuel 7:8 (#2)

אֲנֹכִי לְקַחְתִּיךָ

"I, I took you"

See how you translated the similar expression "you, you were" in 5:2. Alternate translation: [I personally took you]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 7:8 (#1)

וְעַתָּה

"And now"

See how you translated the similar expression in 2:6.

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 7:8 (#3)

מִן־הַנָּוֶה מֵאַחַר הַצֹּאן

"from the pasture, from after the flock"

Yahweh is referring to the way a shepherd works in a **pasture** and walks behind a **flock** to represent the work of a shepherd generally. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [from being a shepherd]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 7:9 (#1)

וָאֶהְיֶה עִמְּךָ

"And I have been with you"

Yahweh is using **I have been with you** as a common expression of this culture to mean "I have helped you." If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And I have helped you]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 7:9 (#3)

מִפָּנֶיךָ

"from your face"

Here, **from your face** means "in front of you," with the implication that these enemies were confronting David and opposing him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [before you] or [who opposed you]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 7:9 (#2)

וָאַכְרִתָה

"and I have cut off"

Yahweh is speaking as if he had physically **cut off** David's enemies, as if they had been a branch he wanted to remove from a tree. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and I have destroyed]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 7:9 (#5)

הַגְּדֹלִים

"the great"

Yahweh is using the adjective **great** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the great leaders]

See: Nominal Adjectives

2 Samuel 7:9 (#4)

שֵׁשֵׁם גָּדוֹל כְּשֵׁשֵׁם

"a great name, like the name of"

Here, a person's **name** represents his reputation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [a great reputation, like the reputation of]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 7:10 (#4)

וְלֹא יִרְגַּז

“and he will not tremble”

Here, **tremble** represents being afraid. It refers to trembling with fear. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and he will not be afraid]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 7:10 (#6)

כַּאֲשֶׁר בָּרִאשׁוֹנָה

“as at first”

The phrase **at first** refers to an earlier time. If your language would not represent a number in a form such as **first**, you could represent this number in a form that your language would use or in some other way that would be clear in your language. Alternate translation: [as formerly]

See: Ordinal Numbers

2 Samuel 7:10 (#1)

וּנְטַעְתִּיו֙ וְשָׁכַן תַּחְתָּ֔יו וְלֹ֥א יִרְגַּ֖ז & לְעַנּוֹתֹֽתוֹ

“and I will plant him that he may dwell under him, and he will not tremble & to afflict him”

In this verse, the words **him** and **he** are singular in form, but they refer to all the Israelites as a group. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use the plural forms of these words. Alternate translation: [and I will plant them that they may dwell in their place, and they will not tremble ... to afflict them]

See: Collective Nouns

2 Samuel 7:10 (#2)

וּנְטַעְתִּיו֙

“and I will plant him”

Yahweh is speaking here as if he would physically **plant** the Israelites, as if they were a tree or some other plant. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and I will make them secure]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 7:10 (#3)

וְשָׁכַן תַּחְתָּ֔יו

“that he may dwell under him”

Yahweh is using a common expression of this culture that means “that the Israelites may live on the ground that is under them.” Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. You could also use plain language. If you have already translated the book of 1 Samuel, see how you translated the similar expression in 1 Samuel 14:9. Alternate translation: [that the Israelites may live in that place]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 7:10 (#5)

בְּנֵי־עַוְלָה֙

“the sons of wickedness”

See how you translated the similar expression in 3:34. Alternate translation: [wicked people]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 7:10 (#7)

כַּאֲשֶׁר בָּרִאשׁוֹנָה

“as at first”

The expression **at first** refers to the time when Israel was oppressed in Egypt. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [as at the time when you were slaves in Egypt]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 7:11 (#1)

וּלְמִן־הַיּ֗וֹם אֲשֶׁ֤ר

“and from the day when”

Yahweh is using the term **day** to refer to a specific time. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and during the time when]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 7:11 (#2)

וַהֲנִיחֹתִי֙ לְךָ֔ מִכָּל־אֹיְבֶ֖יךָ

“And I will give rest to you from all of your enemies”

See how you translated the similar expression in 7:1. Alternate translation: [And I will make it so that you are not at war with any of your enemies]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 7:11 (#3)

וְהִגִּ֣יד לְךָ֔ יְהוָ֖ה כִּ֣י & יַעֲשֶׂ֑ה & יְהוָ֖ה

“And Yahweh declares to you that Yahweh will make”

In making an official declaration, Yahweh is speaking about himself formally in the third person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in the first person. Alternate translation: [And I, Yahweh, declare to you that I will make]

See: First, Second or Third Person

2 Samuel 7:11 (#4)

בַּ֖יִת

“a house”

See how you translated the similar expression in 3:1. Alternate translation: [a royal dynasty]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 7:12 (#4)

וַהֲקִימֹתִ֤י & אַחֲרֶ֙יךָ֙

“then I will raise up after you”

Yahweh is speaking as if he will physically **raise up** one of David’s descendants to a high location. He means that he will make him become the next king. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [then I will make reign as king after you]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 7:12 (#2)

וְשָׁכַבְתָּ֣ אֶת־אֲבֹתֶ֔יךָ

“and you lie down with your fathers”

Yahweh is referring to death in a polite way by using the phrase **lie down**. Depending on what is helpful in your language, you could use a polite way of referring to this in your language, or you could state this plainly. Alternate translation: [and you pass away as your fathers have] or [and you join your fathers in death]

See: Euphemism

2 Samuel 7:12 (#3)

אֲבֹתֶ֔יךָ

“your fathers”

Yahweh is using the term **fathers** to mean “ancestors.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [your ancestors]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 7:12 (#5)

אֶת־זַרְעֲךָ֖

“your seed”

Yahweh is speaking of David’s descendant as if he were a **seed** and as if David were a plant that had produced it. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [one of your offspring]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 7:12 (#6)

אֲשֶׁ֥ר יֵצֵ֛א מִמֵּעֶ֖יךָ

“who will come forth from your belly”

The implication is that David will be the actual father of this son (that is, he will not be an adopted or foster son), and that this will happen in the future. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [whom you will father in the future]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 7:12 (#1)

כִּֽי־ יִמְלְא֣וּ יָמֶ֔יךָ

“When your days are full”

When your days are full is a common expression of his culture to mean “when you have lived out your life.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [When you have lived out your life]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 7:13 (#1)

הוּא֙ יִבְנֶ֣ה

“He, he will build”

See how you translated the similar expression "you, you will shepherd" in 5:2. Alternate translation: [I promise that he will build]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 7:13 (#2)

בַּיִת

"a house"

Yahweh is speaking as if this descendant of David would build him a physical **house**. He means that he will build him a temple, a special building for worshiping him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [a temple]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 7:13 (#3)

אֶת־כִּסֵּא מַמְלַכְתּוֹ

"the throne of his kingdom"

Here, **throne** represents the authority to rule as king. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [his reign as king]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 7:14 (#2)

בְּשֵׁבֶט אֲנָשִׁים וּבִנְגְעֵי בְּנֵי אָדָם

"with the rod of men and with the blows of the sons of man"

The terms **rod of men** and **blows of the sons of man** mean similar things. Yahweh is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [with human punishments]

See: Doublet

2 Samuel 7:14 (#1)

אֲנִי֙ אֶהְיֶה־לּ֣וֹ לְאָ֔ב וְה֖וּא יִהְיֶה־לִּ֥י לְבֵֽן

"I, I will be a father to him, and he, he will be a son to me"

Yahweh is speaking here as if he and David's descendant would actually be **father** and **son**. He means that he will treat David's descendant the way a father treats a son. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will treat him the way a father treats his son]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 7:14 (#5)

בְּנֵי אָדָם

"the sons of man"

Here the masculine term **sons of man** has a generic sense that includes both men and women. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use language in your translation that is clearly inclusive of both men and women. Alternate translation: [human beings]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

2 Samuel 7:14 (#3)

בְּשֵׁבֶט אֲנָשִׁים וּבִנְגְעֵי בְּנֵי אָדָם

"with the rod of men and with the blows of the sons of man"

Here, **rod** and **blows** represent punishment or discipline. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [with human discipline]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 7:14 (#4)

בְּשֵׁבֶט אֲנָשִׁים וּבִנְגְעֵי בְּנֵי אָדָם

"with the rod of men and with the blows of the sons of man"

This could mean: (1) that Yahweh will discipline David's son with measures of the same type and purpose that humans use to correct their children, not with divine judgments that would destroy him and his descendants. Alternate translation: [with measures such as humans use to correct their children]; (2) that Yahweh will use human beings as his agents to punish David's son. Alternate translation: [I will use people to punish him]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 7:15 (#1)

וְחַסְדִּי֙ לֹא־יָס֣וּר מִמֶּ֔נּוּ

"But my covenant faithfulness will not turn away from you"

Yahweh is speaking of **covenant faithfulness** as if it were a living thing that could **turn away** from someone. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [But I will not stop treating you with covenant faithfulness]

See: Personification

2 Samuel 7:15 (#3)

כַּאֲשֶׁ֣ר הֵסַ֔רְתִּי מֵעִ֖ם שָׁא֑וּל

“as I turned it away from with Saul”

Here, Yahweh is speaking as if he had physically **turned it away** his covenant faithfulness away from Saul. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [as I stopped treating Saul with it]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 7:15 (#2)

מִמֶּֽנּוּ

“from you”

The word **you** is plural here because Yahweh is using it to mean both David and his descendants. So use the plural form in your translation if your language marks that distinction. Other languages may have other ways of making the meaning clear. Alternate translation: [from you and your descendants]

See: Forms of ‘You’ — Singular

2 Samuel 7:15 (#4)

הֵסַ֔רְתִּי מִלְּפָנֶ֖יךָ

“I turned away from your face”

Here, **face** represents the area in front of someone. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [I turned away from in front of you]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 7:15 (#5)

הֵסַ֔רְתִּי מִלְּפָנֶ֖יךָ

“I turned away from your face”

Yahweh is speaking as if Saul had been in front of David, that is, in his way, as David moved toward becoming king. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I removed so that you could be king]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 7:16 (#5)

כִּסְאֲךָ֖ יִהְיֶ֥ה נָכ֖וֹן

“Your throne will be established”

The expression **will be established** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [I will establish your throne]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 7:16 (#7)

יִהְיֶ֥ה נָכ֖וֹן עַד־עוֹלָֽם

“will be established to forever”

This is the end of Yahweh’s message to Nathan. Review your translation of verses 5–16 to ensure that you have consistently used punctuation or some other convention of your language to indicate the second-level, third-level, and fourth-level quotations in this message. Alternatively, you may have decided to translate the entire message in such a way that there are not quotations within quotations. If so, ensure that you have done that consistently.

See: Quote Markings

2 Samuel 7:16 (#2)

וְנֶאֱמַ֥ן בֵּיתְךָ֛ וּמַמְלַכְתְּךָ֖

“And your house and your kingdom will be confirmed”

The expression **will be confirmed** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [And I will confirm your house and your kingdom]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 7:16 (#4)

לְפָנָ֑יךָ

“to your face”

Here, **face** represents what is in front of someone, but in time rather than in space. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [beyond you into the future]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 7:16 (#6)

כִּסְאֲךָ֖

“Your throne”

Here, **throne** represents royal authority or rule. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [The reign of your descendants]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 7:16 (#1)

וְנֶאֱמַן֙ בֵּיתְךָ֣ וּמַמְלַכְתְּךָ֔ עַד־עוֹלָ֖ם לְפָנֶ֑יךָ כִּסְאֲךָ֖ יִהְיֶ֥ה נָכ֖וֹן עַד־עוֹלָֽם

“And your house and your kingdom will be confirmed to forever to your face. Your throne will be established to forever”

The two phrases **your house and your kingdom will be confirmed to forever to your face** and **your throne will be established to forever** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and it would be good to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation rather than combining them. It may be clearer in your language to connect the phrases with a word other than **and** in order to show that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [And your house and your kingdom will be confirmed to forever to your face, yes, your throne will be established to forever]

See: Parallelism

2 Samuel 7:16 (#3)

בֵּיתְךָ֣ וּמַמְלַכְתְּךָ֔

“your house and your kingdom”

The terms **house** and **kingdom** mean similar things. Yahweh is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [your royal dynasty]

See: Doublet

2 Samuel 7:17 (#1)

כְּכֹ֣ל הַדְּבָרִ֣ים הָאֵ֔לֶּה וּכְכֹ֖ל הַחִזָּי֣וֹן הַזֶּ֑ה

“According to all of these words and according to all of this vision”

Together, the terms **words** and **vision** express a single idea. The term **vision** tells how Yahweh conveyed these **words** to David. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning in a different way. Alternate translation: [According to all of these words that Yahweh had spoken to him in a vision]

See: Hendiadys

2 Samuel 7:17 (#2)

כְּכֹ֣ל הַדְּבָרִ֣ים הָאֵ֔לֶּה וּכְכֹ֖ל הַחִזָּי֣וֹן הַזֶּ֑ה

“According to all of these words and according to all of this vision”

Here, **words** represents what Yahweh said by using words. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [According to all of these things that Yahweh had said to him in a vision]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 7:18 (#2)

מִ֣י אָ֤נֹכִי֙ אֲדֹנָ֣י יְהוִ֔ה וּמִ֥י בֵיתִ֖י כִּֽי־הֵבֵאתָ֥נִי עַד־הֵֽלֹם

“Who {am} I, my Lord Yahweh, and what {is} my house, that you have brought me to here”

David is using the question form to express his humility and amazement at what God has done for him. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate these questions as statements or as exclamations. Alternate translation: [I am not so significant, my Lord Yahweh, and neither is my house, that you should have brought me to here!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 7:18 (#3)

בֵּיתִ֥י

“is} my house”

By **my house**, David probably means his “father’s house,” that is, the extended family from which he comes. Alternate translation: [my family]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 7:18 (#4)

כִּֽי־הֵבֵאתָ֥נִי עַד־הֵֽלֹם

“that you have brought me to here”

The implication is that **here** means being the king of Israel. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [that you have made me the king of Israel]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 7:18 (#1)

לִפְנֵי יְהוָה

“to the face of Yahweh”

Here, **face** represents “presence.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in the presence of Yahweh]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 7:19 (#4)

וְזֹאת תּוֹרַת הָאָדָם אֲדֹנָי יְהוִה

“And this {is} the law of man, my Lord Yahweh”

This could mean: (1) that David is marveling that Yahweh has established the perpetual reign of his descendants as a **law** that people must obey. Alternate translation: [And you, my Lord Yahweh, have made the perpetual reign of my descendants a law that people must obey!]; (2) that David is marveling that Yahweh has said that if his descendants do wrong, he will correct them with human-style discipline, not destroy them with divine judgments (verse 14). Alternate translation: [And you, my Lord Yahweh, have said that you will not destroy my descendants if they do wrong but correct them as humans discipline their children!]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 7:19 (#3)

בֵּית־עַבְדֶּךָ

“the house of your servant”

Here, **house** means all the people descended from a particular person. It envisions them as if they were one household living together. So **the house of your servant** figuratively means all the people who would descend from David. Alternate translation: [my descendants]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 7:19 (#1)

וַתְּקַטֹּן עֹוד זֹאת בְּעֵינֶיךָ

“And this was yet small in your eyes”

David is using **this was small in your eyes** as a common expression of his culture to mean “you considered this to be insignificant.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And you considered even this a small thing]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 7:19 (#5)

הָאָדָם

“man”

Here the masculine term **man** has a generic sense that includes both men and women. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use language in your translation that is clearly inclusive of both men and women. Alternate translation: [human beings]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

2 Samuel 7:19 (#2)

בֵּית־עַבְדֶּךָ

“the house of your servant”

David is speaking of himself in the third person as **your servant** to show humility. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a humble form in the first person, here and in the rest of this chapter. Alternate translation: [my house]

See: First, Second or Third Person

2 Samuel 7:20 (#1)

וּמַה־יֹּוסִיף דָּוִד עֹוד לְדַבֵּר אֵלֶיךָ

“And what more shall David add to say to you”

David is using the question form to express that he is too overwhelmed to say anything more. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [I find that I am now at a loss for words!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 7:20 (#2)

וְאַתָּה יָדַעְתָּ אֶת־עַבְדֶּךָ

“But you, you know your servant”

David is stating the pronoun **you** separately, even though the verb translated as **you know** already includes this meaning. He is doing that in order to contrast Yahweh’s knowledge of what he is thinking and feeling with his own inability to say anything further. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the

meaning here. Alternate translation: [But for your part, you know your servant]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 7:20 (#3)

וְאַתָּה יָדַעְתָּ אֶת־עַבְדֶּךָ

“But you, you know your servant”

Here, **your servant** represents what David wants to say. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [But you certainly know what I, your servant, want to say]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 7:21 (#1)

בַּעֲבֻר דְּבָרְךָ

“For the sake of your word”

David is using the term **word** to represent what Yahweh said on some previous occasion by using words. In context, he seems to be referring to how Yahweh instructed Samuel in 1 Samuel 16:12 to anoint him as king. This constituted a commitment on Yahweh’s part to make David the king. The idea here seems to be that in order to keep this promise in the fullest sense, Yahweh is going to make David the head of a royal dynasty. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [In order to keep your promise in the fullest sense]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 7:21 (#4)

לְהוֹדִיעַ אֶת־עַבְדֶּךָ

“to make your servant know {this”

In this context, the verb form **to make … know** does not describe the purpose of the preceding action **you have done all this greatness**. Instead, it describes an accompanying action. Use an appropriate verbal form in your language to convey this meaning. Alternate translation: [and you have made me, your servant, know this]

See: Irregular Use of Tenses

2 Samuel 7:21 (#3)

אֵת כָּל־הַגְּדוּלָּה הַזֹּאת

“all this greatness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **greatness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [all these great things]

See: Abstract Nouns

2 Samuel 7:21 (#2)

וּכְלִבְּךָ

“and according to your heart”

Here, the **heart** represents a person’s desires. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [according to your desire] or [because you wanted to]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 7:22 (#1)

עַל־כֵּן

“Therefore”

David is not saying that the reason why Yahweh is **great** is that he has done the great things for him that he describes in the previous verse. David means that he is able to declare confidently to Yahweh **you are great** because he has personally experienced his greatness and goodness in these ways. If this would not be clear, you may want to use a different connecting word or phrase to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. It may be possible to make the relationship clear without using any connecting word or phrase. The UST models one way to do that. Alternate translation: [As a result, I can confidently declare]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

2 Samuel 7:22 (#3)

אֵין כָּמוֹךָ וְאֵין אֱלֹהִים זוּלָתֶךָ

“there is} none like you and {there is} no God except you”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and it would be good to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation rather than combining them. It may be clearer in your language to connect the phrases with a word other than **and** in order to show that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [no god is like you, indeed, you are the only God]

See: Parallelism

2 Samuel 7:22 (#4)

בְּכֹל֙ אֲשֶׁר־שָׁמַ֣עְנוּ בְאָזְנֵ֔ינוּ

“in all that we have heard with our ears”

It might seem that in this context, the expression **with our ears** contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you could leave it out. Alternate translation: [in all that we have heard]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 7:22 (#2)

כִּ֤י

“for”

Here the word **for** provides not a reason but an explanation. Alternate translation: [and after all]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

2 Samuel 7:23 (#2)

כְּעַמְּךָ֣ כְיִשְׂרָאֵ֔ל

“is} like your people, like Israel”

The terms **like your people** and **like Israel** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [is like your people Israel]

See: Doublet

2 Samuel 7:23 (#10)

מִפְּנֵ֣י

“from the face of”

Here, **from the face of** means “in front of,” with the implication that Yahweh did these fearsome things to defeat the enemies who were confronting the Israelites and opposing them. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in front of] or [against the nations that opposed]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 7:23 (#3)

הָלְכ֥וּ

“went”

See how you translated the similar expression in 7:3. Alternate translation: [took action]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 7:23 (#4)

שֵׁ֑שֶׁם

“a name”

See how you translated the similar expression in 7:9. Alternate translation: [a reputation]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 7:23 (#5)

הַגְּדוּלָּ֔ה

“greatness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **greatness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [great things]

See: Abstract Nouns

2 Samuel 7:23 (#6)

לָכֶ֖ם

“for you”

The word **you** is plural here because it refers to the Israelites, so use the plural form in your translation if your language marks that distinction. Alternate translation: [for you, O Israel] or [for them]

See: Forms of ‘You’ — Singular

2 Samuel 7:23 (#1)

וּמִ֣י כְעַמְּךָ֗ & וֵֽאלֹהָ֔יו

“And who {is} like your people & and its gods”

David is using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [And there is no other nation like your people ... and its gods!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 7:23 (#7)

לָכֶ֖ם

“for you”

David has been addressing Yahweh in his prayer, but now he briefly addresses the nation of Israel (as **you**), even though he knows that the people of this nation cannot hear him. (David has gone to the sacred tent to speak with Yahweh alone, as verse 18 indicates.) He

does this in order to express more powerfully his feelings about the **greatness** (great things) that Yahweh has done for Israel. You may be able to use punctuation or some other convention of your language to show that the addressee changes briefly here. You might also use a first-person plural pronoun to show that by **you** (plural), David is referring to the people group to which he belongs, not to Yahweh, to whom the singular forms of "you" refer in the rest of the verse. Alternate translation: [for us]

See: Aside

2 Samuel 7:23 (#8)

וְנֹרָאוֹת

"and {things} being feared"

The expression **being feared** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and fearsome things]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 7:23 (#9)

לְאַרְצֶךָ

"for your land"

The word **your** is singular here because it refers to Yahweh. So use the singular form in your translation if your language marks that distinction. Alternate translation: [for your land, O Yahweh]

See: Forms of 'You' — Singular

2 Samuel 7:23 (#11)

גּוֹיִם וֵאלֹהָיו

"nations and its gods"

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and from other enemy nations and the gods of each one]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 7:25 (#1)

וְעַתָּה

"And now"

And now was an expression that speakers in this culture commonly used to introduce their main topic. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. You could also use plain language. See how you translated the similar expression in 2:6.

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

2 Samuel 7:25 (#3)

בֵּיתֹו

"his house"

See how you translated the similar expression in 3:1. Alternate translation: [my royal dynasty]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 7:25 (#2)

הַדָּבָר אֲשֶׁר דִּבַּרְתָּ

"the word that you have spoken"

David is using the term **word** to represent what God said by using words. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the things that you have said]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 7:25 (#4)

הָקֵם עַד־עוֹלָם וַעֲשֵׂה כַּאֲשֶׁר דִּבַּרְתָּ

"raise up to forever, and do just as you have spoken"

The phrases **raise up to forever** and **do just as you have spoken** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and it would be good to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation rather than combining them. It may be clearer in your language to connect the phrases with a word other than **and** in order to show that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [raise up to forever, indeed, fulfill what you have promised]

See: Parallelism

2 Samuel 7:25 (#5)

הָקֵם

"raise up"

David is speaking as if Yahweh's **word** were an object that Yahweh could physically **raise up** or lift into a high position. He means that he wants Yahweh to

fulfill the promise that he has made. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. If you have already translated the book of 1 Samuel, see how you translated the similar expressions in 1 Samuel 1:23, 1 Samuel 3:12, and 1 Samuel 15:11. Alternate translation: [perform] or [fulfill]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 7:26 (#1)

שִׁמְךָ

“your name”

Here, **name** represents “reputation.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [your reputation]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 7:26 (#2)

לֵאמֹר יְהוָה צְבָאוֹת אֱלֹהִים עַל־יִשְׂרָאֵל

“saying, ‘Yahweh of Armies {is} God over Israel”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [as people say that you, Yahweh of Armies, are God over Israel]

See: Quotes within Quotes

2 Samuel 7:26 (#3)

לֵאמֹר

“saying”

The term **saying** introduces a direct quotation. In your translation, use a natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language. (In some languages, it may not be necessary to represent this term explicitly.) Alternate translation: [so that people will say]

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

2 Samuel 7:26 (#4)

וּבֵית עַבְדְּךָ דָּוִד יִהְיֶה נָכוֹן

“and the house of your servant David will be established”

The expression **will be established** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and you will establish the house of your servant David]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 7:26 (#5)

וּבֵית

“and the house of”

See how you translated the similar expression in the previous verse. Alternate translation: [and the dynasty of]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 7:26 (#6)

לְפָנֶיךָ

“to your face”

This could mean: (1) that David is using one part of Yahweh, his **face**, to mean all of him in the act of maintaining the rule of David and his descendants. The idea is that Yahweh would be watching them and protecting them. Alternate translation: [as you maintain it]; (2) that David is using Yahweh’s **face** to represent his presence. Alternate translation: [in your presence]

See: Synecdoche

2 Samuel 7:27 (#1)

כִּי

“For”

Here the word **For** provides not a reason but an explanation. Alternate translation: [After all]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

2 Samuel 7:27 (#2)

גָּלִֽיתָה אֶת־אׇזֶן עַבְדְּךָ

“You have uncovered the ear of your servant”

David is using a common expression, **You have uncovered the ear**, that described one person telling something to another person. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You have told this to your servant] or [You have told this to me]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 7:27 (#3)

לֵאמֹר בַּיִת אֶבְנֶה־לָּךְ

“saying, ‘I will build a house for you”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [saying that you will build a house for me]

See: Quotes within Quotes

2 Samuel 7:27 (#4)

מָצָא עַבְדְּךָ אֶת־לִבּוֹ

“your servant has found his heart”

David is using **found his heart** as a common expression of his culture to mean “found courage” or “became brave enough.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [your servant has found the courage] or [I have found the courage]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 7:28 (#2)

אַתָּה־הוּא הָאֱלֹהִים

“you {are} he, God”

The implication is that Yahweh is the only true God. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [you are the only true God]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 7:28 (#4)

אֶת־הַטּוֹבָה הַזֹּאת

“this good”

David is using the adjective **good** as a noun to mean a certain kind of thing. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [this good thing]

See: Nominal Adjectives

2 Samuel 7:28 (#1)

אַתָּה־הוּא הָאֱלֹהִים

“you {are} he, God”

It might seem that the expression **you {are} he, the God** contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [you are God]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 7:28 (#3)

וּדְבָרֶיךָ יִהְיוּ אֱמֶת

“so your words are true”

David is using the term **words** to represent what Yahweh says by using words. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and what you say is true]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 7:29 (#3)

לְפָנֶיךָ

“to your face”

See how you translated the similar expression in 7:26. Alternate translation: [maintained by you] or [in your presence]

See: Synecdoche

2 Samuel 7:29 (#4)

כִּי

“For”

Here the word **For** provides not a reason but an explanation. Alternate translation: [After all]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

2 Samuel 7:29 (#5)

כִּי־אַתָּה אֲדֹנָי יְהוִה דִּבַּרְתָּ

“For you, my Lord Yahweh, you have spoken”

See how you translated the similar expression “you, you were” in 5:2. Alternate translation: [For you, my Lord Yahweh, have told me this personally]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 7:29 (#1)

הוֹאֵל וּבָרֵךְ

“take pleasure and bless”

The phrase **take pleasure and bless** expresses a single idea. The word **take pleasure** tells with what attitude David hopes Yahweh will **bless** him and his descendants. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning in a different

way. Alternate translation: [gladly bless] or [may it please you to bless]

See: Hendiadys

2 Samuel 7:29 (#6)

וּמִבִּרְכָתְךָ֙ יְבֹרַ֣ךְ בֵּית־עַבְדְּךָ֔ לְעוֹלָ֑ם

“and from your blessing the house of your servant will be blessed forever”

The expression **will be blessed** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and you will bless the house of your servant forever with your blessing]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 7:29 (#2)

אֶת־בֵּ֖ית עַבְדֶּ֑ךָ

“the house of your servant”

David is speaking here as if the dynasty Yahweh has promised him would actually be a **house**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the dynasty of your servant] or [my dynasty]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel - Chapter 8 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter continues the story of what David did as the king of Israel. It describes how he defeated the enemy nations that surrounded Israel and took great plunder from them, bringing safety and prosperity to the Israelites. It then gives some details of his government administration.

If you chose to present the lists in 3:2–5 and 5:13–16 as the lists would appear in your culture, you should present the list in 8:15–18 in the same way. For example, you might put verse 15 on a separate line as a summary of David’s government. You might then put the name of each official on a separate line, like this: And David was king over all of Israel. And it happened, David did justice and righteousness for all of his people. Joab, the son of Zeruiah, was over the army Jehoshapat, the son of Ahilud, was the recorder. Zadok, the son of Ahitub, and Ahimelech, the son of Abiathar, were priests Seraiah was the scribe. Benaiah, the son of Jehoiada, was over both the Kerethites and the Pelethites. The sons of David were priests.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Translation Issues in This Chapter

Numbers

There are large numbers in verses 4, 5, and 13. Decide how you will represent large numbers in your translation.

“struck”

In several places in this chapter, the author says that David “struck” an opposing army. He means that David and his army defeated those opponents in battle.

“to restore his hand at the River”

In 8:3, the author says that Hadadezer, the ruler of the Syrian kingdom of Zobah, “went to restore his hand at the River.” Interpreters understand this expression in two main ways. (1) It could mean that Hadadezer led his army against the Israelites in order to ensure that he continued to control his own territory. The kingdom of Zobah lay between the Euphrates River on the east and Israel on the west. Hadadezer may have seen how David had conquered and subdued the Philistines and Moabites, and he may have launched a pre-emptive attack to keep David from conquering him as well. The author may be saying that Hadadezer felt that his authority and control over his territory (his “hand”) had been diminished by David’s military successes against other nations, and so he marched his army out to “restore” it. If you follow this interpretation, you might say in your translation that Hadadezer went out “to reassert his control over his territory, from its border with Israel all the way to the Euphrates River.” (2) The expression could also mean that Hadadezer had built a monument to himself at the Euphrates River, asserting his control over the territory west of the river, and that he led his army out to “restore” the monument in order to reassert that control. The term “hand” means “monument” in 1 Samuel 15:12, and that could also be the meaning here. However, in this interpretation Hadadezer and his army would have been marching away from Israel and would not necessarily have come into conflict with David. The further implication would have to be that David learned of this action by a hostile king to reassert control over his territory, and so he led the Israelite army against him to subdue him. If you follow this interpretation, you might say in your translation that Hadadezer went “to repair his monument at the Euphrates River.”

Textual Issues in This Chapter

Betah

In 8:8, the author refers to a city by the name of **Betah**. However, in the parallel passage in 1 Chronicles

18:8, it is called Tibhath. It appears possible that at some point in the process of transmission, scribes transposed two of the letters in this name. However, this is not certain, and it is not clear which may have been the original form, so we do not recommend that you change the name either here or in 1 Chronicles so that it is the same in both places. Instead, if it would be helpful to your readers, you may wish to note the difference in a footnote.

2 Samuel 8:1 (#4)

מִיַּד פְּלִשְׁתִּים

“from the hand of the Philistines”

Here, **hand** represents possession or control. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from the possession of the Philistines]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 8:1 (#3)

אֶת־מֶתֶג הָאַמָּה

“Metheg Ammah”

The expression **Metheg Ammah** seems to be a description rather than the name of a place. No place is known by that name. The parallel passage in 1 Chronicles 18:1 says that David captured the city of Gath and its surrounding towns. **Metheg Ammah** means “the bridle of the mother city.” Gath was the capital city of the Philistine confederation, and the author may speak of it here as a “bridle” to mean that conquering it gave David the means to control the entire Philistine confederation. (The word “bridle” could also indicate that previously the Philistines had exercised control over the Israelites from their capital city of Gath.) In your translation, you may wish to represent the expression “Metheg Ammah” and spell it the way it sounds in your language. Alternatively, you could express the probable meaning and translate the expression as a reference to Gath. If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to take the approach that it takes. Alternate translation: [Gath, their capital city]

See: How to Translate Names

2 Samuel 8:1 (#2)

דָּוִד

“David”

Here and frequently in this chapter, the author uses **David**, one person who was involved in these actions, to represent everyone who was involved. See how you translated the similar expression in 3:1, where “David” means “David and his supporters.” Alternate translation: [David and his army]

See: Synecdoche

2 Samuel 8:1 (#1)

וַיַּךְ דָּוִד אֶת־פְּלִשְׁתִּים

“that David struck the Philistines”

See how you translated the similar expression in 2:17. Alternate translation: [that David defeated the Philistines]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 8:2 (#4)

אֶת־מוֹאָב

“Moab”

In this verse, the word **Moab** is singular in form, but it refers to all the Moabite people as a group. If it would be helpful in your language, you could refer to these people by using a plural form. Alternate translation: [the Moabites]

See: Collective Nouns

2 Samuel 8:2 (#1)

וַיְמַדְּדֵם בַּחֶבֶל֙ הַשְׁכֵּ֣ב אוֹתָ֔ם אַ֖רְצָה

“and he measured them with a rope, making them lie on the ground”

The author is describing one event, David measuring these enemy soldiers **with a rope**, before describing another event that preceded it, David **making them lie on the ground**. If it would be helpful your language, you may wish to relate these events in the order in which they happened, as in the UST. Alternate translation: [and he made them lie on the ground and measured them with a rope]

See: Order of Events

2 Samuel 8:2 (#2)

וַיְמַדְּדֵם

“and he measured them”

The pronoun **them** refers to the Moabite soldiers. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the Moabite soldiers]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 8:2 (#3)

וַיְמַדֵּד שְׁנֵי־חֲבָלִים֙ לְהָמִ֣ית וּמְלֹ֔א הַחֶ֖בֶל לְהַחֲיֹ֑ות

“And he measured two ropes to kill and the fullness of the rope to let live”

The implication is that David used a rope divided into three equal parts to measure groups of Moabite soldiers. He killed those who were lying under the first two parts but let those under the third part live. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [He used a rope divided into three equal parts. He stretched it out and killed the soldiers lying under the first two parts, but he let the soldiers lying under the rest of the rope live]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 8:2 (#5)

נֹשְׂאֵי מִנְחָה

“lifters of tribute”

The author is using the first thing that subject peoples would do to deliver tribute, lift it onto the backs of animals that would transport it, to represent the entire action of paying tribute. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [bringers of tribute] or [vassals]

See: Synecdoche

2 Samuel 8:3 (#1)

בְּלֶכְתּ֖וֹ

“when he went”

The pronoun **he** refers to Hadadezer. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [when Hadadezer went]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 8:3 (#2)

לְהָשִׁ֥יב יָדֹ֛ו בְּנָהַ֖ר

“to establish his hand at the River”

See the Introduction to this chapter for a discussion of this phrase and for suggestions of how you might represent it in your translation.

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 8:3 (#3)

בְּנָהַר

“at the River”

The author is referring to the Euphrates River, which was the most important river in this region and so was sometimes simply called **the River**. You could use your language’s name for this river if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [at the Euphrates River]

See: How to Translate Names

2 Samuel 8:4 (#3)

וַיְעַקֵּ֣ר דָּוִד֮ אֶת־כָּל־הָרֶ֣כֶב וַיּוֹתֵ֣ר מִמֶּ֔נּוּ מֵאָ֥ה רָכֶֽב

“And David hamstrung all of the chariots, but he left from them 100 chariots”

If, in your language, it would appear that the author was making a statement here and then contradicting it, you could reverse the order of the clauses so that the exception is stated first and then the larger group is named second. Alternate translation: [And after choosing 100 horses from the chariots, David had his soldiers hamstring the rest]

See: Connect — Exception Clauses

2 Samuel 8:4 (#1)

אֶ֚לֶף וּשְׁבַ֣ע־מֵא֔וֹת פָּרָשִׁ֖ים

“1,700 horsemen”

The Septuagint (an ancient Greek translation of the Hebrew Bible) and the parallel passage in 1 Chronicles 18:4 read “1,000 chariots and 7,000 horsemen.” That may have been the original reading. At one point in the process of transmission, scribes may have accidentally left out the word “chariots,” and the letters or points that indicated numbers may also have been unintentionally altered. If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to use the reading that it uses. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to use the reading of the ULT.

See: Textual Variants

2 Samuel 8:4 (#2)

וַיְעַקֵּ֣ר דָּוִד֮ אֶת־כָּל־הָרֶ֣כֶב וַיּוֹתֵ֣ר מִמֶּ֔נּוּ מֵאָ֥ה רָכֶֽב

“And David hamstrung all of the chariots, but he left from them 100 chariots”

Here the term **chariots** represents the horses that pulled these chariots. If it would be helpful in your

language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [And David hamstrung all of the chariot horses, but he left from them 100 horses]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 8:4 (#4)

וַיְעַקֵּר דָּוִד֙ אֶת־כָּל־הָרֶ֔כֶב

“And David hamstrung all of the chariots”

When the author says that David **hamstrung** these horses, he meant that he had his soldiers use a method of disabling them by cutting tendons in their legs. This would be done carefully so that horses would still be able to walk and carry loads, but they would no longer be able to run. As a result, they could no longer be used in warfare. If your readers would not be familiar with what hamstringing is, you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [And David had his soldiers disable all of the chariot horses by cutting their leg tendons]

See: Translate Unknowns

2 Samuel 8:5 (#1)

אֲרַ֣ם דַּמֶּ֔שֶׂק

“Aram of Damascus”

Here, **Aram of Damascus** represents the army of the Aramean kingdom whose capital was Damascus. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the army of the Aramean kingdom whose capital was Damascus]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 8:6 (#2)

וַיּ֤וֹשַׁע יְהוָה֙ אֶת־דָּוִ֔ד בְּכֹ֖ל אֲשֶׁ֥ר הָלָֽךְ׃

“And Yahweh saved David in every {place} where he went”

The author is making a summary comment about everything he has described since introducing a new event in 8:1. This signals the end of his account of these wars that David fought. Use the natural form in your language for indicating the conclusion of a story.

See: End of Story

2 Samuel 8:6 (#1)

וַתְּהִ֥י אֲרָ֛ם לְדָוִ֖ד לַֽעֲבָדִ֑ים נוֹשְׂאֵ֖י מִנְחָ֥ה

“and Aram became servants to David, lifters of tribute”

See how you translated the similar expression in 8:2. Alternate translation: [and the Arameans became servants to David and brought him tribute]

See: Collective Nouns

2 Samuel 8:7 (#1)

אֵ֚ת שִׁלְטֵ֣י הַזָּהָ֔ב אֲשֶׁ֥ר הָי֖וּ אֶל־עַבְדֵ֣י הֲדַדְעֶ֑זֶר

“the shields of gold that were on the servants of Hadadezer”

The meaning of the word translated as **shields** is uncertain. It could be a general term for military equipment whose meaning must be understood from the context. In some contexts, such as Jeremiah 51:11, it seems to mean “quivers” or arrow-cases, and some versions also translate it that way here. However, the context seems to support the meaning of **shields**. Some ancient rulers had their bodyguard carry shields that were plated with precious metals, and Hadadezer may have done that. Alternate translation: [the gold-plated shields that Hadadezer’s bodyguard had carried]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 8:8 (#1)

לָקַ֥ח & נְחֹ֖שֶׁת הַרְבֵּ֥ה מְאֹֽד

“took bronze, making very much”

The phrase **took bronze, making very much** expresses a single idea. The expression **making very much** tells in what way David **took bronze**. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning in a different way. Alternate translation: [greatly took bronze] or [took very much bronze]

See: Hendiadys

2 Samuel 8:10 (#2)

כִּֽי־אִ֥ישׁ מִלְחֲמוֹת֙ תֹּ֣עִ֔י הָיָ֖ה הֲדַדְעֶ֑זֶר

“For Hadadezer had been a man of war of Toi”

The author is using **a man of war** as a common expression of his culture to mean “someone who fought wars against.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [For Hadadezer had been fighting wars against Toi]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 8:10 (#1)

לִשְׁאָל־לוֹ לְשָׁלוֹם

“to ask about him regarding peace”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **peace**, you could express the same idea in another way. Here the word **peace** indicates the idea of “welfare.” Alternate translation: [to ask about his welfare] or [to say that he hoped he was doing well]

See: Abstract Nouns

2 Samuel 8:10 (#4)

וּבְיָדוֹ הָיוּ

“And in his hand were”

The author does not mean that Joram somehow held all of these **vessels** in his **hand**. He is using the term **hand** to indicate that Joram was the agent who conveyed the vessels to David. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [And he brought]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 8:10 (#5)

וּבְיָדוֹ הָיוּ

“And in his hand were”

The pronoun **his** refers to Joram. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [And in Joram’s hand were] or [And Joram brought]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 8:10 (#3)

אִישׁ מִלְחֲמוֹת תֹּאתִי הָיָה הֲדַדְעָזֶר

“Hadadezer had been a man of war of Toi”

Here the author is providing background information to help readers understand what is happening in the story. In your translation, introduce this information in a way that would be natural in your own language and culture. Alternate translation: [Hadadezer had been fighting wars against him]

See: Background Information

2 Samuel 8:12 (#1)

וּמִבְּנֵי עַמּוֹן

“and from the sons of Ammon”

See how you translated the similar expression in 7:6. Alternate translation: [and from the Ammonites]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 8:13 (#3)

שְׁמוֹנָה עָשָׂר אָלֶף

“18,000”

The author is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [killing 18,000 Edomites]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 8:13 (#1)

שֵׁשֵׁם

“a name”

See how you translated the similar expression in 7:9. Alternate translation: [a reputation]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 8:13 (#2)

אֶת־אֲרָם

“Aram”

The Septuagint (an ancient Greek translation of the Hebrew Bible) and the parallel passage in 1 Chronicles 18:12 read “Edom.” That may have been the original reading, particularly since the **the Valley of Salt** (the Arabah south of the Dead Sea) was close to Edom, not to Aram. If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to use the reading that it uses. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to use the reading of the ULT.

See: Textual Variants

2 Samuel 8:14 (#3)

וַיּוֹשַׁע יְהוָה אֶת־דָּוִד בְּכֹל אֲשֶׁר הָלָךְ

“And Yahweh saved David in all that he went”

After providing some further details about the plunder David captured, the gifts he received, and how he defeated Edom, the author is once again making a summary comment about everything he has described since introducing a new event in 8:1. See how you translated the similar expression in 8:6.

See: End of Story

2 Samuel 8:14 (#2)

בְּכָל־אֱדוֹם שָׂשָׂם נְצִבִֽים

“In all of Edom, garrisons there”

The author is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [there were garrisons throughout all of Edom] or [he placed garrisons throughout all of Edom]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 8:14 (#1)

וַיָּ֤שֶׂם בֶּאֱדֹום֙ נְצִבִ֔ים בְּכָל־אֱדֹ֖ום שָׂשָׂ֣ם נְצִבִ֑ים

“And he put garrisons in Edom. In all of Edom, garrisons there”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [And he stationed military garrisons throughout all of Edom]

See: Parallelism

2 Samuel 8:15 (#1)

דָּוִ֖ד עֹשֶׂ֣ה מִשְׁפָּ֔ט וּצְדָקָ֖ה

“David did justice and righteousness”

The phrase **justice and righteousness** expresses a single idea. The word **righteousness** describes what kind of **justice** David carried out. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning in a different way. Alternate translation: [David did righteous judgment]

See: Hendiadys

2 Samuel 8:16 (#1)

מַזְכִּֽיר

“was} the recorder”

A **recorder** was a kind of royal official who kept records of important events and handled official documents. If your readers would not be familiar with what a recorder is, you could use the name of a similar thing that your readers would recognize, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [was the royal secretary] or [was in charge of the official records]

See: Translate Unknowns

2 Samuel 8:18 (#3)

וּבְנֵ֥י דָוִ֖ד כֹּהֲנִ֣ים הָיֽוּ

“and the sons of David were priests”

David’s sons were from the tribe of Judah, not Levi, and so they could not serve as priests who offered sacrifices on the altar at the sacred tent. In this context, the author is probably using the term **priests** to mean high-ranking royal officials. The parallel passage in 1 Chronicles 18:17 says that they were “chief officials,” suggesting that that is the meaning here. Alternate translation: [and the sons of David were chief officials]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 8:18 (#2)

וְהַכְּרֵתִ֖י וְהַפְּלֵתִֽי

“both the Cherethites and the Pelethites”

The **Cherethites and the Pelethites** were special groups of soldiers who served as David’s personal bodyguards and elite fighting force. If your readers would not be familiar with what these groups were, you could use the name of a similar thing that your readers would recognize, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [the royal guard and special soldiers] or [the elite bodyguards and special military units]

See: Translate Unknowns

2 Samuel 8:18 (#1)

וְהַכְּרֵתִ֖י וְהַפְּלֵתִֽי

“both the Cherethites and the Pelethites”

The author is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [was over both the Cherethites and the Pelethites] or [commanded both the Cherethites and the Pelethites]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel - Chapter 9 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter continues the story of what David did as the king of Israel. It describes how David honored his promise to Jonathan by providing for his son Mephibosheth.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Since Saul was dead, how could he still have had a servant?
The author says in 9:2 that the "house of Saul" had a servant named Ziba. The Law of Moses said that if an Israelite had a servant who was not an Israelite, that servant would remain the property of the Israelite's family after he died. So it appears that Ziba was not an Israelite and that he had stayed on in his role as the steward of Saul's property in Gibeah of Benjamin even after Saul died and even though Saul's only surviving son Ishbosheth had fled across the Jordan River to Mahanaim. As the story in this chapter makes clear, Saul had other descendants, including his grandson Mephibosheth, so Ziba, his sons, and his servants had an obligation to maintain the family property for their benefit. In 9:11, Ziba pledges to David that he will do this for Mephibosheth.

2 Samuel 9:1 (#1)

לְבֵ֖ית שָׁא֑וּל

"to the house of Saul"

The author is using the term **house** by association to mean all the people descended from a particular person. It envisions them as if they were one household living together. So **the house of Saul** figuratively means all the people descended from King Saul. (This is slightly different from the uses of this phrase in chapter 3 to mean "the supporters of Saul" or "the successors of Saul.") Alternate translation: [among the descendants of Saul]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 9:2 (#1)

וּלְבֵ֣ית שָׁא֗וּל עֶ֚בֶד וּשְׁמ֣וֹ צִיבָ֔א

"Now to the house of Saul {was} a servant, and his name {was} Ziba"

Here the author is introducing **Ziba** as a new participant in the story. Your language may have its own way of introducing new participants that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [Now there was a certain servant named Ziba in Saul's household]

See: Introduction of New and Old Participants

2 Samuel 9:2 (#2)

עַבְדֶּ֔ךָ

"Your servant"

Ziba is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [Yes, your servant is Ziba]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 9:2 (#3)

עַבְדֶּ֔ךָ

"Your servant"

Ziba is speaking of himself in the third person as **Your servant** to show humility. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a humble form in the first person. Alternate translation: [Yes, I am Ziba]

See: First, Second or Third Person

2 Samuel 9:2 (#4)

עַבְדֶּ֔ךָ

"Your servant"

Ziba is responding to David with the courteous expression that a person in this culture would use to tell a superior that he had heard a summons and was ready and willing to obey. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [Yes, I am Ziba, and I am ready to obey you]

See: Politeness

2 Samuel 9:3 (#1)

אִישׁ֙

"a man"

Here the masculine term **a man** has a generic sense that includes both men and women. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use language in your translation that is clearly inclusive of both men and women. Alternate translation: [a person] or [anyone]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

2 Samuel 9:3 (#2)

חֶ֥סֶד אֱלֹהִ֖ים

"the covenant faithfulness of God"

David is using the possessive form **the covenant faithfulness of God** to mean the covenant faithfulness that he will show to such a person because of the oath he swore to God. He does not mean God's own covenant faithfulness. It may be helpful to clarify this

for your readers. Alternate translation: [the covenant faithfulness that I swore to God I would do]

See: Possession

2 Samuel 9:4 (#1)

הִנֵּה

“Behold”

Ziba is using the term **behold** to focus his listeners’ attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [I will tell you]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 9:6 (#3)

הִנֵּנִֽי עַבְדֶּֽךָ

“Behold your servant”

Mephibosheth is responding to David with the courteous expression that a person in this culture would use to tell a superior that he had heard a summons and was ready and willing to obey. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. The meaning here is the same as for the expression “Behold me” in 1:7. See how you translated that expression there.

See: Politeness

2 Samuel 9:6 (#1)

וַיִּפֹּ֤ל עַל־פָּנָיו֙ וַיִּשְׁתָּ֔חוּ

“and he fell on his face, and he prostrated himself”

Be sure that it is clear in your translation that Mephibosheth did not fall down accidentally. He knelt down in front of David, pressing his face to the ground and stretching himself out completely, as a gesture to honor David. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action. Alternate translation: [and he knelt down and pressed his face to the ground in front of David, stretching himself out completely, to show David great honor]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 9:6 (#2)

הִנֵּנִֽי עַבְדֶּֽךָ

“Behold your servant”

Mephibosheth is speaking of himself in the third person as **your servant** to show humility. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a humble form in the first person. Alternate translation: [Behold me]

See: First, Second or Third Person

2 Samuel 9:7 (#1)

אַל־תִּירָ֔א כִּֽי־עָשֹׂ֥ה אֶֽעֱשֶׂה־עִמְּךָ֖ חֶ֑סֶד בַּֽעֲב֣וּר יְהוֹנָתָ֣ן אָבִ֔יךָ

“Do not fear, for doing, I will do covenant faithfulness with you for the sake of Jonathan your father”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Doing, I will do covenant faithfulness with you for the sake of Jonathan your father, so do not fear]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

2 Samuel 9:7 (#3)

שְׂדֵ֣ה

“the field of”

In this verse, the word **field** is singular in form, but it refers to all of Saul’s agricultural lands. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use the plural form of “field.” Alternate translation: [the fields of] or [the lands of]

See: Collective Nouns

2 Samuel 9:7 (#5)

לֶ֖חֶם

“bread”

David is using **bread** to represent food in general. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [food] or [meals]

See: Synecdoche

2 Samuel 9:7 (#4)

שָׁא֣וּל אָבִ֑יךָ

“Saul your father”

Your language may have its own term or expression for this relationship. Saul was actually the father of the father of Mephibosheth. Alternate translation: [Saul your grandfather]

See: Kinship

2 Samuel 9:7 (#6)

עַל־שֻׁלְחָנִי

“at my table”

David is using the term **table** to represent eating meals as part of his household. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [with the rest of my household]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 9:7 (#2)

עָשֹׂה אֶעֱשֶׂה

“doing, I will do”

David is repeating forms of the verb **do** in order to intensify his expression of the idea that it conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [I will certainly do]

See: Reduplication

2 Samuel 9:8 (#2)

כִּכְּי פָּנִיתָ אֶל

“that you should turn to”

Mephibosheth is speaking as if David would physically **turn** toward him. In this context, **turn to** represents “show regard for” or “show kindness to.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [that you should show any regard for]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 9:8 (#3)

הַכֶּלֶב הַמֵּת אֲשֶׁר כָּמוֹנִי

“a dead dog that {is} like me”

Mephibosheth is speaking as if he were actually a **dead dog**. In this culture, dogs were wild, and they were considered dirty and regarded with contempt. Moreover, a **dead dog** would be powerless. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. If you have already translated the book of 1 Samuel, see how you translated the similar expression in 1 Samuel 24:14. Alternate translation: [someone like me who is powerless and whom people regard with contempt]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 9:8 (#1)

מָה עַבְדֶּךָ כִּי פָנִיתָ אֶל־הַכֶּלֶב הַמֵּת אֲשֶׁר כָּמוֹנִי

“What {is} your servant, that you should turn to a dead dog that {is} like me”

Mephibosheth is using the question form to express humility and to emphasize that he does not deserve such kindness. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Your servant is not anyone important, that you should turn to a dead dog that is like me!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 9:9 (#2)

בֵּיתוֹ

“his house”

See how you translated the similar expression in 9:1. Alternate translation: [his family]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 9:9 (#1)

נַעַר שָׁאאוּל

“the young man of Saul”

While the author refers to Ziba as a **young man** who belonged to Saul, in this context he is using that term to mean “servant,” which is what he calls Ziba in the rest of this chapter. Since Ziba had many grown sons, he was not physically a “young man.” If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use the term “servant” here. Alternate translation: [the servant of Saul]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 9:9 (#3)

לְבֶן

“to the son of”

Mephibosheth was actually the son of the son of Ziba’s master. Your language may have its own term or expression for this relationship that would be appropriate to use here and in the next verse. Alternate translation: [to the grandson of]

See: Kinship

2 Samuel 9:10 (#2)

לֶּחֶם & לַחְמְךָ

“bread & bread”

See how you translated the similar expression in 9:7. Alternate translation: [food ... meals]

See: Synecdoche

2 Samuel 9:10 (#3)

עַל־שֻׁלְחָנִי

“at my table”

See how you translated the similar expression in 9:7.

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 9:10 (#1)

וְעָבַדְתָּ & וְהֵבֵאתָ

“And you shall work & and you shall bring”

The word **you** is singular here because David is addressing Ziba directly. However, the context makes clear that David is commanding Ziba’s sons and servants to be involved in these actions as well. It may be more appropriate to use a plural form of “you” in your translation if your language marks that distinction.

See: Forms of ‘You’ — Singular

2 Samuel 9:10 (#4)

וּלְצִיבָא חֲמִשָּׁה עָשָׂר בָּנִים וְעֶשְׂרִים עֲבָדִים

“Now to Ziba {were} 15 sons and 20 servants”

Here, the author is providing background information to help readers understand something that happens later in the story. In your translation, introduce this information in a way that would be natural in your own language and culture.

See: Background Information

2 Samuel 9:11 (#3)

עַל־שֻׁלְחָנִי

“at my table”

The author is quoting David’s words directly, perhaps to show that his command was carried out. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this as an indirect quotation. Alternate translation: [at his table]

See: Direct and Indirect Quotations

2 Samuel 9:11 (#2)

יְצִוָּה

“commands”

Ziba is using a verb form that describes action in the present. The implication is that he will do not just what David has commanded him on this occasion but also anything further that David might command him in the future regarding Mephibosheth. Use an appropriate verb form in your language to convey this sense.

See: Irregular Use of Tenses

2 Samuel 9:11 (#1)

יְצִוָּה אֲדֹנִי הַמֶּלֶךְ אֶת־עַבְדּוֹ כֵּן יַעֲשֶׂה עַבְדֶּךָ

“my lord the king commands his servant, thus shall your servant do”

Ziba is speaking about David respectfully and about himself humbly in the third person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate his reference to David in the second person and his reference to himself in the first person. Alternate translation: [you, my lord the king, command me, your servant, thus shall I do]

See: First, Second or Third Person

2 Samuel 9:12 (#1)

מוֹשַׁב בֵּית

“the dwelling of the house of”

Here, **the dwelling of the house** means the people who lived in Ziba’s house, that is, the members of his household. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the members of the household of]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 9:13 (#1)

וּמְפִיבֹשֶׁת יֹשֵׁב בִּירוּשָׁלַ͏ִם כִּי עַל־שֻׁלְחַן הַמֶּלֶךְ תָּמִיד הוּא אֹכֵל

“But Mephibosheth dwelled in Jerusalem, for he was continually eating at the table of the king”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [But since Mephibosheth was continually eating at the table of the king, he dwelled in Jerusalem]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

2 Samuel 9:13 (#2)

וְהוּא פִסֵּחַ שְׁתֵּי רַגְלָיו

“And he {was} lame, the two of his feet”

Here, the author is providing background information to help readers understand something that happens later in the story. In your translation, introduce this information in a way that would be natural in your own language and culture.

See: Background Information

2 Samuel - Chapter 10 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter continues the story of what David did as the king of Israel. It describes how David tried to express sympathy to the new king of the Ammonites for the death of his father but was instead insulted and rebuffed. It describes how the Ammonites, knowing they had offended David, hired Aramean mercenaries to help them fight Israel and how Joab and his brother Abishai, David’s generals, defeated those armies. Finally, it describes how the Arameans gathered an even larger army and how David led the entire army of Israel to defeat them.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Why did Hanun shave half of the beards of David’s messengers and cut their garments in the middle?

In 10:4, to insult David’s messengers, the Ammonite king, Hanun, has his servants shave off half of their beards and cut off half of their robes. In just about any context, these actions would have made the men look foolish and exposed them to shame and embarrassment. But in this culture, there may have been a further significance. In this culture, men wore beards, while women did not have them. By leaving the messengers with half-beards, Hanun was symbolically making them neither men nor women. Humans wear clothes, while animals do not. By leaving the messengers with half-robes, Hanun was symbolically making them neither human nor animal. So this was a way of making the messengers symbolically non-existent. Since they represented David personally, it was a way of insulting David by telling him, “You are nothing.” The author of this book does not explain the significance of this action, since his readers would already have understood it. But if it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain it in a footnote.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

Numbers

There are large numbers in verses 6 and 18. Translate these according to the decision you made for chapter 8 about how you would represent large numbers in your translation.

2 Samuel 10:1 (#2)

בְּנֵי עַמּוֹן

“the sons of Ammon”

See how you translated the similar expression in 8:12. Alternate translation: [the Ammonites]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 10:1 (#1)

וַיְהִי

“And it happened”

The author is using the phrase **And it happened** to introduce a new event in the story. Use a word, phrase, or other method in your language that is natural for introducing a new event.

See: Introduction of a New Event

2 Samuel 10:2 (#3)

וַיִּשְׁלַח דָּוִד & בְּיַד־עֲבָדָיו

“And David sent by the hand of his servants”

Here, the **hand** of David’s servants represents their agency in acting with David’s authority as his representatives. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And David sent some of his servants as his representatives]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 10:2 (#2)

וַיֹּ֣אמֶר דָּוִד֮ אֶעֱשֶׂה־חֶ֣סֶד ׀ עִם־חָנוּן֒ בֶּן־נָחָ֣שׁ כַּאֲשֶׁ֣ר עָשָׂ֣ה אָבִ֔יו עִמָּדִי֙ חֶ֣סֶד

“And David said, “I will do kindness with Hanun the son of Nahash, just as his father did kindness with me”

The author presents David’s thoughts as a direct quotation. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this as an indirect quotation. Alternate translation: [And David decided that he should do kindness with Hanun the son of Nahash, just as his father had done kindness with him]

See: Direct and Indirect Quotations

2 Samuel 10:2 (#1)

וַיֹּ֣אמֶר דָּוִ֔ד

“And David said”

In this instance, the author is using the term **said** to introduce what David was thinking or saying to himself. David did not necessarily say this out loud to anyone. In your translation, use a natural way of introducing what people say to themselves or think. Alternate translation: [And David thought]

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

2 Samuel 10:3 (#4)

הֲלֹ֗א בַּעֲבֻ֤ר חֲקֹ֙ר אֶת־הָעִ֔יר וּלְרַגְּלָ֖הּ וּלְהָפְכָ֑הּ שָׁלַ֥ח דָּוִ֛ד אֶת־עֲבָדָ֖יו אֵלֶ֥יךָ

“Is it} not in order to explore the city and to spy on it and to overthrow it {that} David has sent his servants to you”

The advisors are using the question form to strongly assert that David sent his servants for a different reason, to explore, spy on, and overthrow the city. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [No, David has sent his servants to you in order to explore the city and to spy on it and to overthrow it!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 10:3 (#6)

וּלְהָפְכָ֑הּ

“and to overthrow it”

The advisors are using one group of people who would be involved in the **overthrow** of their city, the messengers whom they believe to be spies, to represent everyone who would be involved. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [so that he can lead the Israelite army to overthrow it]

See: Synecdoche

2 Samuel 10:3 (#5)

בַּעֲבֻ֤ר חֲקֹ֙ר אֶת־הָעִ֔יר וּלְרַגְּלָ֖הּ

“in order to explore the city and to spy on it”

The terms **explore the city** and **spy on it** mean similar things. The commanders are using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [to investigate the city thoroughly]

See: Doublet

2 Samuel 10:3 (#1)

הֲמְכַבֵּ֤ד דָּוִד֙ אֶת־אָבִ֣יךָ בְּעֵינֶ֔יךָ כִּֽי־שָׁלַ֥ח לְךָ֖ מְנַחֲמִ֑ים

“In your eyes, is David honoring your father, since he has sent consolers to you”

The advisors are using the question form to deny emphatically that David was honoring Hanun’s father. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [You should not believe that David is honoring your father by sending consolers to you!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 10:3 (#2)

בְּעֵינֶ֔יךָ

“In your eyes”

See how you translated the similar expression in 3:19. Alternate translation: [In your opinion]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 10:3 (#3)

הֲמְכַבֵּ֤ד דָּוִד֙ אֶת־אָבִ֣יךָ בְּעֵינֶ֔יךָ כִּֽי־שָׁלַ֥ח לְךָ֖ מְנַחֲמִ֑ים

“In your eyes, is David honoring your father, since he has sent consolers to you”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [since David has sent consolers to you, is he honoring your father]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

2 Samuel 10:4 (#2)

זִקְנָ֔ם

“their beard”

In this verse, the word **beard** is singular in form, but it refers to all of the beards of David’s servants. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use the plural form of “beard.” Alternate translation: [their beards]

See: Collective Nouns

2 Samuel 10:4 (#1)

וַיְגַלַּח֙ אֶת־חֲצִ֣י זְקָנָ֔ם וַיִּכְרֹ֛ת אֶת־מַדְוֵיהֶ֥ם בַּחֵצִ֖י עַ֣ד שְׁתוֹתֵיהֶ֑ם

“and he shaved half of their beard, and he cut their garments in the middle, to their buttocks”

Shaving half of the beards of these men and cutting their garments in the middle was a symbolic action by which the Ammonite king sought to humiliate David’s messengers. (See the further discussion in the Introduction to this chapter.) If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [and he humiliated them by shaving half of their beard and cutting their garments in the middle, to their buttocks]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 10:5 (#2)

וַיִּשְׁלַ֖ח לִקְרָאתָ֑ם כִּי־הָ֥יוּ הָאֲנָשִׁ֖ים נִכְלָמִ֣ים מְאֹ֔ד

“and he sent to meet them, for the men were greatly humiliated”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [and since the men were greatly humiliated, he sent to meet them]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

2 Samuel 10:5 (#3)

הָיוּ הָאֲנָשִׁים נִכְלָמִים מְאֹד

“the men were greatly humiliated”

The expression **were greatly humiliated** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [this had greatly humiliated the men]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 10:5 (#4)

וַיֹּ֣אמֶר הַמֶּ֔לֶךְ

“And the king said”

The author is saying **the king** to mean his messengers, who were speaking on his behalf. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [And the king’s messengers told them]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 10:5 (#1)

וַיַּגִּ֖דוּ לְדָוִ֑ד

“And they declared to David”

Here the author is using the pronoun **they** in a general sense, not to refer to specific people. Use an expression for this that would be natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Someone declared to David] or [David was told]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 10:6 (#2)

אֶת־אֲרַ֤ם בֵּית־רְחֹוב֙ וְאֶת־אֲרַ֣ם צוֹבָ֔א עֶשְׂרִ֥ים אֶ֖לֶף רַגְלִ֑י וְאֶת־מֶ֣לֶךְ מַעֲכָ֗ה אֶ֚לֶף אִ֔ישׁ וְאִ֥ישׁ טֹ֖וב שְׁנֵים־עָשָׂ֣ר אֶ֑לֶף אִֽישׁ

“Aram of Beth Rehob and Aram of Zoba, 20,000 footsoldiers, and the king of Maacah, 1,000 men, and a man of Tob, 12,000 men”

The author is using the names of each of these kingdoms to represent soldiers from those kingdoms. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [20,000 footsoldiers from Aram of Beth-Rehob and Aram of Zoba, 1,000 men of the king of Maacah, and 12,000 men of Tob]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 10:6 (#1)

נִבְאַשׁ֖וּ בְּדָוִֽד

“they had made themselves stink to David”

The author is speaking as if the Ammonites had made themselves smell so bad that they were offensive to David. He is using this image to mean that the Ammonites had provoked David. Your language may have a comparable image that you could use in your translation. You could also use plain language. If you have already translated the book of 1 Samuel, see how you translated the similar expression in 1 Samuel 13:4. Alternate translation: [they had incensed David] or [they had provoked David]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 10:6 (#3)

וְאִ֥ישׁ טֹֽוב

“and a man of Tob”

The author is not referring to a specific **man of Tob**. He means men from Tob in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that

would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and men from Tob]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

2 Samuel 10:7 (#1)

וְאֵת כָּל־הַצָּבָא הַגִּבֹּרִים

“and all of the army, the mighty”

The expressions **all of the army** and **the mighty** mean similar things. The author is using the two expressions together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [all of the valiant warriors]

See: Doublet

2 Samuel 10:7 (#2)

הַגִּבֹּרִים

“the mighty”

The author is using the adjective **mighty** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. In context, he seems to mean regular army soldiers who were experienced in warfare, as opposed to other men capable of fighting who would be summoned when large armies were needed. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the elite soldiers]

See: Nominal Adjectives

2 Samuel 10:8 (#1)

פֶּתַח הַשָּׁעַר

“at} the entrance of the gate”

The author is using one central location in the city wall, **the entrance of the gate**, to represent the entire wall, which served as a defensive support for the Ammonite battle line. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in front of the city wall]

See: Synecdoche

2 Samuel 10:8 (#2)

וְאִישׁ־טטוֹב

“and a man of Tob”

See how you translated the similar expression in 10:6. Alternate translation: [and the men from Tob]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

2 Samuel 10:9 (#1)

הָיְתָה אֵלָיו פְּנֵי הַמִּלְחָמָה מִפָּנִים וּמֵאָחוֹר

“the faces of the battle were against him from before and from behind”

Here, **the faces of the battle** represents the battle lines that the enemy armies had drawn up in order to fight the Israelites. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. You could also use plain language. Alternate translation: [there were battle fronts ahead of him and behind him]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 10:9 (#2)

בְּחוּרֵי

“the chosen of”

The author is using the adjective **chosen** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the chosen troops]

See: Nominal Adjectives

2 Samuel 10:9 (#3)

בְּחוּרֵי

“the chosen of”

The expression **chosen** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the select troops] or [the elite troops]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 10:10 (#1)

הָעָם

“the people”

See how you translated the similar expression in 1:4. Alternate translation: [the army]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 10:10 (#2)

בְּיַד

“in the hand of”

Here, **hand** represents control. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [under the control of] or [under the command of]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 10:10 (#3)

וַיַּעֲרֹךְ֙

“and he arrayed {them”

The pronoun **he** refers to Abishai. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [and Abishai arrayed {them}]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 10:11 (#1)

וַיֹּ֣אמֶר

“And he said”

The pronoun **he** refers to Joab. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [And Joab said]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 10:11 (#2)

וְהָיְתָה֙ לִ֣לְי֔ לִישׁוּעָ֖ה

“then you shall be to me for salvation”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [then you shall come and save me]

See: Abstract Nouns

2 Samuel 10:12 (#1)

עָרֵ֣י אֱלֹהֵ֔ינוּ

“the cities of our God”

Here, **the cities of our God** represents the cities of Israel, where the true God was worshiped. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [our Israelite cities]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 10:12 (#2)

הַטּ֥וֹב בְּעֵינָ֖יו

“the good in his eyes”

See how you translated the similar expression in 3:19. Alternate translation: [as he sees fit] or [what he considers to be right]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 10:13 (#1)

מִפָּנָ֔יו

“from his face”

The author is using one part of Joab, his **face**, to represent all of him in the act of leading an attack against the Arameans. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from him as he led the attack]

See: Synecdoche

2 Samuel 10:14 (#1)

מִפְּנֵ֣י אֲבִישַׁ֔י

“from the face of Abishai”

See how you translated the similar expression in the previous verse. Alternate translation: [from Abishai as he led the attack]

See: Synecdoche

2 Samuel 10:15 (#1)

וַיַּ֣רְא אֲרָ֔ם כִּֽי־נִגַּ֖ף

“And Aram saw that it had been struck”

The author is using the name of this people group, **Aram**, to represent the soldiers of its army. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [And the Arameans saw that they had been struck]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 10:15 (#2)

נִגַּ֖ף

“it had been struck”

Here, **struck** represents “defeated.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. See the discussion of the term “struck” in the Introduction to 2 Samuel. Alternate translation: [it had been defeated] or [they had been defeated]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 10:15 (#3)

לִפְנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל

“to the face of Israel”

See how you translated the similar expression in 2:17. Alternate translation: [as it opposed Israel] or [as they opposed Israel]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 10:15 (#4)

נִגַּף לִפְנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל

“it had been struck to the face of Israel”

The expression **it had been struck** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the Israelites had defeated them in battle]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 10:16 (#1)

הַנָּהָר

“the River”

The author is referring to the Euphrates River, which was the most important river in this region and so was sometimes simply called **the River**. You could use your language’s name for this river if that would be helpful to your readers. See how you translated the similar expression in 8:3. Alternate translation: [the Euphrates River]

See: How to Translate Names

2 Samuel 10:16 (#2)

לִפְנֵיהֶם

“was} to their faces”

This expression depicts Shobach as being in front of this combined army, and the author is using that position to represent his leadership of the army. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [was leading them] or [was commanding them]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 10:17 (#1)

וַיֻּגַּד לְדָוִד

“And it was declared to David”

The expression **it was declared to David** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Someone declared to David]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 10:17 (#2)

אֶת־כָּל־יִשְׂרָאֵל

“all of Israel”

The author is using the name **Israel** to represent the soldiers of the Israelite army. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the whole Israelite army]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 10:18 (#4)

וְאֶת שׁוֹבַךְ שַׂר־צְבָאוֹ הִכָּה וַיָּמָת שָׁם

“And he struck Shobach, the commander of his army, and he died there”

The pronoun **he** refers to David and his soldiers in the first instance, and it refers to Shobach in the second instance. The pronoun **his** refers to Hadadezer. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [And David and his soldiers struck Shobach, the commander of Hadadezer’s army, and Shobach died there]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 10:18 (#1)

מִפְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל

“from the face of Israel”

See how you translated the similar expression in 10:14. Alternate translation: [from the Israelites as they attacked]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 10:18 (#3)

פָּרָשִׁים

“horsemen”

The parallel passage in 1 Chronicles 19:18 reads “foot-soldiers” instead of **horsemen**. So does the Septuagint, an ancient Greek translation. (It is possible that here in 2 Samuel and in that passage in 1 Chronicles the biblical author is mentioning one kind of soldier in order to mean soldiers in general. The UST models

one way to express that meaning, which would be the same in both cases.) If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to use the reading that it uses. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to use the reading of the ULT.

See: Textual Variants

2 Samuel 10:18 (#2)

וַיַּהֲרֹ֥ג דָּוִֽד

“and David killed”

The author is using one person who was involved in this action of the Israelite army, **David**, to represent the entire army. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and David’s army killed] or [and David’s forces defeated]

See: Synecdoche

2 Samuel 10:19 (#2)

וַיַּשְׁלִ֖מוּ אֶת־יִשְׂרָאֵ֑ל

“and they made peace with Israel”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **peace**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and they asked to have peaceful relations with Israel]

See: Abstract Nouns

2 Samuel 10:19 (#1)

נִגְּפ֥וּ לִפְנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵ֖ל

“they had been struck to the face of Israel”

See how you translated the similar expression in 10:15. Alternate translation: [the Israelites had defeated them in battle]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel - Chapter 11 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter continues the story of what David did as the king of Israel. However, it marks a turning point in his life. David commits two very serious sins, adultery and murder. For the rest of his life, David experienced the consequences of these sins as his children committed sexual violence and murder against one another and as one of his sons rebelled against him to try to replace him as king.

This chapter describes specifically how David saw a beautiful woman, Bathsheba, and required her have sexual relations with him. When she became pregnant, David brought her husband Uriah home from fighting against the Ammonites. David encouraged him to relax at home with his wife so it would appear as if he was the father of the child. But Uriah remained on duty, staying with the palace guards. So David arranged with his general Joab to have Uriah killed in battle. He then married Bathsheba. The author concludes this account by noting that “the thing that David had done was bad in the eyes of Yahweh.” David begins to experience the consequences in the following chapter.

2 Samuel 11:1 (#2)

לִתְשׁוּבַ֣ת הַשָּׁנָ֔ה

“at the return of the year”

Here, **at the return of the year** was a common expression that referred to the beginning of a new year. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. You could also use plain language. Alternate translation: [at the start of the next year]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 11:1 (#5)

אֶת־בְּנֵ֥י עַמּ֖וֹן

“the sons of Ammon”

See how you translated the similar expression in 7:6. Alternate translation: [the Ammonites]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 11:1 (#1)

וַיְהִי֩

“And it happened”

The author is using the phrase **And it happened** to introduce a new event in the story. Use a word, phrase, or other method in your language that is natural for introducing a new event.

See: Introduction of a New Event

2 Samuel 11:1 (#3)

לִתְשׁוּבַ֣ת הַשָּׁנָ֔ה

“at the return of the year”

The people in this culture considered that a new year began in the spring, when they could once again

start the cycle of planting and harvesting crops. You could indicate this in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [in the spring]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 11:1 (#4)

לְעֵ֣ת ׀ צֵ֣את הַמְּלָאכִ֗ים

“at the time of the going out of kings”

The author says **going out** as a common expression that meant “going to war.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. See how you translated the similar expression in 3:25. Alternate translation: [in the season when kings go to war]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 11:2 (#3)

בֵּ֣ית־הַמֶּ֔לֶךְ

“the house of the king”

Since David is the subject of this sentence, it may be more natural in your language to refer to his **house** or palace with a pronoun. Alternate translation: [his house] or [his palace]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 11:2 (#1)

וַיְהִ֣י

“And it happened”

The author is using the phrase **And it happened** to introduce a new development in this episode. Use a word, phrase, or other method in your language that is natural for introducing a new development.

See: Introduction of a New Event

2 Samuel 11:2 (#2)

לְעֵ֣ת הָעֶ֔רֶב

“at the time of the evening”

This culture considered the **evening** to begin once the day had become cooler. Some cultures would describe that time as “late afternoon” rather than evening. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could describe what the author means here. Alternate translation: [after the hottest part of the day]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 11:3 (#1)

וַיִּשְׁלַ֥ח דָּוִ֖ד וַיִּדְרֹ֣שׁ

“And David sent and inquired”

The phrase **sent and inquired** expresses a single idea. The word **inquired** tells for what purpose David **sent** someone. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning in a different way. Alternate translation: [And David sent to inquire]

See: Hendiadys

2 Samuel 11:3 (#2)

וַיֹּ֣אמֶר

“And one said”

Here the author is using **one** in a general sense, not to refer to a specific person. Use an expression for this that would be natural in your language. Alternate translation: [And he was told]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 11:3 (#3)

הֲלוֹא־זֹ֣את בַּת־שֶׁ֣בַע בַּת־אֱלִיעָ֔ם אֵ֖שֶׁת אוּרִיָּ֥ה הַחִתִּֽי

“Is this not Bathsheba, the daughter of Eliam, the wife of Uriah the Hittite”

The messenger is using the question form to give information to David. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [The woman is Bathsheba, the daughter of Eliam, the wife of Uriah the Hittite.]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 11:4 (#1)

וַיִּשְׁכַּ֥ב עִמָּ֖הּ

“and he lay with her”

The author is referring to sexual relations in a polite way by using the phrase **lay with her**. Depending on what is helpful in your language, you could use a polite way of referring to this in your language or you could state this plainly. Alternate translation: [and he slept with her]

See: Euphemism

2 Samuel 11:4 (#2)

וְהִ֥יא מִתְקַדֶּ֖שֶׁת מִטֻּמְאָתָ֑הּ

“Now she had been sanctifying herself from her uncleanness”

The author is providing background information to help readers understand what happens next in the story. He is explaining that Bathsheba had been washing herself in order to restore ceremonial cleanness at the end of the seven-day period of uncleanness that followed her monthly period. This meant that she was at the time in her monthly cycle when she could conceive a child when David had sexual relations with her. In your translation, introduce this background information in a way that would be natural in your own language and culture.

See: Background Information

2 Samuel 11:5 (#1)

וַתֹּ֥אמֶר

“and she said”

The author is using Bathsheba (referring to her with the pronoun **she**) to represent the person she **sent** to give this message to David. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and the person she sent said on her behalf]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 11:6 (#1)

וַיִּשְׁלַ֥ח דָּוִד֙ אֶל־יוֹאָ֔ב

“And David sent to Joab”

It may be natural in your language to use a term such as “saying” to introduce the direct quotation that follows this phrase.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

2 Samuel 11:7 (#1)

הָעָ֑ם

“the people”

See how you translated the similar expression in 1:4. Alternate translation: [the army]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 11:7 (#2)

וְלִשְׁלֹ֥ום הַמִּלְחָמָ֖ה

“and about the welfare of the war”

The author is speaking of **the war** as if it were a living thing that could experience **welfare** or well-being. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and about whether the Israelites were winning the war]

See: Personification

2 Samuel 11:8 (#3)

וַתֵּצֵ֖א & מַשְׂאֵ֣את הַמֶּ֑לֶךְ

“and a gift {from} the king went out”

The author is speaking of **a gift** as if it were a living thing that could have gone out from the palace on its own. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and the king sent messengers with a gift]

See: Personification

2 Samuel 11:8 (#4)

מַשְׂאֵ֣את

“a gift”

The implication is that this **gift** was special food that David had told someone to prepare. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and a choice portion of food]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 11:8 (#1)

רֵ֖ד

“Go down”

In keeping with what is usual for his language and culture, David is marking travel for change in elevation. His palace was on the highest mountain in Jerusalem, so Uriah would have to go **down** from there to get to his **house**. If this expression contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [Go]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 11:8 (#2)

וּרְחַ֥ץ רַגְלֶ֖יךָ

“and wash your feet”

In this culture, people wore sandals or went barefoot, and so their feet became dirty during work and travel. They would wash their feet when they returned home for the day and intended to do no further work or traveling. When David tells Uriah **wash your feet**, the

implication is he should consider himself to be finished with his military mission of bringing news from the battlefield. You could indicate this in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and consider yourself to be off duty]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 11:9 (#1)

וַיִּשְׁכַּב אוּרִיָּה פֶּתַח בֵּית הַמֶּלֶךְ אֵת כָּל־עַבְדֵי אֲדֹנָיו וְלֹא יָרַד אֶל־בֵּיתוֹ

“But Uriah lay down {at} the entrance of the house of the king with all of the servants of his master, and he did not go down to his house”

If it would be more natural in your language, you may want to put the information that Uriah did not go to his house as David told him to do before the new information about what he did instead. Alternate translation: [But Uriah did not go down to his house. Instead, lay down at the entrance of the house of the king with all of the servants of his master]

See: Information Structure

2 Samuel 11:10 (#1)

וַיַּגִּדוּ לְדָוִד

“And they declared to David”

Here the author is using the pronoun **they** in a general sense, not to refer to specific people. Use an expression for this that would be natural in your language. Alternate translation: [And someone declared to David] or [And David was told]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 11:10 (#2)

הֲלֹלְוֹא מִדֶּרֶךְ אַתָּה בָּא מַדּוּעַ לֹא־יָרַדְתָּ אֶל־בֵּיתֶךָ

“Are you not coming from a journey? Why did you not go down to your house”

David is using the question form for emphasis, to express his disapproval of Uriah not going to his house. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate these questions as statements or as exclamations. Alternate translation: [You are coming from a journey! You should have gone down to your house!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 11:11 (#2)

הַשָּׂדֶה

“the field”

Uriah is not referring to a specific **field**. He means open ground in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the ground]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

2 Samuel 11:11 (#7)

חַיֶּיךָ וְחֵי נַפְשֶׁךָ

“Your life, and the life of your soul”

The terms **life** and **life of your soul** mean similar things. Uriah is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [I swear by your very life]

See: Doublet

2 Samuel 11:11 (#1)

עַל־פְּנֵי הַשָּׂדֶה

“on the face of the field”

Uriah is using **the face of the field** as a common expression of his culture to mean “the surface of the field.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [on the bare earth] or [on the surface of the ground]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 11:11 (#3)

וְלִשְׁכַּב עִם־אִשְׁתִּתִי

“and to lie with my wife”

Uriah is referring to sexual relations in a polite way by using the phrase **to lie with my wife**. Depending on what is helpful in your language, you could use a polite way of referring to this in your language or you could state this plainly. Alternate translation: [and to sleep with my wife]

See: Euphemism

2 Samuel 11:11 (#4)

וַאֲנִי אָבוֹא אֶל־בֵּיתִי לֶאֱכֹל וְלִשְׁתּוֹת וְלִשְׁכַּב עִם־אִשְׁתִּתִי

“And I, shall I go to my house to eat and to drink and to lie with my wife”

Uriah is using the question form for emphasis, to express his strong conviction that he should not go to his house. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [So I myself should not go to my house to eat and to drink and to lie with my wife!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 11:11 (#5)

וַאֲנִ֞י אָבֹ֗וא

“And I, shall I go”

See how you translated the similar expression “you, you know” in 17:20. Alternate translation: [And shall I, for my part, go]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 11:11 (#6)

חַיֶּ֣יךָ וְחֵ֣י נַפְשֶׁ֔ךָ

“Your life, and the life of your soul”

Following the custom of his culture, Uriah is swearing an oath and guaranteeing it by something that he holds sacred. In your translation, express this in such a way that your readers will recognize it as an oath. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [I swear by your life, the life of your soul] or [As you live and breathe]

See: Oath Formulas

2 Samuel 11:13 (#1)

וַיֹּ֤אכַל לְפָנָיו֙ וַיֵּ֣שְׁתְּ וַיְשַׁכְּרֵ֔הוּ

“and he ate to his face, and he drank, and he got him drunk”

The pronouns **he** refer to Uriah in the first two instances and to David in the third instance. The pronoun **his** refers to David. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [and Uriah ate to David’s face, and Uriah drank, and David got him drunk]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 11:13 (#2)

לְפָנָיו

“to his face”

The author is speaking of David’s **face** to represent his presence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in his presence] or [as his guest]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 11:14 (#2)

וַיִּשְׁלַ֖ח בְּיַ֣ד אוּרִיָּֽה

“and he sent {it} by the hand of Uriah”

The author is using the term **hand** to indicate that Uriah was the agent who delivered the letter to Joab. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. See how you translated the similar expression in 8:10. Alternate translation: [and he had Uriah deliver it]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 11:14 (#1)

וַיְהִ֣י

“And it happened”

The author is using the phrase **And it happened** to introduce a new development in this episode. Use a word, phrase, or other method in your language that is natural for introducing a new development.

See: Introduction of a New Event

2 Samuel 11:15 (#3)

וְנִכֶּ֥ה וָמֵֽת

“so he will be struck and die”

The expression **will be struck** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [so that the Ammonites will strike him and he will die]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 11:15 (#1)

פְּנֵ֣י הַמִּלְחָמָ֔ה הֶֽחָזָקָ֖ה

“the face of the strongest battle”

See how you translated the similar expression in 10:9. Alternate translation: [the deadliest battle front]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 11:15 (#2)

וְשֹׁבְתֶּ֥ם

“and turn them back”

The pronoun **them** refers to the other soldiers who were fighting with Uriah. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [and turn the other soldiers back]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 11:16 (#1)

אַנְשֵׁי־חַיִל

“men of valor”

See how you translated the similar expression in 2:7. Alternate translation: [valiant warriors]

See: Abstract Nouns

2 Samuel 11:17 (#2)

וַיִּפֹּל מִן־הָעָם מֵעַבְדֵי דָוִד

“and some of the people from the servants of David fell”

See how you translated the similar expression in 2:7. Alternate translation: [and some of the people from the servants of David died]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 11:17 (#1)

אֶת־יוֹאָב

“with Joab”

The author is using **Joab** to represent his entire army. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [against Joab’s army]

See: Synecdoche

2 Samuel 11:17 (#3)

הָעָם מֵעַבְדֵי דָוִד

“the people from the servants of David”

By **the people**, the author means the Israelite army. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. See how you translated the similar expression in 1:4. Alternate translation: [the soldiers in David’s army]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 11:18 (#1)

וַיִּשְׁלַח יוֹאָב וַיַּגֶּד

“And Joab sent, and he declared”

The author is speaking as if Joab himself **declared** this to David. The author means that Joab sent a messenger to speak to David on his behalf. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [And Joab sent a messenger, and that messenger declared]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 11:19 (#1)

אֵת כָּל־דִּבְרֵי הַמִּלְחָמָה

“all of the things of the battle”

Joab is saying **all of the things of the battle** as a generalization. Since Joab expects that the messenger will not initially tell David that Uriah has been killed, the word **all** might not be appropriate in your language. If it would be clearer in your language, you could indicate that **all** is a generalization. Alternate translation: [a general report about the battle]

See: Hyperbole

2 Samuel 11:20 (#3)

מַדּוּעַ נִגַּשְׁתֶּם אֶל־הָעִיר לְהִלָּחֵם הֲלֹוא יְדַעְתֶּם אֵת אֲשֶׁר־יֹרְיוּ מֵעַל הַחוֹמָה

“Why did you draw near to the city to fight? Did you not know that they would shoot from the wall”

Joab anticipates that David may use the question form to rebuke the army for fighting so close to the city wall. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate these questions as statements or as exclamations. Alternate translation: [You should not have drawn near to the city to fight! You should have known that they would shoot from the wall!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 11:20 (#4)

נִגַּשְׁתֶּם & הֲלֹוא יְדַעְתֶּם

“did you draw near & Did you not know”

The word **you** is plural here because David would be addressing all of the Israelite soldiers. So use the plural form in your translation if your language marks that distinction. Alternate translation: [did you soldiers draw near ... Did you soldiers not know]

See: Forms of ‘You’ — Singular

2 Samuel 11:20 (#1)

תַּעֲלֶה֙ חֲמַ֣ת הַמֶּ֔לֶךְ

“the heat of the king rises”

See how you translated the similar expression in 6:7. Alternate translation: [the king becomes angry]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 11:20 (#2)

וְאָמַ֥ר לְךָ֖ מַדּ֣וּעַ נִגַּשְׁתֶּ֣ם אֶל־הָעִ֔יר לְהִלָּחֵ֑ם הֲלֹ֣וא יְדַעְתֶּ֗ם אֵ֚ת אֲשֶׁר־יֹ֣רּוּ מֵעַ֔ל הַחוֹמָֽה

“and he says to you, ‘Why did you draw near to the city to fight? Did you not know that they would shoot from the wall”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [he may ask you why we drew near to the city to fight. He may say that we should have known that they would shoot from the wall.]

See: Quotes within Quotes

2 Samuel 11:21 (#1)

מִֽי־הִכָּ֞ה אֶת־אֲבִימֶ֣לֶךְ בֶּן־יְרֻבֶּ֗שֶׁת הֲלוֹא־אִשָּׁ֤ה הִשְׁלִ֙יכָה֙ עָלָ֣יו׀ פֶּ֣לַח רֶ֔כֶב מֵעַ֖ל הַחוֹמָ֑ה וַיָּ֣מָת בְּתֵבֵ֔ץ לָ֚מָּה נִגַּשְׁתֶּ֣ם אֶל־הַחוֹמָ֔ה

“Who struck Abimelech, the son of Jerubbesheth? Did not a woman throw a piece of a millstone onto him from the wall, and he died in Thebez? Why did you draw near to the wall”

If, in the previous verse, you translated the first two questions that Joab suggests David might ask so that there was not a quotation within a quotation, you can continue doing that here. Alternate translation: [He may ask you who struck Abimelech the son of Jerubbesheth. He may ask whether it was not a woman who threw a piece of a millstone onto him from the wall so that he died in Thebez. He may ask you why we drew near to the wall]

See: Quotes within Quotes

2 Samuel 11:21 (#2)

מִֽי־הִכָּ֞ה אֶת־אֲבִימֶ֣לֶךְ בֶּן־יְרֻבֶּ֗שֶׁת הֲלוֹא־אִשָּׁ֤ה הִשְׁלִ֙יכָה֙ עָלָ֣יו׀ פֶּ֣לַח רֶ֔כֶב מֵעַ֖ל הַחוֹמָ֑ה וַיָּ֣מָת בְּתֵבֵ֔ץ לָ֚מָּה נִגַּשְׁתֶּ֣ם אֶל־הַחוֹמָ֔ה

“Who struck Abimelech, the son of Jerubbesheth? Did not a woman throw a piece of a millstone onto him from the wall, and he died in Thebez? Why did you draw near to the wall”

Joab continues to anticipate that David may use the question form to rebuke the army. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate these questions as statements or as exclamations. Alternate translation: [Remember who struck Abimelech the son of Jerubbesheth! It was a woman who threw a piece of a millstone onto him from the wall, so that he died in Thebez! You should not have drawn near to the wall!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 11:21 (#3)

יְרֻבֶּ֥שֶׁת

“Jerubbesheth”

Jerubbesheth is another name for the person who is called Jerubbaal in the book of Judges. (That was a second name that people gave to Gideon.) Here in this book, either the original author or later scribes did not want to reproduce the name “Baal,” since that was the name of a foreign god whom the Israelites detested. So the author or scribes replaced “baal” with “besheth,” a Hebrew word that means “shame.” We recommend that you use the name **Jerubbesheth** in your translation to reflect this. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain in a footnote that this is the same person known as Jerubbaal or Gideon in Judges.

See: How to Translate Names

2 Samuel 11:21 (#4)

וְאָֽמַרְתָּ֣ גַּ֔ם עַבְדְּךָ֖ אוּרִיָּ֣ה הַחִתִּ֑י מֵ֖ת

“then you shall say, ‘Your servant Uriah the Hittite is also dead”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [then you shall tell him that his servant Uriah the Hittite is also dead]

See: Quotes within Quotes

2 Samuel 11:23 (#1)

וַיֹּ֣אמֶר הַמַּלְאָךְ֮ אֶל־דָּוִד֒ כִּ֣י & הֶֽאֱנָשִׁ֗ים

“And the messenger said to David that “the men”

The author is using the term **that** to introduce a direct quotation from the messenger. This is a shorter version of the usual introductory phrase. More typically he would write, “And the messenger spoke to David, saying.” This shorter form suggests the haste with which the messenger gave this report, fearing that

David would become angry. Your language may have a way of introducing quotations that would similarly suggest this. Some languages may not need to use any introductory term. Alternate translation: [And the messenger told David, "The men]

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

2 Samuel 11:23 (#2)

גָּבְרוּ עָלֵינוּ הָאֲנָשִׁים

"the men became strong against us"

The messenger is using **the men became strong against us** as a common expression of his culture to mean that the Ammonites organized a force to attack the Israelites. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the men organized a force against us]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 11:23 (#3)

וַנִּהְיֶה עֲלֵיהֶם

"but we were against them"

The messenger is using **we were against them** as a common expression of his culture to mean that the Israelite soldiers repulsed this attack. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [but we drove them back]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 11:23 (#4)

עַד־פֶּתַח הַשָּׁעַר

"to the entrance of the gate"

See how you translated the similar expression in 10:8. Alternate translation: [to in front of the city wall]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 11:24 (#1)

מֵעַבְדֵי הַמֶּלֶךְ

"some of the servants of the king"

Even though the messenger is addressing David directly, he is speaking of him in the third person as **the king** to show respect. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a respectful form in the second person. Alternate translation: [some of your servants]

See: First, Second or Third Person

2 Samuel 11:25 (#4)

כָּזֹאת וְכָזֹאת תֹּאכַל הֶחָרֶב

"like this and like this the sword devours"

Here, **like this and like this** was a common expression that described things as uncertain and unpredictable. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the sword devours people here and there]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 11:25 (#3)

אַל־יֵרַע בְּעֵינֶיךָ אֶת־הַדָּבָר הַזֶּה

"May this matter not be bad in your eyes"

David is using **May this matter not be bad in your eyes** as a common expression of his culture to mean "Do not think that this matter is wrong" or "Do not be troubled about this matter." If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Do not believe that you have done the wrong thing in this matter]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 11:25 (#5)

כָּזֹאת וְכָזֹאת תֹּאכַל הֶחָרֶב

"like this and like this the sword devours"

Here, David is speaking as if a **sword** were a living thing, such as a wild animal, that **devours** people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [soldiers die in battle here and there]

See: Personification

2 Samuel 11:25 (#1)

כֹּה־תֹאמַר אֶל־יוֹאָב אַל־יֵרַע בְּעֵינֶיךָ אֶת־הַדָּבָר הַזֶּה כִּי־כָזֹאת וְכָזֹאת תֹּאכַל הֶחָרֶב הַחֲזֵק מִלְחַמְתְּךָ אֶל־הָעִיר וְהָרְסָהּ

"Thus you shall say to Joab, 'May this matter not be bad in your eyes, for like this and like this the

sword devours. Strengthen your battle against the city and destroy it"

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [Tell Joab not to let this matter be bad in his eyes, for like this and like this the sword devours. Tell him to strengthen his battle against the city and destroy it]

See: Quotes within Quotes

2 Samuel 11:25 (#2)

אַל־יֵרַע בְּעֵינֶיךָ אֶת־הַדָּבָר הַזֶּה כִּי־כָזֹה וְכָזֶה תֹּאכַל הֶחָרֶב

"May this matter not be bad in your eyes, for like this and like this the sword devours"

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Since like this and like this the sword devours, may this matter not be bad in your eyes]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

2 Samuel 11:26 (#1)

וַתִּשְׁמַע אֵשֶׁת אוּרִיָּה כִּי־מֵת אוּרִיָּה אִישָׁהּ וַתִּסְפֹּד עַל־בַּעְלָהּ

"And the wife of Uriah heard that Uriah her man had died. And she lamented for her husband"

Here the author describes Uriah as Bathsheba's husband in two different ways. First he calls him her **man**, perhaps referring more to the personal relationship that they had. Then he calls him her **husband**, using a word that can also mean "lord," perhaps referring more to their social status in the context of Bathsheba's public mourning for him. If your language has different terms for this relationship with these shades of meaning, it would be appropriate to use them in your translation.

See: Kinship

2 Samuel 11:27 (#1)

וַיֵּרַע הַדָּבָר אֲשֶׁר־עָשָׂה דָּוִד בְּעֵינֵי יְהוָה

"But the thing that David had done was bad in the eyes of Yahweh"

The author is using the expression **in the eyes of** to mean "in the judgment of" or "in the opinion of." If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [But the thing that David had done was bad in the judgment of Yahweh] or [But Yahweh considered that David had done an evil thing]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel - Chapter 12 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter continues the story of what David did as the king of Israel. It describes how Yahweh began to make David experienced the consequences of his sins of adultery and murder. Yahweh sent the prophet Nathan to David to get him to acknowledge and confess these sins. Nathan told a story that enabled David to recognize how wrong his actions had been. David confessed his sin, and Nathan told him that Yahweh had forgiven him, but nevertheless there would be consequences. The child whom David had fathered would die, and there would be perpetual violence within David's family. David fasted and prayed in the hopes that Yahweh would spare the child, but the child died. David showed that he respected Yahweh's will by ending his fast and going to worship Yahweh. Later, David and Bathsheba had another child, one whom Yahweh welcomed. David also participated in the final conquest of the Ammonite capital city of Rabbah.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

In verses 7–12, where Nathan gives David a message from Yahweh, there is a long quotation within a quotation. The entire message is something that Nathan said that the author is quoting, so that is a first-level quotation. But within this message, Nathan tells David what Yahweh has said, so that is a quotation within a quotation, or a second-level quotation. Your language may use quotation marks or some other punctuation or convention to indicate various levels of quotation. The ULT and UST models ways to do that. You could also translate the whole message in such a way that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Notes suggest how you might do that.

Textual Issues in This Chapter

"the enemies of Yahweh" (12:14)

In 12:14, Nathan tells David that he has utterly spurned "the enemies of Yahweh." The Septuagint (an ancient Greek translation of the Hebrew Bible) and three of the Dead Sea Scrolls (ancient manuscripts that are independent of the traditional Hebrew text) do not have the expression "the enemies of." Some interpreters suggest that out of respect for David, in order to avoid saying that he had utterly spurned Yahweh, later scribes may have substituted the phrase about Yahweh's enemies for a direct reference to Yahweh

himself. Scribes may have done similar things in other places. (For example, if you have already translated the book of 1 Samuel, see how you translated the expression in 1 Samuel 20:16 about "the enemies of David.") Another possibility is that the word translated as "spurned" has a meaning here that it does not have in other places. Here it might mean that David has given the enemies of Yahweh occasion to blaspheme him, that is, to say that worshiping Yahweh does not make someone a better person. If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to use the reading that it uses. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to use the reading of the ULT.

2 Samuel 12:1 (#1)

וַיֹּ֥אמֶר לוֹ֖

"and he said to him"

To help David understand what Yahweh has sent him to say, Nathan tells David a story as if it were true. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could state that explicitly. Alternate translation: [and to help him understand what Yahweh had sent him to say, he told him a story as if it were true. He said to him]

See: Parables

2 Samuel 12:1 (#2)

אֶחָ֣ד עָשִׁ֔יר וְאֶחָ֖ד רָאֹֽשׁ

"one rich and one poor"

Nathan is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [One man was rich, and the other one was poor]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 12:2 (#1)

לֶֽעָשִׁ֑יר

"To the rich {one"

The author is using the adjective **rich** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. The ULT indicates this by adding the word **one**. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [To the rich man]

See: Nominal Adjectives

2 Samuel 12:3 (#1)

כִּבְשָׂ֣ה אַחַ֔ת קְטַנָּ֖ה

"one little ewe"

A **ewe** is a female sheep. If your readers would not be familiar with what a ewe is, you could use the name of a similar thing that your readers would recognize, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [a young female sheep]

See: Translate Unknowns

2 Samuel 12:3 (#2)

מִפִּתּ֥וֹ

"from his morsel"

The author is not referring to a specific **morsel**. He means portions of food in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [scraps of food that he gave it]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

2 Samuel 12:4 (#1)

הַֽלֶּ֔דֶךְ׃ & לְאֹרֵ֣חַ הַבָּ֔א־לְ֖לוֹ

"a traveler & for the wayfarer having come to him"

Nathan uses two different terms to describe the rich man's guest. The first term, **traveler**, simply refers to someone who is on a journey. The second term, **wayfarer**, refers in this context to a traveler whom someone has taken into his home as a guest. If your language has separate words or phrases that express these ideas, it would be appropriate to use them in your translation. Alternate translation: [a man who was on a journey ... his guest]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 12:5 (#1)

וַיִּֽחַר־אַ֤ף דָּוִד֙ בָּאִ֣ישׁ מְאֹ֔ד

"And the nose of David burned greatly against the man"

See how you translated the similar expression in 6:7. Alternate translation: [And David became very angry with the man]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 12:5 (#3)

בֶּן־מָ֖וֶת

"is} a son of death"

In certain contexts, biblical authors and characters use the expression **son of** to indicate that a person has the characteristic of something. In this case, David is saying that the rich man has the characteristic of **death**, in the sense that David feels he deserves to die for what he did. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an equivalent expression from your language or state the meaning plainly. If you have already translated the book of 1 Samuel, see how you translated the similar expression in 1 Samuel 26:16. Alternate translation: [deserves to die]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 12:5 (#2)

חַי־יְהוָה

“The life of Yahweh”

See how you translated the similar expression in 2:27. Alternate translation: [I swear by Yahweh]

See: Oath Formulas

2 Samuel 12:6 (#2)

לֹא־חָמָל

“he did not spare”

David is using the same term, **spare**, that Nathan used in his story. Nathan said that the rich man spared all of the animals in his flock and herd from being butchered, while David means that the rich man did not spare the poor man, that is, he had no pity on him but cruelly took his lamb and butchered it. Your language may have a term that you can use meaningfully in both places in your translation. If not, be sure that the meaning of **spare** in this verse is clear. Alternate translation: [he had no pity on the poor man]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 12:6 (#1)

עֵ֚קֶב אֲשֶׁ֣ר עָשָׂ֔ה אֶת־הַדָּבָ֖ר הַזֶּ֑ה וְעַ֛ל אֲשֶׁ֥ר לֹא־חָמָֽל

“because he did this thing and because he did not spare”

The author is describing one event, **he did this thing**, before describing another event that preceded it, **he did not spare**. If it would be helpful your language, you may wish to relate these events in the order in which they happened, as in the UST. Alternate translation: [because he did not spare but instead did this thing]

See: Order of Events

2 Samuel 12:7 (#4)

מִיַּ֖ד שָׁאֽוּל

“from the hand of Saul”

Here, **hand** represents the actions of a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. See how you translated the similar expression in 3:18. Alternate translation: [from Saul when he was trying to kill you]

See: Synecdoche

2 Samuel 12:7 (#2)

כֹּה־אָמַ֞ר יְהוָ֣ה אֱלֹהֵ֣י יִשְׂרָאֵ֗ל אָנֹכִ֤י מְשַׁחְתִּ֙יךָ֙ לְמֶ֣לֶךְ
עַל־יִשְׂרָאֵ֔ל וְאָנֹכִ֖י הִצַּלְתִּ֥יךָ מִיַּ֖ד שָׁאֽוּל

“Thus says Yahweh, the God of Israel: ‘I, I anointed you as king over Israel, and I, I delivered you from the hand of Saul”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [Yahweh, the God of Israel, says that he himself anointed you as king over Israel and that he himself delivered you from the hand of Saul]

See: Quotes within Quotes

2 Samuel 12:7 (#1)

אַתָּ֥ה הָאִ֖ישׁ

“You {are} the man”

Nathan is speaking as if David actually were **the man** in his story. He means that David has done something just like what the man in the story did. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [You are just like that man] or [You have done something just like what that man did]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 12:7 (#3)

אָנֹכִ֤י מְשַׁחְתִּ֙יךָ֙ & וְאָנֹכִ֖י הִצַּלְתִּ֥יךָ

“I, I anointed you & and I, I delivered you”

See how you translated the similar expression “you, you were” in 5:2. Alternate translation: [I personally ensured that the Israelites would anoint you ... and I personally delivered you]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 12:8 (#3)

וְאֶת־נְשֵׁשֵׁי אֲדֹנֶיךָ בְּחֵיקֶךָ

“and the wives of your master into your lap”

Yahweh is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and I gave the wives of your master into your lap]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 12:8 (#6)

וְאֹסִפָה לְּךָ כָּהֵנָּה וְכָהֵנָּה

“then I would have added to you like them and like them”

Here, **like them and like them** was a common expression that described unspecified things similar to ones just mentioned. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [then I would have given to you even more of such things]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 12:8 (#4)

וְאֶת־נְשֵׁשֵׁי אֲדֹנֶיךָ בְּחֵיקֶךָ

“and the wives of your master into your lap”

Yahweh is referring to sexual intimacy in a polite way by using the phrase **into your lap**. Depending on what is helpful in your language, you could use a polite way of referring to this in your language, or you could state this plainly. Alternate translation: [and I allowed you to have your master’s harem as your own harem]

See: Euphemism

2 Samuel 12:8 (#5)

וָאֶתְּנָה לְּךָ אֶת־בֵּית יִשְׂרָאֵל וְיהוּדָה

“and I gave to you the house of Israel and Judah”

Here, **house** means all the people descended from a particular person. It envisions them as if they were one household living together. So **the house of Israel and Judah** figuratively means all the people descended from the patriarch Jacob, who was also known as Israel, including specifically those descended from his son Judah. Alternate translation: [and I made you the king of the people of Israel and Judah]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 12:8 (#1)

וָאֶתְּנָה & וָאֶתְּנָה & וְאֹסִפָה

“And I gave & and I gave & then I would have added”

Nathan is continuing to speak a message from Yahweh to David. If, in the previous verse, you started translating this so that there was not a quotation within a quotation, you can continue doing that here and through verse 12. Alternate translation: [He says that he gave ... and he gave ... then he would have added]

See: Quotes within Quotes

2 Samuel 12:8 (#2)

אֶת־בֵּית

“the house of”

The author is using the term **house** by association to mean all the people and property associated with a person. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the property and possessions of]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 12:9 (#2)

אֶת־דְּבַר יְהוָה

“the word of Yahweh”

Because he is officially rebuking David, Yahweh is speaking about himself formally in the third person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in the first person. Alternate translation: [my word]

See: First, Second or Third Person

2 Samuel 12:9 (#1)

מַדּוּעַ בָּזִיתָ ׀ אֶת־דְּבַר יְהוָה לַעֲשׂוֹת הָרַע בְּעֵינָיו

“Why have you despised the word of Yahweh to do evil in my eyes”

Yahweh is using the question form to rebuke David. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [You should not have despised the word of Yahweh to do evil in my eyes!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 12:9 (#3)

אֶת־דְּבַר יְהוָה

“the word of Yahweh”

Here, **word** represents the commandments that Yahweh gave by using words. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [my commandments]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 12:9 (#8)

בְּחֶרֶב

“with the sword of”

Here, Yahweh is using the **sword**, one kind of weapon, to represent weapons in general. (What the messenger tells David in 11:24 suggests that the Ammonites actually killed Uriah primarily with arrows.) If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [with the weapons of]

See: Synecdoche

2 Samuel 12:9 (#4)

הָרַע֙ בעינו

“evil in my eyes”

Yahweh is using **in my eyes** as a common expression of this culture to mean “in my judgment.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [what I regard as evil]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 12:9 (#7)

בַּחֶרֶב

“with the sword”

Here, **sword** represents warfare, since in this culture people used swords as a primary weapon of war. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [using warfare]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 12:9 (#9)

בְּנֵי עַמּוֹן

“the sons of Ammon”

See how you translated the similar expression in 7:6. Alternate translation: [the Ammonites]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 12:9 (#5)

אֵת֙ אוּרִיָּ֣ה הַחִתִּ֔י הִכִּ֖יתָ בַּחֶ֑רֶב וְאֶת־אִשְׁתּ֣וֹ לָקַ֤חְתָּ לְךָ֙ לְאִשָּׁ֔ה וְאֹת֥וֹ הָרַ֖גְתָּ בְּחֶ֥רֶב בְּנֵ֥י עַמּֽוֹן

“You struck Uriah the Hittite with the sword, and you took his wife for yourself as a wife, and you murdered him with the sword of the sons of Ammon”

If it would be more natural in your language, you may want to put the information about Uriah’s murder with the information about striking him with the sword, before the information about David taking his wife. Alternate translation: [You struck Uriah the Hittite with the sword, murdering him with the sword of the sons of Ammon, and then you took his wife for yourself as a wife]

See: Information Structure

2 Samuel 12:9 (#6)

בָּזִ֣יתָ & הִכִּ֔יתָ

“you despised & You struck”

See how you translated the similar expression in 1:1. Alternate translation: [you killed]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 12:10 (#1)

לֹא־תָס֥וּר חֶ֛רֶב מִבֵּיתְךָ֖ עַד־עוֹלָ֑ם עֵ֚קֶב כִּֽי־בְזִתָ֔נִי וַתִּקַּ֕ח אֶת־אֵ֖שֶׁת אוּרִיָּ֣ה הַחִתִּ֑י לִהְיוֹת֥ לְךָ֖ לְאִשָּֽׁה

“the sword will not turn away from your house to forever, because you despised me and took the wife of Uriah the Hittite to be a wife for you”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [because you despised me and took the wife of Uriah the Hittite to be a wife for you, the sword will not turn away from your house to forever]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

2 Samuel 12:10 (#4)

מִבֵּיתְךָ

“from your house”

Here, **house** means all the people descended from a particular person. It envisions them as if they were one household living together. So **the house** figuratively means all the people descended from David, here and in the next verse. Alternate translation: [from your household] or [from your family]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 12:10 (#2)

וְעַתָּה

“And now”

Speakers in this culture used the expression **And now** to introduce their main point. See how you translated this expression in 2:6.

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

2 Samuel 12:10 (#3)

לֹא־תָסוּר חֶרֶב מִבֵּיתְךָ עַד־עוֹלָם

“the sword will not turn away from your house to forever”

The author is speaking of **the sword** as if it were a living thing that could **turn away** and leave David and his family. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [there will always be deadly fighting within your house]

See: Personification

2 Samuel 12:11 (#1)

הִנְנִי֙ מֵקִ֣ים

“Behold me, raising up”

Here, **Behold me** was a common expression that speakers used to mean that they were about to do something. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I am about to raise up]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 12:11 (#2)

מֵקִים עָלֶיךָ רָעָה

“raising up harm against you”

Here, God is speaking as if harm were an object that he could be **raising up** or lifting into a higher position. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [causing harm to happen to you]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 12:11 (#3)

לְעֵינֶיךָ

“to your eyes”

Here, the **eyes** represent being aware or conscious of something happening. Yahweh does not necessarily mean that David will see this, but he will know about it. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [with your full awareness]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 12:11 (#4)

וְשָׁכַב עִם־נָשֶׁיךָ

“And he will lie with your wives”

Yahweh is referring to sexual relations in a polite way by using the phrase **lie with**. Depending on what is helpful in your language, you could use a polite way of referring to this in your language or you could state this plainly. Alternate translation: [And he will sleep with your wives]

See: Euphemism

2 Samuel 12:11 (#5)

לְעֵינֵי הַשֶּׁמֶשׁ הַזֹּאת

“to the eyes of this sun”

God is speaking of the **sun** as if it were a living thing that had **eyes** and could see. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [out in the open]

See: Personification

2 Samuel 12:12 (#3)

בַּסָּתֶר

“in secret”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **secret**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [secretly]

See: Abstract Nouns

2 Samuel 12:12 (#1)

כִּֽי

“For”

Here the word **For** introduces not a reason but further consideration. Alternate translation: [Indeed]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

2 Samuel 12:12 (#2)

אַתָּ֣ה עָשִׂ֔יתָ בַּסָּתֶ֖ר וַאֲנִ֑י אֶֽעֱשֶׂ֞ה

“you, you did {this} in secret, but I, I will do”

See how you translated the similar expression “you, you know” in 17:20. Alternate translation: [For you, for your part, did this in secret, but I, for my part, will do]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 12:12 (#4)

נֶ֚גֶד כָּל־יִשְׂרָאֵ֔ל וְנֶ֖גֶד הַשָּֽׁמֶשׁ

“before all of Israel and before the sun”

See how you translated the similar expression about the sun in the previous verse. Alternate translation: [out in the open where any Israelite can see it]

See: Hyperbole

2 Samuel 12:13 (#1)

גַּם

“also”

In this context, the word translated as **also** indicates a correspondence between what David has said, **I have sinned against Yahweh**, and what Yahweh has done, **taken away** his sin. Use a connecting word in your language that shows how Nathan’s statement relates to the statement that David made before it. Alternate translation: [consequently]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

2 Samuel 12:14 (#2)

אֶת־אֹיְבֵ֣י יְהוָ֔ה

“the enemies of Yahweh”

See the discussion of this phrase in the Introduction to this chapter.

See: Textual Variants

2 Samuel 12:14 (#4)

מָ֥וֹת יָמֽוּת

“dying, will die”

Nathan is repeating forms of the verb **die** in order to intensify his expression of the idea that it conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [will certainly die]

See: Reduplication

2 Samuel 12:14 (#1)

נָאֵ֣ץ נִאַצְתָּ֔

“spurning, you have spurned”

Nathan is repeating forms of the verb **spurn** in order to intensify his expression of the idea that it conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [you have utterly spurned]

See: Reduplication

2 Samuel 12:14 (#3)

גַּ֖ם

“also”

The word translated as **also** here has the same meaning as in the previous verse. Alternate translation: [consequently]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

2 Samuel 12:15 (#2)

אֵ֖שֶׁת־אוּרִיָּֽה

“the wife of Uriah”

Your language may have its own term or expression for this relationship, since Uriah was now dead and Bathsheba was no longer his legal **wife**. Alternate translation: [the widow of Uriah]

See: Kinship

2 Samuel 12:15 (#1)

וַיִּגֹּ֥ף יְהוָ֛ה אֶת־הַיֶּ֖לֶד אֲשֶׁ֣ר יָלְדָ֑ה אֶֽשֶׁת־אוּרִיָּ֖ה לְדָוִ֥ד וַיֵּאָנָֽשׁ

“And Yahweh struck the child whom the wife of Uriah had borne to David, and he became sick”

Here, the author is speaking as Yahweh had physically **struck** a blow against this **child**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly.

Alternate translation: [And Yahweh caused the child whom the wife of Uriah had borne to David to become sick]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 12:16 (#2)

וַיְצַם דָּוִד צוֹם וּבָבָא וְלָלַן וְשָׁכַב אָרְצָה

“And David fasted a fast, and he went in and lodged and lay on the ground”

Abstaining from food and lying on the ground were symbolic actions by which David expressed deep mourning and humility before God. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of these actions in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [David showed his deep sorrow by refusing to eat and by going inside and spending the night lying on the ground]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 12:16 (#3)

וַיְצַם דָּוִד צוֹם

“And David fasted a fast”

It might seem that the expression **fasted a fast** contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [And David fasted] or [And David kept a fast]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 12:16 (#4)

וְלָלַן וְשָׁכַב אָרְצָה

“and lodged and lay on the ground”

The phrase **lodged and lay on the ground** expresses a single idea. The phrase **lay on the ground** tells how David **lodged**, that is, how he slept at night. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning in a different way. Alternate translation: [and lodged by lying on the ground] or [and slept on the floor at night]

See: Hendiadys

2 Samuel 12:16 (#1)

וַיְבַקֵּשׁ דָּוִד אֶת־הָאֱלֹהִים

“And David sought God”

Here, the author is speaking as if David had actually **sought** or looked for God somewhere. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And David entreated God]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 12:17 (#1)

בֵּיתוֹ

“his house”

See how you translated the similar expression in 2:3. Alternate translation: [his household]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 12:17 (#3)

לָחֶם

“bread”

The author is using **bread** to represent food in general. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [food]

See: Synecdoche

2 Samuel 12:17 (#2)

וַיָּקֻמוּ & עָלָיו

“And & arose upon him”

See how you translated the similar expression in 2:14. Alternate translation: [took action regarding]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 12:18 (#3)

וְלֹא־שָׁמַע בְּקוֹלֵנוּ

“but he did not listen to our voice”

In this verse, the word **voice** is singular in form, but the servants are using it to refer to all of their voices. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use the plural form of “voice.” Alternate translation: [but he did not listen to our voices]

See: Collective Nouns

2 Samuel 12:18 (#7)

וְאֵאָיךְ נֹאמַר אֵלָיו מֵת הַיֶּלֶד

“So how shall we say to him, ‘The child has died”

The servants are using the question form to emphasize that they think it would be risky to tell David that his child has died. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could

translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [So we cannot safely say to him, 'The child has died'!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 12:18 (#5)

וְלֹא־שָׁמַע בְּקוֹלֵנוּ

"but he did not listen to our voice"

See the discussion in the Introduction to 2 Samuel of this use of the term "listen." Alternate translation: [but he did not agree to do what we said]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 12:18 (#1)

וַיְהִי

"And it happened"

The author is using this phrase to introduce a new development in the story. Use a word, phrase, or other method in your language that is natural for introducing a new development.

See: Introduction of a New Event

2 Samuel 12:18 (#2)

הִנֵּה

"Behold"

See how you translated the similar expression in 1:2.

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 12:18 (#4)

וְלֹא־שָׁמַע בְּקוֹלֵנוּ

"but he did not listen to our voice"

The servants are speaking of their **voice** to represent what they said to David by using their voices. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [but he did not listen to what we said]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 12:18 (#6)

וְאֵאֵיךְ נֹאמַר אֵלָיו מֵת הַיֶּלֶד

"So how shall we say to him, 'The child has died"

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [So how can we tell him that the child has died?]

See: Quotes within Quotes

2 Samuel 12:20 (#2)

לֶחֶם

"bread"

The author is using **bread** to represent food in general. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [food] or [a meal]

See: Synecdoche

2 Samuel 12:20 (#1)

וַיָּקָם דָּוִד מֵהָאָרֶץ וַיִּרְחַץ וַיָּסָךְ וַיְחַלֵּף שִׂמלתו

"Then David arose from the ground, and he washed, and he anointed {himself}, and he changed his clothes"

Getting up from the ground, washing, anointing himself, and changing his clothes were symbolic actions by which David showed that he was accepting God's decision about his child. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [Then David showed that he accepted God's will regarding the child by getting up from the ground, washing himself, putting olive oil on his hair and body, and changing into clean clothes]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 12:22 (#3)

מִמִּי יוֹדֵעַ יחנני יְהוָה

"Who knows? Yahweh may be gracious to me"

David is using the question form to express uncertainty about what might happen. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [For all anyone knows, Yahweh may be gracious to me]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 12:22 (#1)

אָמַרְתִּי מִמִּי יוֹדֵעַ יחנני יְהוָה וְחַי הַיָּלֶד

"I said, 'Who knows? Yahweh may be gracious to me, and the child may live"

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [I said that for all

anyone knew, Yahweh might be gracious to me and the child might live]

See: Quotes within Quotes

2 Samuel 12:22 (#2)

אָמַ֣רְתִּי

“I said”

See how you translated the similar expression in 10:2. Alternate translation: [I thought]

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

2 Samuel 12:23 (#1)

לָֽמָּה זֶּה֙ אֲנִ֣י צָ֔ם הַאוּכַ֖ל לַהֲשִׁיבֹ֑ו עֹ֣וד

“Why {is} this, {that} I should fast? Am I able to bring him back again”

David is using the question form to emphasize that there is no reason to continue fasting since he cannot bring his son back to life. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate these questions as statements or as exclamations. Alternate translation: [I have no reason to fast any longer. I am not able to bring him back again.]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 12:23 (#2)

וְה֥וּא לֹא־יָשׁ֖וּב

“but he, he will not return”

See how you translated the similar expression “you, you know” in 17:20. Alternate translation: [but he, for his part, will not return]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 12:24 (#2)

ויקרא אֶת־שְׁמֹ֖ו שְׁלֹמֹֽה

“and he called his name Solomon”

It might seem that the expression **called his name** contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [and he called him Solomon]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 12:24 (#1)

וַיִּשְׁכַּ֥ב עִמָּ֖הּ

“and lay with her”

The author is referring to sexual relations in a polite way by using the phrase **lay with her**. Depending on what is helpful in your language, you could use a polite way of referring to this in your language or you could state this plainly. Alternate translation: [and slept with her]

See: Euphemism

2 Samuel 12:25 (#2)

וַיִּקְרָ֗א אֶת־שְׁמֹו֙ יְדִֽידְיָ֔ה בַּעֲבֻ֖ר יְהוָֽה

“and he called his name Jedidiah because of Yahweh”

The name **Jedidiah** means “beloved of Yahweh.” The pronoun **he** could mean: (1) that Yahweh named the child Jedidiah. Alternate translation: [and Yahweh gave him the name Jedidiah because he loved him]; (2) that Nathan named the child Jedidiah. Alternate translation: [and Nathan called his name Jedidiah, since Yahweh loved him]; (3) that David named the child Jedidiah. Alternate translation: [and David called his name Jedidiah, since Yahweh loved him]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 12:25 (#3)

וַיִּקְרָ֖א אֶת־שְׁמֹֽו

“and he called his name”

See how you translated the similar expression in 12:24. Alternate translation: [and he called him]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 12:25 (#1)

וַיִּשְׁלַ֤ח בְּיַד֙ נָתָ֣ן הַנָּבִ֔יא

“And he sent by the hand of Nathan the prophet”

The author is using one part of Nathan, his **hand**, to mean all of him in the act of bringing a message from Yahweh, as if he had carried that message in his hand. Alternate translation: [And Yahweh sent Nathan the prophet to bring a message from him]

See: Synecdoche

2 Samuel 12:26 (#1)

וַיִּלָּ֥חֶם יוֹאָ֖ב

“And Joab fought”

The word that the ULT translates as **And** indicates that Joab fought against Rabbah at the same time as when the events described in the previous part of this chapter took place in Jerusalem. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could describe the time relationship more explicitly. Alternate translation: [At the same time, Joab was fighting]

See: Connect — Simultaneous Time Relationship

2 Samuel 12:27 (#1)

וַיִּשְׁלַ֤ח יוֹאָב֙ מַלְאָכִ֔ים אֶל־דָּוִ֖ד וַיֹּ֣אמֶר

“And Joab sent messengers to David, and he said”

The author is speaking as if Joab himself **said** this to David. The author means that the messengers Joab sent said this to David on his behalf. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [And Joab sent messengers to David, and those messengers said on Joab’s behalf]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 12:27 (#3)

אֶת־עִ֥יר הַמָּ֖יִם

“the city of waters”

Joab is using the possessive form to describe the part of this **city** that was characterized by **waters**. If your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the part of the city near the water]

See: Possession

2 Samuel 12:27 (#2)

גַּ֖ם

“Also”

See how you translated the similar expression in 12:13. Alternate translation: [Consequently]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

2 Samuel 12:28 (#1)

אֶת־יֶ֣תֶר הָעָ֑ם

“the rest of the people”

See how you translated the similar expression in 1:4. Alternate translation: [the rest of the army]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 12:28 (#2)

הָעִ֔יר

“the city”

The implication is that this was the main fortified part of the city. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [the citadel] or [the fortress]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 12:28 (#4)

וְנִקְרָ֥א שְׁמִ֖י עָלָֽיהָ

“and my name be called to it”

Joab is using **my name be called to it** as a common expression of his culture to mean “people give me credit for capturing it.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and it be named after me]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 12:28 (#3)

פֶּן־אֶלְכֹּ֤ד אֲנִי֙ אֶת־הָעִ֔יר וְנִקְרָ֥א שְׁמִ֖י עָלָֽיהָ

“lest I myself capture the city and my name be called to it”

Joab is using the word translated as **lest** to introduce an outcome that he does not want to happen. Because he does not want this outcome to happen, he first encourages David to do something so that this will not happen. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that avoiding this outcome is the purpose of the encouragement. Alternate translation: [otherwise, I myself will capture the city and my name will be called to it]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

2 Samuel 12:30 (#2)

וּמִשְׁקָלָ֣הּ כִּכֶּ֣כֶר זָהָ֔ב

“and its weight {was} a talent of gold”

It is possible that this expression describes the value of the crown rather than its weight, since a crown weighing 34 kilograms or 75 pounds would have been too heavy to wear. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and it was worth a talent of gold]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 12:30 (#4)

הַרְבֵּה מְאֹד

“very much”

The author is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [There was very much of it]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 12:30 (#1)

וּמִשְׁקָלָהּ כִּכַּר זָהָב

“and its weight {was} a talent of gold”

A **talent** of gold weighed about 34 kilograms or 75 pounds. In your translation, you could use the ancient measurement and spell the word “talent” the way it sounds in your language. You could also use the metric measurement given in the UST or use the measurement that your language and culture customarily use. Alternatively, you could use the ancient measurement and put a modern measurement in parentheses in the text or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [and its weight was 34 kilograms of gold] or [and its weight was 75 pounds of gold]

See: Biblical Weight

2 Samuel 12:30 (#3)

וְאֶבֶן יְקָרָה

“and a precious stone”

The author is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. He seems to be noting one particular **precious stone** of exceptional value that was in the crown. (One Jewish historian says that it was a very large sardonyx.) This does not mean that there were not other precious stones in the crown as well. Alternate translation: [and one of the stones it contained was especially precious]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel - Chapter 13 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter continues the story of what David did as the king of Israel. The prophet Nathan had told him that as a consequence of his sins of adultery and murder, there would be perpetual violence within his family. This chapter tells how that violence began. David’s oldest son Amnon committed sexual violence against one of David’s daughters, Amnon’s half-sister Tamar. Another of David’s sons, Absalom, Tamar’s full brother, then murdered Amnon for revenge and fled to another country.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

“keep silent, he is your brother”

When Absalom learned that his half-brother Amnon had raped his sister Tamar, he told Tamar, “keep silent, he is your brother.” Absalom did not mean that women should say nothing about sexual violence when it is committed by a family member. The Bible warns that sexual violence is a serious sin, and it forbids sexual relations between close family members. So what Absalom says here should not be taken as approval of either of those things. Instead, as the rest of the story indicates, Absalom wanted to pretend that he was not going to try to get revenge against Amnon. That way Amnon would be unsuspecting, and Absalom would be able to murder him. The author describes in 13:23–29 how he did that. Absalom needed Tamar not to make Amnon’s crime public. The reason he gave Tamar, “he is your brother,” may have been intended to suggest to her that making the crime public would have brought shame to the whole family. To carry out his own treacherous murder plot, Absalom appealed to Tamar’s wish for her family to have a good reputation, and in the process, he left her feeling shame for the rest of her life.

Why did Absalom flee to Talmai, the son of Ammihud, the king of Geshur?

The author reports in 13:37 that after he murdered Amnon, Absalom fled to Talmai, the son of Ammihud, the king of Geshur. The author records in 3:3 that Absalom was “the son of Maacah, the daughter of Talmai, the king of Geshur.” So Talmai was Absalom’s grandfather, his mother’s father. In many cultures in which a woman goes to live with her husband’s family when she marries, a person in trouble can flee for safety back to where his mother’s family lives. That is what Absalom did. You may have some way of indicating this naturally in your translation, in the text or in a footnote, particularly if your readers would be familiar with this cultural practice. The UST models one way to do this.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

“brother,” “sister”

Frequently in this chapter, the author and characters refer to someone as the “brother” or “sister” of some-

one who has the same father but not the same mother. Your language may have its own term or expression for this relationship, such as “half-brother” and “half-sister.” (See: Kinship)

2 Samuel 13:1 (#1)

וַיְהִי

“And it happened”

The author is using the word translated **And it happened** to introduce a new event in the story. Use a word, phrase, or other method in your language that is natural for introducing a new event.

See: Introduction of a New Event

2 Samuel 13:1 (#2)

וּלְאַבְשָׁלוֹם בֶּן & אֲחוֹת יָפָה וּשְׁמָהּ תָּמָר & דָּוִד

“that to Absalom, the son of David, {was} a beautiful sister, and her name {was} Tamar”

Here the author is introducing **Tamar** as a new participant in the story. Your language may have its own way of introducing new participants that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [that there was a beautiful young woman named Tamar who was the sister of Absalom, David’s son]

See: Introduction of New and Old Participants

2 Samuel 13:1 (#3)

דָּוִד & וַיֶּאֱהָבֶהָ אַמְנוֹן בֶּן

“and Amnon, the son of David, loved her”

The rest of the story makes clear that Amnon felt sexual desire for Tamar but that he did not care about her as a person, and he was not unselfishly devoted to her. If your language has different words for love, in your translation, use the word that indicates sexual desire.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 13:2 (#2)

וַיֵּצַר לְאַמְנוֹן לְהִתְחַלּוֹת

“And it narrowed to Amnon, so that he made himself sick”

The author is using the expression **it narrowed to Amnon** as a common expression of his culture to mean that Amnon became very distressed. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And Amnon felt so thwarted that he became sick] or [And Amnon felt so distressed that he became sick]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 13:2 (#3)

אֲחֹתֹו

“his sister”

Here and throughout the chapter, the author and characters refer to Tamar as Amnon’s **sister**. Since they had the same father but different mothers, your language may have its own term or expression for this relationship that you can use in your translation.

See: Kinship

2 Samuel 13:2 (#1)

וַיֵּצֶר לְאַמְנוֹן לְהִתְחַלּוֹת בַּעֲבוּר תָּמָר אֲחֹתֹו כִּי בְתוּלָה הִהִיא וַיִּפָּלֵא בְּעֵינֵי אַמְנוֹן לַעֲשׂוֹת לָהּ מְאוּמָה

“And it narrowed to Amnon, so that he made himself sick over Tamar his sister. For she {was} a virgin, so it was difficult in the eyes of Amnon to do anything to her”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [She {was} a virgin, so it was difficult in the eyes of Amnon to do anything to her. As a result, it narrowed to Amnon, so that he made himself sick over Tamar his sister]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

2 Samuel 13:2 (#4)

וַיִּפָּלֵא בְּעֵינֵי אַמְנוֹן

“so it was difficult in the eyes of Amnon”

The author is using the expression **in the eyes of** to mean “in the judgment of” or “in the opinion of.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [so Amnon considered it difficult]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 13:3 (#1)

וּלְאַמְנוֹן רֵעַ וּשְׁמוֹ יְהוֹנָדָב בֶּן־שִׁמְעָה אֲחִי דָוִד וְיְהוֹנָדָב אִישׁ חָכָם מְאֹד

“Now to Amnon {was} a friend, and his name {was} Jonadab, the son of Shimeah the brother of David. And Jonadab {was} a very cunning man”

Here the author is introducing **Jonadab** as a new participant in the story. Your language may have its own way of introducing new participants that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [Now there was a man named Jonadab, the son of David's brother Shimeah, who was a very cunning man and who was a friend of Amnon]

See: Introduction of New and Old Participants

2 Samuel 13:4 (#1)

וַיֹּ֣אמֶר לֹ֔ו

"And he said to him"

The pronoun **he** refers to Jonadab, while the pronoun **him** refers to Amnon. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [And Jonadab said to Amnon]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 13:4 (#4)

הֲלֹ֖ואּ תַּגִּ֣יד לִ֑י

"Will you not declare to me"

Jonadab is using the question form as a polite way of urging Amnon to tell him what is wrong. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Please declare to me]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 13:4 (#2)

בֶּן־הַמֶּ֥לֶךְ

"son of the king"

Jonadab is referring to Amnon by the respectful title **son of the king**. Use a comparable title or expression for addressing someone in such a position respectfully in your language. Alternate translation: [Your Highness] or [Prince Amnon]

See: Politeness

2 Samuel 13:4 (#5)

אָחִ֛י

"my brother"

Here and throughout the chapter, the author and characters refer to Absalom and Amnon as each other's **brother**. Since they had the same father but different mothers, your language may have its own term or expression for this relationship that you can use in your translation.

See: Kinship

2 Samuel 13:4 (#3)

בַּבֹּ֥קֶר בַּבֹּ֖קֶר

"by morning, by morning"

The author is using **by morning, by morning** as a common expression of his culture to mean "every morning." If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [every morning]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 13:5 (#2)

לֶ֔חֶם

"bread"

Jonadab is using **bread** to represent a meal or food in general. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [a meal]

See: Synecdoche

2 Samuel 13:5 (#3)

לְעֵינַ֣י

"to my eyes"

Here, **to my eyes** represents "where I can see." If it would be helpful in your language, in your translation you could use an equivalent expression or plain language, here and in verses 6 and 8. Alternate translation: [in my sight]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 13:5 (#1)

וְאָמַרְתָּ֣ אֵלָ֗יו תְּתָּבֹא נָ֤א ׀ תָּמָר֙ אֲחוֹתִ֣י וְתַכְרֵ֣נִי לֶ֔חֶם וְעָשְׂתָ֥ה לְעֵינַ֖י אֶת־הַבִּרְיָ֑ה לְמַ֨עַן֙ אֶרְאֶ֣ה וְאֹכְלָ֔ה מִיָּדָ֖הּ

"and you shall say to him, 'Please let Tamar my sister come and let her serve me bread, and let her make the food to my eyes so that I may see, and I will eat from her hand"

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [and you shall ask

him please to let Tamar your sister come and let her serve you bread, and let her make the food to your eyes so that you may see, and you will eat from her hand]

See: Quotes within Quotes

2 Samuel 13:5 (#4)

מִיָּדָהּ

“from her hand”

Here, **hand** represents the service and care of Tamar bringing food to Amnon. If it would be helpful in your language, in your translation you could use an equivalent expression or plain language here and in verses 6 and 10. Alternate translation: [if she serves it to me]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 13:6 (#1)

לִבְבֹת

“pancakes”

A **pancake** is a kind of flat bread cooked in a pan. If your readers would not be familiar with what a pancake is, you could use the name of a similar thing that your readers would recognize, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [flat bread] or [breadcakes]

See: Translate Unknowns

2 Samuel 13:7 (#1)

הַבַּיְתָה

“at the house”

The implication is that Tamar lived in the women’s quarters of David’s palace. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [in the women’s apartments in his palace]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 13:9 (#2)

הוֹצִיאוּ כָל־אִישׁ מֵעָלָי

“Make every man go out from me”

Here the masculine term **man** has a generic sense that includes both men and women. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use language in your translation that is clearly inclusive of both men and women. Alternate translation: [Make every person go out from me]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

2 Samuel 13:9 (#3)

הוֹצִיאוּ כָל־אִישׁ מֵעָלָי

“Make every man go out from me”

While this is a plural imperative that Amnon appears to be using to tell two or more people to **Make** everyone in the room leave, he is actually addressing everyone in the room except Tamar and telling them to leave. Translate this with the appropriate verbal form in your language. Alternate translation: [All of you people, go out from me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

2 Samuel 13:9 (#1)

לְפָנָיו

“to his face”

Here, **to his face** represents “in front of him.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in front of him]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 13:11 (#3)

אֲחוֹתִי

“my sister”

In this context, Amnon may be using the word **sister** not to describe a kinship relationship but as a term of endearment, as in Song of Songs 4:9 and several other places in that book. Your language may have a comparable term that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [my darling]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 13:11 (#1)

בּוֹאִי שִׁכְבִי עִמִּי

“Come, lie with me”

Amnon is not telling Tamar to **Come** somewhere. She is already in his room. He is saying **Come** to mean that he wants her to take action. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. You could also use plain language. Alternate translation: [Come on, lie with me]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 13:11 (#2)

שִׁכְבִ֥י עִמִּֽי

“lie with me”

Amnon is referring to having sexual relations in a polite way by using the phrase **lie with me**. Depending on what is helpful in your language, you could use a polite way of referring to this in your language or you could state this plainly. Alternate translation: [sleep with me]

See: Euphemism

2 Samuel 13:12 (#2)

לֹא־יֵעָשֶׂ֥ה כֵּ֖ן בְּיִשְׂרָאֵ֑ל

“it is not done thus in Israel”

The expression **it is not done** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [people in Israel do not do thus]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 13:12 (#1)

אַל־תְּעַנֵּ֔נִי כִּ֚י לֹא־יֵעָשֶׂ֣ה כֵּ֔ן בְּיִשְׂרָאֵ֑ל

“do not humble me, for it is not done thus in Israel”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [it is not done thus in Israel, so do not humble me]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

2 Samuel 13:12 (#4)

אֶת־הַנְּבָלָ֥ה הַזֹּ֖את

“this wickedness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **wickedness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [this wicked thing]

See: Abstract Nouns

2 Samuel 13:12 (#3)

אַל־תְּעַנֵּ֔נִי

“do not humble me”

Here the expression **humble me** has the sense of forcibly violating and raping a woman. You could translate the expression that way if that would be clearer for your readers. Alternate translation: [do not rape me]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 13:13 (#4)

וְעַתָּה֙

“And now”

And now was an expression that speakers in this culture commonly used to introduce their main topic. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. You could also use plain language. See how you translated the similar expression in 2:6.

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

2 Samuel 13:13 (#3)

אָ֣נָה אוֹלִ֔יךְ אֶת־חֶרְפָּתִ֑י

“where would I bring my shame”

Here, Tamar is speaking as if **shame** were actually something that could be carried to a different place. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I could never get rid of my shame]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 13:13 (#6)

לֹ֣א יִמְנָעֵ֔נִי מִמֶּ֖ךָּ

“he would not withhold me from you”

This is a double negative, consisting of the negative particle **not** and the negative word **withhold**. If it would be clearer in your language, you could use a positive expression to translate this. Alternate translation: [he would give me to you]

See: Double Negatives

2 Samuel 13:13 (#1)

וַאֲנִ֣י & וְאַתָּ֔ה

“And I & And you”

Tamar is stating the pronouns **I** and **you** separately, even though the verbs translated as **would I bring** and **you would be** already include their meanings. She is doing that because she is comparing the situations that she and Amnon would each be in. If a speaker of your language would use explicit pronouns for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have

other ways of showing that Tamar is comparing these situations. It may not be necessary to represent the separately stated pronouns explicitly. Alternate translation: [For my part ... And for your part]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 13:13 (#2)

אָ֣נָה אוֹלִ֣יךְ אֶת־חֶרְפָּתִ֔י

“where would I bring my shame”

Tamar is using the question form to emphasize that she would be permanently disgraced if Amnon raped her. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [I would not be able to bring my shame anywhere!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 13:13 (#5)

דַּבֶּר־נָ֣נָא אֶל־הַמֶּ֔לֶךְ כִּ֥י לֹ֛א יִמְנָעֵ֥נִי מִמֶּֽךָּ

“please, speak to the king, for he would not withhold me from you”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [since the king would not withhold me from you, please speak to him]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

2 Samuel 13:14 (#2)

וַיְעַנֶּ֖הָ

“and he humbled her”

See how you translated the similar expression in 13:12. Alternate translation: [and he raped her]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 13:14 (#1)

לִשְׁמֹ֥עַ בְּקוֹלָ֖הּ

“to listen to her voice”

See how you translated the similar expression in 12:18. Alternate translation: [to do what she said]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 13:15 (#1)

מֵאַהֲבָ֣ה אֲשֶׁר־אֲהֵבָ֔הּ

“than the love {with} which he had loved her”

See how you translated the similar expression in 13:1. Alternate translation: [the sexual attraction that he had felt toward her]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 13:15 (#2)

קוּמִ֖י לֵֽכִי

“Arise, go”

While Tamar would have to **Arise** from the bed in order to **go**, Amnon seems to be saying **Arise** brusquely to tell Tamar to take action. See how you translated the similar expression in 2:14. Alternate translation: [Go on, get out of here]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 13:16 (#1)

הָרָעָ֥ה הַגְּדוֹלָ֛ה הַזֹּ֖את

“this great evil”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **evil**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [this very evil action]

See: Abstract Nouns

2 Samuel 13:16 (#2)

מֵאַחֶ֖רֶת

“than the other”

Tamar is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [is worse than the other]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 13:16 (#3)

מֵאַחֶ֖רֶת

“than the other”

Tamar is using the adjective **other** as a noun to mean a certain kind of action. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the other very evil action]

See: Nominal Adjectives

2 Samuel 13:16 (#4)

וְלֹ֥א אָבְתָ֖ה לִשְׁמֹ֥עַ לָֽהּ

“But he was not willing to listen to her”

See how you translated the similar expression in 13:14. Alternate translation: [But he was not willing to do what she said]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 13:17 (#1)

אֶת־זֹ֖את

“this {one”

Amnon is using the adjective **this** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Amnon is being hostile and dismissive toward the woman he previously admired but whom he now detests because of his own guilt. Use an expression in your translation that reflects this. The UST models one way to do that.

See: Nominal Adjectives

2 Samuel 13:18 (#3)

תִּלְבַּ֣בָּשֶׁן

“dressed {in} garments”

It might seem that the expression **dressed in garments** contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [dressed]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 13:18 (#1)

וְעָלֶ֣יהָ כְּתֹ֤נֶת פַּסִּים֙ כִּי֣ כֵ֔ן תִּלְבַּ֖שֶׁן בְּנ֣וֹת־הַמֶּ֑לֶךְ הַבְּתוּלֹ֣ת

מְעִילִ֔ים וַיֹּצֵ֥א אוֹתָ֖הּ מְשָׁרְתוֹ֙ הַח֔וּץ וְנָעַ֥ל הַדֶּ֖לֶת אַחֲרֶֽיהָ

“Now a long robe {was} on her, for thus the virgin daughters of the king dressed {in} garments. And the one attending him brought her outside, and he locked the door behind her”

If it would be more natural in your language, you may want to put the information about the servant forcing Tamar outside and locking the door first in the verse to connect it with Amnon’s instruction in the previous verse. Alternate translation: [So the one attending him brought her outside, and he locked the door behind her. Now a long robe was on her, for thus the virgin daughters of the king dressed in garments]

See: Information Structure

2 Samuel 13:18 (#4)

מְעִילִ֔ים & מְשָׁרְתוֹ֙

“And the one attending him”

The pronoun **him** refers to Amnon. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [And the one attending Amnon]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 13:18 (#2)

וְעָלֶ֣יהָ כְּתֹ֤נֶת פַּסִּים֙ כִּי֣ כֵ֔ן תִּלְבַּ֖שֶׁן בְּנ֣וֹת־הַמֶּ֑לֶךְ הַבְּתוּלֹ֣ת

“Now a long robe {was} on her, for thus the virgin daughters of the king dressed {in} garments”

The author is providing background information to help readers understand what happens next in the story. In your translation, introduce this information in a way that would be natural in your own language and culture.

See: Background Information

2 Samuel 13:19 (#2)

הָלֹ֥וךְ וְזָעָֽקָה

“going and she cried out”

The phrase **going and she cried out** expresses a single idea. The word **going** describes what she did as she **cried out**. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning in a different way. Alternate translation: [crying out as she went]

See: Hendiadys

2 Samuel 13:19 (#1)

וַתִּקַּ֤ח תָּמָר֙ אֵ֣פֶר֔ עַל־רֹאשָׁ֖הּ וּכְתֹ֣נֶת הַפַּסִּ֑ים אֲשֶׁ֥ר עָלֶ֖יהָ

קָרָ֣עָה וַתָּ֤שֶׂם יָדָהּ֙ עַל־רֹאשָׁ֔הּ

“And Tamar put ashes on her head, and she tore the long robe that {was} on her, and she put her hand on her head”

Putting ashes on her head, tearing her robe, and putting her hand on her head were symbolic actions by which Tamar showed extreme grief and distress. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [And Tamar showed her deep grief by putting ashes on her head, tearing her long robe, and putting her hand on her head]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 13:20 (#1)

הַאָמְנוֹן אָחִיךְ הָיָה עִמָּךְ

“Has Amnon your brother been with you”

Absalom is referring to sexual relations in a polite way by using the phrase **been with you**. Depending on what is helpful in your language, you could use a polite way of referring to this in your language or you could state this plainly. Alternate translation: [Has Amnon your brother slept with you?]

See: Euphemism

2 Samuel 13:20 (#2)

אַל־תָּשֶׁת־לִבֵּךְ לַדָּבָר הַזֶּה

“Do not set your heart to this matter”

Absalom is using a common expression of his culture to mean that Tamar should not continue to think about what happened and be upset about it. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Do not take this matter to heart] or [Do not dwell on this matter]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 13:20 (#3)

וְשֹׁמֵמָה

“and was desolate”

The meaning of the term **desolate** in this context is that Tamar remained unmarried because of her defilement. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and never married]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 13:21 (#1)

וַיִּיחַר לוֹ מְאֹד

“and it burned to him greatly”

See how you translated the similar expression in 3:8. Alternate translation: [And he became very angry]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 13:22 (#1)

וְלֹא־דִבֶּר אַבְשָׁלוֹם עִם־אַמְנוֹן לְמֵרָע וְעַד־טוֹב כִּי־שָׂנֵא אַבְשָׁלוֹם אֶת־אַמְנוֹן עַל־דְּבַר אֲשֶׁר עִנָּה אֶת תְּמָר אֲחֹתוֹ

“But Absalom did not speak with Amnon to evil or to good, for Absalom hated Amnon for the reason that he had humbled Tamar his sister”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [But since Absalom hated Amnon for the reason that he had humiliated Tamar his sister, Absalom did not speak with Amnon to evil or to good]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

2 Samuel 13:22 (#2)

וְלֹא־דִבֶּר אַבְשָׁלוֹם עִם־אַמְנוֹן לְמֵרָע וְעַד־טוֹב

“But Absalom did not speak with Amnon to evil or to good”

The author is referring to all of Absalom’s speech by naming two extremes, **evil** and **good**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [But Absalom did not say anything at all to Amnon about this]

See: Merism

2 Samuel 13:22 (#3)

עִנָּה

“he had humbled”

See how you translated the similar expression in 13:12. Alternate translation: [he had raped]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 13:23 (#1)

וַיְהִי

“And it happened”

The author is using the words translated **And it happened** to introduce a new development in the story. Use a word, phrase, or other method in your language that is natural for introducing a new development.

See: Introduction of a New Event

2 Samuel 13:23 (#2)

לִשְׁנָתַיִם יָמִים

“after two years of days”

Here, **days** represents "time." If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [after two years' time]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 13:24 (#3)

יֵלֶךְ־נָ֣א הַמֶּ֔לֶךְ וַעֲבָדָ֖יו

"May the king and his servants please go"

In a context such as this, your language might say "come" instead of **go**, here and in the next verse. Alternate translation: [May the king and his servants please come]

See: Go and Come

2 Samuel 13:24 (#4)

הַמֶּ֔לֶךְ וַעֲבָדָ֖יו

"the king and his servants"

Even though Absalom is addressing David directly, he is speaking of him in the third person as **the king** to show respect. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a respectful form in the second person. Alternate translation: [you, O king, and your servants]

See: First, Second or Third Person

2 Samuel 13:24 (#1)

הִנֵּה

"Behold"

See how you translated the similar expression in 1:2. Alternate translation: [Listen]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 13:24 (#2)

גֹּזְזִ֖ים לְעַבְדֶּ֑ךָ & עִם־עַבְדֶּֽךָ

"shearers {are} to your servant & with your servant"

Absalom is speaking of himself in the third person as **your servant** to show humility. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a humble form in the first person. Alternate translation: [I have hired shearers ... with me]

See: First, Second or Third Person

2 Samuel 13:25 (#2)

וְלֹ֥א נִכְבַּ֖ד עָלֶֽיךָ

"and let us not be heavy to you"

Here, the king is speaking as if he and his sons were **heavy** objects that would weigh Absalom down. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. You could also use plain language, as the UST does. Alternate translation: [so that we will not be a burden to you]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 13:25 (#1)

וְלֹ֥א נִכְבַּ֖ד עָלֶֽיךָ

"and let us not be heavy to you"

The king is using the word translated as **and** to introduce an outcome that he does not want to happen. Because of this, he first gives Absalom an instruction to follow so that this will not happen. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that avoiding this outcome is the purpose of the instruction. Alternate translation: [otherwise, we would be heavy to you]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

2 Samuel 13:25 (#3)

וַיִּפְרָץ־בּ֖וֹ וְלֹא־אָבָ֣ה לָלֶ֑כֶת וַיְבָ֖רְכֵֽהוּ

"Then he urged him, but he was not willing to go, but he blessed him"

The pronoun **he** refers to Absalom in the first instance and to David in the next two instances. The pronoun **him** refers to David in the first instance and to Absalom in the second instance. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Then Absalom urged David, but David was not willing to go, but David blessed Absalom]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 13:26 (#1)

לָֽמָּה֙ יֵלֵ֣ךְ עִמָּ֔ךְ

"Why should he go with you"

The king is using the question form to emphasize that Amnon does not need to go with Absalom. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [There is no need for him to go with you.]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 13:28 (#1)

רְא֣וּ

“See”

Here, Absalom is speaking as if to pay attention meant to **See**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Listen]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 13:28 (#3)

וְאָמַרְתִּתִי אֲלֵיכֶם הַכּוּ אֶת־אַמְנוֹן

“and I say to you, ‘Strike Amnon”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [and I call out to you to strike Amnon,]

See: Quotes within Quotes

2 Samuel 13:28 (#4)

הֲלֹוֹא כִּכִי אָנֹכִי צִוִּיתִי אֶתְכֶם

“Is it} not that I, I have commanded you”

Absalom is using the question form to emphasize that he himself has given this command. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [It is I myself who have commanded you.]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 13:28 (#7)

חִזְקוּ וִהְיוּ לִבְנֵי־חָיִל

“Be courageous and be sons of valor”

The expressions **Be courageous** and **be sons of valor** mean similar things. Absalom is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [Be very courageous]

See: Doublet

2 Samuel 13:28 (#5)

אָנֹכִי צִוִּיתִי אֶתְכֶם

“I, I have commanded you”

See how you translated the similar expression “you, you were” in 5:2. Alternate translation: [I have commanded you personally]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 13:28 (#6)

חִזְקוּ וִהְיוּ לִבְנֵי־חָיִל

“Be courageous and be sons of valor”

In certain contexts, biblical authors and characters use the expression **sons of** to indicate that a person has a certain characteristic. In this case, Absalom means that he wants his servants to have the characteristic of **valor**. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an equivalent expression from your language or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Be courageous and be brave men]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 13:28 (#2)

כְּטוֹב לֵב & בַּיַּיִן

“when & is} good of heart with wine”

Absalom is using **good of heart with wine** as a common expression of his culture to describe Amnon beginning to become drunk from the wine he would serve. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [is tipsy from the wine] or [has begun to become drunk from the wine]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 13:30 (#1)

וְהַשְּׁמֻעָה בָּאָה אֶל־דָּוִד לֵאמֹר

“and the report came to David, saying”

The author is speaking of **the report** as if it were a living thing that could have come to David. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and someone brought a report to David, saying]

See: Personification

2 Samuel 13:30 (#2)

הִכָּה אַבְשָׁלוֹם אֶת־כָּל־בְּנֵי הַמֶּלֶךְ וְלֹא־נוֹתַר מֵהֶם אֶחָד

“Absalom has struck all of the sons of the king, and not one of them is left”

These two phrases **Absalom has struck all of the sons of the king** and **not one of them is left** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis

in another way. Alternate translation: [Absalom has killed every single one of the king's sons]

See: Parallelism

2 Samuel 13:30 (#3)

הִכָּה

"has struck"

See how you translated the similar expression in 12:9. Alternate translation: [has murdered]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 13:30 (#4)

נוֹתַר

"is left"

The expression **is left** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [remains alive]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 13:31 (#1)

וַיִּקְרַע אֶת־בְּגָדָיו וַיִּשְׁכַּב אָרְצָה וְכָל־עֲבָדָיו נִצָּבִים קְרֻעֵי בְגָדִים

"and he tore his clothes, and he lay on the ground, and all of his servants were standing, torn of clothes"

Tearing his clothes and lying on the ground were symbolic actions by which David showed extreme grief and distress. David's servants similarly tore their clothes to show their grief. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of these actions in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [and he showed his deep anguish by tearing his clothes and lying on the ground, and all his servants stood there, having also torn their clothes in grief]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 13:31 (#2)

קְרֻעֵי בְגָדִים

"torn of clothes"

The expression **torn of clothes** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [having torn their clothes]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 13:32 (#1)

וַיַּעַן יוֹנָדָב ׀ בֶּן־שִׁמְעָה אֲחִי־דָוִד וַיֹּאמֶר

"But Jonadab, the son of Shimeah the brother of David, answered and said"

The expression **and said** introduces a direct quotation. In your translation, use a natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language. It may not be necessary to represent this expression explicitly. Alternate translation: [But Jonadab, the son of Shimeah the brother of David, responded]

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

2 Samuel 13:32 (#3)

אַל־יֹאמַר אֲדֹנִי אֶת כָּל־הַנְּעָרִים בְּנֵי־הַמֶּלֶךְ הֻמְּתוּ

"May my lord not say, 'All of the young men, the sons of the king, have been killed"

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [May my lord not say that all of the young men, the sons of the king, have been killed]

See: Quotes within Quotes

2 Samuel 13:32 (#2)

אַל־יֹאמַר אֲדֹנִי אֶת כָּל־הַנְּעָרִים בְּנֵי־הַמֶּלֶךְ הֻמְּתוּ כִּי־אַמְנוֹן לְבַדּוֹ מֵת

"May my lord not say, 'All of the young men, the sons of the king, have been killed,' for Amnon alone has died"

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Since Amnon alone has died, may my lord not say, 'All of the young men, the sons of the king, have been killed.']

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

2 Samuel 13:32 (#4)

אַל־יֹאמַר אֲדֹנִי

"May my lord not say"

Even though Jonadab is addressing David directly, he is speaking of him in the third person as **my lord** to show respect. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a respectful form in the

second person. Alternate translation: [Please do not say, my lord]

See: First, Second or Third Person

2 Samuel 13:32 (#5)

אֵת כָּל־הַנְּעָרִים בְּנֵי־הַמֶּלֶךְ הֻמְּתוּ

“All of the young men, the sons of the king, have been killed”

The expression **have been killed** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Absalom has killed all of the young men, the sons of the king] or [All of the young men, the sons of the king, are dead]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 13:32 (#6)

כִּי

“For”

Here the word **For** provides not a reason but an explanation. Alternate translation: [You see]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

2 Samuel 13:32 (#8)

מִיּוֹם עַנֹּתוֹ אֶת תָּמָר אֲחֹתוֹ

“from the day of his humbling Tamar his sister”

The pronoun **his** refers to Amnon in the first instance and to Absalom in the second instance. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state these names explicitly. Alternate translation: [from the day when Amnon humbled Absalom’s sister Tamar]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 13:32 (#7)

עַל־פִּי אַבְשָׁלוֹם הָיְתָה שׂוּמָה

“it was placed on the mouth of Absalom”

By saying **it was placed on the mouth of Absalom**, Jonadab is using a common expression of his culture to mean that Absalom had been talking about this. (The context suggests that he had been talking about it only to himself or perhaps a few close confidants over the previous two years, not talking about it publicly.) If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Absalom has been telling himself that he would do this]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 13:33 (#2)

אַל־יָשֵׂם אֲדֹנִי הַמֶּלֶךְ אֶל־לִבּוֹ דָּבָר

“may my lord the king not put the matter to his heart”

See how you translated the similar expression in 13:20. Alternate translation: [may my lord the king not be distressed about the matter]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 13:33 (#3)

אַל־יָשֵׂם אֲדֹנִי הַמֶּלֶךְ

“may my lord the king not put”

Even though Jonadab is addressing David directly, he is speaking of him in the third person as **my lord the king** to show respect. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a respectful form in the second person. Alternate translation: [may you, my lord the king, not put]

See: First, Second or Third Person

2 Samuel 13:33 (#4)

לֵאמֹר כָּל־בְּנֵי הַמֶּלֶךְ מֵתוּ

“saying, ‘All of the sons of the king have died”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [saying that all of the sons of the king have died]

See: Quotes within Quotes

2 Samuel 13:33 (#1)

אַל־יָשֵׂם אֲדֹנִי הַמֶּלֶךְ אֶל־לִבּוֹ דָּבָר לֵאמֹר כָּל־בְּנֵי הַמֶּלֶךְ מֵתוּ כִּי־אִם־אַמְנוֹן לְבַדּוֹ מֵת

“may my lord the king not put the matter to his heart, saying, ‘All of the sons of the king have died,’ for only Amnon has died”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [since only Amnon has died, may my lord the king not put the matter to his heart, saying, ‘All of the sons of the king have died.’]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

2 Samuel 13:34 (#2)

וַיִּשָּׂא & אֶת־עֵינוֹ

“And & lifted his eyes”

The author is using **lifted his eyes** as a common expression of his culture to mean that this young man looked off into the distance. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. If you have already translated the book of 1 Samuel, see how you translated the similar expression in 1 Samuel 6:13. Alternate translation: [looked off into the distance]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 13:34 (#1)

וַיִּבְרַח אַבְשָׁלוֹם

“Now Absalom had fled”

The author is providing background information to help readers understand what happens next in the story. In your translation, introduce this information in a way that would be natural in your own language and culture. Alternate translation: [By this time, Absalom had already escaped] or [Meanwhile, Absalom had run away]

See: Background Information

2 Samuel 13:34 (#3)

וַיַּ֤רְא וְהִנֵּ֨ה עַם־רַ֜ב הֹלְכִ֗ים

“and he saw, and behold, many people were coming”

Here and in the next two verses, the term **behold** calls attention to the information that follows. Your language may have its own way of calling attention to information that you can use in your translation.

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 13:34 (#4)

אַחֲרָיו

“behind him”

The author is indicating a direction in the way that was customary in his culture, in which people spoke as if someone were facing in the direction of the sunrise. So **behind him** would mean in the direction of the sunset, or to the west. Your culture may have its own way of indicating directions that you can use in your translation. You could also use plain language. Alternate translation: [from the west]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 13:35 (#1)

הַמֶּ֔לֶךְ & בְּנֵי־הַמֶּ֖לֶךְ & עַבְדְּךָ֑

“the king & the sons of the king & your servant”

Jonadab is speaking in the third person respectfully about David as **the king** and about himself humbly as **your servant**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in the second person and the first person. Alternate translation: [your sons ... I, your servant]

See: First, Second or Third Person

2 Samuel 13:36 (#3)

בָּכֹ֥ו בָּכֶ֖י גְּדֹולָ֥ה מְאֹֽד

“wept a very great weeping”

It might seem that the expression **wept a very great weeping** contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [wept very greatly]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 13:36 (#1)

וַיִּשְׂאוּ֙ קוֹלָ֔ם וַיִּבְכּ֖וּ

“and they lifted up their voice and wept”

See how you translated the similar expression in 3:32. Alternate translation: [and they wept very loudly]

See: Hendiadys

2 Samuel 13:36 (#2)

קוֹלָ֔ם

“their voice”

In this verse, the word **voice** is singular in form, but the author is using it to refer to the voices of all of David’s sons. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use the plural form of “voice.” Alternate translation: [their voices]

See: Collective Nouns

2 Samuel 13:37 (#2)

כָּל־הַיָּמִים

“all of the days”

The author is using **all of the days** as a common expression of his culture to mean “every day” or “continually.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [day after day]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 13:37 (#1)

עַל־בְּנֹֽו

“for his son”

The phrase **for his son** refers to Amnon, who had been killed. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [for his son Amnon]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 13:39 (#2)

וַתְּכַל֙ דָּוִ֣ד הַמֶּ֔לֶךְ לָצֵ֖את אֶל־אַבְשָׁל֑וֹם

“And it ceased, David the king to go out against Absalom”

This could mean: (1) that David had planned to **go out against** Absalom (that is, to attack him so that he could capture and punish him), but he **ceased** to plan that. Alternate translation: [Then David the king would no longer go out against Absalom]; (2) that David longed (another possible meaning of the term translated as **ceased**) to **go out** to see Absalom. Alternate translation: [Then David the king longed to see Absalom]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 13:39 (#1)

וַתְּכַל֙ דָּוִ֣ד הַמֶּ֔לֶךְ לָצֵ֖את אֶל־אַבְשָׁל֑וֹם כִּי־נִחַ֥ם עַל־אַמְנ֖וֹן כִּי־מֵֽת

“And it ceased, David the king to go out against Absalom, for he was comforted concerning Amnon, that he had died”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Then, since he was comforted concerning Amnon, that he had died, it ceased, David the king to go out against Absalom]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

2 Samuel 13:39 (#3)

נֻחַ֥ם

“he was comforted”

The expression **he was comforted** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [he felt consolation]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel - Chapter 14 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter continues the story of what David did as the king of Israel. It describes how Joab got a woman to go to David and tell him a story that would provide an illustration that would convince David that he should permit Absalom to return to the city of Jerusalem and not punish him for killing his half-brother Amnon. The chapter also describes Absalom’s appearance and family and how he ruthlessly got Joab to appeal to David to allow him to return to the royal court itself.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

How much did Absalom’s hair weigh?

In 14:26, the author says that when Absalom cut his hair each year, it weighed “200 shekels by the stone of the king.” The author is helping readers understand how much Absalom’s hair weighed by expressing the weight in terms of a measurement they know. The “stone of the king” was a standard for the weight of a shekel, but it is no longer certain exactly what this was. If it was the same as the shekel of the sanctuary, Absalom’s hair would have weighed about five pounds or about two kilograms, which seems improbable. Some interpreters suggest that the final version of 2 Samuel was edited during or after the Babylonian exile and that the book is referring to the Babylonian shekel as a standard that readers would recognize. In that case the weight would be about two pounds or about one kilogram, which is more probable. Since the actual weight is uncertain, in your translation, you could use the ancient measurement, “shekels by the stone of the king,” and spell the word “shekel” the way it sounds in your language. You could also use a general expression, as the UST does.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

“my lord the king”

In several places in this chapter, people who are addressing David directly speak of him in the third

person as “the king” or “my lord the king” to show respect. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a respectful form in the second person.

2 Samuel 14:1 (#2)

לֵבָב הַמֶּלֶךְ עַל־אַבְשָׁלוֹם

“the heart of the king {was} against Absalom”

Here, the **heart** represents a person’s feelings. This could mean: (1) that David felt hostile toward Absalom. That is the meaning in Daniel 11:28, the only other instance of this expression in the Bible. The rest of this chapter shows that David had to be persuaded through an elaborate ruse to allow Absalom to return to Jerusalem, and even then he would not allow him to come into his presence. Alternate translation: [that King David felt hostile toward Absalom]; (2) that David was longing to see Absalom. Many versions follow this interpretation, and you may wish to follow it if a translation of the Bible exists in your region and follows it. Alternate translation: [that King David longed to see Absalom]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 14:1 (#1)

וַיֵּדַע יוֹאָב בֶּן־צְרוּיָה כִּי־לֵבָב הַמֶּלֶךְ עַל־אַבְשָׁלוֹם

“Now Joab the son of Zeruiah knew that the heart of the king {was} against Absalom”

The author is providing background information to help readers understand what happens next in the story. In your translation, introduce this information in a way that would be natural in your own language and culture.

See: Background Information

2 Samuel 14:2 (#1)

וְלִבְשִׁי־נָא בִגְדֵי־אֵבֶל וְאַל־תָּסֹכִי שֶׁמֶן

“and please put on clothes of mourning. And you shall not anoint {yourself} {with} oil”

Putting on **clothes of mourning** and not anointing oneself **with oil** were symbolic actions that in ancient Israel showed grief and sorrow over someone who had died. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of these actions in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [and act as if you are grieving by wearing dark clothes and not applying any oil to yourself]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 14:2 (#2)

כְּאִשָּׁה זֶה

“like this woman”

Joab is not referring to a specific **woman**. He means any woman who had been **mourning many days**. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [like a woman]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

2 Samuel 14:3 (#3)

וַיָּשֶׂם יוֹאָב אֶת־הַדְּבָרִים בְּפִיהָ

“And Joab put the words in her mouth”

Here, the author is speaking as if **words** were actually objects that Joab could have placed in the woman’s **mouth**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Then Joab specified what she ought to say]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 14:3 (#1)

וּבָאתְ

“And you shall come”

In a context such as this, your language might say “go” instead of **come**. Alternate translation: [And you shall go]

See: Go and Come

2 Samuel 14:3 (#2)

כַּדָּבָר הַזֶּה

“according to this word”

Joab is using the term **word** to represent what he is going to say by using words. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and tell him the following]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 14:4 (#3)

הוֹשִׁיעָה הַמֶּלֶךְ

“Save, O king”

The woman is referring to King David by a respectful title, and she is using the customary expression of this culture to ask him to use his royal power to help her.

Use a comparable title and expression from your language. Alternate translation: [Help me, Your Majesty]

See: Politeness

2 Samuel 14:4 (#1)

וַתֹּאמֶר הָאִשָּׁה הַתְּקֹעִית אֶל־הַמֶּלֶךְ

“So the Tekoite woman spoke to the king”

The author is using a summary statement to introduce a new part of this story, which takes place in verses 4–20. Your language may have its own way of offering an introductory summary at the beginning of a new part of a story. Alternate translation: [So the Tekoite woman went to speak to the king]

See: Introduction of a New Event

2 Samuel 14:4 (#2)

וַתִּפֹּל עַל־אַפֶּיהָ אַרְצָה וַתִּשְׁתָּחוּ

“And she fell on her nose to the ground, and she prostrated herself”

Be sure that it is clear in your translation that the woman did not fall down accidentally. She knelt down in front of David, pressing her face **to the ground** as a gesture to honor him. She then **prostrated herself** or stretched out flat on the ground to show David great honor. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [and she knelt on the ground in front of David, stretching herself out flat, to honor him greatly]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 14:5 (#3)

אָבְלָה אִשָּׁה־אַלְמָנָה אָנֹכִי וַיָּמָת אִישִׁי

“Truly I {am} a woman, a widow, for my husband has died”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. The woman is clarifying that she is not without the support of a male relative for some other reason, for example, she has not separated from a husband who is still living. Alternate translation: [Since my husband has died, I am truly a widow]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

2 Samuel 14:5 (#1)

מַה־לָּךְ

“What {is} to you”

The king is using **What {is} to you** as a common expression of his culture to ask the woman why she needs help. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [What is the matter]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 14:5 (#4)

אִשָּׁה־אַלְמָנָה

“am} a woman, a widow”

The woman is using **a woman, a widow** as a common expression of her culture to mean “a woman who is a widow.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [a woman who is a widow] or [a widow]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 14:5 (#2)

וַתֹּאמֶר

“And she said”

To try to convince David that he should allow Absalom to return, the woman, as instructed by Joab, tells David a story as if it were true. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could state that explicitly. Alternate translation: [And to try to convince David to allow Absalom, she told him a story as if it were true. She said to him]

See: Parables

2 Samuel 14:6 (#1)

וּלְשִׁפְחָתְךָ

“And to your maidservant”

The woman is speaking of herself in the third person as **your maidservant** to show humility. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a humble form in the first person. You could translate similar expressions in the same way throughout the chapter. Alternate translation: [And to me, your maidservant]

See: First, Second or Third Person

2 Samuel 14:6 (#2)

וַיַּכֵּהוּ הָאֶחָד אֶת־הָאֶחָד

“And the one struck him, the one”

It might seem that the expression **And the one struck him, the one** contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [And one of them struck the other]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 14:7 (#4)

בְּנֶפֶשׁ אָחִיו

“for the life of his brother”

Here, **life** represents “death.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [to avenge the death of his brother]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 14:7 (#9)

עַל־פְּנֵי הָאֲדָמָה

“on the face of the ground”

The woman is using one part of the earth, **the face of the ground**, to represent the entire earth. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [alive on earth]

See: Synecdoche

2 Samuel 14:7 (#5)

וְנַשְׁמִידָה גַּם אֶת־הַיּוֹרֵשׁ

“and let us destroy the heir also”

The other members of the clan would not have spoken these words directly to the woman. Since they say **let us**, in her depiction of them, they are pausing to speak confidentially to one another. They are speaking in this way because they are betraying their real motive, which is to get the late husband’s property by killing his sole remaining **heir**. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could indicate this explicitly in your translation, ending the second-level direct quotation after **he slew** and beginning a new sentence. Alternate translation: [But their real motive is to destroy the heir also]

See: Aside

2 Samuel 14:7 (#10)

עַל־פְּנֵי הָאֲדָמָה

“on the face of the ground”

See how you translated the similar expression in 11:11. Alternate translation: [on the surface of the ground]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 14:7 (#1)

וְהִנֵּהׇ

“And behold”

The woman is using the term **behold** to call attention to what she is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. See how you translated the term “behold” in 1:2.

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 14:7 (#6)

וְכִבּוּ אֶת־גַּחַלְתִּי אֲשֶׁר נִשְׁאָרָה

“And they would quench my coal that remains”

Here, the woman is speaking as if her son were actually a **coal** that could be extinguished. She uses this image to describe her son as her family’s last remaining source of life, hope, and continuation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And they would destroy my only remaining son]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 14:7 (#7)

שֵׁשֵׁם וּשְׁאֵרִית

“a name or remnant”

The terms **name** and **remnant** mean similar things. The woman is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [any survivors]

See: Doublet

2 Samuel 14:7 (#2)

קָמָה

“has arisen”

The woman is using **has arisen** as a common expression of her culture to mean “has taken action.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language,

you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [has taken action]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 14:7 (#3)

וַיֹּאמְרוּ֩ תְּנֵ֨נִי ׀ אֶת־מַכֵּ֜ה אָחִ֗יו וּנְמִתֶ֙נּוּ֙ בְּנֶ֣פֶשׁ אָחִ֔יו אֲשֶׁ֖ר הָרָ֑ג וְנַשְׁמִ֥ידָה גַּ֛ם אֶת־הַיּוֹרֵ֖שׁ

“and they have said, ‘Give the one having struck his brother, and we will kill him for the life of his brother whom he slew, and let us destroy the heir also”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [and they have told me to give them the one having struck his brother so that they can kill him for the life of his brother whom he slew, and they want to destroy the heir also]

See: Quotes within Quotes

2 Samuel 14:7 (#8)

שֵׁ֥שֶׁם

“a name”

Here, **a name** represents “someone to carry on the family line.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [anyone to carry on his name]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 14:8 (#1)

לְכִ֥י לְבֵיתֵ֖ךְ וַאֲנִ֣י אֲצַוֶּ֑ה עָלָ֖יִךְ

“Go to your house, and I, I will command concerning you”

If it would be more natural in your language, you may want to put the information about the king’s command with the information about the woman going home. Alternate translation: [Since I myself will command concerning you, you may go to your house]

See: Information Structure

2 Samuel 14:8 (#2)

וַאֲנִ֣י אֲצַוֶּ֑ה עָלָ֖יִךְ

“and I, I will command concerning you”

The implication is that the king will take some action that will ensure that the woman and her son are protected. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and I myself will take care of this matter for you]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 14:8 (#3)

וַאֲנִ֣י אֲצַוֶּ֑ה

“and I, I will command”

David is stating the pronoun **I** separately, even though the verb translated as **I will command** already includes this meaning. He is doing that because he is making a promise to the woman. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for this same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing that David is making a promise. It may not be necessary to represent the separately stated pronoun explicitly. Alternate translation: [and I promise that I will command]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 14:9 (#1)

עָלַ֤י אֲדֹנִי֙ הַמֶּ֣לֶךְ הֶעָוֹ֔ן וְעַל־בֵּ֖בֵית אָבִ֑י

“On me, my lord the king, {be} the iniquity, and on the house of my father”

The woman is actually describing a possible condition. She is saying that if there is any wrong in this situation, she and her family, not David, will be guilty and bear the responsibility. Express this possible condition in a way that would be natural in your language. Alternate translation: [If there is any iniquity, my lord the king, then let it be on me and on the house of my father]

See: Connect — Hypothetical Conditions

2 Samuel 14:9 (#2)

בֵּ֖בֵית אָבִ֑י

“the house of my father”

See how you translated the similar expression in 3:29. Alternate translation: [my extended family]

See: Kinship

2 Samuel 14:9 (#4)

וְכִסְאֹ֖ו

“and his throne”

Here, **throne** represents "kingdom." If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and his kingdom]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 14:9 (#3)

וְהַמֶּמְלָכָה וְכִסְאוֹ נָקִי

"and {may} the king and his throne {be} innocent"

Even though the woman is addressing the king directly, she is speaking of him in the third person as **the king and his throne** to show respect. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a respectful form in the second person, here and in similar instances throughout the chapter. Alternate translation: [and may you, O king, and your throne]

See: First, Second or Third Person

2 Samuel 14:10 (#1)

הַמְדַבֵּר אֵלַיִךְ וְהֵבֵאתִיו אֵלָיַי

"The one speaking to you, then bring him to me"

The king is actually describing a possible condition. He is telling the woman that if anyone speaks to her about this matter, then she should bring that person to him. Express this possible condition in a way that would be natural in your language. Alternate translation: [If anyone speaks to you about this again, then bring him to me]

See: Connect — Hypothetical Conditions

2 Samuel 14:10 (#2)

וְלֹא־יֹסִיף עוֹד לָגַעַת בָּךְ

"and he will not continue to touch you further"

It might seem that the expression **he will not continue to touch you further** contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [and he will not continue to touch you] or [and he will not touch you further]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 14:10 (#3)

וְלֹא־יֹסִיף עוֹד לָגַעַת בָּךְ

"and he will not continue to touch you further"

The king is using **he will not continue to touch you further** as a common expression of his culture to mean "he will not do any further harm to you." If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and he will not do any further harm to you]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 14:11 (#1)

יִזְכָּר־נָא הַמֶּמְלֶךְ אֶת־יְהוָה אֱלֹהֶיךָ

"May the king please remember Yahweh your God"

The woman is using **remember Yahweh your God** as a common expression of her culture to mean "swear an oath by Yahweh your God." If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [May you, the king, please swear an oath by Yahweh your God]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 14:11 (#3)

וְלֹא יַשְׁמִידוּ אֶת־בְּנִי

"Then they will not destroy my son"

Here the author is using the pronoun **they** in a general sense, not to refer to specific people. Use an expression for this that would be natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Then no one will destroy my son] or [Then my son will not be destroyed]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 14:11 (#4)

חַי־יְהוָה אִם־יִפֹּל מִשַּׂעֲרַת בְּנֶךָ אָרְצָה

"The life of Yahweh, if from the hair of your son should fall to the ground"

Following the custom of his culture, David is swearing an oath and guaranteeing it by something that he holds sacred. He is then stating the first part of a condition ("if") but not the second part ("then"). If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explicitly state the second part of this condition. Alternate translation: [I swear by Yahweh that not a single hair from your son will fall to the ground. If he suffers any harm, then may Yahweh punish me severely]

See: Oath Formulas

2 Samuel 14:11 (#2)

מהרבית גֹּאֵל הַדָּם לְשַׁחֵת

“from the increasing of the avenger of blood to destroy”

The implication is that the woman wants the king to protect her son from the avenger of blood who is trying to kill him, since that would increase the number of people who had died. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [so that the avenger of blood will not cause any further destruction of life]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 14:11 (#5)

אִם־יִפֹּל מִשַּׂעֲרַת בְּנֶךָ אָרְצָה

“if from the hair of your son should fall to the ground”

David is using one small part of the woman’s son, implicitly a single strand from his **hair**, to emphasize that he will not allow any harm to come to him at all. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. If you have already translated the book of 1 Samuel, see how you translated the same expression in 1 Samuel 14:45. Alternate translation: [I swear that no one shall harm your son in the slightest way]

See: Synecdoche

2 Samuel 14:12 (#2)

דַּבֶּרִי

“Speak”

This is an imperative, but it communicates permission rather than a command. Use a form in your language that communicates permission. Alternate translation: [You may speak]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

2 Samuel 14:12 (#1)

תְּדַבֶּר & דָּבָר

“May & speak a word”

The woman is using the term **word** to represent what she wants to say by using words. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [say something further]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 14:13 (#2)

עַעַם אֱלֹהִים

“the people of God”

Here, **the people of God** represents the Israelite people, who worshiped the one true **God**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the Israelite people]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 14:13 (#3)

וּמְדַבֵּר & הַדָּבָר הַזֶּה

“For from speaking this word”

Here, **word** represents the judgment that David pronounced by using words. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [For as a result of giving this judgment]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 14:13 (#1)

וְלָמָּה חָשַׁבְתָּה כָזֹאת עַל־עַעַם אֱלֹהִים

“Then why have you devised like this against the people of God”

The woman is using the question form to rebuke the king mildly and indirectly. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Then you should not have devised like this against the people of God.]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 14:13 (#5)

אֶת־נִדָּחוֹ

“his banished one”

The expression **his banished one** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the one he has banished]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 14:13 (#4)

כְּאָשֵׁם & הַמֶּלֶךְ

“is} like the guilty & the king”

The woman is not referring to a specific **guilty** person. She means guilty people in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [is like a guilty person]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

2 Samuel 14:14 (#2)

וְכַמַּ֣יִם הַנִּגָּרִ֔ים אַ֥רְצָה אֲשֶׁ֖ר לֹ֣א יֵאָסֵֽפוּ

“and like water spilled on the ground that is not gathered”

The woman is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and we will die like water spilled on the ground that is not gathered]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 14:14 (#1)

כִּי־מ֣וֹת נָמ֔וּת

“For dying, we will die”

The woman is repeating forms of the verb **die** in order to intensify her expression of the idea that it conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [For we will certainly die]

See: Reduplication

2 Samuel 14:14 (#3)

וְכַמַּ֣יִם הַנִּגָּרִ֔ים אַ֥רְצָה אֲשֶׁ֖ר לֹ֣א יֵאָסֵֽפוּ

“and like water spilled on the ground that is not gathered”

The expressions **water spilled** and **is not gathered** are passive verbal forms. If your language would not use those forms, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and we will die like water that someone has spilled on the ground that no one can gather up]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 14:14 (#4)

וְכַמַּ֣יִם הַנִּגָּרִ֔ים אַ֥רְצָה אֲשֶׁ֖ר לֹ֣א יֵאָסֵֽפוּ

“and like water spilled on the ground that is not gathered”

The point of this comparison is that just as **water spilled on the ground** cannot be **gathered** up again, so a person who dies cannot be brought back to life. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [and after that we cannot be brought back to life]

See: Simile

2 Samuel 14:14 (#7)

לְבִלְתִּ֥י יִדַּ֛ח מִמֶּ֥נּוּ נִדָּֽח

“so that the banished will not be banished from him”

Here, the woman is speaking as if God had actually **banished** some people. She is referring to the way God works to restore people who have alienated themselves from him through sin and rebellion. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [to bring people back who have gone away from him]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 14:14 (#5)

וְחָשַׁ֣ב מַחֲשָׁבֹ֔ות

“but he devises devices”

The woman is using a construction in which a verb and its object come from the same root. You may be able to use the same construction in your language to express the meaning here. Alternatively, your language may have another way of saying this. Alternate translation: [but he makes merciful arrangements]

See: Poetry

2 Samuel 14:14 (#6)

לְבִלְתִּ֥י יִדַּ֛ח מִמֶּ֥נּוּ נִדָּֽח

“so that the banished will not be banished from him”

The expressions **the banished** and **will not be banished** are passive verbal forms. If your language would not use those forms, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [so that people whom he has banished will not remain in banishment]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 14:15 (#1)

לְדַבֵּ֥ר & הַדָּבָ֖ר הַזֶּ֑ה

“to speak this word”

The woman is using the term **word** to the case she presented by using words. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to present my case]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 14:15 (#2)

הָעָ֔ם

“the people”

The implication is that **the people** are specifically the members of the woman’s own clan. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [the members of my clan]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 14:15 (#4)

וַתֹּ֤אמֶר שִׁפְחָתְךָ֙

“And your maidservant said”

See how you translated the similar expression in 10:2. Alternate translation: [And your maidservant said to herself] or [And your maidservant thought]

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

2 Samuel 14:15 (#5)

אֶת־דְּבַ֣ר אֲמָתְו֔

“the word of his female servant”

The woman is using the term **word** to represent what she planned to say by using words. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [what his female servant asks] or [what I ask]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 14:15 (#3)

וַתֹּ֤אמֶר שִׁפְחָתְךָ֙ אֲדַבְּרָה־נָּ֣א אֶל־הַמֶּ֔לֶךְ אוּלַ֖י יַעֲשֶׂ֣ה הַמֶּ֑לֶךְ אֶת־דְּבַ֣ר אֲמָתֹֽו

“And your maidservant said, ‘Let me now speak to the king. Perhaps the king will do the word of his female servant”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [And I told myself that I should come and speak to you, since you might do what I requested]

See: Quotes within Quotes

2 Samuel 14:15 (#6)

אֲמָתְו֔

“his female servant”

Here and in the next verse, the woman describes herself as a **female servant**, using a different term than the one she had been using, which the ULT translates as “maidservant.” This term refers to a higher-ranking member of the household whose master might feel some sense of obligation toward her. If your language and culture have different terms for female servants of different rank, use the term for a female servant of higher rank here and in the next verse.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 14:16 (#3)

מִכַּ֖ף הָאִ֑ישׁ

“from the palm of the man”

Here, **palm**, equivalent to “hand” in other contexts, represents the power and capability of a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from the power of the man]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 14:16 (#1)

כִּֽי־יִשְׁמַ֤ע הַמֶּ֙לֶךְ֙ לְהַצִּ֔יל אֶת־אֲמָתֹ֖ו מִכַּ֣ף הָאִ֑ישׁ לְהַשְׁמִ֤יד אֹתִי֙ וְאֶת־בְּנִ֔י יַ֖חַד מִנַּֽחֲלַ֥ת אֱלֹהִֽים

“For the king will listen to deliver his female servant from the palm of the man {who is} to destroy me and my son together from the inheritance of God”

If you decided in the previous verse to translate what the woman claims she said to herself so that there would not be a quotation within a quotation, you can continue to do that here.

See: Quotes within Quotes

2 Samuel 14:16 (#2)

יִשְׁמַ֤ע

“will listen”

See how you translated the similar expression in 12:18. Alternate translation: [will agree]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 14:16 (#4)

מִנַּחֲלַ֖ת אֱלֹהִֽים

“from the inheritance of God”

The woman is speaking of the people of Israel as if they were something that Yahweh had inherited as a lasting possession. She is referring to the Israelites as the people who belong to Yahweh perpetually. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. If you have already translated the book of 1 Samuel, see how you translated the similar expression in 1 Samuel 10:1. Alternate translation: [from living among the people of Israel]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 14:17 (#1)

וַתֹּ֣אמֶר֮ שִׁפְחָתְךָ֣ יְהִי־נָ֣א דְבַר־אֲדֹנִ֣י הַמֶּ֣לֶךְ לְמְנוּחָ֑ה כִּֽי־ כְמַלְאַ֤ךְ הָאֱלֹהִים֙ כֵּ֣ן אֲדֹנִ֣י הַמֶּ֣לֶךְ לִשְׁמֹ֣עַ הַטּ֣וֹב וְהָרָ֔ע

“Then your maidservant said, ‘Now the word of my lord the king will be for rest, because like an angel of God, so {is} my lord the king, to understand good and evil”

Some versions end the second-level quotation after **rest**. Alternate translation: [Then your maidservant said, ‘Now the word of my lord the king will be for rest.’ For like an angel of God, so {is} my lord the king, to understand good and evil]

See: Direct and Indirect Quotations

2 Samuel 14:17 (#3)

יְהִ֣י & דְבַר־אֲדֹנִ֣י הַמֶּ֣לֶךְ לְמְנוּחָ֑ה

“the word of my lord the king will be for rest”

The woman is using the term **word** to represent what the king would say by using words. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [what my lord the king tells me will be for rest]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 14:17 (#4)

יְהִ֣י & לְמְנוּחָ֑ה

“will be for rest”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **rest**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [will restore me to a restful situation]

See: Abstract Nouns

2 Samuel 14:17 (#7)

וַיהוָ֥ה אֱלֹהֶ֖יךָ יְהִי־עִמָּֽךְ

“And may Yahweh your God be with you”

See how you translated the similar expression in 3:12. Alternate translation: [And may Yahweh your God help you]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 14:17 (#2)

יְהִי־נָ֣א דְבַר־אֲדֹנִ֣י הַמֶּ֣לֶךְ לְמְנוּחָ֑ה כִּֽי־ כְמַלְאַ֤ךְ הָאֱלֹהִים֙ כֵּ֣ן אֲדֹנִ֣י הַמֶּ֣לֶךְ לִשְׁמֹ֣עַ הַטּ֣וֹב וְהָרָ֔ע

“Now the word of my lord the king will be for rest, because like an angel of God, so {is} my lord the king, to understand good and evil”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Since my lord the king is like an angel of God, to understand good and evil, now the word of my lord the king will be for rest]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

2 Samuel 14:17 (#5)

כֵּ֣ן אֲדֹנִ֣י הַמֶּ֣לֶךְ

“so {is} my lord the king”

Since the woman has already referred to David as **my lord the king** once in this sentence, it may be more natural in your language to use a pronoun in this second instance. Alternate translation: [so is he]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 14:17 (#6)

וַיהוָ֥ה אֱלֹהֶ֖יךָ יְהִי־עִמָּֽךְ

“And may Yahweh your God be with you”

The woman is asking God to bless King David. In your translation, use a form that people would recognize as a blessing in your language. You could express this as a prayer if that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [I pray that Yahweh your God will continue to guide and support you]

See: Blessings

2 Samuel 14:18 (#2)

יְדַבֶּר־נָ֣א אֲדֹנִ֔י הַמֶּ֖לֶךְ

“May my lord the king please speak”

The woman is responding to David with a courteous expression that implies that she will answer truthfully. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [Ask whatever you want, and I will tell you the truth]

See: Politeness

2 Samuel 14:18 (#1)

וַיַּ֥עַן הַמֶּ֖לֶךְ וַיֹּ֣אמֶר

“And the king answered and said”

The expression **and said** introduces a direct quotation. In your translation, use a natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language. It may not be necessary to represent this expression explicitly. Alternate translation: [And the king replied]

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

2 Samuel 14:19 (#2)

וַתַּ֥עַן הָאִשָּׁ֖ה וַתֹּ֥אמֶר

“And the woman answered and said”

See how you translated the similar expression in 14:18. Alternate translation: [And the woman responded]

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

2 Samuel 14:19 (#4)

חֵי־נַפְשְׁךָ֙

“The life of your soul”

The woman is using **your soul** to represent David himself. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Your life]

See: Synecdoche

2 Samuel 14:19 (#8)

הַה֥וּא צִוָּ֖נִי וְה֣וּא שָׂ֑שָׂם

“he, he commanded me, and he, he put”

The woman is stating the pronoun **he** separately in both of these instances, even though the verbs translated as **he commanded** and **he put** already include this meaning. She is doing that to confirm Joab’s personal role in these actions. If a speaker of your language would use explicit pronouns for this same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing that the woman is confirming Joab’s personal role. It may not be necessary to represent the separately stated pronouns explicitly. Alternate translation: [he was the one who commanded me, and he was the one who put]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 14:19 (#1)

הֲיַ֤ד יוֹאָב֙ אִתְּךָ֣ בְּכָל־זֹ֔את

“Is} the hand of Joab with you in all of this”

The king is using **the hand of Joab** to represent Joab himself. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Is Joab with you in all this]

See: Synecdoche

2 Samuel 14:19 (#5)

לְהַמְעִ֥ין וּלְהַשְׂמִ֖יל מִכֹּ֑ל

“turning to the right or turning to the left from all”

The woman is using **turning** in two basic directions, **the right** and **the left**, to represent all directions. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [any turning away at all from anything]

See: Merism

2 Samuel 14:19 (#7)

כִּ֣י

“For”

Here the word **For** provides not a reason but a further explanation. Alternate translation: [In fact,]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

2 Samuel 14:19 (#9)

שָׂ֗שָׂם בְּפִי֙ שִׁפְחָתֶ֔ךָ אֵ֚את כָּל־הַדְּבָרִ֔ים הָאֵ֑לֶּה

“he put all of these words in the mouth of your maidservant”

Here, the woman is speaking as if words were actually objects that could be **put** in the **mouth** of a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [told your

maidservant everything she should say] or [told me everything I should say]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 14:19 (#6)

לְהַמְעִין וּלְהַשְׂמִיל מִכֹּל

“turning to the right or turning to the left from all”

Here, the woman is speaking of agreeing completely with the king’s words as if that were staying on a straight path and not **turning to the right or turning to the left**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [contradicting anything]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 14:19 (#3)

חֵי־נַפְשְׁךָ֙ אֲדֹנִ֔י הַמֶּ֖לֶךְ אִם־אִ֑ישׁ ׀ לְהַמְעִ֣ין וּלְהַשְׂמִ֔יל מִכֹּ֕ל אֲשֶׁר־דִּבֶּ֖רֶת אֲדֹנִ֣י הַמֶּ֑לֶךְ

“The life of your soul, my lord the king, if there is turning to the right or turning to the left from all that my lord the king has spoken”

Following the custom of her culture, the woman is swearing an oath and guaranteeing it by something that he holds sacred. She is then stating the first part of a condition (“if”) but not the second part (“then”). Use a natural way in your language to express an oath. In a context such as this, it may be natural to express just the first part of the condition as a negative statement. Alternate translation: [I swear by the life of your soul, my lord the king, that there is no turning to the right or turning to the left from all that my lord the king has spoken]

See: Oath Formulas

2 Samuel 14:20 (#1)

לְבַעֲבוּר֙ סֹבֵ֣ב אֶת־פְּנֵ֣י הַדָּבָ֔ר עָשָׂ֖ה עַבְדְּךָ֣ יוֹאָ֑ב אֶת־הַדָּבָ֥ר הַזֶּ֖ה

“In order to turn the face of the matter, your servant Joab did this thing”

The woman is speaking as if the **matter** of Absalom’s banishment were a living thing that had a **face** that Joab could **turn**, in other words, as if Joab could get it to head in a different direction. This could mean: (1) that Joab wanted to change the situation so that Absalom could come home. Alternate translation: [In order to help Absalom come home from banishment, your servant Joab sent me to speak with you]; (2) that Joab told the woman to pretend to be a widow in order to make her appeal to David for Absalom appear to be an appeal for a son of her own. Alternate translation: [So that you would not realize I was talking about Absalom, your servant Joab told me to pretend I was talking about my own situation]

See: Personification

2 Samuel 14:20 (#2)

לָדַ֣עַת אֶת־כָּל־אֲשֶׁ֔ר בָּאָ֖רֶץ

“to know everything that {is} in the land”

The woman is making an overstatement for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. She could be saying: (1) that David knows what is happening in **the land**, that is, in the kingdom of Israel. Alternate translation: [since you clearly know what is happening in the land]; (2) that David knows everything that is happening on earth. Alternate translation: [as if you knew everything that was happening on earth]

See: Hyperbole

2 Samuel 14:21 (#1)

וַיֹּ֤אמֶר הַמֶּ֙לֶךְ֙ אֶל־יוֹאָ֔ב

“And the king said to Joab”

Joab was clearly not present when the woman was speaking with David, since David had to ask her whether Joab had sent her to him. David must first have summoned Joab and then spoken to him as this verse describes. It may be appropriate in your language to reintroduce Joab as a participant in the story here. Alternate translation: [And the king summoned Joab and said to him]

See: Introduction of New and Old Participants

2 Samuel 14:22 (#4)

אֶת־דְּבַ֥ר עבדו

“the word of his servant”

Here, **the word** represents what Joab said by using words. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [what his servant has requested] or [what I, your servant, have requested]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 14:22 (#1)

וַיִּפֹּ֤ל יוֹאָב֙ אֶל־פָּנָ֔יו אַ֖רְצָה וַיִּשְׁתַּ֑חוּ

“And Joab fell on his face to the ground, and he prostrated himself”

See how you translated the similar expression in 14:4. Alternate translation: [And Joab bowed down all the way to the ground as a sign of deep respect]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 14:22 (#2)

וַיְבָרֶךְ אֶת־הַמֶּלֶךְ

“and he blessed the king”

The author does not mean that Joab gave David his blessing, since an inferior does not bless a superior. He means that Joab wished that Yahweh would bless David for agreeing that Absalom could return. In your translation, you may wish to represent what Joab may have said as a direct quotation. Alternate translation: [and he said, “May Yahweh bless you, O king!”]

See: Blessings

2 Samuel 14:22 (#3)

מָצָאתִי חֵן בְּעֵינֶיךָ

“I have found favor in your eyes”

See how you translated the similar expression in 3:19. Alternate translation: [you regard me with favor]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 14:23 (#1)

וַיָּקָם יוֹאָב

“And Joab arose”

See how you translated the similar expression in 2:14. Alternate translation: [And Joab took action]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 14:24 (#2)

וּפָנַי לֹא יִרְאֶה & וּפְנֵי הַמֶּלֶךְ לֹא רָאָה

“but my face he shall not see & but the face of the king he did not see”

Here, **face** represents the presence of a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [but he shall not come into my presence … but he did not come into the presence of the king]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 14:24 (#1)

וַיֹּאמֶר הַמֶּלֶךְ יִסֹּב אֶל־בֵּיתוֹ וּפָנַי לֹא יִרְאֶה

“Now the king had said, “He may return to his house, but my face he shall not see”

The author is providing background information to help readers understand what happens next in the story. In your translation, introduce this information in a way that would be natural in your own language and culture.

See: Background Information

2 Samuel 14:25 (#2)

וּכְאַבְשָׁלוֹם לֹא־הָיָה אִישׁ־יָפֶה בְּכָל־יִשְׂרָאֵל לְהַלֵּל מְאֹד

“Now {there} was not a handsome man like Absalom in all of Israel to praise greatly”

If it would be more natural in your language, you may want to put the information about Absalom being a handsome man with the information about people praising him. Alternate translation: [Now there was not another man in all of Israel whom people praised as greatly as they praised Absalom for being a handsome man]

See: Information Structure

2 Samuel 14:25 (#1)

וּכְאַבְשָׁלוֹם לֹא־הָיָה אִישׁ־יָפֶה בְּכָל־יִשְׂרָאֵל לְהַלֵּל מְאֹד

“Now {there} was not a handsome man like Absalom in all of Israel to praise greatly”

The author is providing background information to help readers understand what happens next in the story. This verse describes Absalom’s outstanding physical appearance, which helps explain his popularity among the people and sets up his ability to gain followers later in the narrative. In your translation, introduce this information in a way that would be natural in your own language and culture.

See: Background Information

2 Samuel 14:25 (#3)

מִכַּף רַגְלוֹ וְעַד קָדְקֳדוֹ לֹא־הָיָה בּוֹ מוּם

“From the sole of his foot and to his pate, no blemish was on him”

The author is referring to all of Absalom’s body by naming two extremes, **the sole of his foot** and **his pate**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [He did not have a single blemish anywhere on his body]

See: Merism

2 Samuel 14:25 (#4)

מִכַּף רַגְלוֹ֙ וְעַ֣ד קָדְקֳד֔וֹ לֹא־הָיָ֥ה בּ֖וֹ מֽוּם

“From the sole of his foot and to his pate, no blemish was on him”

The author is making an overstatement for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [People felt that he was attractive in every part of his body]

See: Hyperbole

2 Samuel 14:26 (#1)

וּבְגַלְּח֣וֹ אֶת־רֹאשׁ֗וֹ וְֽהָיָה֙ מִקֵּ֣ץ יָמִ֔ים ׀ לְיָמִ֖ים אֲשֶׁ֣ר יְגַלַּ֑ח כִּי־כָבֵ֤ד עָלָיו֙ וְגִלְּחָ֔ן וְשָׁקַל֙ אֶת־שְׂעַ֣ר רֹאשׁ֔וֹ מָאתַ֥יִם שְׁקָלִ֖ים בְּאֶ֥בֶן הַמֶּֽלֶךְ

“And when he shaved his head (and it was at the end of years to years that he would shave, because {it was} heavy on him, so he would shave it) and he weighed the hair of his head, 200 shekels by the stone of the king”

If it would be more natural in your language, you may want to put the initial statement about Absalom shaving his hair with the information about him weighing his hair. Alternate translation: [At the end of years to years he would shave, because it was heavy on him, so he would shave it. And when he shaved his head and weighed the hair of his head, it weighed 200 shekels by the stone of the king]

See: Information Structure

2 Samuel 14:26 (#2)

מִקֵּ֣ץ יָמִ֔ים ׀ לְיָמִ֖ים

“at the end of years to years”

The author is using **at the end of years to years** as a common expression of his culture to mean “at the end of each year.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [at the end of each year]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 14:26 (#4)

מָאתַ֥יִם שְׁקָלִ֖ים בְּאֶ֥בֶן הַמֶּֽלֶךְ

“200 shekels by the stone of the king”

The author is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [he found that it weighed 200 shekels by the stone of the king]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 14:26 (#3)

כִּי־כָבֵ֤ד עָלָיו֙ וְגִלְּחָ֔ן

“because {it was} heavy on him, so he would shave it”

The pronoun **it** refers in the first instance to Absalom’s hair and in the second instance to his head. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [because his hair heavy on him, so he would shave his head]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 14:26 (#5)

בְּאֶ֥בֶן הַמֶּֽלֶךְ

“by the stone of the king”

See the discussion of this phrase in the Introduction to this chapter for an explanation of what it might mean and for suggestions as to how you might represent it in your translation.

See: Biblical Weight

2 Samuel 14:27 (#1)

וַיִּוָּלְד֣וּ לְאַבְשָׁל֗וֹם שְׁלוֹשָׁ֤ה בָנִים֙ וּבַ֣ת אַחַ֔ת

“And to Absalom were born three sons and one daughter”

The expression **were born** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [And Absalom’s wife bore him three sons and one daughter]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 14:28 (#2)

וּפְנֵ֥י הַמֶּ֖לֶךְ לֹ֣א רָאָֽה

“but the face of the king he did not see”

See how you translated the similar expression in 14:24. Alternate translation: [but he did not come into the presence of the king]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 14:28 (#1)

שְׁנָתַיִם יָמִים

“two years, days”

The author is using **two years, days** as a common expression of his culture to mean “two full years.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [two full years]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 14:29 (#2)

וַיִּשְׁלַח עוֹד שֵׁנִית

“So Absalom sent again a second time”

It might seem that the expression **Absalom sent again a second time** contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [So Absalom sent for him again] or [So Absalom sent for him a second time]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 14:29 (#1)

וְלֹא אָבָה לָבוֹא אֵלָיו

“but he was not willing to come to him”

The pronoun **he** refers to Joab, while the pronoun **him** refers to Absalom. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [but Joab was not willing to come to Absalom]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 14:30 (#1)

רְאוּ

“See”

Absalom is using the term **See** to focus his servants’ attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. See how you translated the similar expression in 7:2. Alternate translation: [Listen]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 14:30 (#2)

אֶל־יָדִי

“is} to my hand”

Absalom is using **to my hand** as a common expression of his culture to mean “next to mine.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [is next to mine]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 14:30 (#4)

חֶלְקַת

“the property of”

Here, the author is saying **the property** to represent the barley that was growing on the property. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the barley]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 14:30 (#3)

לְכוּ והוצתיה בָאֵשׁ

“Go and burn it with fire”

It might seem that the expression **burn it with fire** contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it, here, in the next sentence, and in the next verse. Alternate translation: [Go and burn it] or [Go and set it on fire]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 14:31 (#2)

אֶת־הַחֶלְקָה אֲשֶׁר־לִי

“the property that {is} to me”

Joab is using this expression to represent the barley on his **property**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the barley on my property]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 14:31 (#1)

וַיָּקָם יוֹאָב

“And Joab arose”

See how you translated the similar expression in 2:14. Alternate translation: [And Joab took action]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 14:32 (#5)

אֶרְאֶהוּ֙ פְּנֵ֣י הַמֶּ֔לֶךְ

“let me see the face of the king”

Here, **the face of the king** represents “the presence of the king.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [arrange for me to come into the presence of the king]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 14:32 (#6)

וְאִם־יֶ֥שׁ־בִּ֖י עָוֹ֑ן

“but if iniquity is in me”

Absalom is speaking as if iniquity were an object that was actually **in him**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [but if I am guilty of a serious crime]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 14:32 (#1)

הִנֵּ֨ה שָׁלַ֜חְתִּי אֵלֶ֗יךָ ׀ לֵאמֹר֮ בֹּ֣א הֵ֒נָּה וְאֶשְׁלְחָ֣ה אֹֽתְךָ֮ אֶל־הַמֶּ֣לֶךְ֒ לֵאמֹר֙ לָֽמָּה בָּ֣אתִי֙ מִגְּשׁ֔וּר טֽוֹב־לִ֥י עֹ֖ד אֲנִי־שָׁ֑ם

“Behold, I sent to you, saying, ‘Come here, that I may send you to the king, saying, “Why have I come from Geshur? {It would be} better for me {if} I {were} still there”

There are three levels of quotation here. The author is quoting what Absalom said (level 1). Absalom is quoting what he sent his messengers to tell Joab on his behalf (level 2). And as he quotes their message, Absalom quotes what the messengers told Joab to say to King David on his behalf (level 3). Use the appropriate punctuation in your language to mark these levels of quotation. Alternatively, you could translate this so that there is not a second-level or third-level quotation (see the Quotes within Quotes note).

See: Quote Markings

2 Samuel 14:32 (#2)

הִנֵּ֨ה שָׁלַ֜חְתִּי אֵלֶ֗יךָ ׀ לֵאמֹר֮ בֹּ֣א הֵ֒נָּה וְאֶשְׁלְחָ֣ה אֹֽתְךָ֮ אֶל־הַמֶּ֣לֶךְ֒ לֵאמֹר֙ לָֽמָּה בָּ֣אתִי֙ מִגְּשׁ֔וּר טֽוֹב־לִ֥י עֹ֖ד אֲנִי־שָׁ֑ם

“Behold, I sent to you, saying, ‘Come here, that I may send you to the king, saying, “Why have I come from Geshur? {It would be} better for me {if} I {were} still there”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [Behold, I sent to you and told you to come here so that I could send you to the king and ask him on my behalf why I had come from Geshur, since it seemed as if it would be better for me if I were still there]

See: Quotes within Quotes

2 Samuel 14:32 (#3)

לָֽמָּה בָּ֣אתִי֙ מִגְּשׁ֔וּר

“Why have I come from Geshur”

Absalom is using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [I should not have come from Geshur!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 14:32 (#4)

וְעַתָּ֖ה

“And now”

And now was an expression that speakers in this culture commonly used to introduce their main topic. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. You could also use plain language. See how you translated the same expression in 2:6.

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

2 Samuel 14:33 (#1)

וַיִּקְרָ֥א אֶל־אַבְשָׁלֹ֖ם

“And he called to Absalom”

The pronoun **he** refers to King David. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [And King David called to Absalom]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 14:33 (#2)

וַיִּשְׁתַּ֤חוּ לוֹ֙ עַל־אַפָּ֔יו אַ֖רְצָה לִפְנֵ֣י הַמֶּ֑לֶךְ

“and he prostrated himself to him on his nose to the ground to the face of the king”

See how you translated the similar expression in 14:4. Alternate translation: [and he bowed down with his face to the ground before the king]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 14:33 (#3)

וַיִּשַּׁ֥ק הַמֶּ֖לֶךְ לְאַבְשָׁלֹֽום

“And the king kissed Absalom”

Kissing Absalom was a symbolic action by which David expressed reconciliation and acceptance. After years of estrangement, this gesture demonstrated that David was officially forgiving his son and restoring him to his position in the royal family. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [And the king kissed Absalom, signifying that he was restoring him to his position in the royal family]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel - Chapter 15 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter continues the story of what David did as the king of Israel. It describes how Absalom got the Israelites to want him to be the king instead of David. It tells how Absalom then proclaimed that he was king and how David and his supporters had to flee from Jerusalem for safety. It describes how Ittai the Gittite, a great soldier, promised to stay with David. It tells how the high priests Zadok and Abiathar wanted to come with David and bring the Box of Yahweh, but he sent them back to Jerusalem with it. And it describes how David also sent his counselor Hushai the Archite back to Jerusalem to pretend he was loyal to Absalom but to try to confuse him instead.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

“your servant”
In several places in this chapter, people speak of themselves to authorities in the third person as **your servant** to show humility. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a humble form in the first person.

Textual Variants in This Chapter

Did Absalom spend four years or 40 years becoming popular among the Israelites?
According to the traditional Hebrew text, Absalom asked David for permission to go to Hebron after he had been back in Jerusalem for “40 years.” The ULT follows that reading. Other ancient versions and authorities read “four years.” The UST follows that reading, which makes sense, because there would not have been time for Absalom to have been trying to win the affections of the Israelites for 40 years. Absalom was born after David became king in Hebron, and David’s entire reign lasted only a little over 40 years. If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to use the reading that it uses. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to use the reading of the ULT.

2 Samuel 15:1 (#1)

וַיְהִי֙ מֵאַחֲרֵ֣י כֵּ֔ן

“And it happened after this”

The author is using this expression to introduce a new development in the story. Use a word, phrase, or other method in your language that is natural for introducing a new development.

See: Introduction of a New Event

2 Samuel 15:1 (#3)

לְפָנָ֑יו

“to his face”

Here, **to his face** represents “ahead of him.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [ahead of him]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 15:1 (#2)

וַחֲמִשִּׁ֣ים אִ֔ישׁ רָצִ֖ים לְפָנָֽיו

“and 50 men running to his face”

Having **50 men** run ahead of his **chariot** to clear the way and announce his coming was a symbolic action by which Absalom asserted his importance. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action. Alternate translation: [and he had 50 men run ahead of his chariot to show how important he was]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 15:2 (#3)

אֵי־מִזֶּ֥ה עִ֖יר אַתָּ֑ה

“Where from this city {are} you”

Absalom was using a common expression of his culture to ask what city a person was from. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. If you have already translated the book of 1 Samuel, see how you translated the similar

expression in 1 Samuel 30:13. Alternate translation: [What city are you from]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 15:2 (#5)

מֵאַחַד שִׁבְטֵי־יִשְׂרָאֵל עַבְדֶּךָ

“Your servant {is} from one of the tribes of Israel”

The man is speaking of himself in the third person as **Your servant** to show humility. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this and similar expressions in a humble form in the first person, here and throughout the chapter. Alternate translation: [I am from one of the tribes of Israel]

See: First, Second or Third Person

2 Samuel 15:2 (#2)

הָאִישׁ

“man”

Here the masculine term **man** has a generic sense that includes both men and women. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use language in your translation that is clearly inclusive of both men and women, here and in verses 5 and 6. Alternate translation: [person]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

2 Samuel 15:2 (#4)

וַיֹּאמֶר מֵאַחַד שִׁבְטֵי־יִשְׂרָאֵל עַבְדֶּךָ

“And he would say, “Your servant {is} from one of the tribes of Israel”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this as an indirect quotation, since these are not the exact words that a person would have spoken. Alternate translation: [And he would tell Absalom what tribe of Israel he came from]

See: Direct and Indirect Quotations

2 Samuel 15:2 (#1)

עַל־יַד דֶּרֶךְ הַשָּׁעַר

“at the hand of the way of the gate”

The author is using **at the hand of the way of the gate** as a common expression of his culture to mean “by the side of the road leading to the city gate.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [by the side of the road leading to the city gate]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 15:3 (#2)

דְּבָרֶךָ טוֹבִים וּנְכֹחִים

“your matter {is} good and right”

Here Absalom is using plural forms of **good** and **right** where he could have used singular forms. This suggests that he is using plural forms to emphasize the validity of the person’s case. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use the singular and express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [your case is very good and very right]

See: Unusual Uses of the Plural

2 Samuel 15:3 (#3)

דְּבָרֶךָ טוֹבִים וּנְכֹחִים

“your matter {is} good and right”

The terms **good** and **right** mean similar things. Absalom is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [your claims are completely justified]

See: Doublet

2 Samuel 15:3 (#1)

רְאֵה

“See”

See how you translated the similar expression in 7:2. Alternate translation: [Listen]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 15:4 (#1)

מִי־יְשִׂמַנִי שֹׁפֵט בָּאָרֶץ וְעָלַי יָבֹא כָּל־אִישׁ אֲשֶׁר־יִהְיֶה־לּוֹ־רִיב וּמִשְׁפָּט וְהִצְדַּקְתִּיו

“Who will appoint me a judge in the land, that every person to whom was a dispute and a judgment would come to me, and I would do him justice”

Absalom is using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Someone should appoint me a judge in the land, that every person to whom was a dispute and a judgment would come to me, and I would do him justice!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 15:4 (#2)

בָּאָרֶץ

“in the land”

Here, **the land** represents “the people of the land.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [for the people of the land]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 15:4 (#3)

רִיב וּמִשְׁפָּט

“a dispute and a judgment”

The phrase **a dispute and a judgment** expresses a single idea. The word **judgment** tells what kind of **dispute** this is. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning in a different way. Alternate translation: [a dispute calling for a judgment] or [a judicial dispute]

See: Hendiadys

2 Samuel 15:5 (#1)

בְּקָרֵב־אִישׁ לְהִשְׁתַּחֲוֹת לוֹ וְשָׁלַח אֶת־יָדוֹ וְהֶחֱזִיק לוֹ וְנָשַׁק לוֹ

“when a man approached to prostrate himself to him, that he would stretch out his hand and take hold of him and kiss him”

A person would start to **prostrate himself** as a symbolic action that showed submission and honor to Absalom as a royal figure. By stopping the person from bowing down and instead embracing him and kissing him, Absalom was treating him as a friend and equal. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of these actions in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [when a man approached him to bow down before him in respect, Absalom would stop him and instead embrace him and kiss him as a friend and equal]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 15:6 (#1)

לְכָל־יִשְׂרָאֵל

“for all of Israel”

Here, **Israel** represents “the Israelites.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [for all the Israelites]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 15:6 (#2)

וַיְגַנֵּב אַבְשָׁלוֹם אֶת־לֵב

“And Absalom stole the heart of”

Here, the **heart** represents the feelings of the Israelite people. The author is speaking as if Absalom actually **stole** these feelings. He mean that Absalom used these manipulative means to get the Israelites to feel positively toward him. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And Absalom manipulatively won the affections]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 15:7 (#3)

אֶת־נִדְרִי אֲשֶׁר־נָדַרְתִּי לַיהוָה

“my vow that I vowed to Yahweh”

It might seem that the expression **my vow that I vowed to Yahweh** contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it here and in the next verse. Alternate translation: [the vow that I made to Yahweh]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 15:7 (#2)

אַרְבָּעִים שָׁנָה

“40 years”

See the discussion of this phrase in the Introduction to this chapter. Many versions read “four years,” following the reading of some ancient manuscripts. If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to use the reading that it uses. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to use the reading of the ULT.

See: Textual Variants

2 Samuel 15:7 (#1)

וַיְהִי

“And it happened”

The author is using the word translated **And it happened** to introduce a new development in the story. Use a word, phrase, or other method in your language that is natural for introducing a new development.

See: Introduction of a New Event

2 Samuel 15:8 (#1)

אִם־יָשׁוֹב יְשִׁיבֵנִי יְהוָה

“If bringing back, Yahweh brings me back”

Absalom is repeating forms of the verb **brings** in order to intensify his expression of the idea that it conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [If Yahweh indeed brings me back]

See: Reduplication

2 Samuel 15:9 (#1)

לֵךְ בְּשָׁלוֹם

“Go in peace”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **peace**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Go with my blessing] or [Go undisturbed]

See: Abstract Nouns

2 Samuel 15:9 (#2)

וַיָּקָם

“So he arose”

See how you translated the similar expression in 2:14. Alternate translation: [So he took action]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 15:10 (#1)

וַאֲמַרְתֶּם מָלַךְ אַבְשָׁלוֹם בְּחֶבְרוֹן

“then you shall say, ‘Absalom reigns in Hebron”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [then you shall shout out that Absalom reigns in Hebron]

See: Quotes within Quotes

2 Samuel 15:11 (#1)

וְהֹלְכִים לְתֻמָּם

“and walking in their innocence”

The author is speaking of how these men lived as if they were **walking** along a path. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and proceeding innocently] or [and acting without knowing Absalom’s plans]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 15:12 (#1)

בְּזָבְחוֹ אֶת־הַזְּבָחִים

“while he sacrificed the sacrifices”

It might seem that the expression **while he sacrificed the sacrifices** contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [while he offered the sacrifices]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 15:12 (#2)

וְהָעָם הוֹלֵךְ וָרָב אֶת־אַבְשָׁלוֹם

“and the people were going and many with Absalom”

See how you translated the similar expression in 3:1. Alternate translation: [and more and more people joined Absalom]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 15:13 (#3)

הָיָה לֵב־אִישׁ יִשְׂרָאֵל אַחֲרֵי אַבְשָׁלוֹם

“The heart of a man of Israel {is} behind Absalom”

Here, the **heart** represents people’s commitments and intentions. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The people of Israel are now supporting Absalom]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 15:13 (#2)

הָיָה לֵב־אִישׁ יִשְׂרָאֵל אַחֲרֵי אַבְשָׁלוֹם

“The heart of a man of Israel {is} behind Absalom”

In this verse, the word **heart** is singular in form, but it refers to all the people of Israel as a group. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use the plural form of “heart.” Alternate translation: [The hearts of the people of Israel are behind Absalom]

See: Collective Nouns

2 Samuel 15:13 (#1)

הָיָה לֵב־אִישׁ יִשְׂרָאֵל אַחֲרֵי אַבְשָׁלוֹם

“The heart of a man of Israel {is} behind Absalom”

Here, **a man of Israel** represents the people of Israel in general, not a specific person. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [The heart of the people of Israel is behind Absalom]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

2 Samuel 15:14 (#3)

מִפְּנֵי אַבְשָׁלֹום

“from the face of Absalom”

David is using Absalom’s **face** to represent the murderous intent with which he regards him and his supporters. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [from Absalom, who would kill us]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 15:14 (#1)

קוּמוּ וְנִבְרָחָה כִּי֩ לֹא־תִהְיֶה־לָּ֨נוּ פְלֵיטָ֜ה מִפְּנֵי֙ אַבְשָׁלֹ֔ום

“Arise, and let us flee, for there will not be for us an escape from the face of Absalom”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Since there will not be for us an escape from the face of Absalom otherwise, arise, and let us flee]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

2 Samuel 15:14 (#4)

מַהֵר֤וּ לָלֶ֙כֶת֙ פֶּן־יְמַהֵ֣ר וְהִשִּׂגָ֔נוּ

“Hurry to go, lest he hurry and overtake us”

David is using the word translated as **lest** to introduce an outcome that he does not want to happen. Because of this, he first gives his servants an instruction to follow so that this will not happen. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that avoiding this outcome is the purpose of the instruction. Alternate translation: [Hurry to go! Otherwise, he will hurry and overtake us]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

2 Samuel 15:14 (#2)

קוּמוּ וְנִבְרָחָה

“Arise, and let us flee”

See how you translated the similar expression in 2:14. Alternate translation: [Let us take action to flee]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 15:14 (#5)

וְהַכָּ֥ה הָעִ֖יר לְפִי־חָֽרֶב

“and strike the city to the mouth of the sword”

David is using a common expression of his culture to mean that Absalom would kill everyone in the city of Jerusalem if David and his supporters tried to resist him there. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. If you have already translated the book of 1 Samuel, see how you translated the same expression in 1 Samuel 15:8. Alternate translation: [and kill everyone in this city]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 15:15 (#1)

אֲדֹנָֽי

“my lord”

Since there are multiple speakers among **the servants of the king**, you could use the plural form of “my” if that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [our lord]

See: Collective Nouns

2 Samuel 15:15 (#2)

הִנֵּ֥ה עֲבָדֶֽיךָ

“behold your servants”

David’s servants are responding to him with the courteous expression that a person in this culture would use to tell a superior that he had heard a summons and was ready and willing to obey. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. See how you translated the similar expression in 1:7. Alternate translation: [we are at your disposal]

See: Politeness

2 Samuel 15:16 (#1)

וְכָל־בֵּיתֹ֑ו

“and all of his house”

See how you translated the similar expression in 12:10. Alternate translation: [and all of his household]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 15:16 (#2)

בְּרַגְלָיו

“was} at his feet”

Here, **at his feet** means that the people of David’s household were following him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [followed him]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 15:16 (#3)

אֵת עֶשֶׂר נָשִׁים פִּלַגְשִׁים

“ten women, concubines”

It might seem that the expression **women, concubines** contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [ten of his concubines]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 15:17 (#1)

בֵּבֵית הַמֶּרְחָק

“at} the farthest house”

This could be the name of a place, Beth Merhak. Some interpreters suggest that it may have been the location of a pavilion on the edge of the Kidron Valley where travelers could rest before going down into and across the valley. If a translation of the Bible exists in your region and represents this as a place name, you may wish to do the same in your translation.

See: How to Translate Names

2 Samuel 15:18 (#2)

וְכָל־הַכְּרֵתִי וְכָל־הַפְּלֵתִי

“And all of the Cherethites and all of the Pelethites”

See how you translated these names in 8:18.

See: How to Translate Names

2 Samuel 15:18 (#3)

בְּרַגְלוֹ

“at his foot”

The author is using this phrase to describe the relationship to David of the **600 men** who gathered around him while he was fleeing from Saul. He calls them **Gittites**, meaning people from the city of Gath, because these men went with David to the city of Gath, as 1 Samuel 27:2 describes, and then returned with him to Hebron, as the author states in 2:3. Alternate translation: [under his leadership]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 15:18 (#1)

עַל־יָדוֹ

“at his hand”

See how you translated the similar expression in 15:2. Alternate translation: [beside him]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 15:18 (#4)

עַל־פְּנֵי הַמֶּלֶךְ

“to the face of the king”

Here, **face** represents “front.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in front of the king]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 15:19 (#1)

אִתַּי הַגִּתִּתִי

“Ittai the Gittite”

The author does not formally introduce **Ittai the Gittite** as a participant in the story, even though he later has an important role in it. The next verse provides some further information about him, but if it would be helpful to your readers, you could introduce him in more detail here. The UST models one way to do that.

See: Introduction of New and Old Participants

2 Samuel 15:19 (#4)

שׁוּב וְשֵׁב עִם־הַמֶּלֶךְ כִּי־נָכְרִי אַתָּה וְגַם־גֹּלֶה אַתָּה לִמְקוֹמֶךָ

“Return and dwell with the king, for you {are} a foreigner and you {are} also an exile to your place”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Since you are a foreigner and you are also an exile to your place, return and dwell with the king]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

2 Samuel 15:19 (#2)

לָ֣מָּה תֵלֵ֔ךְ גַּם־אַתָּ֖ה אִתָּ֑נוּ

“Why are you also going with us”

David is using the question form to tell Ittai the Gittite not to go with him. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [You should not be going with us!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 15:19 (#3)

תֵלֵ֔ךְ גַּם־אַתָּ֖ה

“are you also going”

In a context such as this, your language might say “coming” instead of **going**. Alternate translation: [are you also coming]

See: Go and Come

2 Samuel 15:20 (#5)

אֶת־אַחֶ֖יךָ

“your brothers”

David is speaking as if Ittai’s soldiers were actually his **brothers**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [your soldiers]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 15:20 (#6)

עִמָּ֥ךְ חֶ֖סֶד וֶאֱמֶ֑ת

“May} kindness and faithfulness {be} with you”

David is asking God to bless Ittai. In your translation, use a form that people would recognize as a blessing in your language. You might express this as a prayer, if that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [I pray that Yahweh will make kindness and faithfulness be with you]

See: Blessings

2 Samuel 15:20 (#7)

עִמָּ֥ךְ חֶ֖סֶד וֶאֱמֶ֑ת

“May} kindness and faithfulness {be} with you”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **kindness** and **faithfulness**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [I pray that Yahweh will make people kind and loyal to you]

See: Abstract Nouns

2 Samuel 15:20 (#1)

תְּמ֔וֹל ׀ בּוֹאֶ֖ךָ וְהַיּ֑וֹם אנועך עִמָּ֣נוּ֔ וָלָ֖לֶךְ וַאֲנִ֣י הוֹלֵ֔ךְ עַ֚ל אֲשֶׁר־אֲנִ֣י הוֹלֵ֔ךְ

“Yesterday {was} your coming, and today shall I make you wander with us to go, when I am going upon where I am going”

David is using the question form to express that he should not make Ittai the Gittite wander with him. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Since yesterday was your coming, today I should not make you wander with us to go, when I am going upon where I am going.]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 15:20 (#2)

תְּמ֔וֹל

“Yesterday”

David is using **Yesterday** as a common expression of his culture to mean “only recently” or “a little while ago.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Only recently]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 15:20 (#8)

עִמָּ֥ךְ חֶ֖סֶד וֶאֱמֶ֑ת

“May} kindness and faithfulness {be} with you”

From the vow that Ittai makes in verse 21, it is clear that he has been kind and loyal to David, and David is wishing the same for him. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [I pray that Yahweh will make people kind and loyal to you, just as you have been to me]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 15:20 (#3)

אנועך עִמָּנוּ֙ לָלֶ֔כֶת

“shall I make you wander with us to go”

The phrase **wander with us to go** expresses a single idea. The word **wander** tells in what way Itta would have to **go** with David if he accompanied him. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning in a different way. Alternate translation: [shall I make you go wandering with us]

See: Hendiadys

2 Samuel 15:20 (#4)

וַאֲנִ֗י הוֹלֵ֤ךְ עַל֙ אֲשֶׁר־אֲנִ֣י הוֹלֵ֔ךְ

“when I am going upon where I am going”

David is using **when I am going upon where I am going** as a common expression of his culture to mean “when I do not know where I am going.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [when I am going I know not where] or [when I will have to go wherever I can]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 15:21 (#2)

חַי־יְהוָ֔ה וְחֵ֥י׀ אֲדֹנִ֖י הַמֶּ֑לֶךְ

“The life of Yahweh and the life of my lord the king”

Following the custom of this culture, Ittai is swearing an oath and guaranteeing it by something that he holds sacred. Use a natural way in your language to express such an oath. Alternate translation: [I swear by Yahweh and by the life of my lord the king]

See: Oath Formulas

2 Samuel 15:21 (#1)

וַיַּ֤עַן אִתַּי֙ אֶת־הַמֶּ֔לֶךְ וַיֹּאמֶר֙

“But Ittai answered the king and said”

The expression **and said** introduces a direct quotation. In your translation, use a natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language. It may not be necessary to represent this expression explicitly. Alternate translation: [But Ittai responded to the king]

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

2 Samuel 15:21 (#3)

אֲשֶׁ֥ר יִהְיֶה־שָּׁ֛ם ׀ אֲדֹנִ֥י הַמֶּ֖לֶךְ

“where my lord the king will be there”

It might seem that the expression **where my lord the king will be there** contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [where my lord the king will be]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 15:21 (#4)

אִם־לְמָ֥וֶת֙ אִם־לְחַיִּ֔ים

“whether to death, whether to life”

Ittai is using **whether to death, whether to life** as a common expression of his culture to mean “whether I live or die.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [even if it costs me my life]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 15:22 (#1)

לֵ֖ךְ וַעֲבֹ֑ר

“Go and pass by”

David is not telling Ittai to **go** somewhere. He is saying **go** to mean that Ittai should take action. See how you translated the similar expression in 7:23. Alternate translation: [Go ahead and pass by]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 15:22 (#2)

הַטַּ֔ף

“the little {ones”

The author is using the adjective **little** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. The ULT indicates this by adding the word **ones**. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the children]

See: Nominal Adjectives

2 Samuel 15:23 (#3)

פְּנֵ֣י

“to the face of”

Here, **face** represents "direction." If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in the direction of]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 15:23 (#1)

וְכָל־הָאָ֣רֶץ בּוֹכִ֔יםוְ

"And all of the land was weeping"

Here, **the land** represents the people of the land. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [And all the people of the land were weeping]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 15:23 (#2)

וְכָל־הָאָ֣רֶץ בּוֹכִ֔יםוְ

"And all of the land was weeping"

The author says **all** as an overstatement for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [And people throughout the land were weeping]

See: Hyperbole

2 Samuel 15:24 (#2)

וַיַּ֖עַל אֶבְיָתָ֑ר

"but Abiathar went up"

The implication is that Abiathar went up onto the Mount of Olives, which was across the valley. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [but Abiathar went up onto the Mount of Olives across the valley]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 15:24 (#1)

וְהִנֵּ֖ה

"And behold"

The author is using the term **behold** to focus his listeners' attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. See how you translated the similar expression in 1:2.

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 15:25 (#3)

וְאֶת־נָוֵֽהוּ

"and his habitation"

Here, David is speaking of the sanctuary he prepared for the ark of the covenant (6:17) as if it were actually Yahweh's **habitation** or the place where he lived. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [his sanctuary]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 15:25 (#1)

אִם־אֶמְצָ֞א חֵ֣ן בְּעֵינֵ֗י יְהוָה֙

"If I find favor in the eyes of Yahweh"

David is using the expression **in the eyes of** to mean "in the judgment of" or "in the perspective of." If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [If Yahweh favors me]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 15:25 (#2)

וְאֶת־נָוֵֽהוּ

"and his habitation"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **habitation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the place that he inhabits]

See: Abstract Nouns

2 Samuel 15:26 (#1)

וְאִם־כֹּ֣ה יֹאמַ֔ר לֹ֥א חָפַ֖צְתִּי בָּ֑ךְ

"But if he says thus, 'I do not delight in you"

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [But if he says that he does not delight in me]

See: Quotes within Quotes

2 Samuel 15:26 (#3)

כַּאֲשֶׁ֥ר טֹ֖וב בְּעֵינָ֑יו

"just as {is} good in his eyes"

David is using the expression **as {is} good in his eyes** to mean "in the judgment of" or "in the opinion of." If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [as he sees fit]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 15:26 (#2)

הִנֵּנִי

“behold me”

See how you translated the similar expression in 15:15 and 1:7. Alternate translation: [I am at his disposal]

See: Politeness

2 Samuel 15:27 (#4)

אִתְּכֶם

“with you”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [should go with you]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 15:27 (#2)

בְּשָׁלֹום

“in peace”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **peace**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [without openly taking my side]

See: Abstract Nouns

2 Samuel 15:27 (#1)

הֲרֹואֶה אַתָּה

“Are you seeing”

David is using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. This could mean: (1) that David is using sight to represent attention, as in the expression “behold.” Alternate translation: [Pay attention to what I am about to say!]; (2) that David is questioning whether Zadok is a “seer” or prophet. By asking “Are you a seer?” he would mean “You are not a seer.” Alternate translation: [You have no more idea than I do of what is going to happen]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 15:27 (#3)

שֻׁבָה בְנִיכֶם אִתְּכֶם

“your two sons, with you”

The pronouns **your** and **you** are plural here. David now addressing both Zadok and Abiathar. So use plural forms in your translation if your language marks that distinction.

See: Forms of ‘You’ — Singular

2 Samuel 15:28 (#3)

בִּבֹּוא דָבָר מֵעִמָּכֶם

“word comes from you”

David is speaking of a **word** as if it were a living thing that could come to him on its own from someone. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you send me word]

See: Personification

2 Samuel 15:28 (#4)

בִּבֹּוא דָבָר מֵעִמָּכֶם

“word comes from you”

David is using the term **word** to represent what Zadok would say by using words. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you send me a message]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 15:28 (#1)

רְאוּ

“See”

See how you translated the similar expression in 7:2. Alternate translation: [Listen]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 15:28 (#2)

בעברות הַמִּדְבָּר

“at the fords of the wilderness”

David is identifying the Jordan River by its location in the **wilderness** east of Jerusalem. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [at the fords of the Jordan River]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 15:30 (#4)

חָפוּ אִישׁ רֹאשׁוֹ

“covered, a man his head”

The author is using **covered, a man his head** as a common expression of his culture to mean “each person covered his own head.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [covered their own heads]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 15:30 (#1)

עֹלֶה ׀ וּבוֹכֶה

“going up and weeping”

The phrase **going up and weeping** expresses a single idea. The word **weeping** tells in what way David was **going up**. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning in a different way, here and at the end of the verse. Alternate translation: [going up weepingly] or [weeping as he went]

See: Hendiadys

2 Samuel 15:30 (#2)

וְרֹאשׁ לוֹ חָפוּי וְהוּא הֹלֵךְ יָחֵף

“and his head was covered, and he was walking barefoot”

Covering his head and walking barefoot were symbolic actions by which David expressed mourning, humiliation, and distress. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [and he had covered his head and removed his sandals as signs of his deep sorrow]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 15:30 (#3)

וְרֹאשׁ לוֹ חָפוּי

“and his head was covered”

The expression **his head was covered** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and he had covered his head]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 15:32 (#4)

קָרוּעַ כֻּתָּנְתּוֹ

“His robe was torn”

The expression **His robe was torn** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [He had torn his robe]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 15:32 (#2)

וְהִנֵּה לְקָרָאתוֹ חוּשַׁי הָאַרְכִּי

“and behold, meeting him {was} Hushai the Architе”

The author is using the term **behold** to focus his listeners’ attention on an unexpected development in the story. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use for this purpose in your translation. Alternate translation: [and whom do you think he should meet but Hushai the Archite]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 15:32 (#3)

קָרוּעַ כֻּתָּנְתּוֹ וַאֲדָמָה עַל־רֹאשׁוֹ

“His robe was torn, and dirt {was} on his head”

Tearing his robe and putting dirt on his head were symbolic actions by which Hushai was expressing deep mourning, grief, and distress. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [He had torn his robe and put dirt on his head to show his great distress]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 15:32 (#1)

וַיְהִי

“And it happened”

The author is using the word translated **And it happened** to introduce a new development in the story. Use a word, phrase, or other method in your language that is natural for introducing a new development.

See: Introduction of a New Event

2 Samuel 15:33 (#1)

וְהָיִיתָ עָלַי לְמַשָּׂא

“you will become a burden to me”

David is speaking as if Hushai were actually a **burden** that would weigh him down. He means that Hushai would slow him down or make his situation more difficult. If it would be helpful in your language, you

could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you will only make things more difficult for me] or [you will not be able to help me, and you might slow me down]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 15:34 (#1)

וְאָמַרְתָּ֣ לְאַבְשָׁל֗וֹם עַבְדְּךָ֤ אֲנִי֙ הַמֶּ֣לֶךְ אֶהְיֶ֔ה עֶ֥בֶד אָבִ֖יךָ וְאָנִ֣י מֵאָ֑ז וְעַתָּ֥ה וַאֲנִ֖י עַבְדֶּ֣ךָ

“and say to Absalom, ‘I {am} your servant, O king. I was the servant of your father, and {as} I {was} previously, and now, so I {will be} your servant”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [and address Absalom as king and tell him that you are his servant. Say that just as previously you were the servant of his father, so now you will be his servant]

See: Quotes within Quotes

2 Samuel 15:34 (#3)

וְהֵפַרְתָּ֣ה לִּ֔י אֵ֖ת עֲצַ֣ת אֲחִיתֹ֑פֶל

“then you will break up the counsel of Ahithophel for me”

David is speaking as if Ahithophel’s advice were actually a physical object that Hushai could **break up**. He means that Hushai could prevent Absalom from accepting or following Ahithophel’s advice. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [then you will be able to help me by preventing Absalom from following Ahithophel’s advice] or [then you will be able to counter Ahithophel’s advice for my benefit]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 15:34 (#2)

וְעַתָּ֣ה

“and now”

See how you translated the similar expression in 2:6.

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 15:35 (#1)

וַהֲלֹ֨וא עִמְּךָ֜ שָׁ֣ם צָדֹ֗וק וְאֶבְיָתָר֙ הַכֹּהֲנִ֔ים

“Will} not Zadok and Abiathar the priests {be} with you there”

David is using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Zadok and Abiathar the priests will be with you there.]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 15:35 (#2)

כָּל־הַדָּבָר֙ אֲשֶׁ֣ר תִּשְׁמַ֔ע

“every word that you hear”

David is using the term **word** to represent what Absalom or others might say by using words. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [any information that you get]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 15:35 (#3)

מִבֵּ֖ית הַמֶּֽלֶךְ

“from the house of the king”

David is using the term **house** to mean an entire household living together. In this context, it would apply to Absalom’s family and officials. Alternate translation: [in the royal court]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 15:36 (#1)

אֲחִימַ֤עַץ לְצָדוֹק֙ וְיוֹנָתָ֣ן לְאֶבְיָתָ֔ר

“Ahimaaz to Zadok and Jonathan to Abiathar”

David is describing the father-son relationship between these men in the terms of his own culture. Your language may have its own term or expression for this relationship. Alternate translation: [Zadok’s son Ahimaaz and Abiathar’s son Jonathan] or [Ahimaaz the son of Zadok and Jonathan the son of Abiathar]

See: Kinship

2 Samuel 15:36 (#2)

וּשְׁלַחְתֶּ֥ם בְּיָדָ֖ם אֵלַ֑י כָּל־דָּבָ֕ר אֲשֶׁ֥ר תִּשְׁמָֽעוּ

“And you shall send to me by their hand every word that you hear”

The word **you** is plural in both instances. David seems to mean that Hushai, Zadok, and Abiathar should have Ahimaaz and Jonathan inform him of anything they hear. So use the plural form of “you” in your translation if your language marks that distinction.

See: Forms of 'You' — Singular

2 Samuel 15:36 (#3)

וּשְׁלַחְתֶּם בְּיָדָם֙ אֵלַ֔י כָּל־דָּבָ֖ר אֲשֶׁ֥ר תִּשְׁמָֽעוּ

"And you shall send to me by their hand every word that you hear"

See how you translated the similar expression in 11:14. Alternate translation: [And you shall have them come and tell me any news that you hear]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 15:37 (#1)

וַיָּבֹ֣א & הָעִ֔יר וְאַבְשָׁל֖וֹם יָבֹ֥א יְרוּשָׁלִָֽם

"So & came {to} the city. And Absalom came {to} Jerusalem"

The word that the ULT translates as **And** indicates that Hushai **came** to Jerusalem around the same time as when Absalom **came** there himself. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could describe the time relationship more explicitly. Alternate translation: [returned to Jerusalem just as Absalom was arriving there himself]

See: Connect — Simultaneous Time Relationship

2 Samuel - Chapter 16 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter continues the story of what David did as the king of Israel and specifically how he resisted Absalom's attempt to replace him as king. It tells how Ziba, Saul's servant who was helping to provide for Mephibosheth, brought David food to sustain him and the people with him in the wilderness. It tells how a Benjaminite man named Shimei cursed David and threw stones at him as David walked through the area where Shimei lived. It tells how Hushai the Archite got Absalom to accept him as a counselor. It then tells how Ahithophel, Absalom's other counselor, advised him to have sexual relations with the concubines David had left in Jerusalem.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Why did Ahithophel tell Absalom to have sexual relations with David's concubines?

One reason why Ahithophel told Absalom to do this was to make a complete break with David so that his followers would fight desperately. Ahithophel says this himself in 16:21. However, a further reason may have been that having sexual relations with a former king's concubines would be a symbolic assertion that Absalom was now the king instead. This seems to be the background in 3:7 and later in 1 Kings 2:22.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

"the people"

In the story of Absalom's rebellion against David, the author and characters use the term "people" in various contexts to mean either the crowd of supporters who left Jerusalem with David or the soldiers who fought for David or for Absalom. In chapter 15, the term "people" seems to refer in each instance to the crowd, which included both soldiers and others. In chapters 16–19, the term means different things in different contexts. For example, in 16:6, it seems to describe David's soldiers, who surrounded him to protect him from the stones that Shimei was throwing at him. But in 16:14 it seems to refer to the entire crowd that was with David. The UST gives an indication of the meaning in each context, and this may help you translate the term in that context in a way that will be helpful to your readers.

Hushai's overstatement for emphasis

In 16:18, Hushai tells Absalom that "every man of Israel" is supporting him. Hushai is saying **every** as an overstatement for emphasis to try to convince Absalom of his loyalty. Absalom himself has just acknowledged that many Israelites have gone with David, and he has suggested that Hushai might have done that himself. So Hushai really means that "very many" Israelites are supporting Absalom. However, it would be good to show in your translation that he is making an overstatement for emphasis, so we recommend that you not translate his statement as a less emphatic one. (See: Hyperbole)

2 Samuel 16:1 (#4)

וּמֵאָ֥ה קַ֖יִץ

"and 100 summer fruit"

Here, **summer fruit** represents "figs." If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and 100 bunches of figs]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 16:1 (#1)

וְהִנֵּ֣ה צִיבָ֔א & לִקְרָאתֹ֑ו

"and behold, meeting him {was} Ziba"

See how you translated the similar expression in 15:32.

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 16:1 (#3)

וְצֶ֣מֶד חֲמֹרִ֔ים חֲבֻשִׁ֖ים

“and a pair of saddled donkeys”

The expression **saddled** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [donkeys that someone had saddled]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 16:1 (#2)

נַ֣עַר מְפִי־בֹ֑שֶׁת

“the young man of Mephibosheth”

See how you translated this expression in 9:9, where it has a similar meaning. Alternate translation: [the servant of Mephibosheth]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 16:2 (#4)

הַיָּעֵ֥ף בַּמִּדְבָּ֖ר

“is for} the faint in the wilderness”

Ziba is using the adjective **faint** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [is for people who become faint in the wilderness]

See: Nominal Adjectives

2 Samuel 16:2 (#2)

לְבֵית־הַמֶּ֣לֶךְ

“are} for the house of the king”

Even though Ziba is addressing David directly, he is speaking of him in the third person as **the king** to show respect. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a respectful form in the second person. Alternate translation: [for your house]

See: First, Second or Third Person

2 Samuel 16:2 (#1)

מָה־אֵ֣לֶּה לָ֔ךְ

“What {are} these to you”

David is using **What {are} these to you?** as a common expression of his culture to mean “Why have you brought these things?” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [What do you have here] or [Why have you brought these things]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 16:2 (#3)

לְבֵית־הַמֶּ֣לֶךְ

“are} for the house of the king”

Ziba is using the term **house** to mean David’s household, that is, his family and servants. Alternate translation: [for the household of the king] or [for your household]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 16:3 (#3)

אָבִ֑י

“my father”

See how you translated the similar expression in 9:7. Alternate translation: [my grandfather]

See: Kinship

2 Samuel 16:3 (#1)

יוֹשֵׁ֣ב בִּירוּשָׁלַ֔͏ִם כִּֽי־אָמַ֗ר הַיּ֤וֹם יָשִׁ֙יבוּ֙ לִ֣י בֵּ֣ית יִשְׂרָאֵ֔ל אֵ֖ת מַמְלְכ֥וּת אָבִֽי

“he is staying in Jerusalem, for he said, ‘Today, the house of Israel will return the kingdom of my father to me”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [since he said, ‘Today, the house of Israel will return the kingdom of my father to me,’ he is staying in Jerusalem]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

2 Samuel 16:3 (#2)

בֵּ֣ית יִשְׂרָאֵ֔ל

“the house of Israel”

See how you translated the similar expression in 1:12. Alternate translation: [the people of Israel]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 16:4 (#1)

הִשְׁתַּחֲוֵ֖יתִי

“I prostrate myself”

Ziba did **prostrate** himself as he said this. This was a symbolic action that expressed submission, respect, and gratitude to the king. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [I prostrate myself to you in submission and gratitude]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 16:4 (#2)

אֶמְצָא־חֵן בְּעֵינֶיךָ

“May I find favor in your eyes”

See how you translated the similar expression in 3:19. Alternate translation: [May you regard me with favor]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 16:5 (#1)

מִשָּׁם֮ אִישׁ יוֹצֵא מִמִּשְׁפַּחַת בֵּית־שָׁאוּל וּשְׁמוֹ֒ שִׁמְעִי בֶּן־גֵּרָא

“a man from the clan of the house of Saul was coming out from there, and his name {was} Shimei, the son of Gera”

Here the author is introducing Shimei as a new participant in the story. Your language may have its own way of introducing new participants that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [a certain man named Shimei son of Gera, who belonged to the same clan as Saul’s family, was coming out from there]

See: Introduction of New and Old Participants

2 Samuel 16:5 (#2)

יָצוֹא וּמְקַלֵּל

“coming out and cursing”

The phrase **coming out and cursing** expresses a single idea. The word **cursing** tells in what way Shimei was **coming out**. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning in a different way. Alternate translation: [and he was cursing as he came out]

See: Hendiadys

2 Samuel 16:6 (#3)

וְכָל־הָעָם֮ וְכָל־הַגִּבֹּרִים מִימִינוֹ֒ וּמִשְּׂמֹאלוֹ

“and all of the people and all of the mighty {were} on his right and on his left”

The author is using this clause to describe something that was ongoing. This provides the background for the event that he describes in the first part of the verse. Connect this clause to that event in a way that makes it clear in your language that this clause is describing something that was ongoing at the same time. Alternate translation: [even though all of the people and all of the mighty had formed a protective shield on his right and on his left]

See: Connect — Background Information

2 Samuel 16:6 (#5)

מִימִינוֹ֒ וּמִשְּׂמֹאלוֹ

“were} on his right and on his left”

The author is referring to the area all around David by naming two directions, **on his right** and **on his left**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [were surrounding him]

See: Merism

2 Samuel 16:6 (#1)

וַיְסַקֵּל בָּאֲבָנִים֮ אֶת־דָּוִד֒

“And he stoned David with stones”

It might seem that the expression **stoned David with stones** contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [And he hurled stones at David]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 16:6 (#4)

הַגִּבֹּרִים

“the mighty”

The author is using the adjective **mighty** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the mighty warriors]

See: Nominal Adjectives

2 Samuel 16:6 (#2)

וַיְסַקֵּל בָּאֲבָנִים֮ אֶת־דָּוִד֒

“And he stoned David with stones”

Throwing stones at David was a symbolic action by which Shimei showed contempt and rebellion against

David's authority as king. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [he contemptuously threw stones at David]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 16:7 (#3)

אִ֣ישׁ הַדָּמִ֔ים

"man of blood"

The word **blood** is plural here because it refers to blood shed by violence. Your language may use the plural form of its word for blood to mean the same thing. If not, you could express the meaning in another way, here and in the next verse. See how you translated the similar expression in 3:28. Alternate translation: [man of bloodshed]

See: Unusual Uses of the Plural

2 Samuel 16:7 (#1)

צֵ֥א צֵ֖א

"Get out, get out"

Shimei is repeating the verb **get out** in order to intensify his expression of the idea that it conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [Get all the way out of here]

See: Reduplication

2 Samuel 16:7 (#2)

אִ֣ישׁ הַדָּמִ֔ים וְאִ֖ישׁ הַבְּלִיָּֽעַל

"man of blood, man of wickedness"

Shimei is saying **man of** here in the same way that biblical authors and characters often use the similar expression "son of" to indicate that a person has the characteristic of something. In this case, Shimei is saying that David has the characteristics of being deadly violent and wicked. The first phrase describes what David has done, and the second phrase describes what kind of person Shimei believes David to be. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an equivalent expression from your language or state the meaning plainly. The UST models one way to do that.

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 16:8 (#2)

הֵשִׁ֤יב עָלֶ֙יךָ֙ יְהוָ֔ה כֹּ֖ל ׀ דְּמֵ֣י בֵית־שָׁא֑וּל

"Yahweh has brought back upon you all of the blood of the house of Saul"

Shimei is using **blood** to represent death, since people bleed when they are killed violently. He is referring to the many people whom David's soldiers killed when, in order to make David the king, they fought against soldiers loyal to Saul's descendants. Alternate translation: [Yahweh is holding you responsible for the deaths of all of the people loyal to Saul whom your soldiers killed]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 16:8 (#3)

וְהִנְּךָ֖ בְּרָעָתֶ֑ךָ

"And behold you in your evil"

Shimei is using the term **evil** to represent what he believes are the consequences of evil actions on David's part. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [And behold you suffering the consequences of your evil actions]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 16:8 (#1)

הֵשִׁ֤יב עָלֶ֙יךָ֙ יְהוָ֔ה כֹּ֖ל ׀ דְּמֵ֣י בֵית־שָׁא֑וּל

"Yahweh has brought back upon you all of the blood of the house of Saul"

Shimei is using an expression similar to the one David used in 3:29 when he spoke of the blood of Abner being on the head of Joab. By saying that Yahweh has brought the blood of the house of Saul **upon** David, Shimei means that Yahweh is holding David responsible for shedding this blood and punishing him for doing that. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Yahweh is holding you responsible for all of the blood of the house of Saul that you shed]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 16:8 (#4)

וְהִנְּךָ֖ בְּרָעָתֶ֑ךָ

"And behold you in your evil"

Shimei is using **behold you** as a common expression of his culture to mean that one can **behold** or look at David and see that what he is saying is true. If

this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Now look at you, suffering the consequences of your evil actions] or [It is clear that you are suffering the consequences of your evil actions]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 16:9 (#1)

לָֽמָּה יְקַלֵּ֞ל הַכֶּ֤לֶב הַמֵּת֙ הַזֶּ֔ה אֶת־אֲדֹנִ֖י הַמֶּ֣לֶךְ

“Why should this dead dog curse my lord the king”

Abishai is using the question form for emphasis to express his outrage that Shimei would curse King David. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [This dead dog should not be cursing my lord the king!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 16:9 (#2)

הַכֶּ֤לֶב הַמֵּת֙

“dead dog”

See how you translated the similar expression in 9:5. Alternate translation: [contemptible person]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 16:9 (#3)

אֶת־אֲדֹנִ֖י הַמֶּ֣לֶךְ

“my lord the king”

Even though Abishai is addressing David directly, he is speaking of him in the third person as **my lord the king** to show respect. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a respectful form in the second person. Alternate translation: [you, my lord the king]

See: First, Second or Third Person

2 Samuel 16:10 (#3)

כִּ֣י יְקַלֵּ֔ל וְכִ֣י יְהוָ֔ה אָמַ֖ר לּ֑וֹ קַלֵּ֣ל אֶת־דָּוִ֗ד וּמִֽי־יֹאמַ֙ר֙ מַדּ֣וּעַ עָשִׂ֔יתָ כֵּֽן

“If he curses because Yahweh has said to him, ‘Curse David,’ then who shall say, ‘Why have you done thus”

David is using the question form for emphasis to express that no one should tell Shimei that he should not curse David. He is suggesting that someone might use the question form to tell Shimei that. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for those purposes, you could translate these questions as statements or as exclamations. Alternate translation: [If he is cursing me because Yahweh has said to him, ‘Curse David,’ then no one should tell him, ‘You should not be doing thus’!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 16:10 (#1)

מַה־לִּ֥י וְלָכֶ֖ם בְּנֵ֣י צְרוּיָ֑ה

“What to me and to you, sons of Zeruiah”

David is using **What to me and to you** as a common expression of his culture to say that he has nothing in common with these **sons of Zeruiah** in terms of what they want to do. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will have nothing to do with your suggestion, sons of Zeruiah!]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 16:10 (#2)

מַה־לִּ֥י וְלָכֶ֖ם

“What to me and to you”

The word **you** is plural here because David is addressing both Abishai and Joab. Joab seems to have been nearby and supporting his brother Abishai’s suggestion. So use the plural form in your translation if your language marks that distinction.

See: Forms of ‘You’ — Singular

2 Samuel 16:10 (#4)

וכי יְהוָ֔ה אָמַ֖ר לּ֑וֹ קַלֵּ֣ל אֶת־דָּוִ֗ד וּמִֽי־יֹאמַ֙ר֙ מַדּ֣וּעַ עָשִׂ֔יתָ כֵּֽן

“because Yahweh has said to him, ‘Curse David,’ then who shall say, ‘Why have you done thus”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [because Yahweh has told him to curse me, then no one should ask him why he is doing this] or [because Yahweh has told him to curse me, then no one should tell him that he should not be doing this]

See: Quotes within Quotes

2 Samuel 16:10 (#5)

יְהוָה֙ אָ֣מַר לוֹ֔ קַלֵּ֖ל אֶת־דָּוִ֑ד

“Yahweh has said to him, ‘Curse David”

David probably does not mean to suggest that Yahweh may have said this directly to Shimei. Instead, he probably means that Yahweh may have led Shimei to do this. So even if your language could put a quotation within a quotation, you may wish not to represent this as a direct quotation. Alternate translation: [Yahweh has led him to curse me]

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

2 Samuel 16:11 (#1)

אֲשֶׁר־יָצָ֥א מִמֵּעַ֖י

“who came out from my belly”

See how you translated the similar expression in 7:12. Alternate translation: [whose actual father I am]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 16:11 (#4)

כִּי־עַתָּ֕ה בֶּן־הַיְמִינִ֖י

“that now a Benjaminite”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [that now a Benjaminite should wish that I were dead]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 16:11 (#2)

מְבַקֵּ֥שׁ אֶת־נַפְשִׁ֖י

“is seeking my life”

See how you translated the similar expression in 4:8. Alternate translation: [is seeking to kill me]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 16:11 (#3)

וְאַ֣ף

“And how much more”

See how you translated the similar expression in 4:11. Alternate translation: [And with how much greater reason]

See: Exclamations

2 Samuel 16:13 (#1)

הָלוֹךְ֙ וְקַלֵּ֔ל

“walking and he cursed”

The phrase **walking and he cursed** expresses a single idea. The word **cursed** tells in what way Shimei was **walking**. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning in a different way. Alternate translation: [walking cursingly] or [cursing as he walked]

See: Hendiadys

2 Samuel 16:13 (#2)

וַיְסַקֵּ֥ל בָּאֲבָנִ֛ים לְעֻמָּת֖וֹ

“and he stoned with stones beside him”

See how you translated the similar expression in 16:6. Alternate translation: [and he threw stones at him]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 16:13 (#3)

וְעִפַּ֥ר בֶּעָפָֽר

“and he dusted with dust”

It might seem that the expression **dusted with dust** contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [and he showered dirt on him]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 16:13 (#4)

וְעִפַּ֥ר בֶּעָפָֽר

“and he dusted with dust”

Throwing dust on David was a symbolic action by which Shimei showed extreme disrespect and contempt for him. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [and he threw dirt at him to show his contempt]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 16:14 (#1)

וַיָּבֹ֥א

“And & came”

The implication is that David and his people arrived at the fords of the Jordan River. That was where David specified he would be going in 15:28. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [arrived at the fords of the Jordan]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 16:15 (#1)

הָעָ֖ם אִ֣ישׁ יִשְׂרָאֵ֑ל

“the people, a man of Israel”

The author is using **the people, a man of Israel** as a common expression of his culture to refer to Israelites from various tribes. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the Israelites from various tribes who had joined him]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 16:16 (#2)

יְחִ֥י הַמֶּ֖לֶךְ יְחִ֥י הַמֶּֽלֶךְ

“May the king live! May the king live”

Hushai is using a courteous and deferential expression that people in this culture would use to greet and acknowledge someone as their ruler. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [Long live the king! Long live the king!] or [God save the king! God save the king!]

See: Politeness

2 Samuel 16:16 (#1)

יְחִ֥י הַמֶּ֖לֶךְ יְחִ֥י הַמֶּֽלֶךְ

“May the king live! May the king live”

Hushai is repeating this phrase in order to intensify his expression of the idea that it conveys. If speakers of your language repeat phrases for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [May the king live forever!]

See: Reduplication

2 Samuel 16:17 (#1)

זֶ֣ה חַסְדְּךָ֔ אֶת־רֵעֶ֖ךָ לָ֣מָּה לֹא־הָלַ֔כְתָּ אֶת־רֵעֶֽךָ

“Is} this your loyalty to your friend? Why did you not go with your friend”

Absalom is using the question form to express disappointment with Hushai and to rebuke him for not being loyal to David. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate these questions as statements or as exclamations. Alternate translation: [You are not showing loyalty to your friend! I would have expected you to go with him.]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 16:18 (#2)

וְכָל־אִ֥ישׁ יִשְׂרָאֵ֖ל

“and every man of Israel”

See the discussion of this phrase in the Introduction to this chapter.

See: Hyperbole

2 Samuel 16:18 (#1)

וְכָל־אִ֥ישׁ יִשְׂרָאֵ֖ל

“and every man of Israel”

Here the masculine term **man** has a generic sense that includes both men and women. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use language in your translation that is clearly inclusive of both men and women. Alternate translation: [all the people of Israel]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

2 Samuel 16:19 (#1)

וְהַשֵּׁנִ֖ית

“And second”

If your language would not represent a number in a form such as **second**, you could represent this number in a form that your language would use, or you could use a comparable expression. Alternate translation: [And point number two] or [Furthermore]

See: Ordinal Numbers

2 Samuel 16:19 (#2)

לְמִי֙ אֲנִ֣י אֶֽעֱבֹ֔ד הֲלֹ֖וא לִפְנֵ֣י בְנ֑וֹ

“I, before whom shall I serve? {Is it} not to the face of his son”

Hushai is using the question form to emphasize that it is right and proper for him to serve Absalom, David’s son. If a speaker of your language would not use the

question form for that purpose, you could translate these questions as statements or as exclamations. Alternate translation: [it is appropriate for you, his son, to be the one before whose face I serve!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 16:19 (#3)

לְמִי֙ אֲנִ֣י אֶֽעֱבֹ֔ד

“I, before whom shall I serve”

After saying that Yahweh, the people present, and many other Israelites have chosen Absalom as king, Hushai is stating the pronoun **I**, even though its meaning is already included in the verb translated as **shall I serve**, to indicate that for his part, he will do the same thing. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing that Hushai is saying that his own actions will be comparable to those of others. It may not be necessary to represent the separately stated pronoun explicitly. Alternate translation: [before whom shall I, for my part, serve]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 16:19 (#4)

הֲלֹ֕וא לִפְנֵ֖י בְּנ֑וֹ כַּאֲשֶׁ֤ר עָבַ֙דְתִּי֙ לִפְנֵ֣י אָבִ֔יךָ כֵּ֖ן אֶֽהְיֶ֥ה לְפָנֶֽיךָ׃

“Is it} not to the face of his son? Just as I served to the face of your father, thus I will be to your face”

Here, **to the face of** represents being in the presence of someone. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Is it not in the presence of his son? Just as I served in the presence of your father, thus I will be in your presence]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 16:20 (#1)

וַיֹּ֤אמֶר אַבְשָׁלֹם֙ אֶל־אֲחִיתֹ֔פֶל הָב֥וּ לָכֶ֖ם עֵצָֽה

“And Absalom said to Ahithophel, “Give counsel for yourselves”

The implied “you” in the imperative **Give** is plural, as the plural pronoun **yourselves** indicates. While the author says that Absalom spoke these words to Ahithophel, Absalom was evidently addressing him as chief among a group of advisors. So use a plural form of the imperative in your translation if your language marks that distinction. You may also wish to indicate more fully whom Absalom was addressing. Alternate translation: [And Absalom said to Ahithophel and his other advisors, “Give counsel for yourselves]

See: Forms of ‘You’ — Singular

2 Samuel 16:20 (#2)

הָב֥וּ לָכֶ֖ם עֵצָֽה

“Give counsel for yourselves”

Absalom is using the pronoun **yourselves** because his advisors are part of the group for whose benefit this **counsel** will be given. Since the speaker, Absalom, is also part of this group, it may be natural in your language to use a first-person plural pronoun. Alternate translation: [Give counsel for us]

See: Reflexive Pronouns

2 Samuel 16:21 (#1)

בְּב֣וֹא אֶל

“Go in to”

The author is referring to sexual relations in a polite way by using the phrase **Go in to**. Depending on what is helpful in your language, you could use a polite way of referring to this in your language or you could state this plainly, here and in the next verse. Alternate translation: [Sleep with]

See: Euphemism

2 Samuel 16:21 (#2)

נִבְאַ֖שְׁתָּ אֶת־אָבִ֑יךָ

“you have made yourself stink with your father”

See how you translated the similar expression in 10:6. Alternate translation: [you have incensed your father] or [you have made yourself abhorrent to your father]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 16:21 (#3)

וְחָזְק֖וּ יְדֵ֣י כָל־אֲשֶׁ֥ר אִתֶּֽךָ

“and the hands of all who {are} with you will become strong”

See how you translated the similar expression in 2:7. Alternate translation: [and all who are with you will become more determined]

See: Synecdoche

2 Samuel 16:22 (#2)

לְעֵינֵ֖י כָּל־יִשְׂרָאֵֽל

“to the eyes of all of Israel”

The author says **all of Israel** as an overstatement for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [for any Israelite to see]

See: Hyperbole

2 Samuel 16:22 (#1)

לְעֵינֵי כָּל־יִשְׂרָאֵל

“to the eyes of all of Israel”

Here, the word **eyes** represents sight. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in the sight of all of Israel]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 16:23 (#1)

וַעֲצַת אֲחִיתֹפֶל אֲשֶׁר יָעַץ בַּיָּמִים הָהֵם כַּאֲשֶׁר יִשְׁאַל־בִּדְבַר הָאֱלֹהִים

“Now the counsel of Ahithophel that he counseled in those days {was} just as if one inquired of the word of God”

The author is providing background information to help readers understand what has just happened in the story. He is accounting for why Absalom did such an outrageous thing without questioning it. In your translation, introduce this information in a way that would be natural in your own language and culture.

See: Connect — Background Information

2 Samuel 16:23 (#2)

וַעֲצַת אֲחִיתֹפֶל אֲשֶׁר יָעַץ

“Now the counsel of Ahithophel that he counseled”

It might seem that the expression **counsel of Ahithophel that he counseled** contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [Now the counsel that Ahithophel gave]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 16:23 (#3)

בִּדְבַר הָאֱלֹהִים

“of the word of God”

The author is using the term **word** to represent what God would say by using words. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [what God had to say]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel - Chapter 17 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter continues the story of what David did as the king of Israel and specifically how he resisted Absalom’s attempt to replace him as king. It tells how Hushai the Archite, David’s friend, persuaded Absalom to reject the counsel of Ahithophel and not attack David immediately. This gave Hushai time to send David a warning so that he crossed the Jordan River to safety while Absalom was gathering a great army. The chapter also tells how other friends of David provided food and supplies for him.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

“the people”

In this chapter, the term “people” continues to vary in meaning. Sometimes it refers to David’s or Absalom’s soldiers, and sometimes it refers to the large group that left Jerusalem with David, which included many individuals who were not soldiers. The UST gives an indication of the meaning in each context, and this may help you translate the term in that context in a way that will be helpful to your readers.

Hushai’s overstatements for emphasis

In this chapter, Hushai continues to make overstatements for emphasis as he speaks to Absalom. He says in 17:11 that Absalom may gather an army that is “like the sand that {is} by the sea for multitude,” that is, one that has too many troops to count. In 17:12, he says that not a single soldier from David’s army will escape. And in 17:13, he says that Absalom’s troops may tear down a city so that “not even a pebble will be found there.” These overstatements suggest that Hushai is loyal to Absalom. They also appeal to Absalom’s pride and vanity in order to get him to follow a course that is actually foolish and not in his interests. As with the overstatement made in 16:18, we suggest that it would be good to show in your translation that Hushai is making overstatements for emphasis in these further cases, so we recommend that you not translate his statements as less emphatic ones.

2 Samuel 17:1 (#1)

וְאָקוּמָה

“and let me arise”

See how you translated the similar expression in 2:14. Alternate translation: [let me take action]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 17:2 (#2)

וְהַחֲרַדְתִּי אֹתוֹ

“and I will make him tremble”

Ahithophel assumes that Absalom will understand that he means he will **make** David **tremble** with fear. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. If you have already translated the book of 1 Samuel, see how you translated the similar expression in 1 Samuel 13:7. Alternate translation: [and I will make him tremble with fear] or [and I will terrify him]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 17:2 (#3)

וְהִכֵּיתִי אֶת־הַמֶּלֶךְ לְבַדּוֹ

“And I will strike the king alone”

See how you translated the similar expression in 1:1. Also see the discussion of the term “strike” in the Introduction to 2 Samuel. Alternate translation: [And I will kill the king alone]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 17:2 (#1)

וּרְפֵיָה יָדַיִם

“and weak of hands”

See how you translated the similar expression in 4:1. Alternate translation: [and worn out]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 17:3 (#1)

כָּל־הָעָם יִהְיֶה שָׁלוֹם

“All of the people will be {at} peace”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **peace**, you could express the same idea in another way. This could mean: (1) that all of the other people with David will be unharmed. The term “peace” would have the sense of “welfare” or “well-being.” Alternate translation: [All of the other people will be unharmed]; (2) that none of the people with David will continue fighting against Absalom once David is dead. The term “peace” would have the sense of “absence of war.” Alternate translation: [None of the other people will continue fighting against you]

See: Abstract Nouns

2 Samuel 17:4 (#1)

וַיִּישַׁר הַדָּבָר

“And the word was right”

The author is using the term **word** to represent what Ahithophel said by using words. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And what Ahithophel had said]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 17:4 (#2)

וַיִּישַׁר & בְּעֵינֵי אַבְשָׁלוֹם וּבְעֵינֵי כָּל־זִקְנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל

“And & was right in the eyes of Absalom and in the eyes of all of the elders of Israel”

The author is using the common expression of his culture **in the eyes of** to mean “in the judgment of” or “in the opinion of.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. See how you translated the similar expression in 3:19. Alternate translation: [seemed to Absalom and all of the elders of Israel to be the right thing to do]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 17:5 (#2)

מַה־בְּפִיו

“what {is} in his mouth”

Here, **in his mouth** represents “what he has to say.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [what he has to say]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 17:5 (#1)

וְנִשְׁמְעָה

“and let us hear”

Absalom is probably speaking to a servant or official while using the pronoun **us** to refer to himself and the elders of Israel. Since the addressee is probably not included, use the exclusive form of “us” if your language marks that distinction.

See: Exclusive and Inclusive ‘We’

2 Samuel 17:5 (#3)

גַּם־הוּא

“even he”

Absalom adds this phrase to clarify his meaning. Without it, the word **his** might apply to Ahithophel, and Absalom might mean that he wants to hear what Ahithophel says about what Hushai recommends. He is clarifying that his meaning is simply that he wants to hear what Hushai has to say. You could indicate this in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [for his part]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 17:6 (#1)

לֵאמֹר כַּדָּבָר הַזֶּה דִּבֶּר אֲחִיתֹפֶל הֲנַעֲשֶׂה

“saying, “According to this word, Ahithophel has spoken. Shall we do”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could express the first part of this as an indirect quotation, since Absalom did not actually say **According to this word**. Rather, he gave Hushai a summary of what Ahithophel had said. Alternate translation: [and told him what Ahithophel had said. Then he asked, “Shall we do]

See: Direct and Indirect Quotations

2 Samuel 17:6 (#2)

אֶת־דְּבָרוֹ

“his word”

Absalom is using the term **word** to represent what Ahithophel said by using words. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [what he has recommended]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 17:6 (#3)

אַתָּה דַּבֵּר

“you speak”

See how you translated the similar expression “you, you know” in 7:20. Alternate translation: [tell us what you, for your part, would recommend]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 17:7 (#1)

הָעֵצָה אֲשֶׁר־יָעַץ אֲחִיתֹפֶל

“The counsel that Ahithophel has counseled”

It might seem that this expression contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. See how you translated the similar expression in 16:23. Alternate translation: [The counsel that Ahithophel has given]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 17:8 (#1)

אַתָּה יָדַעְתָּ אֶת־אָבִיךָ וְאֶת־אֲנָשָׁיו כִּי גִבֹּרִים הֵמָּה

“You, you know your father and his men, that they {are} warriors”

Hushai is stating the pronoun **you** separately, even though the verb translated as **you know** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that Absalom has knowledge that should make him realize that Ahithophel has not given good advice. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [You know quite well that your father and his men are warriors]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 17:8 (#2)

וְאֶת־אֲנָשָׁיו & וּמָרֵי נֶפֶשׁ

“and his men & and & are} bitter of soul”

Hushai is speaking as if David and his men actually had souls that were **bitter**. He means that they were easily provoked to violence. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. If you have already translated the book of Judges, see how you translated the similar expression in Judges 18:25. Alternate translation: [and prone to violence]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 17:8 (#3)

כְּדֹב שַׁכְכָוּל

“like a bear bereaved”

The expression **bereaved** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [like a she-bear whose cubs someone has taken from her]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 17:8 (#4)

כְּדֹ֣ב שַׁכּ֔וּל בַּשָּׂדֶ֑ה

“like a bear bereaved in the field”

Hushai is using this comparison to make the point that just as a **bear bereaved in the field** is enraged and aggressive, so David and his men will be as well. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [as vicious as a bear in the wild whose cubs have been taken] or [as fierce as a bear in the wild that has lost her young]

See: Simile

2 Samuel 17:8 (#5)

אִ֣ישׁ מִלְחָמָ֔ה

“is} a man of war”

Hushai is using this possessive form to describe a **man** who is characterized by having much experience in **war**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form in that way, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [is an experienced warrior]

See: Possession

2 Samuel 17:9 (#7)

בָּעָ֔ם אֲשֶׁ֖ר אַחֲרֵ֣י אַבְשָׁלֹֽם

“among the people who {are} behind Absalom”

See how you translated the similar expression in 2:25. Alternate translation: [the soldiers who are fighting for Absalom]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 17:9 (#1)

הִנֵּ֤ה

“Behold”

See how you translated the similar expression in 1:2. Alternate translation: [Listen]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 17:9 (#3)

כִּנְפֹּ֥ל בָּהֶ֖ם

“when {some} among them fall”

The author is using the term **fall** by association to mean that they died, since people fall down when they die. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. See how you translated the similar expression in 2:16. Alternate translation: [when some among them die] or [when some among them are killed]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 17:9 (#4)

כִּנְפֹּ֥ל בָּהֶ֖ם

“when {some} among them fall”

The pronoun **them** refers to the soldiers whom Ahithophel wants to lead out against David. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [when some among the soldiers whom Ahithophel wants to lead out tonight fall]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 17:9 (#5)

וְשָׁמַ֣ע הַשֹּׁמֵ֔עַ וְאָמַ֕ר

“the hearer will hear and say”

It might seem that this expression contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you state this differently. Alternate translation: [people will hear and say]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 17:9 (#6)

וְאָמַ֕ר הָיְתָ֥ה מַגֵּפָ֖ה בָּעָ֔ם אֲשֶׁ֖ר אַחֲרֵ֣י אַבְשָׁלֹֽם

“and say, ‘A slaughter has happened among the people who {are} behind Absalom”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [and say that a slaughter has happened among the people who are behind Absalom]

See: Quotes within Quotes

2 Samuel 17:9 (#2)

אוֹ֖ בְּאַחַ֣ד הַמְּקוֹמֹֽת

“or in one of the places”

The author is using **one of the places** as a common expression of his culture to mean “some other such place.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [or in some other such place]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 17:10 (#4)

הַמֵּמֵס יִמָּמֵס כִּי־יוֹדֵעַ כָּל־יִשְׂרָאֵל כִּי־גִבּוֹר אָבִיךָ וּבְנֵי־חַיִל אֲשֶׁר אִתּוֹ

“melting, he will melt, because all of Israel knows that your father {is} a warrior and {they} who {are} with him {are} sons of valor”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [since all of Israel knows that your father is a warrior and they who are with him are sons of valor, melting, he will melt]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

2 Samuel 17:10 (#5)

הַמֵּמֵס יִמָּמֵס

“melting, he will melt”

Hushai is repeating forms of the verb **melt** in order to intensify his expression of the idea that it conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [he will certainly melt]

See: Reduplication

2 Samuel 17:10 (#1)

בֶּן־חַיִל & וּבְנֵי־חַיִל

“a son of valor & and & are} sons of valor”

See how you translated the similar expression in 2:7. Alternate translation: [a valiant warrior ... are valiant warriors]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 17:10 (#2)

אֲשֶׁר לִבּוֹ כְּלֵב הָאַרְיֵה

“whose heart {is} like the heart of a lion”

Here, the **heart** represents a person’s courage. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [whose courage is like the courage of a lion]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 17:10 (#3)

אֲשֶׁר לִבּוֹ כְּלֵב הָאַרְיֵה

“whose heart {is} like the heart of a lion”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a lion** has great courage, so does King David. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [whose courage is great, like the courage of a lion]

See: Simile

2 Samuel 17:10 (#6)

הַמֵּמֵס יִמָּמֵס

“melting, he will melt”

Hushai is speaking as if even the bravest warrior in Absalom’s army would actually **melt** when he heard that David’s soldiers were killing the soldiers in his army. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. If you have already translated the book of Joshua, see how you translated the similar expressions in Joshua 2:11, Joshua 5:1, and Joshua 7:5. Alternate translation: [he will certainly become terrified]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 17:11 (#7)

וּפָנֶיךָ הֹלְכִים בַּקְּרָב

“And your face shall be going into the battle”

Hushai is using one part of Absalom, his **face**, to represent Absalom himself. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And you personally shall go into the battle as the Israelite commander]

See: Synecdoche

2 Samuel 17:11 (#3)

הֶאָסֹף יֵאָסֵף & כָּל־יִשְׂרָאֵל

“being gathered, all of Israel shall be gathered”

Israel represents “the soldiers of Israel.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language, here and in verse 13. Alternate translation: [you shall certainly gather all of the soldiers of Israel] or [you shall certainly gather the entire Israelite army]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 17:11 (#4)

מִדָּן וְעַד־בְּאֵר שָׁשֶׁבַע

“from Dan and to Beersheba”

Hushai is referring to all of Israel by naming cities at its northern and southern extremes, **Dan** and **Beersheba**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. See how you translated the similar expression in 3:10. Alternate translation: [from throughout the country]

See: Merism

2 Samuel 17:11 (#1)

הֵאָסֹף יֵאָסֵף & כָּל־יִשְׂרָאֵל

“being gathered, all of Israel shall be gathered”

The author is repeating forms of the verb **gathered** in order to intensify his expression of the idea that it conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [all of Israel shall certainly be gathered]

See: Reduplication

2 Samuel 17:11 (#2)

הֵאָסֹף יֵאָסֵף & כָּל־יִשְׂרָאֵל

“being gathered, all of Israel shall be gathered”

The expression **being gathered ... shall be gathered** uses passive verbal forms. If your language would not use those forms, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [you shall certainly gather all of Israel]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 17:11 (#5)

כַּחוֹל אֲשֶׁר־עַל־הַיָּם לָרֹב

“like the sand that {is} by the sea for multitude”

The point of this comparison is that just as **the sand that is by the sea** is uncountable, so would be the soldiers whom Absalom would gather. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [like the seemingly countless grains of sand that are by the sea for multitude]

See: Simile

2 Samuel 17:11 (#6)

כַּחוֹל אֲשֶׁר־עַל־הַיָּם לָרֹב

“like the sand that {is} by the sea for multitude”

By suggesting that Absalom will have too many troops to count, Hushai is making an overstatement for emphasis in order to convince Absalom to follow his advice. See the discussion in the Introduction to this chapter of how you might represent this overstatement and the ones in the next two verses in your translation.

See: Hyperbole

2 Samuel 17:12 (#2)

אֲשֶׁר נִמְצָא שָׁם

“where he may be found there”

The expression **will be found** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [where we may find him]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 17:12 (#5)

נִנּוֹתַר

“will be left”

The expression **will be left** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [will remain]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 17:12 (#3)

כַּאֲשֶׁר יִפֹּל הַטַּל עַל־הָאֲדָמָה

“just as the dew falls upon the ground”

The point of this comparison is that just as the **dew** that **falls upon the ground** completely covers the ground, so Absalom’s army would completely overwhelm David and his soldiers. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [just as the dew falls everywhere upon the ground]

See: Simile

2 Samuel 17:12 (#4)

וְלֹא־נִנּוֹתַר בּוֹ וּבְכָל־הָאֲנָשִׁים אֲשֶׁר־אִתּוֹ גַּם־אֶחָד

“And not even one will be left of him or of any of the men who {are} with him”

We recommend that you represent this overstatement in your translation, like the one in the previous verse.

See: Hyperbole

2 Samuel 17:12 (#1)

אֲשֶׁ֥ר נִמְצָ֖א שָׁ֑שָׁם

“where he may be found there”

It might seem that this expression contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you can shorten it. Alternate translation: [where he may be found]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 17:13 (#1)

וְאָסַ֤ף

“he gathers himself”

Here, David **himself** represents him and all of his forces. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [he gathers his forces]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 17:13 (#3)

לֹא־נִמְצָ֥א שָׁ֖שָׁם גַּם־צְרֽוֹר

“not even a pebble will be found there”

Hushai is using the term **found** in a way characteristic of his language and culture to mean that such a **pebble** will not be able to **be found**, that is, it will not be there. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. If you have already translated the book of 1 Samuel, see how you translated the similar expression in 1 Samuel 9:8. Alternate translation: [not even a pebble will be there]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 17:13 (#4)

לֹא־נִמְצָ֥א שָׁ֖שָׁם גַּם־צְרֽוֹר

“not even a pebble will be found there”

We recommend that you represent this overstatement in your translation, like the ones in the previous two verses.

See: Hyperbole

2 Samuel 17:13 (#2)

עַד־הַנַּ֔חַל

“to the wadi”

Hushai is assuming that David would retreat into a fortified city that had been built on a hill above a valley or ravine through which water sometimes flowed. Since 16:2 indicates that it was summer at this time, Hushai may not be expecting that water would be flowing. So you may wish to describe this feature without implying that there would be water in it. Alternate translation: [down into the ravine below]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 17:14 (#4)

לְבַעֲב֗וּר הָבִ֤יא יְהוָה֙ אֶל־אַבְשָׁל֔וֹם אֶת־הָרָעָ֖ה

“for the sake of Yahweh bringing harm to Absalom”

Since the author has already mentioned Yahweh earlier in the sentence, it may be more natural in your language to refer to him with a pronoun here. Alternate translation: [so that he could bring harm to Absalom]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 17:14 (#1)

וַיהוָ֔ה

“For Yahweh”

Here the word **For** introduces not a reason but an explanation. Alternate translation: [This happened because]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

2 Samuel 17:14 (#2)

לְהָפֵ֔ר

“to break up”

See how you translated the similar expression in 15:34. Alternate translation: [to counter]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 17:14 (#3)

אֶת־עֲצַ֥ת אֲחִיתֹ֖פֶל הַטּוֹבָ֑ה

“the good counsel of Ahithophel”

The author does not mean that it was morally **good** for Ahithophel to have recommended launching a sudden attack in order to kill David. He means that Ahithophel’s counsel would have been “good” for

Absalom in the sense that it would have been more effective in defeating David. You could translate the term that way if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [the counsel of Ahithophel that would have been more effective]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 17:15 (#2)

כָּזֹאת וְכָזֹאת & וְכָזֹאת וְכָזֹאת

“Like this and like this & but like this and like this”

The author is using the phrase **Like this and like this** as a common expression of his culture to indicate that Hushai summarized what he and Ahithophel had said. If you choose to translate this as a direct quotation, but if this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [In such and such a way ... but in such and such a way]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 17:15 (#3)

יָעַצְתִּי אֲנִי

“I, I have counseled”

See how you translated the similar expression “you, you know” in 17:20. Alternate translation: [I, for my part, have counseled]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 17:15 (#1)

וַיֹּ֨אמֶר חוּשַׁ֜י אֶל־צָדֹ֣וק וְאֶל־אֶבְיָתָ֗ר כָּזֹאת֩ וְכָזֹאת֙ יָעַ֣ץ אֲחִיתֹ֔פֶל אֶת־אַבְשָׁל֖וֹם וְאֶת־זִקְנֵ֣י יִשְׂרָאֵ֑ל וְכָזֹאת֙ וְכָזֹאת֔ יָעַ֖צְתִּי אֲנִֽי

“Then Hushai said to Zadok and to Abiathar, the priests, “Like this and like this Ahithophel counseled Absalom and the elders of Israel, but like this and like this I, I have counseled”

Since Hushai did not actually say the words **like this and like this**, if it would be more natural in your language, you could express this as an indirect quotation. Alternate translation: [Then Hushai told Zadok and Abiathar, the priests, what Ahithophel had counseled Absalom and the elders of Israel and what he himself had counseled instead]

See: Direct and Indirect Quotations

2 Samuel 17:16 (#3)

בְּעַרְבוֹת הַמִּדְבָּ֑ר

“at the fords of the wilderness”

See how you translated the similar expression in 15:28. Alternate translation: [at the fords of the Jordan River]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 17:16 (#4)

וְגַ֣ם עָבֹ֣ר תַּעֲבֹ֔ר

“but also crossing over, cross over”

Hushai is repeating forms of the verb **cross over** in order to intensify his expression of the idea that it conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [but instead certainly cross over]

See: Reduplication

2 Samuel 17:16 (#6)

פֶּ֚ן יְבֻלַּ֣ע לַמֶּ֔לֶךְ

“lest the king be swallowed”

Here, Hushai is speaking as if King David would actually be **swallowed**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [lest the king be destroyed]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 17:16 (#1)

וְעַתָּ֣ה

“And now”

See how you translated the similar expression in 2:6.

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 17:16 (#2)

לֵאמֹ֗ר אַל־תָּ֤לֶן הַלַּיְלָה֙ בְּעַרְבוֹת֙ הַמִּדְבָּ֔ר וְגַ֣ם עָבֹ֣ר תַּעֲבֹ֔ר פֶּ֚ן יְבֻלַּ֣ע לַמֶּ֔לֶךְ וּלְכָל־הָעָ֖ם אֲשֶׁ֥ר אִתּֽוֹ

“saying, ‘Do not lodge tonight at the fords of the wilderness, but also crossing over, cross over, lest the king be swallowed and all of the people who {are} with him”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [and tell him not to lodge tonight at the fords of the wilderness but

instead, crossing over, to cross over, lest the king be swallowed and all of the people who are with him]

See: Quotes within Quotes

2 Samuel 17:16 (#5)

פֶּֽן יְבֻלַּ֣ע לַמֶּ֔לֶךְ

“lest the king be swallowed”

Hushai is using the word translated as **lest** to introduce an outcome that he does not want to happen. Because of this, he first gives David an instruction for him and his men to follow so that this will not happen. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that avoiding this outcome is the purpose of the instruction. Alternate translation: [Otherwise, the king will be swallowed]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

2 Samuel 17:16 (#7)

פֶּֽן יְבֻלַּ֣ע לַמֶּ֔לֶךְ

“lest the king be swallowed”

The expression **be swallowed** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [lest Absalom and his army swallow up the king] or [lest Absalom and his army destroy the king]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 17:16 (#8)

לַמֶּ֔לֶךְ

“the king”

Even though the priests’ messengers would be addressing David directly, Hushai tells them to speak of him in the third person as **the king** to show respect. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a respectful form in the second person. Alternate translation: [you, the king]

See: First, Second or Third Person

2 Samuel 17:17 (#2)

וְהָלְכָ֣ה הַשִּׁפְחָה֮ וְהִגִּ֣ידָה לָהֶם֒ וְהֵ֣מָּה יֵלְכ֗וּ וְהִגִּ֙ידוּ֙ לַמֶּ֣לֶךְ דָּוִ֔ד כִּֽי־ לֹ֥א יוּכְל֛וּ לְהֵרָא֖וֹת לָבֹ֣וא הָעִֽירָה

“and a maidservant would go and declare to them, and they, they would go and declare to King David, for they were not able to be seen entering the city”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Since they could not risk being seen in the city, a servant girl would bring them messages, which they would then deliver to King David]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

2 Samuel 17:17 (#5)

לֹ֥א יוּכְל֛וּ לְהֵרָא֖וֹת

“they were not able to be seen”

The expression **be seen** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [they could not allow people to see them]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 17:17 (#3)

וְהָלְכָ֣ה הַשִּׁפְחָה֮

“and a maidservant would go”

In a context such as this, your language might say “come” instead of **go**. Alternate translation: [and a maidservant would come]

See: Go and Come

2 Samuel 17:17 (#4)

וְהֵ֣מָּה֒ יֵלְכ֗וּ

“and they, they would go”

See how you translated the similar expression “you, you know” in 17:20. Alternate translation: [and for their part, they would go]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 17:17 (#1)

וִיהוֹנָתָ֤ן וַאֲחִימַ֙עַ֙ עֹמְדִ֣ים בְּעֵין־רֹגֵ֔ל וְהָלְכָ֣ה הַשִּׁפְחָה֮ וְהִגִּ֣ידָה לָהֶם֒ וְהֵ֣מָּה֒ יֵלְכ֗וּ וְהִגִּ֙ידוּ֙ לַמֶּ֣לֶךְ דָּוִ֔ד כִּֽי־ לֹ֥א יוּכְל֛וּ לְהֵרָא֖וֹת לָבֹ֣וא הָעִֽירָה

“Now Jonathan and Ahimaaz were staying at En Rogel, and a maidservant would go and declare to them, and they, they would go and declare to King David, for they were not able to be seen entering the city”

Here, the author is providing background information to help readers understand what happens next in

the story. This information explains how Jonathan and Ahimaaz were secretly communicating with David after he had fled from Jerusalem. In your translation, introduce this information in a way that would be natural in your own language and culture.

See: Background Information

2 Samuel 17:18 (#1)

מְהֵרָ֔ה

“in} haste”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **haste**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [hastily]

See: Abstract Nouns

2 Samuel 17:19 (#1)

וַתִּקַּ֤ח הָֽאִשָּׁה֙

“And the woman took”

The context indicates that this **woman** was married to the man whom the author describes in the previous verse. Your language may have its own term or expression for this relationship. Alternate translation: [And his wife]

See: Kinship

2 Samuel 17:19 (#3)

וְלֹ֥א נוֹדַ֖ע דָּבָֽר

“so the matter was not known”

The expression **was not known** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [so no one knew the matter]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 17:19 (#2)

פְּנֵ֥י הַבְּאֵֽר

“the face of the well”

The author is using **the face of the well** as a common expression of his culture to mean “the top of the well” or “the opening of the well.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the mouth of the well]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 17:20 (#1)

מִיכַ֖ל הַמָּֽיִם

“the brook of waters”

It might seem that the expression **brook of waters** contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [that brook]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 17:21 (#6)

אֶת־הַמַּ֔יִם

“the waters”

The implication is that **the waters** refers to the Jordan River. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [the Jordan River]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 17:21 (#1)

וַיְהִ֗י

“And it happened”

The author is using the phrase **And it happened** to introduce a new development in the story. Use a word, phrase, or other method in your language that is natural for introducing a new development.

See: Introduction of a New Event

2 Samuel 17:21 (#3)

וַיֹּאמְר֣וּ אֶל־דָּוִ֗ד קוּמ֤וּ וְעִבְרוּ֙ מְהֵרָ֔ה אֶת־הַמַּ֖יִם כִּי־כָ֣כָה יָעַ֤ץ עֲלֵיכֶם֙ אֲחִיתֹ֔פֶל

“And they said to David, “Arise and cross over the waters in haste, for according to this Ahithophel has counseled against you”

Since Jonathan and Ahimaaz did not actually say **according to this**, but provided an actual summary, if it would be more natural in your language, you could express the first part of this as an indirect quotation. Alternate translation: [And they told David what Ahithophel had counseled against him and then said, “Arise and cross over the waters in haste.”]

See: Direct and Indirect Quotations

2 Samuel 17:21 (#4)

קוּמ֤וּ וְעִבְרוּ֙ מְהֵרָ֔ה אֶת־הַמַּ֖יִם כִּי־כָ֣כָה יָעַ֤ץ עֲלֵיכֶם֙ אֲחִיתֹ֔פֶל

“Arise and cross over the waters in haste, for according to this Ahithophel has counseled against you”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Since according to this Ahithophel has counseled against you, arise and cross over the waters in haste]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

2 Samuel 17:21 (#5)

קוּמוּ וְעִבְרוּ & עֲלֵיכֶם

“Arise and cross over & against you”

The word **you** and the implied “you” in the imperatives **Arise** and **cross over** are plural because Jonathan and Ahimaaz mean David and all of the people who are with him. So use plural forms in your translation if your language marks that distinction.

See: Forms of ‘You’ — Singular

2 Samuel 17:21 (#2)

אַחֲרֵי לֶכְתָּם וַיַּעֲלוּ

“after they went that they came up”

The first pronoun **they** refers to Absalom’s soldiers, while the second pronoun **they** refers to Jonathan and Ahimaaz. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [after the soldiers left that Jonathan and Ahimaaz came up]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 17:22 (#2)

אֶחָד לֹא נֶעְדָּר

“not one was missing”

The expression **was missing** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [they were not missing anyone]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 17:22 (#1)

אֶחָד לֹא נֶעְדָּר אֲשֶׁר לֹא־עָבַר אֶת־הַיַּרְדֵּן

“not one was missing who had not crossed the Jordan”

This is a double negative, consisting of two instances of the negative word **not**. If it would be clearer in your language, you could use a positive expression to translate this. Alternate translation: [every one of them had crossed the Jordan]

See: Double Negatives

2 Samuel 17:23 (#1)

לֹא נֶעֱשְׂתָה עֲצָתוֹ

“his counsel was not done”

The expression **was not done** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Absalom had not followed his counsel] or [Absalom had not done what he advised]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 17:23 (#2)

וַיְצַו אֶל־בֵּיתוֹ

“and he commanded about his house”

The author is using **commanded about his house** as a common expression of his culture to mean “put his affairs in order” or “arranged his household affairs.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and he put his house in order]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 17:23 (#3)

וַיִּקָּבֵר

“And he was buried”

The expression **was buried** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [And his family buried him]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 17:24 (#1)

וְכָל־אִישׁ יִשְׂרָאֵל

“and all of the men of Israel”

The author is saying **all of the men of Israel** as a generalization for emphasis. If it would be clearer in your language, you could express the emphasis in a

different way. Alternate translation: [and all of the Israelite soldiers who were supporting him]

See: Hyperbole

2 Samuel 17:25 (#1)

וַעֲמָשָׂא בֶן־אִישׁ וּשְׁמוֹ יִתְרָא הַיִּשְׂרְאֵלִי אֲשֶׁר־בָּא אֶל־אֲבִיגַל
בַּת־נָחָשׁ אֲחוֹת צְרוּיָה אֵם יוֹאָב

“Now Amasa {was} the son of a man and his name {was} Ithra the Israelite, who had gone in to Abigail, the daughter of Nahash, the sister of Zeruiah the mother of Joab”

Here the author is introducing Amasa as new participant in the story. Your language may have its own way of introducing new participants that you can use in your translation.

See: Introduction of New and Old Participants

2 Samuel 17:25 (#4)

אֲבִיגַל בַּת־נָחָשׁ אֲחוֹת צְרוּיָה אֵם יוֹאָב

“Abigail, the daughter of Nahash, the sister of Zeruiah the mother of Joab”

Abigail was the sister of Zeruiah. Zeruiah was the mother of Joab. Be sure that these relationships are clear in your translation.

See: Kinship

2 Samuel 17:25 (#5)

אֲשֶׁר־בָּא אֶל־אֲבִיגַל בַּת־נָחָשׁ

“who had gone in to Abigail, the daughter of Nahash”

The author is referring to sexual relations in a polite way by using the phrase **had gone in to**. The implication, which the author is politely not stating directly, is that Ithra had not necessarily been married to Abigail. Depending on what is helpful in your language, you could use a polite way of referring to this in your language, or you could state this plainly. Alternate translation: [who had slept with Abigail, the daughter of Nahash]

See: Euphemism

2 Samuel 17:25 (#2)

אִישׁ וּשְׁמוֹ יִתְרָא הַיִּשְׂרְאֵלִי

“a man and his name {was} Ithra the Israelite”

It might seem that this expression contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [a man named Ithra the Israelite]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 17:25 (#3)

וּשְׁמוֹ יִתְרָא הַיִּשְׂרְאֵלִי

“and his name {was} Ithra the Israelite”

The account of Amasa’s lineage in 1 Chronicles 2:17 identifies his father as “Jether the Ishmaelite.” The name Jether is simply a variant of the name Ithra, but “Ishmaelite” may have been the original reading here, since identifying Ithra as an **Israelite** would not provide information that would help readers distinguish him from other men by the same name. If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to use the reading that it uses. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to use the reading of the ULT.

See: Textual Variants

2 Samuel 17:28 (#2)

וּכְלֵי יוֹצֵר

“and vessels of the potter”

Here, **vessels of the potter** represents “earthenware vessels” or “clay pots.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [earthenware vessels]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 17:28 (#1)

מִשְׁכָּב וְסַפּוֹת

“beds and basins”

The main verb of this sentence, “brought,” occurs in the next verse. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine 17:28 and 17:29 into a verse bridge so that you can put the verb “brought” before the list of things that these men provided. You could also state the verb, which is implied in the context, in this verse and repeat it in the next verse. The UST models one way to do that.

See: Verse Bridges

2 Samuel 17:28 (#3)

וְקָלִי & וְקָלִי

“and roasted grain & and roasted beans”

The term that the ULT translates as **roasted grain** is the same one that it translates as **roasted beans**, but the context suggests that the author is not listing the same item twice. Instead, this term describes the way in which the grain and beans were prepared.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 17:28 (#4)

וּפׇפּוֹל וַעֲדָשִׁים

“and beans and lentils”

The term **beans** describes edible seeds that typically grow in pods. A **lentil** is a kind of small, round, edible seed. If your readers would not be familiar with these foods, you could use the name of a similar thing that your readers would recognize, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [and peas and small beans]

See: Translate Unknowns

2 Samuel 17:29 (#2)

רָעֵ֥ב וְעָיֵ֖ף וְצָמֵֽא

“will be} hungry and weary and thirsty”

If it would be more natural in your language, you may want to put the information about thirst with the information about hunger. Alternate translation: [hungry and thirsty and weary]

See: Information Structure

2 Samuel 17:29 (#1)

וְחֶמְאָה

“and curds”

The word **curds** describes a soft, thickened milk product similar to yogurt. If your readers would not be familiar with what curds are, you could use the name of a similar thing that your readers would recognize, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [and yogurt] or [and soured milk]

See: Translate Unknowns

2 Samuel - Chapter 18 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter continues the story of what David did as the king of Israel and specifically how he finally overcame Absalom’s attempt to replace him as king. It tells how David’s soldiers fought against Absalom’s army and defeated it. It describes how Joab killed Absalom even though David had publicly ordered him to spare Absalom. And it tells how messengers brought the news of Absalom’s defeat and death to David and how David mourned publicly for his son.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Why did Joab want to send his Cushite servant as a messenger to David instead of Ahimaaz?

In 18:19, Ahimaaz asks Joab for permission to run to David and bring him the news that his soldiers have defeated Absalom’s army. Joab at first refuses and instead sends an Ethiopian man who served him as a runner. We learn from the story in 4:10 that in this culture, someone who brought good news often received a reward. Joab tells Ahimaaz in 18:22 that he would not receive a reward if he brought the news of the battle to David. By sending a slave with the news instead of a friend or a person of rank (such as the high priest’s son, Ahimaaz), Joab was signaling in advance that he did not expect the news to win a reward for the messenger. This was a way of breaking the news of Absalom’s death to David slowly and in stages. Joab evidently also anticipated that David would be more upset at the news of Absalom’s death than he would be with the news that his army had won a great victory, and since he apparently liked and appreciated Ahimaaz (he calls him “my son” in 18:22), he may have wanted to spare him from any angry reaction that David may have had. But Ahimaaz, for his part, seems to have wanted to encourage David first with the news of the victory, and so he persisted in asking for permission to run as a messenger. When Joab gave his permission, Ahimaaz ran by a route he knew would be faster, and he got to David first with this part of the news. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain all or some of this in the text of your translation or in a footnote.

2 Samuel 18:2 (#1)

הַשְּׁלִשִׁ֔ית

“a third”

A **third** means one part out of three equal parts. Represent this in the way your language and culture characteristically would.

See: Fractions

2 Samuel 18:2 (#2)

בְּיַד־יוֹאָ֖ב

“in the hand of Joab”

Here, **hand** represents the control of a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an

equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly, in this case and for the same expression as applied to Abishai and Ittai. Alternate translation: [under the command of Joab]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 18:2 (#4)

יָצֹא אֵצֵא גַּם־אָנֹכִי

“Going out, I will go out, I too”

David is repeating forms of the verb **go out** in order to intensify his expression of the idea that it conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [I will certainly go out, I too]

See: Reduplication

2 Samuel 18:2 (#3)

אֲבִישַׁי בֶּן־צְרוּיָהּ אֲחִי יוֹאָב

“Abishai, the son of Zeruiah, the brother of Joab”

The author is identifying **Abishai**, not **Zeruiah**, as the **brother of Joab**. Be sure that this is clear in your translation.

See: Kinship

2 Samuel 18:2 (#5)

יָצֹא אֵצֵא גַּם־אָנֹכִי

“Going out, I will go out, I too”

David is stating the pronoun **I** separately, even though the verb translated as **I will go out** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to indicate that his actions will be comparable to those of the Israelite soldiers and commanders. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing that David is indicating that his actions will be comparable. It may not be necessary to represent the separately stated pronoun explicitly. Alternate translation: [And for my own part, going out, I will go out] or [And for my own part, I will certainly go out]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 18:3 (#1)

אִם־נֹס נָנֻסוּ

“if fleeing, we flee”

The soldiers are repeating forms of the verb **flee** in order to intensify their expression of the idea that it conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [if in fact we flee]

See: Reduplication

2 Samuel 18:3 (#2)

לֹא־יָשִׁימוּ אֵלֵינוּ לֵב

“they will not set a heart to us”

See how you translated the similar expression in 13:20. Alternate translation: [they will not be concerned about us]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 18:3 (#3)

חֶצְיֵנוּ

“half of us”

A **half** means one part out of two equal parts. Represent this in the way your language and culture characteristically would.

See: Fractions

2 Samuel 18:3 (#4)

כִּי־עַתָּה כָּמֹנוּ עֲשָׂרָה אֲלָפִים

“For now {there are} ten thousand like us”

The Septuagint (an ancient Greek translation) reads “you” instead of **now**. This reflects a difference of only one letter in Hebrew, and it gives the meaning, “For you are worth ten thousand of us.” That may have been the original reading, since it does not require the reader to supply the rest of the thought (as the traditional Hebrew text requires, “but there is only one like you”). If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to use the reading that it uses. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to use the reading of the ULT.

See: Textual Variants

2 Samuel 18:4 (#1)

אֲשֶׁר־יִיטַב בְּעֵינֵיכֶם אֶעֱשֶׂה

“What is good in your eyes, I will do”

See how you translated the similar expression in 3:19. Alternate translation: [I will do as you see fit] or [I will do what you think is best]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 18:4 (#3)

אֶל־יַ֣ד הַשַּׁ֑עַר

“at the hand of the gate”

See how you translated the similar expression in 15:2. Alternate translation: [next to the gate]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 18:4 (#2)

וַיַּעֲמֹ֤ד הַמֶּ֙לֶךְ֙ אֶל־יַ֣ד הַשַּׁ֔עַר וְכָל־הָעָ֖ם יָצְא֣וּ לְמֵא֑וֹת וְלַאֲלָפִֽים

“And the king stood at the hand of the gate, and all of the people went out by hundreds and by thousands”

Standing beside the gate was a symbolic action by which the king showed his support for the troops and his authority in sending them to battle. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [And the king took his place beside the gate to review the troops as they marched out in their military units]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 18:5 (#2)

לַנַּ֔עַר

“with the young man”

David could have referred to Absalom as “my son” rather than as **the young man**. However, by rebelling against his father, Absalom was acting in a way unworthy of a son, so David did not describe him in terms of their family relationship. So while the expression “young man” can have the sense of “son” in some contexts, it would not be appropriate to translate it that way here.

See: Kinship

2 Samuel 18:5 (#1)

לְאַט־לִ֥י

“Gently for me”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [Deal gently for my sake]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 18:6 (#1)

יִשְׂרָאֵ֑ל

“Israel”

Here, **Israel** represents “the Israelite army.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the Israelite army]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 18:6 (#2)

בְּיַ֥עַר אֶפְרָֽיִם

“in the Forest of Ephraim”

This is a name, not a description of a forest within the territory of the tribe of Ephraim. That territory was west of the Jordan River, while the narrative makes clear that this battle was fought on the east side of the river. This forest is not mentioned elsewhere in the Bible, and it is not entirely clear how it got this name. But translate this as a name, not as a description.

See: How to Translate Names

2 Samuel 18:7 (#5)

עֶשְׂרִ֥ים אָֽלֶף

“20,000”

The author is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [for 20,000 Israelite soldiers were killed]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 18:7 (#1)

וַיִּנָּגְפ֣וּ שָׁ֠ם עַ֨ם יִשְׂרָאֵ֜ל לִפְנֵ֣י עַבְדֵ֣י דָוִ֗ד

“And the people of Israel were struck there to the face of the servants of David”

Here, **to the face of** represents being in front of David’s servants, that is, opposing them in battle. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [And the people of Israel were struck there in front of the servants of David] or [And the people of

Israel were struck there as they opposed the servants of David]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 18:7 (#2)

וַיִּנָּגְפוּ שָׁם עַם יִשְׂרָאֵל לִפְנֵי עַבְדֵי דָוִד

“And the people of Israel were struck there to the face of the servants of David”

The expression **were struck** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [And the servants of David struck the people of Israel there as they opposed them]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 18:7 (#4)

הַמַּגֵּפָה

“the striking”

While the word **struck** in the previous sentence describes defeat, the term **striking** in this sentence describes killing. You could indicate this in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. See the discussion of the term “struck” in the Introduction to 2 Samuel. Alternate translation: [the slaughter]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 18:7 (#3)

וַיִּנָּגְפוּ & עַם יִשְׂרָאֵל

“And the people of Israel were struck”

See how you translated the similar expression in 2:17. Alternate translation: [And the people of Israel were defeated]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 18:8 (#1)

וַתְּהִי & הַמִּלְחָמָה נפצית

“And the battle was scattered”

The expression **was scattered** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [And the battle spread out]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 18:8 (#4)

וַיִּיֶּרֶב הַיַּעַר לֶאֱכֹל בָּעָם

“And the forest made more to consume among the people”

Together, the terms **made more** and **to consume** expresses a single idea. The term **made more** tells to what extent the forest consumed or killed soldiers, that is, to a greater extent than the weapons opposing soldiers were using. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning in a different way. Alternate translation: [And the forest consumed more of the people] or [And the forest killed more of the people]

See: Hendiadys

2 Samuel 18:8 (#3)

וַיִּיֶּרֶב הַיַּעַר לֶאֱכֹל בָּעָם מֵאֲשֶׁר אָכְלָה הַחֶרֶב בַּיּוֹם הַהוּא

“And the forest made more to consume among the people than what the sword consumed on that day”

The author is speaking of this **forest** and of a **sword** as if they were living things that could have **consumed** or eaten these soldiers. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. This could mean: (1) Alternate translation: [And more of Absalom’s soldiers died from injuries they suffered trying to flee through the forest than died from injuries they suffered from the swords that David’s soldiers used against them]; (2) Alternate translation: [And more of Absalom’s soldiers died during the fighting in the forest, which slowed them down as they were trying to flee, than died from the fighting in the open field]

See: Personification

2 Samuel 18:8 (#2)

פְּנֵי

“the face of”

See how you translated the similar expression in 11:11. Alternate translation: [the surface of]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 18:9 (#5)

וַיָּבֹא הַפֶּרֶד

“and the mule came”

In a context such as this, your language might say “went” instead of **came**. Alternate translation: [and the mule went]

See: Go and Come

2 Samuel 18:9 (#1)

וַיִּקָּרֵא אַבְשָׁלוֹם לִפְנֵי עַבְדֵי דָוִד

“And Absalom was met to the face of the servants of David”

Here, **to the face of** represents being in the presence of David’s servants. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [And Absalom encountered some of the servants of David]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 18:9 (#3)

וְאַבְשָׁלוֹם רֹכֵב עַל־הַפֶּרֶד

“Now Absalom was riding on the mule”

Here, the author is providing background information to help readers understand what happens next in the story. In your translation, introduce this information in a way that would be natural in your own language and culture.

See: Background Information

2 Samuel 18:9 (#6)

בֵּין הַשָּׁמַיִם וּבֵין הָאָרֶץ

“between the heavens and between the earth”

In this context, the term **heavens** refers to the sky, and the term **earth** refers to the ground. Alternate translation: [between the sky and the ground] or [up in the air]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 18:9 (#4)

וְאַבְשָׁלוֹם רֹכֵב עַל־הַפֶּרֶד

“Now Absalom was riding on the mule”

Riding on a mule was a symbolic action by which Absalom showed that he claimed to be king of Israel, since kings rode on mules. (For example, David has Solomon ride on his mule in 1 Kings 1:33 to show that he has chosen him to be the next king.) If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [Now Absalom was riding on the royal mule]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 18:9 (#2)

וַיִּקָּרֵא אַבְשָׁלוֹם לִפְנֵי עַבְדֵי דָוִד

“And Absalom was met to the face of the servants of David”

The author is using **was met** as a common expression of his culture to mean “happened to be.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And Absalom unexpectedly found himself in the presence of the servants of David] or [And Absalom happened to come into the presence of the servants of David]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 18:10 (#1)

הִנֵּהוּ

“Behold”

See how you translated the similar expression in 1:2. Alternate translation: [Listen]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 18:10 (#2)

תָּלוּי בָּאֵלָה

“hung on an oak tree”

The expression **hung** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [hanging from an oak tree]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 18:11 (#1)

וּמַדּוּעַ לֹא־הִכִּיתָתּוֹ שָׁם אָרְצָה

“so why did you not strike him there to the ground”

Joab is using the question form to rebuke the soldier for not killing Absalom. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [so you should have struck him there to the ground!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 18:11 (#5)

וְעָלַי לָתֶת לְךָ

“For {it was} to me to give to you”

Joab is using **{it was} to me** as a common expression of his culture to mean "I had the capacity." If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [For I could have given you]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 18:11 (#2)

הִכִּיתָתּוֹ

"did you & strike him"

See how you translated the similar expression in 1:1. Alternate translation: [kill him]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 18:11 (#3)

אָרְצָה

"to the ground"

Joab is using **to the ground** as a common expression of his culture to mean "right where he is." If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [on the spot]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 18:11 (#4)

כֶּסֶף

"silver"

Joab is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [shekels of silver]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 18:11 (#6)

וַחֲגֹרָה אַחַת

"and one belt"

In this culture, commanders would give a soldier a decorative and costly military **belt** in recognition of distinguished service in battle. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [and a military belt for distinguished service] or [and a military decoration]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 18:12 (#4)

לֹא־אֶשְׁלַח יָדִי

"I would not stretch out my hand"

See how you translated the similar expression in 1:14. Alternate translation: [I would not use violence]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 18:12 (#6)

בְּאָזְנֵינוּ

"in our ears"

The soldier is using the term **ears** to mean hearing. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in our hearing]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 18:12 (#8)

שִׁמְרוּ־מִמִּי בַּנַּעַר

"Guard who {is} upon the young man"

In paraphrasing what David said, the soldier is using **Guard who is upon** as a common expression of his culture to mean "make sure that no one hurts." If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Make sure that no one hurts]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 18:12 (#1)

אֶנֹכִי שֹׁקֵל עַל־כַּפַּי

"I were weighing on my palm"

While this soldier might have hefted the silver in his **palm** or hand to be sure it was the entire weight Joab promised, the term **palm** in this context also represents possession. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [I had in my possession]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 18:12 (#3)

אֶלֶף כֶּסֶף

“a thousand silver”

These 1,000 **silver** shekels would have weighed nearly 12 kilograms or over 25 pounds. In your translation, you could use the ancient measurement and spell the word “shekel” the way it sounds in your language. You could also use the metric measurement given in the UST or use the measurement that your language and culture customarily use. Alternatively, you could use the ancient measurement and put a modern measurement in parentheses in the text or in a footnote.

See: Biblical Weight

2 Samuel 18:12 (#2)

אֶאֱלֹף כֶּסֶף

“a thousand silver”

The soldier is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [a thousand shekels of silver]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 18:12 (#5)

כִּי

“For”

Here the word **For** provides not a reason but an explanation. Alternate translation: [After all]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

2 Samuel 18:12 (#7)

לֵאמֹר שִׁמְרוּ־מִמִּי בַּנַּעַר בְּאַבְשָׁלוֹם

“saying, ‘Guard who {is} upon the young man Absalom”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [to guard who was upon the young man Absalom]

See: Quotes within Quotes

2 Samuel 18:13 (#3)

וְאַתָּה תִתְיַצֵּב

“and you, you would have stationed yourself”

See how you translated the similar expression “you, you know” in 17:8. Alternate translation: [and you know quite well that you would have stationed yourself]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 18:13 (#4)

וְאַתָּה תִתְיַצַּב מִנֶּגֶד

“and you, you would have stationed yourself from before {me”

The soldier is using **stationed yourself from before me** as a common expression of his culture to mean “kept your distance” or “would not have defended me.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and you would have kept your distance from me] or [and you would not have defended me]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 18:13 (#1)

עָשִׂיתִי בנפשו שֶׁשֶׁקֶר וְכָל־דָּבָר לֹא־יִכָּחֵד מִן־הַמֶּלֶךְ

“I would have done wrong against my life, for every matter is not hidden from the king”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [since every matter is not hidden from the king, I would have done wrong against my life]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

2 Samuel 18:13 (#2)

שֶׁשֶׁקֶר

“wrong”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **wrong**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [something wrong]

See: Abstract Nouns

2 Samuel 18:14 (#1)

לְפָנֶיךָ

“to your face”

Here, **to your face** represents being in your presence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in your presence] or [here with you]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 18:14 (#3)

בְּלֵב אַבְשָׁלוֹם

“into the heart of Absalom”

Here the word **heart** probably refers to Absalom’s chest or torso, the central part of his body. (It has the same sense as in the phrase **the heart of the oak tree** in the next clause.) It is unlikely that Absalom would still have been alive afterwards if Joab had thrust three spears into his actual heart. You could indicate this meaning in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [into the chest of Absalom] or [into Absalom’s body]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 18:14 (#2)

בְּכַפּוֹ

“in his palm”

Here, **in his palm** represents possession and conveyance. (These **spears** were likely too large to have all fit in Joab’s palm.) If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [with him]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 18:14 (#4)

בְּלֵבַ֖ הָאֵלָ֑ה

“in the heart of the oak tree”

The author is using **in the heart of the oak tree** as a common expression of his culture to mean “in the midst of the oak tree” or “among the branches of the oak tree.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in the midst of the oak tree] or [among the branches of the oak tree]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 18:16 (#1)

וַיָּ֤שָׁב הָעָם֙ מֵרְדֹ֣ף אַחֲרֵ֣י יִשְׂרָאֵ֔ל כִּ֥י־חָשַׂ֖ךְ יוֹאָ֑ב אֶת־הָעָֽם

“and the people returned from pursuing after Israel, for Joab restrained the people”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [and since Joab had restrained the people, the people returned from pursuing after Israel]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

2 Samuel 18:16 (#2)

יִשְׂרָאֵ֔ל

“Israel”

Here, **Israel** represents “the Israelite soldiers.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the Israelite soldiers]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 18:17 (#1)

וַיִּצְבְּר֨וּ עָלָ֜יו גַּל־אֲבָנִ֣ים גָּדוֹל֮ מְאֹד֒

“and they set up a very great heap of stones over him”

In this culture, piling a **heap of stones** over a grave was a way putting shame on the person who had died. The Israelites had done this, for example, to Achan in Joshua 7:26. Some interpreters believe that in this case, it was also symbolic of the stoning that the Law of Moses said was the penalty for a rebellious son (Deuteronomy 21:18–21). If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [and to shame him, they set over him a very great heap of stones]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 18:17 (#2)

אִ֖ישׁ לְאָהֳלֽוֹ

“a man to his tent”

The author is using **a man to his tent** as a common expression of his culture to mean that the soldiers stopped their military campaign altogether and each of them went back to his home and family. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [abandoning the army and returning home]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 18:18 (#3)

וַיִּקְרָ֣א לָהּ֮

“and it is called”

The expression **it is called** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that

is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and people call it]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 18:18 (#5)

יַד אַבְשָׁלֹם

“the Hand of Absalom”

In this culture, people used the term **Hand** to mean a monument. They may have done this because ancient monuments may have had an image of a hand engraved or sculpted on them as a symbol of power and strength, or because monuments called attention to an achievement, as a gesturing hand would do. If you have already translated the book of 1 Samuel, see how you translated the similar expression in 1 Samuel 15:12. Alternate translation, as in the UST: [Absalom’s Monument]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 18:18 (#1)

וְאַבְשָׁלֹם לָקַח וַיַּצֶּב־לוֹ בחיו אֶת־מַצֵּבָתוֹ

“Now while he was living, Absalom had taken and set up for himself a pillar”

The author is providing background information to help readers appreciate the irony of Absalom wanting to have a high monument that would make people remember him. His monument turned out to be the shameful pile of stones, not the one described here. In your translation, introduce this information in a way that would be natural in your own language and culture.

See: Background Information

2 Samuel 18:18 (#2)

אֵין־לִי בֵּן

“There is} no son to me”

The author says in 14:27 that Absalom had three sons, so they had all apparently died by the time Absalom set up this pillar. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. The UST models one way to do that.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 18:18 (#4)

עַד הַיּוֹם הַזֶּה

“to this day”

See how you translated the similar expression in 4:3. Alternate translation: [as of the time of this writing]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 18:19 (#2)

שְׁפָטַתּוּ יְהוָה מִיַּד אֹיְבָיו

“Yahweh has judged him out of the hand of his enemies”

The author is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [Yahweh has judged him favorably and has delivered him out of the hand of his enemies]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 18:19 (#3)

מִיַּד אֹיְבָיו

“out of the hand of his enemies”

Here, **hand** represents the capability of a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the power of his enemies]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 18:19 (#1)

אָרֻצָה נָּא וַאֲבַשְּׂרָה אֶת־הַמֶּלֶךְ כִּי־שָׁפְטַתּוּ יְהוָה מִיַּד אֹיְבָיו

“Please let me run and let me bring news {to} the king, for Yahweh has judged him out of the hand of his enemies”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Since Yahweh has judged the king out of the hand of his enemies, please let me run and bring news to him]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

2 Samuel 18:20 (#1)

אִישׁ בְּשֹׂרָה

“are & a man of news”

Joab is saying **man of** here in the same way that biblical authors and characters often use the similar expression “son of” to indicate that a person has the characteristic of something. See how you translated the similar expression in 16:7. Alternate translation: [a man who brings news] or [the one to bring the news]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 18:20 (#2)

וְהַיּוֹם הַזֶּה֙ לֹ֣א תְבַשֵּׂ֔ר כִּֽי־עַל֙ בֶּן־הַמֶּ֔לֶךְ מֵ֖ת

“But this day you will not bring news, because the son of the king is dead”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [But since the son of the king is dead, this day you will not bring news]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

2 Samuel 18:21 (#1)

לַכּוּשִׁ֑י

“to the Cushite”

The author assumes that his readers will know that by **the Cushite**, he means a particular man from the region of Cush (modern Ethiopia) who was able to run far and fast and so served Joab as a messenger. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [the Cushite man who served him as a swift messenger]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 18:21 (#2)

וַיִּשְׁתַּחֲוֶ֥ה כוּשִׁ֖י לְיוֹאָֽב

“And the Cushite prostrated himself to Joab”

Bowing down before Joab was a symbolic action by which the Cushite showed his respect and submission to Joab’s authority to indicate that he would obey Joab’s command. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [And the Cushite expressed his obedience to Joab]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 18:22 (#2)

וַיֹּ֣סֶף עוֹד֩ אֲחִימַ֨עַץ בֶּן־צָד֜וֹק וַיֹּ֣אמֶר

“And again Ahimaaz, the son of Zadok, resumed and said”

It might seem that saying both **again** and **resumed** would be to present extra information that would not be natural in your language. If so, you can just use one of these terms. Alternate translation: [And Ahimaaz, the son of Zadok, said again]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 18:22 (#4)

לָמָּה־זֶּ֤ה אַתָּה֙ רָ֣ץ בְּנִ֔י וּלְכָ֖ה אֵין־בְּשׂוֹרָ֥ה מֻצֵּֽאת

“Why {is} this, you running, my son, when for you {there is} no news finding”

Joab is using the question form to rebuke Ahimaaz for wanting to run. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [You should not be running, my son, when for you there is no news finding!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 18:22 (#8)

אֵין־בְּשׂוֹרָ֥ה מֻצֵּֽאת

“there is} no news finding”

Joab is speaking of **news** as if it were a living thing that could find something. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [there is no news for which King David would reward you]

See: Personification

2 Samuel 18:22 (#5)

לָמָּה־זֶּ֤ה אַתָּה֙ רָ֣ץ

“Why {is} this, you running”

Joab is using **Why {is} this, you running** as a common expression of his culture to mean “Why would you run?” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [For what reason would you run]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 18:22 (#6)

בְּנִ֔י

“my son”

Joab is referring to Ahimaaz with an affectionate expression. Use a comparable title or expression from your language and culture for addressing someone affectionately. Alternate translation: [young man]

See: Politeness

2 Samuel 18:22 (#7)

אֵין־בְּשׂוֹרָה מֹצֵאת

“there is} no news finding”

Joab is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [there is no news finding a reward]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 18:22 (#1)

וַיֹּ֣סֶף עוֹד֮ אֲחִימַ֣עַץ בֶּן־צָדוֹק֒ וַיֹּ֙אמֶר

“And again Ahimaaz, the son of Zadok, resumed and said”

It might seem that saying both **again** and **resumed** would be extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten this. Alternate translation: [And Ahimaaz, the son of Zadok, resumed and said]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 18:22 (#3)

אָרֻצָה־נָּ֣א גַם־אָ֔אֲנִי

“please let me run, I too”

Ahimaaz is stating the pronoun **I** separately, even though the verb translated as **let me run** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to indicate that his action would be comparable to that of the **Cushite**. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing that Ahimaaz is indicating that his action would be comparable. It may not be necessary to represent the separately stated pronoun explicitly. Alternate translation: [please let me run, for my own part]

See: Reflexive Pronouns

2 Samuel 18:23 (#1)

וִיהִי־מָ֖ה אָרֹֽוץ

“But whatever may be, let me run”

The direct quotation can be marked to clearly show that these are Ahimaaz’s words. Use whatever punctuation or other ways of indicating quotations that are natural in your language. Alternate translation: [But Ahimaaz replied, “But whatever may be, let me run.”]

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

2 Samuel 18:23 (#2)

וַיֹּ֥אמֶר לֽוֹ

“And he said to him”

The pronoun **he** refers to Joab, while the pronoun **him** refers to Ahimaaz. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [And Joab said to Ahimaaz]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 18:23 (#3)

רָ֔רוּץ

“Run”

This is an imperative, but it communicates permission rather than a command. Use a form in your language that communicates permission. Alternate translation: [You may run]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

2 Samuel 18:23 (#4)

וַיַּעֲבֹ֖ר אֶת־הַכּוּשִֽׁי

“and he passed the Cushite”

The implication is that Ahimaaz ran faster than the Cushite and got to King David before he did. The author indicates that Ahimaaz took a different route, so it was not the case that he **passed** the Cushite in the sense of running past him on the same road. Indicate this in your translation in a way that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and he outran the Cushite]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 18:24 (#2)

בֵּין־שְׁנֵ֣י הַשְּׁעָרִ֑ים

“between the two gates”

This phrase means the same thing as the phrase “in the middle of the gate” in 3:27. See how you translated that phrase.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 18:24 (#3)

וַיִּשָּׂ֤א אֶת־עֵינָיו֙

“and he lifted his eyes”

See how you translated the similar expression in 13:34. Alternate translation: [and he looked off into the distance]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 18:24 (#1)

וְדָוִד יוֹשֵׁשֵׁב בֵּין־שְׁנֵי הַשְּׁעָרִים

“Now David was sitting between the two gates”

The author is providing background information to help readers understand what happens next in the story. In your translation, introduce this information in a way that would be natural in your own language and culture.

See: Background Information

2 Samuel 18:25 (#1)

בְּשׂוֹרָה בְּפִיו

“news {is} in his mouth”

David is using the term **mouth** to mean that the messenger would use his mouth to say or tell something. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [he has some news to tell]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 18:25 (#2)

וַיֵּיֶלֶךְ הָלוֹךְ וְקָרֵב

“And he came, coming and near”

Together, the words **coming** and **near** express a single idea. The word **near** indicates that the messenger got nearer and nearer as he was **coming**. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this idea in a different way. Alternate translation: [And as he came, he kept coming nearer and nearer]

See: Hendiadys

2 Samuel 18:26 (#1)

אֶל־הַשֹּׁעֵר

“to the gatekeeper”

The phrase translated as **to the gatekeeper** could also be translated as “into the gate,” that is, down to where David was. That may be the correct translation, since David responds directly to what the watcher says, and there is no mention of a gatekeeper in the previous verse when the watcher similarly calls to David. Alternate translation: [into the gate]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 18:27 (#1)

אֲנִי֙ רֹאֶ֣ה אֶת־מְרוּצַ֣ת הָרִאשׁ֔וֹן כִּמְרֻצַ֖ת אֲחִימַ֣עַץ

“I am seeing the running of the first like the running of Ahimaaz”

The watcher is using a participle form to describe an impression that is forming as he looks. Your language may have a verb form or comparable expression that would convey this meaning. Alternate translation: [The running of the first appears to me like the running of Ahimaaz]

See: Irregular Use of Tenses

2 Samuel 18:28 (#1)

וַיֹּ֣אמֶר

“and said”

The expression **and said** introduces a direct quotation. In your translation, use a natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language. It may not be necessary to represent this expression explicitly.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

2 Samuel 18:28 (#2)

בָּר֣וּךְ יְהוָ֣ה אֱלֹהֶ֑יךָ

“Blessed be Yahweh your God”

The expression **Blessed be** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Bless Yahweh your God]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 18:28 (#3)

אֲשֶׁ֣ר סִגַּ֗ר אֶת־הָֽאֲנָשִׁ֛ים

“who has enclosed the men”

Ahimaaz is speaking as if Yahweh had actually **enclosed** Absalom’s soldiers in the hands of David’s soldiers, that is, as if Yahweh had enabled David’s soldiers to grasp Absalom’s soldiers completely in their hands. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. If you have already translated the book of 1 Samuel, see how you translated the similar expression in 1 Samuel 17:46.

Alternate translation: [who has enabled your soldiers to overpower the men]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 18:28 (#4)

אֲשֶׁר־נָשְׂאוּ אֶת־יָדָם

“who lifted their hand”

Ahimaaz is using **lifted their hand** as a common expression of his culture to mean “used violence.” (The meaning is the same as in the similar phrase “stretch out my hand” in 18:12.) If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [who took up arms] or [who violently rebelled]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 18:28 (#5)

בַּאדֹנִי הַמֶּלֶךְ

“against my lord the king”

Even though Ahimaaz is addressing David directly, he is speaking of him in the third person as **my lord the king** to show respect. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a respectful form in the second person, here and in verses 31 and 32. Alternate translation: [you, my lord the king]

See: First, Second or Third Person

2 Samuel 18:29 (#1)

שָׁלוֹם לַנַּעַר לְאַבְשָׁלוֹם

“Is} peace to the young man, to Absalom”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **peace**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Is the young man Absalom well]

See: Abstract Nouns

2 Samuel 18:29 (#4)

וְלֹא יָדַעְתִּי מָה

“but I do not know what”

Ahimaaz is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [but I do not know what was happening]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 18:29 (#2)

אֶת־עֶבֶד הַמֶּלֶךְ

“the servant of the king”

The implication is that this refers to the Cushite messenger who was sent after Ahimaaz. (He may be gesturing to him as he approaches.) You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [the Cushite]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 18:29 (#3)

וְאֶת־עַבְדֶּךָ

“and your servant”

Ahimaaz is speaking of himself in the third person as **your servant** to show humility. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a humble form in the first person. Alternate translation: [and me, your servant]

See: First, Second or Third Person

2 Samuel 18:31 (#3)

הַקָּמִים עָלֶיךָ

“the ones having arisen against you”

The phrase **the ones having arisen against you** was a common expression meaning those who rebel against authority or try to overthrow someone from power. Alternate translation: [the ones who tried to overthrow you]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 18:31 (#1)

שְׁפָטְךָ יְהוָה הַיּוֹם מִיַּד כָּל־הַקָּמִים עָלֶיךָ

“Yahweh has judged you today out of the hand of all of the ones having arisen against you”

See how you translated the similar expression in 18:19. Alternate translation: [Yahweh has judged you favorably today and has delivered you from the power of all of the ones having arisen against you]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 18:31 (#2)

מִיַּד

“out of the hand of”

In this verse, the word **hand** is singular in form, but it refers to all of the hands of David's enemies as a group. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use the plural form of "hand." Alternate translation: [the hands of]

See: Collective Nouns

2 Samuel 18:32 (#1)

יִהְיוּ כַנַּעַר אֹיְבַי אֲדֹנִי הַמֶּלֶךְ וְכֹל אֲשֶׁר־קָמוּ עָלֶיךָ לְרָעָה

"May the enemies of my lord the king and all who arise against you for harm be like the young man"

The Cushite is courteously and gently not stating directly that Absalom has died. David nevertheless understands his meaning clearly and goes away to grieve. In your translation, it would be appropriate to represent this as an indirect statement, rather than suggest that the Cushite said directly that Absalom had died. You may be able to indicate this meaning another way. The UST models one way to do that.

See: Euphemism

2 Samuel 18:33 (#2)

מִי־יִתֵּתֶן מוּתִי אֲנִי תַחְתֶּיךָ

"Who will give my dying myself in place of you"

The phrase **Who will give my dying myself in place of you** was a common expression meaning "I wish that I had died instead of you." It is a way of expressing deep grief and regret. Alternate translation: [If only I had been the one who had died, not you]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 18:33 (#1)

בְּנִי בְנִי אַבְשָׁלוֹם

"My son, my son, Absalom"

David repeats the words **my son** to show how deeply distressed he is about his son's death. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express his deep distress in another way. Alternate translation: [Oh, my son Absalom]

See: Reduplication

2 Samuel - Chapter 19 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter continues the story of what David did as the king of Israel and specifically how the Israelites restored him to his position as their king. It first tells how Joab warned David not to stay away from his army, shaming them by mourning for the commander of the army they had defeated. It then describes how the people of Israel discussed among themselves how they should bring David back, and how David sent messengers to encourage the leaders of the tribe of Judah to take the lead in doing this. The chapter tells how David met various people on his way back to cross the Jordan River, including Shimei, who had cursed him; Mephibosheth, who had been unable to join him because Ziba deceived him; and Barzillai, who had provided for him. The chapter concludes by describing how the leaders of Judah escorted David across the Jordan River before all the leaders of the other tribes had arrived, causing a dispute between them.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

"your servant," "my lord the king," "the king"
In several places in this chapter, people speak of themselves to King David in the third person as **your servant** to show humility. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a humble form in the first person. In several other places, even though people are addressing David directly, they speak of him in the third person as "my lord the king" to show respect. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a respectful form in the second person. Finally, in 19:11–12, in his message to the leaders of Judah, David refers to himself regally in the third person as "the king." If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a regal form in the first person, if your language has one. (For example, in some cultures, kings and queens refer to themselves with a plural form.) (See: First, Second or Third Person)

2 Samuel 19:1 (#1)

וַיֻּגַּד

"And it was declared"

The expression **it was declared** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [And someone declared]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 19:1 (#2)

הִנֵּה

"Behold"

See how you translated the similar expression in 1:2. Alternate translation: [Listen]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 19:2 (#1)

וַתְּהִי֙ הַתְּשׁוּעָ֣ה בַּיּ֔וֹם הַהִ֖וא לְאֵ֑בֶל לְכָל־הָעָ֗ם כִּֽי־שָׁמַ֤ע הָעָם֙ בַּיּ֣וֹם הַה֔וּא לֵאמֹ֖ר נֶעֱצַ֣ב הַמֶּ֑לֶךְ עַל־בְּנֽוֹ

“And the victory on that day became mourning for all of the people, for the people heard on that day, saying, “The king is grieved because of his son”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Because the people heard on that day, saying, “The king is grieved because of his son,” the victory on that day became mourning for all of the people]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

2 Samuel 19:2 (#2)

שָׁמַ֤ע הָעָם֙ בַּיּ֣וֹם הַה֔וּא לֵאמֹ֖ר נֶעֱצַ֣ב הַמֶּ֑לֶךְ עַל־בְּנֽוֹ

“the people heard on that day, saying, “The king is grieved because of his son”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this as an indirect quotation. Alternate translation: [the people heard on that day that the king was grieved because of his son]

See: Direct and Indirect Quotations

2 Samuel 19:2 (#3)

נֶעֱצַ֣ב הַמֶּ֑לֶךְ עַל־בְּנֽוֹ

“The king is grieved because of his son”

The expression **is grieved** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [What has happened to his son has grieved the king]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 19:3 (#1)

הָעָ֔בֶם הַנִּכְלָמִ֖ים

“ashamed people”

The expression **ashamed** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [people who feel shame]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 19:4 (#1)

וְהַמֶּ֖לֶךְ לְאַ֣ט אֶת־פָּנָ֑יו

“And the king covered his face”

Covering his face was a symbolic action by which David showed his deep grief and distress, as he had done when fleeing Jerusalem in 15:30. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [And to express his deep sorrow, the king covered his face]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 19:4 (#2)

אַבְשָׁל֣וֹם בְּנִ֔י בְּנִ֖י

“Absalom, my son, my son”

See how you translated the similar expression in 18:33. Alternate translation: [Oh, Absalom, my son]

See: Reduplication

2 Samuel 19:5 (#1)

אֶת־פְּנֵ֣י כָל־עֲבָדֶ֔יךָ

“the faces of all of your servants”

The author is using **the faces** to represent the people themselves. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [all of your servants]

See: Synecdoche

2 Samuel 19:5 (#2)

וְאֵ֣ת נֶ֣פֶשׁ בָּנֶ֗יךָ וּבְנֹתֶ֙יךָ֙ וְנֶ֣פֶשׁ נָשֶׁ֔יךָ וְנֶ֖פֶשׁ פִּלַגְשֶֽׁיךָ

“and the life of your sons and your daughters and the life of your wives and the life of your concubines”

In this verse, the word **life** is singular in form, but it refers to all the sons, daughters, wives, and concubines as a group. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use the plural form of “life.” Alternate translation: [and the lives of your sons and your daughters and the lives of your wives and the lives of your concubines]

See: Collective Nouns

2 Samuel 19:5 (#3)

וְאֵ֣ת נֶ֣פֶשׁ בָּנֶ֗יךָ וּבְנֹתֶ֙יךָ֙ וְנֶ֣פֶשׁ נָשֶׁ֔יךָ וְנֶ֖פֶשׁ פִּלַגְשֶֽׁיךָ

“and the life of your sons and your daughters and the life of your wives and the life of your concubines”

It might seem that repeating the term **life** three times would be extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you could represent the term only once. Alternate translation: [and the lives of your sons and your daughters and your wives and your concubines]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 19:6 (#1)

הִגַּדְתָּ

“you have declared”

Joab is saying that the implication is that David has shown by his actions, not necessarily by his words, how little he values his commanders and servants. You could indicate this in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [your actions have shown]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 19:6 (#2)

יָשָׁר בְּעֵינֶיךָ

“it would be} right in your eyes”

See how you translated the similar expression in 3:19. Alternate translation: [you would consider that to be a good thing]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 19:7 (#2)

צֵא וְדַבֵּר עַל־לֵב עֲבָדֶיךָ

“go out and speak to the heart of your servants & and”

Joab is using **speak to the heart of** as a common expression of his culture to mean “speak kindly and encouragingly to.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [speak encouragingly to your servants]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 19:7 (#1)

קוּם

“arise”

See how you translated the similar expression in 2:14. Alternate translation: [take action]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 19:7 (#4)

אֲשֶׁר־בָּאָה עָלֶיךָ

“that has come on you”

Joab is speaking of **trouble** as if it were a living thing that could have **come on** someone. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [that you have experienced]

See: Personification

2 Samuel 19:7 (#3)

כִּי & יָלִין אִישׁ אִתְּךָ הַלַּיְלָה

“if a man will lodge with you tonight”

Following the custom of his culture, Joab is swearing an oath and guaranteeing it by something that he holds sacred (**I swear by Yahweh**). He is then stating the first part of a condition (“if”) but not the second part (“then”). Use a natural way in your language to express an oath. In a context such as this, it may be natural to express the first part of the condition as a negative statement. See how you translated the similar expression in 14:19. Alternate translation: [not a man will lodge with you tonight]

See: Oath Formulas

2 Samuel 19:8 (#1)

הִגִּידוּ

“And they declared”

Here the author is using the pronoun **they** in a general sense, not to refer to specific people. Use an expression for this that would be natural in your language. Alternate translation: [And it was declared]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 19:8 (#2)

וַיָּבֹא & לִפְנֵי הַמֶּלֶךְ

“And & came to the face of the king”

Here, **to the face of** represents being in the presence of the king. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language.

Alternate translation: [came into the presence of the king]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 19:8 (#3)

וְיִשְׂרָאֵל נָנֻס אִישׁ לְאׇהָלָיו

“But Israel had fled, a man to his tent”

The author is using this sentence to describe something that happened while the events he has been describing were taking place. He had already reported this in 18:17, but he mentions it again here in order to provide the background for other events he will describe that happened afterwards. Translate this sentence the same way you did there, and connect it to the story in a way that makes it clear in your language that it is describing something that was ongoing in the background. The UST models one way to do that.

See: Connect — Background Information

2 Samuel 19:9 (#4)

וְהוּא מִלְּטָנוּ

“and he, he rescued us”

See how you translated the similar expression “you, you were” in 5:2. Alternate translation: [and he personally rescued us]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 19:9 (#2)

כָּל־הָעָם נָדוֹן בְּכָל־שִׁבְטֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל

“all of the people were contending in all of the tribes of Israel”

The author is saying **all of the people** as a generalization for emphasis. If it would be clearer in your language, you could express the emphasis in a different way. Alternate translation: [people throughout the tribes of Israel were contending]

See: Hyperbole

2 Samuel 19:9 (#3)

מִכַּף אוֹיְבֵינוּ & מִכַּף פְּלִשְׁתִּים

“from the palm of our enemies & from the palm of the Philistines”

Here, **palm**, equivalent to “hand” in similar contexts, represents the power or control of a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from the power of our enemies … from the power of the Philistines]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 19:9 (#1)

וַיְהִי

“And it happened”

The author is using the phrase **And it happened** to introduce a new event in the story. Use a word, phrase, or other method in your language that is natural for introducing a new event.

See: Introduction of a New Event

2 Samuel 19:10 (#4)

לָמָּה אַתֶּם מַחֲרִישִׁים

“why are you being silent”

Here, **being silent** represents not taking action. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [why are you doing nothing]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 19:10 (#1)

וְעַתָּה

“And now”

See how you translated this expression in 2:6.

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 19:10 (#2)

לָמָּה אַתֶּם מַחֲרִישִׁים לְהָשִׁיב אֶת־הַמֶּלֶךְ

“why are you being silent about bringing back the king”

The people are using the question form to criticize those who are not taking action to bring back the king. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [you should not be silent about bringing back the king!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 19:10 (#3)

לָמָּה אַתֶּם מַחֲרִישִׁים

“why are you being silent”

The word **you** is plural here because groups of Israelites are addressing one another, so use the plural form in your translation if your language marks that distinction.

See: Forms of 'You' — Singular

2 Samuel 19:11 (#5)

וּדְבַר־ כָּל־יִשְׂרָאֵל בָּבָא אֶל־הַמֶּלֶךְ

"For the word of all of Israel has come to the king"

David is speaking of this **word** as if it were a living thing that could have **come** to him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [For the king has heard the word of all of Israel]

See: Personification

2 Samuel 19:11 (#2)

לְהָשִׁיב אֶת־הַמֶּלֶךְ אֶל־בֵּיתוֹ & אֶל־הַמֶּלֶךְ אֶל־בֵּיתוֹ

"to bring back the king to his house & to the king, to his house"

David is speaking through these messengers, as the next verse shows, so here he is speaking of himself regally in the third person as **the king**. Your language may have a regal form that it could use here. (For example, in some languages, kings and queens speak of themselves in the plural.) You could also use the first person. Alternate translation: [to bring me, the king, back to my house ... to me, to my house]

See: First, Second or Third Person

2 Samuel 19:11 (#3)

לָלָמָּה תִּהְיוּ אַחֲרֹנִים לְהָשִׁיב אֶת־הַמֶּלֶךְ אֶל־בֵּיתוֹ

"Why are you the last to bring back the king to his house"

David is using the question form to rebuke those who have not yet acted to bring him back. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [You should not be the last to bring back the king to his house!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 19:11 (#4)

לְהָשִׁיב אֶת־הַמֶּלֶךְ אֶל־בֵּיתוֹ

"to bring back the king to his house"

While this instance of the term **house** may initially mean David's palace in Jerusalem, it seems also to represent David's kingdom and authority. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [to restore the king to his throne] or [to make David king again]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 19:11 (#6)

וּדְבַר־ כָּל־יִשְׂרָאֵל בָּבָא אֶל־הַמֶּלֶךְ

"For the word of all of Israel has come to the king"

David is using the term **word** to represent what Israel said by using words. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [For the king has learned what all of Israel has been saying]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 19:11 (#8)

אֶל־בֵּיתוֹ

"to his house"

This could mean: (1) that David is suggesting that Zadok and Abiathar could leave out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [that they want to return him to his house] or [that they want him to rule them again]; (2) that the **word of all of Israel** has come to David in the **house** where he is staying in Mahanaim. Alternate translation: [at the place where he is staying]; (3) that scribes have accidentally repeated the phrase **to his house** from the end of the previous sentence. Some versions omit the phrase on that assumption.

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 19:11 (#7)

וּדְבַר־ כָּל־יִשְׂרָאֵל בָּבָא אֶל־הַמֶּלֶךְ

"For the word of all of Israel has come to the king"

David is saying **all of Israel** as a generalization for emphasis. If it would be clearer in your language, you could express the emphasis in a different way. Alternate translation: [For the king has learned what people throughout Israel have been saying]

See: Hyperbole

2 Samuel 19:11 (#1)

לֵאמֹ֔ר לָֽמָּה תִֽהְיוּ֙ אַחֲרֹנִ֔ים לְהָשִׁ֖יב אֶת־הַמֶּ֑לֶךְ וּדְבַר־כָּל־יִשְׂרָאֵ֛ל בָּ֥בָא אֶל־הַמֶּ֖לֶךְ אֶל־בֵּיתֽוֹ

“saying, ‘Why are you the last to bring back the king to his house? For the word of all of Israel has come to the king, to his house”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [and ask them why they are the last to bring back the king to his house. Tell them that the word of all of Israel has come to the king, to his house]

See: Quotes within Quotes

2 Samuel 19:12 (#4)

וְלָֽמָּה תִֽהְיֶ֣ו אַחֲרֹנִ֔ים לְהָשִׁ֖יב אֶת־הַמֶּֽלֶךְ

“So why are you last to bring back the king”

David is using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [So you should not be the last to bring back the king!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 19:12 (#1)

אַחַ֤י אַתֶּם֙ עַצְמִ֣י וּבְשָׂרִ֔י אַתֶּ֖ם וְלָֽמָּה תִֽהְיֶ֣ו אַחֲרֹנִ֔ים לְהָשִׁ֖יב אֶת־הַמֶּֽלֶךְ

“You {are} my brothers. You {are} my bone and my flesh. So why are you last to bring back the king”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [Tell them that I say that they are my brothers, my bone and my flesh, and ask them why they are the last to bring back the king]

See: Quotes within Quotes

2 Samuel 19:12 (#3)

עַצְמִ֣י וּבְשָׂרִ֔י אַתֶּ֖ם

“You {are} my bone and my flesh”

David is using **my bone and my flesh** as a common expression of his culture to refer to close relations. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You are my blood relations] or [We belong to the same tribe]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 19:12 (#2)

אַחַ֤י אַתֶּם֙

“You {are} my brothers”

David is using the term **brothers** to describe people who are descended from the same ancestor. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You are my kinsmen]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 19:13 (#2)

הֲלֹ֥וא עַצְמִ֣י וּבְשָׂרִ֔י אָ֖תָּה

“Are} you not my bone and my flesh”

David is using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [You are indeed my bone and my flesh!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 19:13 (#7)

לְפָנָ֑י

“to my face”

Here, **to my face** represents being in the presence of a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in my presence]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 19:13 (#1)

וְלַעֲמָשָׂ֣אי תֹּמְר֗וּ הֲלֹ֤וא עַצְמִ֣י וּבְשָׂרִ֔י אָ֖תָּה כֹּ֣ה יַֽעֲשֶׂה־לִּ֣י אֱלֹהִ֔ים וְכֹ֥ה יוֹסִ֖יף אִם־לֹ֣א שַׂר־צָבָ֑א תִּֽהְיֶ֤ה לְפָנַי֙ כָּל־הַיָּמִ֔ים תַּ֖תַּחַת יוֹאָֽב

“And to Amasa you shall say, ‘{Are} you not my bone and my flesh? Thus may God do to me, and thus may he add, if you are not the commander of the army to my face all of the years in place of Joab”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [And tell Amasa that I say he is indeed my bone and my flesh. Tell him I say that thus may God do to me, and thus may he add, if he is not the commander of the army to the face of all of the years in place of Joab]

See: Quotes within Quotes

2 Samuel 19:13 (#3)

הֲלֹוא עַצְמִי וּבְשָׂרִי אָתָּה

“Are} you not my bone and my flesh”

See how you translated the similar expression in 19:12. Alternate translation: [Are you not my blood relative?] or [You are indeed my blood relative!]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 19:13 (#5)

כֹּה יַעֲשֶׂה־לִּי אֱלֹהִים וְכֹה יוֹסִיף

“Thus may God do to me, and thus may he add”

When David says **thus may he add**, he is using a common expression of his culture. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Thus may God do to me, and may he do even worse]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 19:13 (#8)

כָּל־הַיָּמִים

“all of the years”

David is using the term **years** to represent time, since time is made up of years. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [from this time forward] or [permanently]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 19:13 (#4)

כֹּה יַעֲשֶׂה־לִּי אֱלֹהִים וְכֹה יוֹסִיף אִם־לֹא שַׂר־צָבָא תִּהְיֶה לְפָנַי כָּל־הַיָּמִים תַּחַת יוֹאָב

“Thus may God do to me, and thus may he add, if you are not the commander of the army to my face all of the years in place of Joab”

Following the custom of his culture, David is using a conditional statement to swear an oath. What he states as a condition (“if”) is what he is swearing to do. Use a natural way in your language to express an oath. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could put the condition before the consequence. See how you translated the similar oath in 3:9. Alternate translation: [I swear that you will be the commander of the army to my face all of the years in place of Joab, and if not, then may God do thus to me, and thus may he add]

See: Oath Formulas

2 Samuel 19:13 (#6)

כֹּה יַעֲשֶׂה־לִּי אֱלֹהִים

“Thus may God do to me”

The word **Thus**: (1) could refer to what David describes in the “if” statement of this oath. David could be saying that if he does not give Amasa the privileged position of being his **commander**, then he wants God not to restore him to his privileged position as king of Israel. The UST models one way to express that meaning. (2) could be a general expression introducing the entire statement as a reference to severe punishment. Alternate translation: [May God punish me very severely]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 19:14 (#6)

שֹׁשְׁוּב

“Return”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. Use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please return]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

2 Samuel 19:14 (#2)

וַיֵּט אֶת־לְבַב כָּל־אִישׁ־יְהוּדָה

“And he inclined the heart of every man of Judah”

Here the masculine term **man** has a generic sense that includes both men and women. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use language in your translation that is clearly inclusive of both men and women. Alternate translation: [And he inclined the heart of every person in Judah]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

2 Samuel 19:14 (#3)

וַיֵּט אֶת־לְבַב כָּל־אִישׁ־יְהוּדָה

“And he inclined the heart of every man of Judah”

Here, the **heart** represents where a person’s thoughts, feelings, and desires exist. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And he won the hearts of all the people of Judah] or [And he made everyone in Judah desire that he return as their king]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 19:14 (#5)

וַיִּשְׁלְחוּ֙ אֶל־הַמֶּ֔לֶךְ

“And they sent to the king”

The phrase **And they sent** introduces a direct quotation. In your translation, use a natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language. Alternate translation: [And they sent this message to the king, saying] or [And they sent to the king, saying]

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

2 Samuel 19:14 (#4)

כְּאִ֥ישׁ אֶחָ֖ד

“as one man”

The author is using **as one man** as a common expression of his culture to mean “in complete agreement.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. If you have already translated the book of 1 Samuel, see how you translated the similar expression in 1 Samuel 11:7. Alternate translation: [in complete agreement] or [unitedly]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 19:14 (#1)

וַיֵּ֤ט אֶת־לְבַב֙ כָּל־אִ֣ישׁ־יְהוּדָ֔ה

“And he inclined the heart of every man of Judah”

The pronoun **he** could refer to (1) David. The UST expresses that interpretation. (2) Amasa. Many versions do not replace the pronoun with a name but say “he” in order to allow for either interpretation.

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 19:15 (#2)

לִקְרַ֣את הַמֶּ֗לֶךְ לְהַעֲבִ֛יר אֶת־הַמֶּ֖לֶךְ אֶת־הַיַּרְדֵּֽן

“to meet the king to bring the king across the Jordan”

Meeting the king and escorting him across the Jordan River was a symbolic action by which the leaders of Judah showed their renewed loyalty to David and their acceptance of his restored kingship. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [to welcome the king and demonstrate their loyalty by helping him cross the Jordan]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 19:15 (#1)

וִיהוּדָ֔ה

“And Judah”

Here, **Judah** represents the elders or leaders of Judah. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the elders of Judah]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 19:15 (#3)

לִקְרַ֣את הַמֶּ֗לֶךְ לְהַעֲבִ֛יר אֶת־הַמֶּ֖לֶךְ אֶת־הַיַּרְדֵּֽן

“to meet the king to bring the king across the Jordan”

It may be more natural in your language to use a pronoun rather than the expression **the king** in it second instance. Alternate translation: [to meet the king to bring him across the Jordan]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 19:16 (#4)

אִ֣ישׁ יְהוּדָ֔ה

“a man of Judah”

The author is not referring to a specific **man of Judah**. He means the Judean leaders in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the men of Judah]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

2 Samuel 19:16 (#1)

בֶּן־הַיְמִינִ֖י אֲשֶׁ֣ר מִבַּחוּרִ֑ים

“the Benjaminite, who {was} from Bahurim”

The author is not distinguishing this **Benjaminite**, Shimei, from another Benjaminite who was not **from Bahurim**. The detail is reminding readers about the identity of this character. Be sure that this is clear in your translation.

See: Distinguishing Versus Informing or Reminding

2 Samuel 19:16 (#3)

וַיֵּ֣רֶד

“and came down”

In keeping with what is usual for his language and culture, the author is marking travel for change in elevation. If this expression contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language, you could shorten it. You can do the same for the similar instances in verses 20 and 24. Alternate translation: [and came]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 19:16 (#2)

וַיְמַהֵ֖ר & וַיֵּֽרֶד

“And & hurried and came down”

The phrase **hurried and came down** expresses a single idea. The word **hurried** tells in what way Shimei **came down**. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning in a different way. Alternate translation: [And ... hurriedly came down]

See: Hendiadys

2 Samuel 19:17 (#3)

וְצִיבָ֣א נַ֣עַר בֵּֽית־שָׁא֗וּל

“and & Ziba, the young man of the house of Saul”

The author is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and Ziba, the young man of the house of Saul, also came]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 19:17 (#1)

וְאֶ֨לֶף אִ֤ישׁ עִמּוֹ֙ מִבִּנְיָמִ֔ן וְצִיבָ֖א

“and 1,000 men {were} with him from Benjamin. And Ziba”

Bringing 1,000 Benjaminite men was a symbolic action by which Shimei showed that there was now broad support for David’s kingship within his tribe, even though its members had previously supported Saul’s family. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [and to show his tribe’s support, he brought 1,000 men from Benjamin with him]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 19:17 (#2)

מִבִּנְיָמִ֔ן

“from Benjamin”

Here, **Benjamin** represents the tribe of Benjamin. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [who were Benjaminites]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 19:17 (#5)

לִפְנֵ֖י הַמֶּֽלֶךְ

“to the face of the king”

Here, **to the face of** represents being in the presence of the king. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [into the presence of the king]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 19:17 (#4)

נַ֣עַר בֵּֽית־שָׁא֗וּל

“the young man of the house of Saul”

See how you translated the similar expression in 9:1. Alternate translation: [the servant of the descendants of Saul]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 19:18 (#5)

לִפְנֵ֖י

“to the face of”

Here, **to the face of** represents being in front of the king. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in front of]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 19:18 (#2)

אֶת־בֵּ֥ית הַמֶּ֖לֶךְ

“the house of the king”

See how you translated the similar expression in 15:35. Alternate translation: [the household of the king]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 19:18 (#3)

וְלַעֲשׂ֖וֹת הַטּ֥וֹב בעינו

“and to do the good in his eyes”

See how you translated the similar expression in 3:19. Alternate translation: [and to do what he regarded as right]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 19:18 (#6)

בְּעָבְרוֹ בַּיַּרְדֵּן

“when he crossed in the Jordan”

The pronoun **he** refers to Shimei. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [after Shimei had crossed in the Jordan]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 19:18 (#1)

וְעָבְרָה

“And they crossed”

The pronoun **they** refers to the elders of Judah. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [And the elders of Judah crossed]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 19:18 (#4)

נָפַל

“fell”

Be sure that it is clear in your translation that Shimei did not fall down accidentally. He knelt down in front of David as a gesture to honor him. Alternate translation: [knelt down respectfully]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 19:18 (#7)

בְּעָבְרוֹ בַּיַּרְדֵּן

“when he crossed in the Jordan”

When the author says **in**, the implication is that in order to get to David quickly, Shimei waded through the water of the Jordan River. (Some interpreters suggest that the elders of Judah would instead have crossed the river on rafts and brought David across the same way.) You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [after he had waded across the Jordan]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 19:19 (#3)

וְאַל־תִּזְכֹּר אֵת אֲשֶׁר הֶעֱוָה עַבְדְּךָ

“and may you not remember that your servant committed iniquity”

Shimei is using **may you not remember** as a common expression of his culture to mean “may you not punish.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and may you not punish your servant for the iniquity that he committed]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 19:19 (#2)

אֲדֹנִי & אֲדֹנִי־הַמֶּלֶךְ & הַמֶּלֶךְ

“my lord & my lord the king & the king”

Even though Shimei is addressing David directly, he is speaking of him in the third person as **my lord**, **my lord the king**, and **the king** to show respect. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a respectful form in the second person. See the discussion in the Introduction to this chapter of speakers using the third person either for themselves, to show humility (as Shimei does later in this verse), or for people whom they are addressing directly, to show respect. Use the appropriate forms in your language throughout the chapter. Alternate translation: [you, my lord ... you, my lord the king ... you]

See: First, Second or Third Person

2 Samuel 19:19 (#4)

עַבְדְּךָ

“your servant”

Shimei is speaking of himself in the third person as **your servant** to show humility. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a humble form in the first person. Alternate translation: [me, your servant]

See: First, Second or Third Person

2 Samuel 19:19 (#5)

לְשִׂשְׂוֹם הַמֶּלֶךְ אֶל־לִבּוֹ

“for the king to set {it} to his heart”

See how you translated the similar expression in 13:20. Alternate translation: [Please do not take it to heart] or [Please do not hold it against me]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 19:19 (#1)

אַל־יַחְשֹׁב־לִ֨י אֲדֹנִ֜י עָוֹ֗ן

“May my lord not reckon iniquity to me”

This is a double negative, consisting of the negative particle **not** and the verb **reckon**, which in this context would be negative. If it would be clearer in your language, you could use a positive expression to translate this. Alternate translation: [May my lord please forgive my iniquity]

See: Double Negatives

2 Samuel 19:20 (#3)

בְּבֵ֣ית יוֹסֵ֔ף

“the house of Joseph”

Here, **the house of Joseph** represents the other Israelite tribes. The two largest, Ephraim and Manasseh, consisted of the descendants of Joseph. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the other Israelite tribes]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 19:20 (#1)

כִּ֣י

“For”

Here the word **For** introduces not a reason but an explanation. Alternate translation: [After all]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

2 Samuel 19:20 (#2)

אֲנִ֥י חָטָ֖אתִי

“I, I have sinned”

See how you translated the similar expression “you, you were” in 5:2. Alternate translation: [I have personally sinned]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 19:21 (#2)

הֲתַ֤חַת זֹאת֙ לֹ֣א יוּמַ֔ת שִׁמְעִ֖י

“In place of this, shall not Shimei be killed”

Abishai is using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [In place of this, Shimei should be killed!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 19:21 (#3)

הֲתַ֤חַת זֹאת֙ לֹ֣א יוּמַ֔ת שִׁמְעִ֖י

“In place of this, shall not Shimei be killed”

The expression **shall not Shimei be killed** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [In place of this, should you not kill Shimei?] or [In place of this, you should kill Shimei!]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 19:21 (#5)

אֶת־מְשִׁ֥יחַ יְהוָֽה

“the anointed of Yahweh”

See how you translated the similar expression in 1:14. Alternate translation: [the anointed one of Yahweh] or [the one whom Yahweh anointed as king]

See: Nominal Adjectives

2 Samuel 19:21 (#1)

וַיַּ֨עַן אֲבִישַׁ֜י בֶּן־צְרוּיָ֗הוּ וַיֹּ֣אמֶר

“And Abishai, the son of Zeruiah, answered and said”

The expression **and said** introduces a direct quotation. In your translation, use a natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language. It may not be necessary to represent this expression explicitly. (Shimei had addressed David rather than Abishai, so it was not Shimei personally whom Abishai **answered**. Rather, he was responding to the situation.) Alternate translation: [And Abishai, the son of Zeruiah, responded]

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

2 Samuel 19:21 (#4)

אֶת־מְשִׁ֥יחַ יְהוָֽה

“the anointed of Yahweh”

Even though Abishai is addressing David directly, he is speaking of him in the third person as **the anointed of Yahweh** to show respect. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a respectful form in the second person. Alternate translation: [you, the anointed of Yahweh]

See: First, Second or Third Person

2 Samuel 19:22 (#3)

וְלָכֶם֙ & תִּהְיוּ

“and to you & you have become”

The word **you** is plural in both of these instances because David is addressing both Abishai and also Joab, who seems to have been nearby and supporting his brother’s suggestion. So use the plural form in your translation if your language marks that distinction.

See: Forms of ‘You’ — Singular

2 Samuel 19:22 (#1)

מַה־לִּ֨לְי וְלָכֶם֙ בְּנֵ֣י צְרוּיָ֔ה כִּֽי־תִהְיוּ־לִ֥לְי הַיּ֛וֹם לְשָׂטָ֖ן

“What to me and to you, sons of Zeruiah, that you have become an adversary to me today”

David is using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [I have nothing in common with you, sons of Zeruiah, that I would agree to your suggestion when it is so contrary to my interests!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 19:22 (#2)

מַה־לִּ֨לְי וְלָכֶם֙

“What to me and to you”

See how you translated the similar expression in 16:10. Alternate translation: [What do I have in common with you]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 19:22 (#6)

הַיּ֛וֹם יוּמַ֥ת אִישׁ֙ בְּיִשְׂרָאֵ֔ל

“Shall a man be killed in Israel today”

The expression **Shall a man be killed** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Shall anyone execute a man in Israel today?]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 19:22 (#7)

כִּ֚י הֲלֹ֣וא יָדַ֔עְתִּי כִּֽי־הַיּ֥וֹם אֲנִי־מֶ֖לֶךְ עַל־יִשְׂרָאֵֽל

“For do I not know that I {am} king over Israel today”

David is using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [For I certainly know that I am king over Israel today!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 19:22 (#4)

לְשָׂטָ֖ן

“an adversary”

In this verse, the word **adversary** is singular in form, but it refers to the two sons of Zeruiah, Abishai and Joab. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use the plural form of “adversary.” Alternate translation: [adversaries]

See: Collective Nouns

2 Samuel 19:22 (#5)

הַיּ֛וֹם יוּמַ֥ת אִישׁ֙ בְּיִשְׂרָאֵ֔ל

“Shall a man be killed in Israel today”

David is using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [No man shall be killed in Israel today!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 19:22 (#8)

הַיּ֔וֹם & הַיּ֥וֹם & הַיּ֖וֹם

“today & today & today”

David is repeating the word **today** in order to emphasize that the glorious day of his restoration to the kingship should not be the occasion of an execution. It might seem that repeating this word three times would be extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you translate the word only once, expressing what it means in this context. For example, instead of saying “today” in each sentence, you could just say “on this day of celebration” in the second sentence.

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 19:24 (#2)

וְלֹא־עָשָׂ֣ה רַגְלָ֔יו וְלֹא־עָשָׂ֥ה שִׂפְמֹ֖ו וְאֶת־בְּגָדָ֑יו לֹ֥א כִבֵּֽס

“And he had not done his feet, and he had not done his mustache, and he had not washed his clothes”

Not caring for his feet, mustache, or clothes was a symbolic action by which Mephibosheth showed his deep mourning over David’s departure. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [And to show his grief, he had not done his feet, and he had not done his mustache, and he had not washed his clothes]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 19:24 (#3)

בְּשָׁלֹום

“in peace”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **peace**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [peacefully] or [unharmed]

See: Abstract Nouns

2 Samuel 19:24 (#1)

בֶּן־שָׁאוּל

“the son of Saul”

See how you translated the similar expression in 9:9. Alternate translation: [the grandson of Saul]

See: Kinship

2 Samuel 19:25 (#1)

לָמָּה לֹא־הָלַכְתָּ עִמָּדִי

“Why did you not go with me”

In a context such as this, your language might say “come” instead of **go**. Alternate translation: [Why did you not come with me]

See: Go and Come

2 Samuel 19:26 (#1)

כִּי־אָמַר עַבְדְּךָ אֶחְבְּשָׁה־לִּי֙ הַחֲמֹור וְאֶרְכְּבֶה עָלָיו֙ וְאֵלֵךְ֙ וְאֵלֵךְ֙ אֶת־הַמֶּלֶךְ

“for your servant said, ‘Let me saddle a donkey for myself, and let me ride on it, and let me go with the king”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [for your servant told him to saddle a donkey for me and let me ride on it so that I could go with you]

See: Quotes within Quotes

2 Samuel 19:26 (#2)

אֶחְבְּשָׁה־לִּי֙ הַחֲמֹור

“Let me saddle a donkey for myself”

Mephibosheth was speaking of himself as the one who would actively **saddle** a **donkey** for himself, but this was a way of instructing Ziba to saddle a donkey for him. If it would be clearer in your language, you could use an imperative form. Alternate translation: [Saddle a donkey for me] or [Make it possible for me to have a saddled donkey for myself]

See: Irregular Use of Tenses

2 Samuel 19:26 (#3)

כִּֽי

“For”

Here the word **For** introduces not a reason but an explanation. Alternate translation: [After all]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

2 Samuel 19:27 (#1)

כְּמַלְאַךְ הָאֱלֹהִ֔ים

“is} like an angel of God”

The point of this comparison is that just as **an angel of God** has comprehensive knowledge, so does David. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. See how you translated the similar expression in 14:20. Alternate translation: [is like an angel of God in that he knows what is really happening throughout his kingdom]

See: Simile

2 Samuel 19:27 (#2)

הַטּוֹב בְּעֵינֶיךָ

“the good in your eyes”

See how you translated the similar expression in 3:19. Alternate translation: [as you see fit] or [what you think best]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 19:28 (#2)

בֵּית אָבִי

“the house of my father”

See how you translated the similar expression in 3:29. Alternate translation: [my extended family]

See: Kinship

2 Samuel 19:28 (#3)

אָבִי

“my father”

See how you translated the similar expression in 9:7. Alternate translation: [my grandfather]

See: Kinship

2 Samuel 19:28 (#1)

לֹא הָיָה כָל־בֵּית אָבִי כִּי אִם־אַנְשֵׁי־מָוֶת

“all of the house of my father was nothing except men of death”

If it would appear in your language that Mephibosheth was making a statement and then contradicting it, you could reword this as a positive statement. Alternate translation: [all of the house of my father were only men of death]

See: Connect — Exception Clauses

2 Samuel 19:28 (#4)

אַנְשֵׁי־מָוֶת לַאדֹנִי הַמֶּלֶךְ

“men of death to my lord the king”

See how you translated the similar expressions “son of death” in 12:5 and “man of blood” in 16:7. Alternate translation: [men whom my lord the king could have executed]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 19:28 (#5)

וּמַה־יֵּשׁ־לִי עוֹד צְדָקָה וְלִזְעֹק עוֹד אֶל־הַמֶּלֶךְ

“So what right is there still for me to cry out more to the king”

Mephibosheth is using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [So I have no further right to cry out more to the king.]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 19:29 (#3)

אָמַרְתִּי אַתָּה וְצִיבָא תַּחְלְקוּ אֶת־הַשָּׂדֶה

“I have said, ‘You and Ziba shall divide the field”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [I have said that you and Ziba shall divide the field]

See: Quotes within Quotes

2 Samuel 19:29 (#2)

לָמָּה תְדַבֵּר עוֹד דְּבָרֶיךָ

“Why do you still speak your words”

The king is using the question form to discourage Mephibosheth from speaking further. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [You do not need to keep speaking like that] or [You do not need to speak any further of your affairs]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 19:29 (#5)

אֶת־הַשָּׂדֶה

“the field”

See how you translated the similar expression in 9:7. Alternate translation: [the fields] or [the lands]

See: Collective Nouns

2 Samuel 19:29 (#1)

לָמָּה תְדַבֵּר עוֹד דְּבָרֶיךָ

“Why do you still speak your words”

This could mean: (1) that David is using the term **words** to represent what Mephibosheth has been saying by using words. Alternate translation: [Why are you still speaking like that]; (2) that the term **words** has the sense of “matters,” as in 18:13. Alternate translation: [Why do you still speak of your affairs]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 19:29 (#4)

אָמַרְתִּי

“I have said”

David is using the past tense in order to pronounce his judgment in this case. If it would not be natural to do that in your language, you could use the present

tense in your translation. Alternate translation: [My decision is]

See: Irregular Use of Tenses

2 Samuel 19:30 (#1)

בְּשָׁלֹום

“in peace”

See how you translated the similar expression in 19:24. Alternate translation: [peacefully] or [unharmed]

See: Abstract Nouns

2 Samuel 19:31 (#1)

יָרַד

“came down”

In keeping with what is usual for his language and culture, the author is marking travel for change in elevation. If this expression contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [came]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 19:31 (#2)

וַיַּעֲבֹר אֶת־הַמֶּלֶךְ הַיַּרְדֵּן לְשַׁלְּחוֹ אֶת־בירדן

“And he crossed the Jordan with the king to send him {across} the Jordan”

Crossing the Jordan with the king was a symbolic action by which Barzillai showed his loyalty to David and honored him. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [And he traveled with the king to the Jordan River to honor him by escorting him across]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 19:32 (#2)

בֶּן־שְׁמֹנִים שָׁנָה

“a son of 80 years”

The author is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [for he was a son of 80 years]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 19:32 (#1)

וּבַרְזִלַּי זָקֵן מְאֹד בֶּן־שְׁמֹנִים שָׁנָה

“Now Barzillai had aged greatly, a son of 80 years”

Here, the author is providing background information to help readers understand what happens next in the story. In your translation, introduce this information in a way that would be natural in your own language and culture.

See: Background Information

2 Samuel 19:32 (#4)

וְהוּא־כִלְכַּל אֶת־הַמֶּלֶךְ בְּשִׁבְתּוֹ בְמַחֲנַיִם כִּי־אִישׁ גָּדוֹל הוּא מְאֹד

“And he, he had sustained the king in his stay in Mahanaim, for he {was} a very great man”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [And since he was a very great man, he himself had sustained the king in his stay in Mahanaim]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

2 Samuel 19:32 (#5)

וְהוּא־כִלְכַּל

“And he, he had sustained”

See how you translated the similar expression “you, you were” in 5:2. Alternate translation: [And he had personally sustained]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 19:32 (#6)

אִישׁ גָּדוֹל הוּא מְאֹד

“he {was} a very great man”

In this context, the term **great** means having considerable wealth and possessions. If you have already translated the book of 1 Samuel, see how you translated the similar expression in 1 Samuel 25:2. Alternate translation: [he was a very wealthy man]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 19:32 (#3)

בֶּן־שְׁמֹנִים שָׁנָה

“a son of 80 years”

See how you translated the similar expression in 2:10. Alternate translation: [80 years old]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 19:33 (#2)

אַתָּה֙ עֲבֹ֣ר אִתִּ֔י וְכִלְכַּלְתִּ֖יךָ אֹתְךָ֑

“You, cross over with me, and I will sustain you”

David is stating the pronoun **You** separately, even though the verb translated as **cross over** already includes this meaning. He is doing that because he is making a promise to Barzillai. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing that David is making a promise to Barzillai. It may not be necessary to represent the separately stated pronoun explicitly. Alternate translation: [I promise that if you cross over with me, I will sustain you]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 19:33 (#1)

אַתָּה֙ עֲבֹ֣ר אִתִּ֔י

“You, cross over with me”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. Use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please cross over with me]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

2 Samuel 19:34 (#1)

כַּמָּ֗ה יְמֵי֙ שְׁנֵ֣י חַיַּ֔י כִּֽי־אֶֽעֱלֶ֥ה אֶת־הַמֶּ֖לֶךְ יְרוּשָׁלִָֽם

“How many {will be} the days of the years of my life, that I should go up with the king {to} Jerusalem”

Barzillai is using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [The days of the years of my life will not be many more, that I should go up with the king to Jerusalem!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 19:34 (#2)

יְמֵי֙ שְׁנֵ֣י חַיַּ֔י

“will be} the days of the years of my life”

It might seem that the expression **the days of the years of my life** contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [will be the days of my life] or [will be the years of my life]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 19:34 (#3)

אֶֽעֱלֶ֥ה

“I should go up”

See how you translated the similar expression in 19:31. Alternate translation: [I should go]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 19:35 (#3)

בְּקֹ֖ול

“the voice of”

In this verse, the word **voice** is singular in form, but it refers to all the singers as a group. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use the plural form of “voice.” Alternate translation: [the voices]

See: Collective Nouns

2 Samuel 19:35 (#1)

בֶּן־שְׁמֹנִ֥ים שָׁנָ֖ה אָנֹכִ֑י

“I {am} a son of 80 years”

See how you translated the similar expression in 19:32. Alternate translation: [I am 80 years old]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 19:35 (#2)

הַאֵדַ֤ע ׀ בֵּין־טֹ֙וב לְרָ֔ע אִם־יִטְעַ֥ם עַבְדְּךָ֖ אֶת־אֲשֶׁ֣ר אֹכַ֑ל וְאֶת־אֲשֶׁ֣ר אֶשְׁתֶּ֔ה אִם־אֶשְׁמַ֥ע עֹ֛וד בְּקֹ֥ול שָׁרִ֖ים וְשָׁרֹ֑ות וְלָ֣מָּה יִֽהְיֶ֤ה עַבְדְּךָ֙ עֹ֔ודד לְמַשָּׂ֖א אֶל־אֲדֹנִ֥י הַמֶּֽלֶךְ

“Do I know between good to bad? Or does your servant taste what I eat or what I drink? Or do I still hear the voice of the {male} singers or the {female} singers? So why should your servant become a further burden to my lord the king”

Barzillai is using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate these questions as statements or as exclamations. Alternate translation: [I no longer know between good to bad.

And your servant does not taste what I eat or what I drink. And I no longer hear the voice of the male singers or the female singers. So your servant should not become a further burden to my lord the king.]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 19:35 (#4)

וְלָמָּה֩ יִהְיֶ֨ה עַבְדְּךָ֜ עוֹד֙ לְמַשָּׂ֔א אֶל־אֲדֹנִ֖י הַמֶּ֑לֶךְ

“So why should your servant become a further burden to my lord the king”

Barzillai is speaking as if he would actually become a **burden** or weight that David needed to carry on his back. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [So why should your servant cause my lord the king to have additional responsibilities for his care?]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 19:36 (#2)

וְלָ֣מָּה֩ יִגְמְלֵ֨נִי הַמֶּ֜לֶךְ הַגְּמוּלָ֗ה הַזֹּֽאת

“But why will the king reward me this reward”

Barzillai is using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [But the king does not need to reward me this reward]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 19:36 (#3)

יִגְמְלֵ֨נִי & הַגְּמוּלָ֗ה הַזֹּֽאת

“will & reward me this reward”

Barzillai is using a construction in which a verb and its object come from the same root. You may be able to use the same construction in your language to express the meaning here. Alternatively, your language may have another way of saying this. Alternate translation: [reward me so generously]

See: Poetry

2 Samuel 19:36 (#1)

כִּמְעַ֣ט יַֽעֲבֹ֣ר עַבְדְּךָ֔ אֶת־הַיַּרְדֵּ֖ן אֶת־הַמֶּ֑לֶךְ

“According to a little your servant will go across the Jordan with the king”

Going across the Jordan with the king was a symbolic action by which Barzillai showed respect and honor to David, even though he would only go a short distance beyond the river. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [To show respect and honor, according to a little your servant will go across the Jordan with the king]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 19:37 (#2)

וַעֲשֵׂ֥ה־לּ֛וֹ

“and do for him”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. Use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [and please do for him]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

2 Samuel 19:37 (#3)

אֵ֖ת אֲשֶׁר־טּ֥וֹב בְּעֵינֶ֖יךָ

“what {is} good in your eyes”

See how you translated the similar expression in 3:19. Alternate translation: [as you see fit] or [what you think is best]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 19:37 (#1)

וְהִנֵּ֥ה ׀ עַבְדְּךָ֛ כִּמְהָ֖ם

“But behold your servant Chimham”

While Barzillai may want David to look at Chimham (who has accompanied him, and who is likely his son, as 1 Kings 2:7 suggests), he seems to be saying **behold** as part of the courteous expression that people in this culture would use to tell a superior that someone was ready and willing to obey his orders. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. See how you translated the similar expression in 1:7. Alternate translation: [But now here is your servant Chimham, at your disposal]

See: Politeness

2 Samuel 19:38 (#2)

אֶת־הַטּ֑וֹב

“the good”

The king is using the adjective **good** as a noun to mean a certain kind of thing. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate

this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [what is good]

See: Nominal Adjectives

2 Samuel 19:38 (#1)

וַאֲנִי֙ אֶֽעֱשֶׂה־לּ֔וֹ

“and I, I shall do for him”

David is stating the pronoun **I** separately, even though the verb translated as **I shall do** already includes this meaning. He is doing that because he is making a promise to Barzillai. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing that David is making a promise to Barzillai. It may not be necessary to represent the separately stated pronoun explicitly. Alternate translation: [and I promise that I shall do for him]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 19:38 (#3)

וְכֹ֥ל אֲשֶׁר־תִּבְחַ֖ר עָלָ֑י

“And all that you choose upon me”

The king is using **choose upon me** as a common expression of his culture to mean “require of me.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And all that you require of me]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 19:39 (#1)

וַיַּעֲבֹ֣ר כָּל־הָעָ֗ם אֶת־הַיַּרְדֵּן֙ וְהַמֶּ֣לֶךְ עָבָ֔ר

“And all of the people crossed the Jordan, and the king crossed”

The author seems to be suggesting that first the **people** (the tribal leaders) **crossed the Jordan**, and then **the king crossed**. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [And all of the people crossed the Jordan to lead the way in an honor procession, and then the king crossed]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 19:40 (#2)

חֲצֵ֥י

“half of”

In this context, the word **half** does not indicate exactly one of two equal parts. Alternate translation: [only some of]

See: Fractions

2 Samuel 19:40 (#1)

עַ֚ם יְהוּדָ֔ה & עַ֖ם יִשְׂרָאֵ֑ל

“the people of Judah & the people of Israel”

The implication here and in the next verse is that these were the leaders of Judah and the leaders of the other Israelite tribes rather than all the people. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [the leaders of Judah ... the leaders of the other Israelite tribes]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 19:41 (#5)

גְּנָבֻ֖ךָ

“did & steal you away”

Here, the men of Israel are speaking as if the king were an object that someone could **steal ... away**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [take you away without considering us]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 19:41 (#2)

כָּל־אִ֥ישׁ יִשְׂרָאֵ֖ל

“all of the men of Israel”

The implication is that these were the leaders of the other Israelite tribes rather than all the men of Israel. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [the rest of the leaders of the other Israelite tribes]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 19:41 (#3)

מַדּ֣וּעַ֗ גְּנָבֻ֙ךָ֙ אַחֵ֣ינוּ אַנְשֵׁ֣י יְהוּדָ֔ה וַיַּעֲבִ֥רוּ אֶת־הַמֶּ֛לֶךְ וְאֶת־בֵּיתוֹ֖ אֶת־הַיַּרְדֵּ֑ן וְכָל־אַנְשֵׁ֥י דָוִ֖ד עִמּֽוֹ

“Why did our brothers, the men of Judah, steal you away and bring the king and his house across the Jordan and all of the men of David with him”

The men of Israel are using the question form to express their anger that the men of Judah had brought David back without including them. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [It was not right for our brothers, the men of Judah, to steal you away and bring the king and his house across the Jordan and all of the men of David with him!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 19:41 (#1)

כָּל־אִ֣ישׁ יִשְׂרָאֵ֗ל בָּאִים֙ אֶל־הַמֶּ֔לֶךְ וַיֹּאמְר֣וּ אֵלָ֔יו לַמֶּ֖לֶךְ

“all of the men of Israel were coming to the king, and they said to the king”

The author is saying **all of the men of Israel were coming to the king** to describe something that was ongoing. This provides the background for other events he will describe that began to happen during this time. Connect this clause to the story in a way that makes it clear in your language that this clause is describing something that was ongoing in the background. Alternate translation: [as the rest of the men of Israel continued to arrive where David was, they said to him]

See: Connect — Background Information

2 Samuel 19:41 (#4)

אַחֵ֑ינוּ

“our brothers”

See how you translated the similar expression in 19:12. Alternate translation: [our kinsmen]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 19:41 (#7)

וְאֶת־בֵּיתוֹ֙

“and his house”

See how you translated the similar expression in 19:18. Alternate translation: [and his household] or [and your household]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 19:41 (#8)

אַנְשֵׁ֥י דָוִ֖ד עִמּֽוֹ

“the men of David with him”

Since these tribal leaders are addressing David directly, and since they call him **you** earlier in the sentence, it may be natural to use second-person pronouns here. Alternate translation: [your men with you]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 19:41 (#6)

הַמֶּ֔לֶךְ

“the king”

Even though the men of Israel are addressing David directly, they are speaking of him in the third person as **the king** to show respect. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a respectful form in the second person. Alternate translation: [you, the king]

See: First, Second or Third Person

2 Samuel 19:42 (#3)

כִּי־קָרִ֥וב הַמֶּ֖לֶךְ אֵלָ֑ינוּ

“Because the king {is} near to me”

The men of Judah are leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [We brought the king across the Jordan River because he is near to us]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 19:42 (#6)

וְלָמָ֣ה זֶּ֔ה חָרָ֥ה לְךָ֖ עַל־הַדָּבָ֣ר הַזֶּ֑ה

“And why this, it burns to you about this matter”

The Judean leaders are using **And why this** as a common expression of their culture to mean “There is no need for this.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. If you have already translated the book of 1 Samuel, see how you translated the similar expression in 1 Samuel 20:8. Alternate translation: [And there is no need for it to burn to you about this matter.] or [And it should not be that it burns to you about this matter.]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 19:42 (#7)

חָרָ֥ה לְךָ֖ עַל־הַדָּבָ֣ר הַזֶּ֑ה

“it burns to you about this matter”

Here the phrase **it burns to you** is a common expression that means that the men of Israel have become

angry. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you have become angry about this matter]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 19:42 (#8)

הֶאָכוֹל אָכַלְנוּ֙ מִן־הַמֶּ֔לֶךְ אִם־נִשֵּׂ֥א נִשָּׂ֖א לָנוּ

“Eating, have we eaten from the king? Or being taken, has it been taken for us”

The men of Judah are repeating forms of the verbs **eaten** and **taken** in order to intensify their expression of the ideas that these verbs convey. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [Have we eaten at all from the king? Or has anything at all been taken for us?] or [We certainly have not eaten from the king! And certainly nothing has been taken for us!]

See: Reduplication

2 Samuel 19:42 (#1)

וַיַּעַן֙ כָּל־אִ֣ישׁ יְהוּדָ֔ה עַל־אִ֖ישׁ יִשְׂרָאֵֽל

“And each man of Judah answered to a man of Israel”

In this verse, the expressions **each man** and **a man** are singular in form, but they refer to all the men of Judah and Israel as groups. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use the plural form of “man.” Alternate translation: [And all of the men of Judah answered to the men of Israel]

See: Collective Nouns

2 Samuel 19:42 (#10)

אִם־נִשֵּׂ֥א נִשָּׂ֖א לָנוּ

“Or being taken, has it been taken for us”

The expression **being taken, has it been taken** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [And the king has not taken anything and given it to us]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 19:42 (#2)

כִּי־קָרֹ֥וב הַמֶּ֖לֶךְ אֵלָ֑י

“Because the king {is} near to me”

In this verse, the word **me** is singular in form, but it refers to all the men of Judah as a group. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a plural form. Alternate translation: [Because the king is near to us]

See: Collective Nouns

2 Samuel 19:42 (#4)

קָרֹ֥וב & אֵלָ֑י

“is} near to me”

Here, the men of Judah are speaking as if being related to someone were actually being **near** to that person physically. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [is our close relative]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 19:42 (#5)

וְלָמָ֣ה זֶּ֔ה חָרָ֥ה לְךָ֖ עַל־הַדָּבָ֣ר הַזֶּ֑ה הֶאָכוֹל֙ אָכַ֣לְנוּ מִן־הַמֶּ֔לֶךְ אִם־נִשֵּׂ֥א נִשָּׂ֖א לָנוּ

“And why this, it burns to you about this matter? Eating, have we eaten from the king? Or being taken, has it been taken for us”

The men of Judah are using the question form to emphasize that the men of Israel should not be angry and that they have not received any favors from the king. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate these questions as statements or as exclamations. Alternate translation: [And it should not be that it burns to you about this matter. Eating, we have not eaten from the king, and being taken, it has not been taken for us!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 19:42 (#9)

הֶאָכוֹל֙ אָכַ֣לְנוּ מִן־הַמֶּ֔לֶךְ

“Eating, have we eaten from the king”

The men of Judah are using **eaten from the king** as a common expression of their culture to describe receiving food or other provisions from the king. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Has

the king been providing any of our food?] or [The king has not been providing any of our food!]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 19:43 (#1)

וַיַּעַן אִישׁ־יִשְׂרָאֵל֙ אֶת־אִ֣ישׁ יְהוּדָ֔ה וַיֹּ֖אמֶר

“And a man of Israel answered a man of Judah, and he said”

In this verse, the words **a man of Israel** and **a man of Judah** are singular in form, but they refer to all the men of Israel and all the men of Judah as groups. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use the plural form of “man.” Alternate translation: [And the men of Israel answered the men of Judah, and they said]

See: Collective Nouns

2 Samuel 19:43 (#6)

וּמַדּ֣וּעַ הֻקְלֹתַ֔נִי וְלֹא־הָיָ֥ה דְבָרִ֖י רִאשׁוֹנָ֑ה לְהָשִׁ֣יב אֶת־מַלְכִּ֔י

“So why have you despised me? Was not my word first, to bring back my king to me”

The men of Israel are using the question form to emphasize that the men of Judah should not have despised them and that they were the first to speak of bringing back the king. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate these questions as statements or as exclamations. Alternate translation: [So you should not have despised me! It was my word that was first, to bring back my king to me!] or [So you should not have despised us! It was our word that was first, to bring back my king to us!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 19:43 (#2)

וַיַּעַן אִישׁ־יִשְׂרָאֵל֙ אֶת־אִ֣ישׁ יְהוּדָ֔ה וַיֹּ֖אמֶר

“And a man of Israel answered a man of Judah, and he said”

The phrase **and he said** introduces a direct quotation. In your translation, use a natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language. It may not be necessary to represent this phrase explicitly. Alternate translation: [And the men of Israel responded to the men of Judah]

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

2 Samuel 19:43 (#4)

וְגַם־בְּדָוִ֖ד אֲנִ֣י מִמְּךָ֑

“and also in David, I more than you”

The men of Israel are leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and we also have a greater share in David than you do]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 19:43 (#5)

מִמְּךָ֑ & הֻקְלֹתַ֔נִי

“more than you & have you despised me”

The word **you** is singular here because the author is depicting individual conversations between Israelite and Judean leaders. If you depict this scene in the same way, use the singular form of “you” in your translation if your language marks that distinction. But if you decide to say “men” rather than **man**, use the plural form of “you.”

See: Forms of ‘You’ — Singular

2 Samuel 19:43 (#7)

וְלֹא־הָיָ֥ה דְבָרִ֖י רִאשׁוֹנָ֑ה לְהָשִׁ֣יב אֶת־מַלְכִּ֔י

“Was not my word first, to bring back my king to me”

The men of Israel are using the term **word** to represent what they said by using words. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Were we not the first to say that we should bring our king back to us?]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 19:43 (#3)

עֲשֶׂר־יָדוֹת֙ לִ֣י בַמֶּ֔לֶךְ

“Ten hands {are} to me in the king”

The men of Israel are using **Ten hands {are} to me in the king** as a common expression of their culture to mean “we have ten shares in the king.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [We have ten shares in the king]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 19:43 (#8)

וַיִּקְשֹׁ֣ שִׁבֵּר־אִ֣ישׁ יְהוּדָ֔ה מִדִּבְבַ֖ר אִ֣ישׁ יִשְׂרָאֵ֑ל

“But the word of a man of Judah was harsher than & word of & of Israel”

The author is using the term **word** to represent what the men of Judah and Israel said by using words. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [But the leaders of Judah spoke more harshly than the leaders of Israel spoke]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel - Chapter 20 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter continues the story of what David did as the king of Israel and specifically how he was restored completely to his position as king after Absalom’s rebellion. It describes how a man named Sheba encouraged the Israelites not to accept David as their king again. David had appointed Amasa, who had been Absalom’s military commander, as his own commander. But when he did not take swift action against Sheba, David sent his own personal troops to pursue Sheba. They met Amasa on the way, and Joab murdered him. Joab then trapped Sheba in a city whose inhabitants killed him so that Joab would not destroy their city. That ended the rebellion, and David was firmly established as king once again.

The author indicates this by ending the chapter with a list of David’s officials (20:23–26). This list is much like the one in 8:16–18 that follows the author’s statement that “David was king over all of Israel.” See how you formatted the earlier list. It may be helpful to format this list in the same way, for example: Now Joab {was} over all of the army of Israel. Benaiah, the son of Jehoiada, {was} over the Kerethites and over the Pelethites. Adoniram {was} over the forced labor. Jehoshaphat, the son of Ahilud, {was} the recorder. Sheva {was} the scribe. Zadok and Abiathar {were} priests. Ira the Jairite was also a priest to David.

2 Samuel 20:1 (#1)

וְשָׁ֣ם נִקְרָ֔א אִ֥ישׁ בְּלִיַּ֖עַל

“And a man of wickedness was met there”

See how you translated the similar expression in 18:9. Alternate translation: [And a man of wickedness happened to be there]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 20:1 (#2)

אִ֥ישׁ בְּלִיַּ֖עַל

“a man of wickedness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **wickedness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [a wicked man]

See: Abstract Nouns

2 Samuel 20:1 (#5)

אֵֽין־לָ֙נוּ֙ חֵ֣לֶק בְּדָוִ֔ד וְלֹ֥א נָחֲלָה־לָ֖נוּ בְּבֶן־יִשַׁ֑י

“There} is no portion to us in David, and no inheritance {is} to us in the son of Jesse”

These two phrases **There is no portion to us in David** and **no inheritance is to us in the son of Jesse** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [We will have no part of David son of Jesse]

See: Parallelism

2 Samuel 20:1 (#3)

וּשְׁמ֣וֹ שֶׁ֔בַע בֶּן־בִּכְרִ֖י אִ֣ישׁ יְמִינִ֑י

“and his name {was} Sheba, the son of Bichri, a man of Benjamin”

Here the author is introducing **Sheba, the son of Bichri, a man of Benjamin** as a new participant in the story. Your language may have its own way of introducing new participants that you can use in your translation.

See: Introduction of New and Old Participants

2 Samuel 20:1 (#6)

אֵֽין־לָ֙נוּ֙ חֵ֣לֶק בְּדָוִ֔ד וְלֹ֥א נָחֲלָה־לָ֖נוּ בְּבֶן־יִשַׁ֑י

“There} is no portion to us in David, and no inheritance {is} to us in the son of Jesse”

Sheba is speaking as if David were actually land or property of which the Israelites could have a **portion** that they would receive as an **inheritance**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [We want nothing to do with David son of Jesse]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 20:1 (#7)

אִ֣ישׁ לְאׇהָלָ֔יו יִשְׂרָאֵ֖ל

“A man to his tents, Israel”

Sheba is using **a man to his tent** as a common expression of his culture that often described soldiers stopping a military campaign altogether and each one going back to his home and family. In this particular context, Sheba is using the expression to mean that the soldiers from the other tribes will not obey David as their military commander. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Abandon the army and go home, Israel!]

See: Synecdoche

2 Samuel 20:1 (#4)

אֵין־לָ֥נוּ חֵ֖לֶק בְּדָוִ֑ד וְלֹ֤א נָחֲלָה־לָּ֙נוּ֙ בְּבֶן־יִשַׁ֔י

“There} is no portion to us in David, and no inheritance {is} to us in the son of Jesse”

If Sheba were speaking to the Judeans with whom he and his fellow Israelites have been disputing, the word **us** would not include them, so it would be appropriate to use the exclusive form of that word if your language marks that distinction. That is one interpretive possibility. However, since he directly addresses his fellow Israelites in the next sentence, he may well also be addressing them here, in which case it would be appropriate to use the inclusive form. Decide as a translation team which interpretation you wish to follow.

See: Exclusive and Inclusive ‘We’

2 Samuel 20:1 (#8)

אִ֣ישׁ & אִ֣ישׁ לְאׇהָלָ֔יו יִשְׂרָאֵ֖ל

“a man of & A man to his tents, Israel”

Here, **tents** represents homes or dwelling places. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Each of you return to his own home, you Israelites]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 20:2 (#2)

מֵאַחֲרֵ֣י דָּוִ֔ד אַחֲרֵ֖י שֶׁ֣בַע בֶּן־בִּכְרִ֑י

“from after David {to} after Sheba, the son of Bichri”

Here, the author is speaking as if people who followed either David or Sheba as their leader actually walked **after** or behind them. He means that the people stopped being loyal to David as their king and started being loyal to Sheba instead. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [with Sheba, the son of Bichri, as their leader rather than David]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 20:2 (#1)

וַיַּ֣עַל

“And & went up”

In keeping with what is usual for his language and culture, the author is marking travel for change in elevation with **went up**. If this expression contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [went] or [left there]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 20:2 (#3)

דָּבְק֖וּ

“clung”

The author is speaking as if the men of Judah had actually **clung** to David. He means that they remained loyal to him and supported his leadership. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [remained entirely loyal]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 20:2 (#4)

מִן־הַיַּרְדֵּ֖ן וְעַד־יְרוּשָׁלָֽם

“from the Jordan and to Jerusalem”

The author is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and they escorted him from the Jordan River area to Jerusalem]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 20:3 (#2)

וַאֲלֵיהֶם לֹא־בָבֶא

“but he did not go in to them”

The author is referring to sexual relations in a polite way by using the phrase **go in to them**. Depending on what is helpful in your language, you could use a polite way of referring to this in your language, or you could state this plainly. Alternate translation: [but he did not sleep with them]

See: Euphemism

2 Samuel 20:3 (#3)

אַלְמְנוּת חַיּוּת

“a widowhood of life”

The author is using as a common expression of his culture. This could mean: (1) Alternate translation: [and it was as if each was a widow, even though their husband had not died]; (2) Alternate translation: [and it was as if they were widows without a husband for the rest of their lives]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 20:3 (#1)

בֵּית־מִשְׁמֶֽרֶת

“in} a house of keeping”

The author is using the possessive form to describe a **house** or residence that was a place for **keeping** these women away from other people. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [in seclusion]

See: Possession

2 Samuel 20:4 (#1)

שְׁלֹשֶׁת יָמִים

“three days”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [Have them here in three days]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 20:4 (#2)

שְׁלֹשֶׁת יָמִים

“three days”

See how you translated the similar expression in 1:2. Alternate translation: [Have them here within two days]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 20:4 (#3)

וְאַתָּה פֹּה עֲמֹד

“And you, stand here”

David is stating the pronoun **you** separately, even though the verb translated as **stand** already includes this meaning. See how you translated the similar expression “you, you were” in 5:2. Alternate translation: [And lead them here personally]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 20:4 (#4)

וְאַתָּה פֹּה עֲמֹד

“And you, stand here”

David is not telling Amasa to **stand here** and not leave. He means that once Amasa has gone and summoned the Judean soldiers, he should **stand** or present himself to David along with them. The implication is that he is to present himself as their commander. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [And you, be present here as their commander] or [And it will be your responsibility to bring them here under your command]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 20:5 (#1)

אֶת־יְהוּדָה

“Judah”

Here, **Judah** represents the soldiers or fighting men of Judah. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the soldiers of Judah]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 20:5 (#2)

הַמּוֹעֵד

“the appointment”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **appointment**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [appointed time]

See: Abstract Nouns

2 Samuel 20:6 (#2)

אַתָּה קַח

“You, take”

See how you translated the similar expression “you, you know” in 17:20. Alternate translation: [For your part, take]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 20:6 (#5)

פֶּן־יָמְצָא לוֹ עָרִים בְּצָרוֹת וְהִצִּיל עֵינֵנוּ

“lest he find fortified cities for himself and remove our eyes”

David is using the word translated as **lest** to introduce an outcome that he does not want to happen. Because of this, he first gives Abishai the instruction to pursue Sheba, so that this will not happen. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that avoiding this outcome is the purpose of this instruction. Alternate translation: [Otherwise, he may find fortified cities for himself and remove our eyes]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

2 Samuel 20:6 (#3)

אֶת־עַבְדֵי אֲדֹנֶיךָ

“the servants of your lord”

Even though David is addressing Abishai directly, he is speaking of himself regally in the third person as **your lord**. Your language may have a regal form that it could use here. (For example, in some languages, kings and queens speak of themselves in the plural.) You could also use the first person. Alternate translation: [my servants]

See: First, Second or Third Person

2 Samuel 20:6 (#4)

אֶת־עַבְדֵי אֲדֹנֶיךָ

“the servants of your lord”

By **the servants of your lord**, David means the standing army that is under his direct command. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [my standing troops]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 20:6 (#6)

יָמְצָא לוֹ עָרִים בְּצָרוֹת וְהִצִּיל עֵינֵנוּ

“he find fortified cities for himself and remove our eyes”

David is describing one event, Sheba finding **fortified cities**, before describing another event that would precede it, Sheba figuratively removing the **eyes** of David and his servants. If it would be helpful your language, you may wish to relate these events in the order in which would happen. Alternate translation: [he remove our eyes and find fortified cities for himself]

See: Order of Events

2 Samuel 20:6 (#7)

וְהִצִּיל עֵינֵנוּ

“and remove our eyes”

David is speaking as if Sheba might actually **remove** his **eyes** and those of his soldiers so that they would not be able to see where he had gone. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. You could also use plain language. Alternate translation: [and we lose sight of where he has gone] or [and he go somewhere that we are not aware of]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 20:6 (#1)

לָנוּ

“us”

By **us**, David means to include both himself and Abishai, whom he is addressing, so use the inclusive form of that word if your language marks that distinction.

See: Exclusive and Inclusive ‘We’

2 Samuel 20:7 (#2)

וְהַכְּרֵתִי וְהַפְּלֵתִי

“and the Cherethites and the Pelethites”

See how you translated these names in 8:18 and 15:18.

See: How to Translate Names

2 Samuel 20:7 (#3)

וְכָל־הַגִּבֹּרִים

“and all of the warriors”

These seem to be the same men whom the author describes as "the Gittites" in 15:18. See what expression you used for them there.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 20:7 (#1)

אַנְשֵׁי יוֹאָב

"the men of Joab"

This expression probably refers to Joab's armor bearers or personal guard, whom the author describes as the "carriers of the weapons of Joab" in 18:15. Alternate translation: [Joab's armor bearers]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 20:7 (#4)

אַחֲרָיו

"after him"

The pronoun **him** refers to Abishai. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [after Abishai]

See: Pronouns

2 Samuel 20:7 (#5)

אַחֲרָיו

"after him"

The author is speaking as if these soldiers were all physically traveling **after** or behind Abishai. He means that they were under his command as their leader. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [with Abishai as their commander]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 20:8 (#4)

וְיוֹאָב חָגַר ׀ מִדּוֹ לְבֻשָׁתוֹ

"Now Joab was girded {with}his garment {as} his clothing"

The expression **was girded** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Now Joab was wearing his garment]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 20:8 (#11)

וַתִּפֹּל

"and it fell"

This could mean: (1) that the sword **fell** secretly into Joab's hand in a way that he contrived. Alternate translation: [and it fell secretly into his hand]; (2) that the sword **fell** to the ground without Amasa noticing and Joab picked it up secretly. Alternate translation: [and it fell unseen to the ground, where Joab secretly picked it up]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 20:8 (#3)

וְיוֹאָב חָגַר ׀ מִדּוֹ לְבֻשָׁתוֹ

"Now Joab was girded {with}his garment {as} his clothing"

It might seem that the expression **with his garment as his clothing** contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [Now Joab was girded with his garment]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 20:8 (#5)

מִדּוֹ

"with}his garment"

The author assumes that his readers will know that by **garment**, he means an article of clothing that was designed for soldiers to wear under armor. If you have already translated the book of 1 Samuel, see how you translated the similar expression in 1 Samuel 17:38. Alternate translation: [with his military tunic]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 20:8 (#7)

חֶרֶב

"a sword"

Since Joab was able to hold this **sword** in his hand without Amasa knowing it was there, it was probably a short sword. Your language may have a term for such a weapon that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [a dagger]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 20:8 (#10)

וַתִּפֹּל

"and it fell"

The author is speaking of this sword or dagger as if it had been a living thing that **fell** on its own. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and he let it fall]

See: Personification

2 Samuel 20:8 (#1)

וַעֲמָשָׂא בָּבָא לִפְנֵיהֶם

“and Amasa came to their faces”

Here, **to their faces** represents being in the presence of David’s soldiers. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and Amasa met them] or [and Amasa came before them]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 20:8 (#2)

וְיוֹאָב חָגוּר מַדּוֹ לְבֻשָׁשׁוֹ ועלו [וְעָלָיו] חֲגוֹר חֶרֶב מְצֻמֶּדֶת עַל־מָתְנָיו בְּתַעְרָהּ

“Now Joab was girded {with}his garment {as} his clothing, and on him {was} a belt of a sword strapped on his waist in its sheath”

Here, the author is providing background information to help readers understand what happens next in the story. In your translation, introduce this information in a way that would be natural in your own language and culture.

See: Background Information

2 Samuel 20:8 (#6)

ועלו [וְעָלָיו] חֲגוֹר חֶרֶב מְצֻמֶּדֶת עַל־מָתְנָיו בְּתַעְרָהּ

“and on him {was} a belt of a sword strapped on his waist in its sheath”

If it would be more natural in your language, you may want to put the information about **the sword** with the information about **its sheath**. Alternate translation: [and on him a belt was strapped around his waist holding a sword in its sheath]

See: Information Structure

2 Samuel 20:8 (#8)

וְהוּא יָצָא וַתִּפֹּל

“And he, he went out, and it fell”

The author is stating the pronoun **he** separately, even though the verb translated as **he went out** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that these two actions occurred at the same time. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for this same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing that the author is describing simultaneous actions. Alternate translation: [And as he went out, it fell] or [And he made it fall as he went out]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 20:8 (#9)

וְהוּא יָצָא

“And he, he went out”

The author means that Joab **went out** from the group of soldiers he was in and approached Amasa and the group of soldiers that he was leading. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [And he stepped forward]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 20:9 (#3)

וַתֹּאחֶז יַד־יְמִין יוֹאָב בִּזְקַן עֲמָשָׂא לִנְשָׁק־לוֹ

“And the right hand of Joab held onto the beard of Amasa to kiss him”

The author is speaking of **the right hand of Joab** as if it were a living thing that could hold onto Amasa’s beard. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And Joab held onto the beard of Amasa with his right hand so that he could kiss him]

See: Personification

2 Samuel 20:9 (#2)

אָחִי

“my brother”

This could mean: (1) that Joab is using the term **brother** to describe the close family relationship that he and Amasa have. The narrative indicates elsewhere that Joab’s mother and Amasa’s mother were sisters. Your language may have its own term or expression for this relationship. Alternate translation: [my cousin]; (2) that Joab is using the term **brother** as a term of endearment. Alternate translation: [my friend]

See: Kinship

2 Samuel 20:9 (#1)

הֲשָׁלוֹם אַתָּה

“Peace {to} you”

Joab is addressing Amasa with a polite greeting of his culture. (The term **Peace** has the sense of “well-being” here.) Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [How are you]

See: Politeness

2 Samuel 20:9 (#4)

לִנְשָׁק־לוֹ

“to kiss him”

Kissing Amasa was a symbolic action by which Joab pretended to show friendship and respect. He actually intended to get close to Amasa so he could kill him. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [to greet him with a kiss] or [to pretend friendship by giving him a kiss]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 20:10 (#2)

וְלֹא־שָׁנָה לוֹ

“and he did not do again to him”

The author is using the phrase **he did not do again to him** as a common expression of his culture to mean that Joab did not repeat the action of stabbing Amasa. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and he did not stab him a second time]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 20:10 (#1)

וַיַּכֵּהוּ֨ בָבָ֜ה אֶל־הַחֹמֶ֗שׁ וַיִּשְׁפֹּךְ֙ מֵעָ֣יו אַ֔רְצָה וְלֹא־שָׁנָ֥ה לוֹ֖ וַיָּמֹֽת

“And he struck him with it in the stomach, and his intestines poured out to the ground, and he did not do again to him, and he died”

If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use names instead of pronouns in order to clarify who did what to whom here. Alternate translation: [And Joab struck Amasa with the sword in the stomach, and Amasa’s intestines poured out to the ground, and Joab did not do again to Amasa, and Amasa died.]

See: Pronouns

2 Samuel 20:11 (#1)

עָלָ֔יו

“beside him”

The pronoun **him** refers to Amasa. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [beside Amasa]

See: Pronouns

2 Samuel 20:11 (#2)

אַחֲרֵי֙ יוֹאָ֔ב

“after Joab”

The man is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [go after Joab] or [follow Joab in pursuit of Sheba]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 20:12 (#2)

כַּאֲשֶׁ֤ר רָאָה֙ כָּל־הַבָּ֣א עָלָ֔יו וְעָמֹ֖ד

“because he saw everyone coming to him, that he stood”

If it would be more natural in your language, you may want to put the information that soldiers **stood** before the information that this happened as they were **coming** to where Amasa was. Alternate translation: [because he saw that everyone stopped when they came to him]

See: Information Structure

2 Samuel 20:12 (#3)

כַּאֲשֶׁ֤ר רָאָה֙ כָּל־הַבָּ֣א עָלָ֔יו וְעָמֹ֖ד

“because he saw everyone coming to him, that he stood”

It might seem that this statement provides extra information that would not be natural to express in your language, since it basically repeats what the author says in the first part of the verse. If so, you could present this information only once. The UST models one way to do that.

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 20:12 (#1)

הָאִ֔ישׁ

“the man”

The author assumes that his readers will know that by **the man**, he means the “man from the young man of Joab” whom he describes in the previous verse. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [the man from the young men of Joab]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 20:14 (#2)

בְּכָל־שִׁבְטֵ֥י יִשְׂרָאֵ֖ל

“through all of the tribes of Israel”

The author says **all of the tribes of Israel** as an overstatement for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [the territory of Israel all the way to its northern boundary]

See: Hyperbole

2 Samuel 20:14 (#3)

אָבֵ֣לָה וּבֵֽית־מַעֲכָ֑ה

“to Abel and Beth Maacah”

The phrase **Abel and Beth Maacah** identifies a single place. The name **Beth Maacah** tells which specific city of **Abel** this was, since there were several cities by that name in Israel. The author uses the expression “Abel Beth Maacah” in the next verse, and you may wish to use that name here as well. You could also reflect how the author is identifying this city. Alternate translation: [to the city of Abel, that is, the one in Beth Maacah]

See: Hendiadys

2 Samuel 20:14 (#6)

הַבִּרְי֖ים

“the Berites”

This could be the name of: (1) the people who lived in and around the city of Beroth in the tribe of Benjamin. They may have supported and accompanied Sheba since he was from their tribe. Alternate translation: [the soldiers from the area of Beroth]; (2) some other people group in northern Israel that is otherwise unknown. Alternate translation: [the soldiers of the Berite people group]

See: How to Translate Names

2 Samuel 20:14 (#5)

וְכָל־הַבִּרְי֖ים

“And all of the Berites”

The author says **all of the Berites** as a generalization. He is referring specifically to the fighting men among the Berites. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [And all of the Berite soldiers]

See: Hyperbole

2 Samuel 20:14 (#7)

וַיָּבֹ֖אוּ אַף־אַחֲרָֽיו

“and they also came after him”

The author is speaking as if the Berites actually **came after** their leader, Sheba, in the sense of physically following behind him. He means that they joined his cause and accepted his leadership. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and they were also following him as their leader]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 20:14 (#1)

וַיַּעֲבֹ֖ר בְּכָל

“And he passed through all of”

The pronoun **he** refers to Sheba. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [And Sheba passed through]

See: Pronouns

2 Samuel 20:14 (#4)

וְכָל־הַבִּרְי֖ים & ויקלהו וַיָּבֹ֖אוּ אַף־אַחֲרָֽיו

“And all of the Berites, now they gathered themselves, and they also came after him”

The author is providing background information to help readers understand what happens next in the story. Because Sheba had the support of these troops, Joab and his soldiers had to mount a protracted siege against the city he was in. In your translation, introduce this information in a way that would be natural in your own language and culture.

See: Background Information

2 Samuel 20:15 (#1)

וַיָּבֹאוּ

“And they came”

The pronoun **they** refers to Joab and his soldiers. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state this explicitly. Alternate translation: [And Joab and his soldiers came]

See: Pronouns

2 Samuel 20:15 (#2)

בַּחֵל

“against the rampart”

A **rampart** is a kind of defensive wall or fortification around a city, specifically in this context an outer wall of a city that also has an inner wall. If your readers would not be familiar with what a rampart is, you could use the name of a similar thing that your readers would recognize, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [against the outer wall]

See: Translate Unknowns

2 Samuel 20:16 (#1)

שִׁמְעָו שִׁמְעוּ

“Listen, listen”

The woman is repeating the verb **Listen** in order to intensify her expression of the idea that it conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [Do listen]

See: Reduplication

2 Samuel 20:16 (#2)

אִמְרוּ־נָא אֶל־יוֹאָב קְרַב עַד־הֵהֵנָּה וְאַדַּבְּרָה אֵלֶיךָ

“Please say to Joab, ‘Approach to here, and let me speak to you”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [Please ask Joab to come here so that I can speak to him]

See: Quotes within Quotes

2 Samuel 20:16 (#3)

אֵלֶיךָ

“to you”

If your language has a formal form of **you** that it uses to address a superior respectfully, it would be appropriate to use that form here.

See: Forms of ‘You’ — Formal or Informal

2 Samuel 20:17 (#4)

שֹׁמֵעַ אָנֹכִי

“I am listening”

Joab is using the present tense **I am listening** to describe something that is going to happen in the near future in order to show that it will indeed happen. In other words, he is agreeing to the woman’s request that he **Hear** what she has to say. If it would be clearer in your language, you could use the future tense or express the meaning in plain language. Alternate translation: [I will be listening] or [I agree to listen]

See: Irregular Use of Tenses

2 Samuel 20:17 (#2)

דִּבְרֵי אֲמָתֶךָ

“the words of your female servant”

The woman is using the term **words** to represent what she wants to say by using words. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [what your female servant has to say]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 20:17 (#3)

דִּבְרֵי אֲמָתֶךָ

“the words of your female servant”

The woman is speaking of herself in the third person as **your female servant** to show humility. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a humble form in the first person. Alternate translation: [what I, your female servant, have to say]

See: First, Second or Third Person

2 Samuel 20:17 (#1)

שְׁמַע

“Hear”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. Use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please hear]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

2 Samuel 20:18 (#6)

וְכֵ֥ן הֵתַּ֖מּוּ

“and thus they ended”

The woman is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and thus they ended their disputes]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 20:18 (#1)

דַּבֵּ֥ר יְדַבְּר֖וּ

“Speaking, they spoke”

The woman is repeating forms of the verb **spoke** in order to intensify her expression of the idea that it conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [They surely spoke]

See: Reduplication

2 Samuel 20:18 (#2)

בָּרִאשֹׁנָ֔ה

“in former {times”

The woman is using the adjective **former** as a noun to mean a certain kind of time. The ULT indicates this by supplying the word **times**. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [in the past]

See: Nominal Adjectives

2 Samuel 20:18 (#3)

לֵאמֹ֔ר שָׁאֹ֥ל יִשְׁאֲל֖וּ בְּאָבֵ֑ל

“saying, ‘Inquiring, they shall inquire at Abel”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [saying that inquiring, they should inquire at Abel] or [saying that they should certainly inquire at Abel]

See: Quotes within Quotes

2 Samuel 20:18 (#4)

שָׁאֹ֥ל יִשְׁאֲל֖וּ בְּאָבֵ֑ל

“Inquiring, they shall inquire at Abel”

The woman is repeating forms of the verb **inquire** in order to intensify her expression of the idea that it conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [They shall certainly inquire at Abel]

See: Reduplication

2 Samuel 20:18 (#5)

שָׁאֹ֥ל יִשְׁאֲל֖וּ בְּאָבֵ֑ל

“Inquiring, they shall inquire at Abel”

The woman is quoting a proverb in order to convince Joab that the people of Abel will be able to suggest a wise solution to the problem that has led Joab to put the city under siege. Translate this proverb in a way that will be recognized as a proverb and be meaningful in your language and culture.

See: Proverbs

2 Samuel 20:19 (#1)

אָנֹכִ֞י שְׁלֵמֵ֣י אֱמוּנֵ֗י יִשְׂרָאֵ֔ל

“I {am} pacified and faithful {ones} of Israel”

The woman is speaking on behalf of her city, saying what she believes it would say if it could talk about itself. She is actually speaking for herself and her fellow residents of the city. It may be more natural in your language to use a plural pronoun. Alternate translation: [We are pacified and faithful ones of Israel]

See: Personification

2 Samuel 20:19 (#4)

לְהָמִ֥ית

“to kill”

The woman is speaking of Abel Beth Maacah as if it were a living thing that Joab and his soldiers could **kill**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to destroy]

See: Personification

2 Samuel 20:19 (#2)

שְׁלֵמֵי אֱמוּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל

“am} pacified and faithful {ones} of Israel”

The woman is using the adjectives **pacified** and **faithful** as nouns to mean a certain kinds of people. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate these adjectives with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [pacified and faithful Israelites]

See: Nominal Adjectives

2 Samuel 20:19 (#6)

עִיר וְאֵם

“a city and a mother”

The woman is speaking of Abel Beth Maacah as if it were actually a **mother** in Israel. This was a common image of this culture, which described the towns and villages around a major city as its “daughters.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [an important city] or [a major city]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 20:19 (#7)

לָמָּה תְבַלַּע נַחֲלַת יְהוָה

“Why will you devour the inheritance of Yahweh”

The woman is using the question form to rebuke Joab. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [You should not devour the inheritance of Yahweh!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 20:19 (#9)

נַחֲלַת יְהוָה

“the inheritance of Yahweh”

The woman is speaking of the people of Israel as if they were something that Yahweh had inherited as a lasting possession. She is referring to the Israelites as the people who belong to Yahweh perpetually. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. See how you translated the similar expression in 14:16. Alternate translation: [so many of the people of Israel]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 20:19 (#3)

שְׁלֵמֵי

“am} pacified”

The expression **pacified** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [peaceable]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 20:19 (#5)

עִיר וְאֵם

“a city and a mother”

The phrase **city and a mother** expresses a single idea. The word **mother** tells what kind of **city** this is. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning in a different way. Alternate translation: [a mother-city] or [a metropolis]

See: Hendiadys

2 Samuel 20:19 (#8)

תְבַלַּע

“will you devour”

The wise woman is speaking as if Joab and his soldiers would actually **devour** or eat up Abel Beth Maacah. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [will you destroy]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 20:20 (#2)

חָלִלָה חָלִלָה לִי אִם־אֲבַלַּע וְאִם־אַשְׁחִית

“Profane, profane to me if I should devour or if I should destroy”

Joab is using a common expression of his culture to express his horror at the idea he describes. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. If you have already translated the book of 1 Samuel, see how you translated the similar expression in 1 Samuel 2:30. Alternate translation: [Far be it, far be it from me to devour or to destroy!]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 20:20 (#3)

חָלִלָה חָלִלָה לִי

“Profane, profane to me”

Joab is repeating the word **Profane** in order to intensify his expression of the idea that it conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [Absolutely profane to me] or [Be it far away from me]

See: Reduplication

2 Samuel 20:20 (#1)

וַיַּ֥עַן יוֹאָ֖ב וַיֹּאמַֽר

“And Joab answered and said”

The expression **and said** introduces a direct quotation. In your translation, use a natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language. It may not be necessary to represent this expression explicitly. Alternate translation: [And Joab responded]

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

2 Samuel 20:20 (#4)

אִם־אֲבַלַּ֥ע וְאִם־אַשְׁחִֽית

“if I should devour or if I should destroy”

These two phrases **if I should devour** and **if I should destroy** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [if I should completely destroy]

See: Parallelism

2 Samuel 20:21 (#1)

נָשָׂ֨א יָד֜וֹ בַּמֶּ֣לֶךְ

“has lifted his hand against the king”

See how you translated the similar expression in 18:21. Alternate translation: [has sought to harm the king]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 20:21 (#4)

רֹאשׁ֖וֹ מֻשְׁלָ֥ךְ

“his head will be thrown”

The expression **will be thrown** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [we will throw his head]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 20:21 (#3)

הִנֵּ֥ה

“Behold”

See how you translated the similar expression in 7:2. Alternate translation: [Listen]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 20:21 (#2)

וְאֵלֵ֖כָה מֵעַ֣ל הָעִ֑יר

“and let me go from the city”

Joab is using **me** to represent himself and his soldiers. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and let me and my soldiers go from the city] or [and let us go from the city]

See: Synecdoche

2 Samuel 20:22 (#3)

וַיִּתְקַ֣ע בַּשּׁוֹפָ֔ר וַיָּפֻ֖צוּ מֵעַל־הָעִ֑יר אִ֣ישׁ לְאׇהָלָ֔יו וְיוֹאָ֕ב שָׁ֖שָׁב יְרוּשָׁלַ֥͏ִם אֶל־הַמֶּֽלֶךְ

“And he blew on the shofar, and they dispersed from the city, a man to his tent. And Joab returned {to} Jerusalem, to the king”

The author is making a comment about what happened after the story as a result of the events within the story itself. This signals the end of the story. Use a natural form in your language for expressing the conclusion of a story.

See: End of Story

2 Samuel 20:22 (#4)

אִ֣ישׁ לְאׇהָלָ֔יו

“a man to his tent”

See how you translated the similar expression in 18:17. Alternate translation: [each one leaving the army and returning to his own home]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 20:22 (#1)

וַתָּבוֹא֩ הָאִשָּׁ֨ה

“And the woman came”

In a context such as this, your language might say "went" instead of **came**. Alternate translation: [And the woman went]

See: Go and Come

2 Samuel 20:22 (#2)

כָּל־הָעָם

"all of the people"

The author is saying **all of the people** as a generalization for emphasis. If it would be clearer in your language, you could express the emphasis in a different way. Alternate translation: [an assembly of the people]

See: Hyperbole

2 Samuel 20:23 (#1)

וְיוֹאָב אֶל כָּל־הַצָּבָא יִשְׂרָאֵל

"Now Joab {was} over all of the army of Israel"

See the discussion in the Introduction to this chapter of the list that begins here and continues to the end of the chapter.

See: Background Information

2 Samuel 20:23 (#2)

אֶל & עַל

"was} over & was} over"

Here, the author is speaking as if these commanders had stood physically **over** or above their troops. He means that they commanded them. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly, here and in the next verse. Alternate translation: [commanded ... commanded]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 20:24 (#1)

הַמַּזְכִּיר

"was} the recorder"

See how you translated the similar expression in 8:16. Alternate translation: [the royal secretary]

See: Translate Unknowns

2 Samuel 20:26 (#1)

כֹּהֵן

"a priest"

See how you translated the similar expression in 8:18. Alternate translation: [a chief official]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel - Chapter 21 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

The author seems to conclude his continuous account of what David did as king of Israel at the end of chapter 20. Chapters 21–24 then provide supplemental information. It is not clear at what point in David's reign the events they describe happened. These chapters are composed of six parts. Parts one and six match, parts two and five match, and parts three and four match. (This kind of pattern is called a "chiasm," and Hebrew writers considered it to be elegant.)

21:1–14 A famine, after which "God was entreated for the land." 21:15–22 An account of David's mighty men 22:1–51 A song by David about Yahweh's deliverance 23:1–7 A song by David about what a good ruler is like 23:8–39 An account of David's mighty men

In your translation, you may wish to put a break between 21:14 and 21:15 to show that this chapter contains two of the six parts of the supplemental information at the end of the book.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Famine caused a broken oath

When Israel first conquered the land, they promised not to kill the people of Gibeon. When Saul tried to kill them all, God caused a famine in Israel. David made amends with the people of Gideon and the famine ended. David also kept his vow to Jonathan's sons. This helps to show the wisdom of king David. Although these people were not Israelites, they believed in Yahweh. (See: oath, vow, swear, swearing, swear by, sworn; and wise, wisdom; and believe, believer, belief, unbeliever, unbelief)

Translation Issues in This Chapter

"struck"

In several places in this chapter, the author uses the term "struck" to mean "killed." See the discussion in the Introduction to 1 Samuel of this usage and see how you have been translating the term with this meaning throughout the book.

"Rapha"

In 21:16–22, the author refers several times to "the children of Rapha" or says that someone was "born to Rapha." He probably means that they were descendants of a people group whose members were very

tall. One way to represent the name Rapha would be to use the general term “giant.”

2 Samuel 21:1 (#6)

הַדָּמִ֖ים

“is} blood”

See how you translated the similar expression in 3:29. Alternate translation: [is guilt for murder]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 21:1 (#1)

וַיְהִ֥י רָעָ֛בׄ בִּימֵ֥י דָוִ֖ד

“Now {there} was a famine in the days of David”

The author is using the word translated **Now** to introduce a new event in the story. Use a word, phrase, or other method in your language that is natural for introducing a new event. Alternate translation: [At another time] or [During one period]

See: Introduction of a New Event

2 Samuel 21:1 (#4)

אֶל־שָׁא֥וּלׄ וְאֶל־בֵּ֖ית הַדָּמִ֑ים עַל־אֲשֶׁ֥ר־הֵמִ֖ית אֶת־הַגִּבְעֹנִֽים

“To Saul and to the house {is} blood, because he killed the Gibeonites”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Because Saul killed the Gibeonites, to him and to the house is blood]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

2 Samuel 21:1 (#5)

וְאֶל־בֵּיתֵֽ֖

“and to the house”

See how you translated the similar expression in 6:11. Alternate translation: [and to his household]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 21:1 (#2)

שָׁלֹ֣שׁ שָׁנִ֔ים שָׁנָ֖ה אַחֲרֵ֣י שָׁנָ֑ה

“three years, year after year”

The author is using the phrase **three years, year after year** as a common expression of his culture to mean “for three consecutive years.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [three years in a row] or [for three consecutive years]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 21:1 (#3)

וַיְבַקֵּ֥שׁ דָּוִ֖ד אֶת־פְּנֵ֣י יְהוָ֑ה

“And David sought the face of Yahweh”

The author is using the phrase **sought the face of** as a common expression in of his culture to mean “prayed to” or “asked guidance from.” In this case, David was praying to Yahweh about the cause of the famine. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And David inquired of Yahweh]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 21:2 (#4)

מִבְּנֵ֣י יִשְׂרָאֵ֔ל & לִבְנֵ֥י־יִשְׂרָאֵ֖ל וִיהוּדָֽה

“were & from the sons of Israel & for the sons of Israel and Judah”

The author is speaking as if the people of Israel and Judah were actually the **sons** of the patriarch Jacob, who was also known as Israel, and the patriarch Judah. If you have already translated the book of 1 Samuel, see how you translated the similar expression in 1 Samuel 2:28. Alternate translation: [the Israelites … the Israelites and Judeans]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 21:2 (#1)

לַגִּבְעֹנִֽים

“to the Gibeonites”

The author is saying **the Gibeonites** as a generalization. He does not mean that David spoke with the entire people group, but with some representatives of it. Alternate translation: [representatives of the Gibeonites]

See: Hyperbole

2 Samuel 21:2 (#5)

הָאֱמֹרִ֑י

“the Amorite”

The author is not referring to a specific **Amorite**. He means Amorites in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the Amorites]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

2 Samuel 21:2 (#2)

וְהַגִּבְעֹנִ֖ים לֹ֣א מִבְּנֵ֑י יִשְׂרָאֵ֗ל

“Now the Gibeonites {were} not from the sons of Israel”

Here, the author is providing background information to help readers understand what happens next in the story. In your translation, introduce this information in a way that would be natural in your own language and culture.

See: Background Information

2 Samuel 21:2 (#3)

וּבְנֵ֥י יִשְׂרָאֵ֛ל נִשְׁבְּעָ֥ו לָהֶ֖ם

“And the sons of Israel had sworn to them”

The author assumes that readers will know that the Israelites had sworn to protect the Gibeonites and not kill them, as recorded in Joshua 9. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [And the sons of Israel had sworn to them that they would spare their lives]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 21:2 (#6)

לְהַכֹּתָ֖ם

“to strike them”

See the discussion in the Introduction to this chapter of the term **strike** and its past form “struck,” which mean “kill” or “killed” here and in several other places in the chapter. Alternate translation: [to kill them]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 21:3 (#2)

וּבָרֵכְו֖

“then bless”

This is an imperative, but David is using it to confirm the response he could expect from the Gibeonites if he performed the actions he has just described. Use a form in your language that indicates this. Alternate translation: [that you would then bless]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

2 Samuel 21:3 (#3)

אֶת־נַחֲלַ֥ת יְהוָֽה

“the inheritance of Yahweh”

See how you translated the similar expression in 14:16. Alternate translation: [Yahweh’s people, Israel]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 21:3 (#1)

מָ֣ה אֶֽעֱשֶׂ֣ה לָכֶ֔ם וּבַמֶּ֥ה אֲכַפֵּ֖ר

“What shall I do for you, and with what shall I atone”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [How can I thoroughly make amends to you] or [What can I possibly do to make things right with you]

See: Parallelism

2 Samuel 21:4 (#3)

וְאֵין־לָ֤נוּ אִישׁ֙ לְהָמִ֣ית בְּיִשְׂרָאֵ֔ל

“And {there is} not for us a man to kill in Israel”

The Gibeonites could mean: (1) that there is not a **man** (that is, there is no one) in their people group who is authorized **to kill** anyone **in Israel**. In other words, since they apparently do not have the right to execute Israelites who may have committed capital crimes against them, they are indirectly introducing a request that David execute some of Saul’s descendants. (The next sentence shows that David recognizes they are asking something of him.) Alternate translation: [And we are not allowed to punish any Israelites by executing them]; (2) that the Gibeonites are making a generalization and they expect David to understand that it includes an exception. Alternate translation: [And we do not want to kill anyone in Israel except some of Saul’s descendants to avenge his crime against us]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 21:4 (#1)

אֵין־לִ֥י כֶ֛סֶף וְזָהָ֖ב עִם־שָׁא֑וּל וְעִם־בֵּיתֽוֹ

“There is} no silver or gold for us with Saul or with his house”

The Gibeonites are referring to all forms of payment by naming two major forms of money in this culture, **silver** and **gold**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [We will not accept any form of payment as compensation from Saul or from his house]

See: Merism

2 Samuel 21:4 (#2)

עִם־שָׁאוּל וְעִם־בֵּיתֹו

“with Saul or with his house”

See how you translated the similar expression in 1:12. Alternate translation: [with Saul, that is, with his descendants]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 21:5 (#1)

אֲשֶׁר כִּלָּנוּ וַאֲשֶׁר דִּמָּה־לָּנוּ נִשְׁמַדְנוּ מֵהִתְיַצֵּב בְּכָל־גְּבֻל יִשְׂרָאֵל

“who ended us and who intended against us {that} we should be destroyed from stationing ourselves in all of the border of Israel”

The Gibeonites are describing one event before describing another event that preceded it. If it would be helpful your language, you may wish to relate these events in the order in which they happened, as in the UST. Alternate translation: [who intended against us that we should be destroyed from stationing ourselves in all of the border of Israel and who then ended us]

See: Order of Events

2 Samuel 21:5 (#2)

נִשְׁמַדְנוּ

“that} we should be destroyed”

The expression **we should be destroyed** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [to destroy us]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 21:5 (#3)

מֵהִתְיַצֵּב

“from stationing ourselves”

The Gibeonites are using the common expression of their culture, **from stationing ourselves in all of the border of Israel**, to mean “from living anywhere in the territory of Israel.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from living anywhere]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 21:5 (#4)

גְּבֻל יִשְׂרָאֵל

“the border of Israel”

Here, **border** represents the territory of Israel, since that territory is defined by its border. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the territory of Israel]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 21:6 (#6)

אֲנִי אֶתֵּן

“I, I will give”

David is stating the pronoun **I** separately, even though the verb translated as **I will give** already includes this meaning. He is doing that because he is making a promise to the Gibeonites. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing that David is making a promise. It may not be necessary to represent the separately stated pronoun explicitly. Alternate translation: [I promise that I will give]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 21:6 (#2)

יִנָּתֶן־לָנוּ שִׁבְעָה אֲנָשִׁים מִבָּנָיו

“let seven men from his sons be given to us”

The expression **be given to us** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [give us seven men from his sons]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 21:6 (#3)

מִבָּנָיו

“from his sons”

Here, the Gibeonites are speaking as if Saul's **sons** were actually sons he had personally fathered. They mean his descendants, including grandsons and other male relatives. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from his male descendants]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 21:6 (#4)

לַיהוָֹה

"before Yahweh"

The Gibeonites are using the common expression of their culture **before Yahweh** to mean that Yahweh would witness their act of justice. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [where Yahweh can see that justice has been done]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 21:6 (#5)

בְּחִירֵ֣י יְהוָ֔ה

"the chosen of Yahweh"

The Gibeonites are using the adjective **chosen** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the one whom Yahweh chose to be king]

See: Nominal Adjectives

2 Samuel 21:6 (#1)

יִתְּנ־לָ֨נוּ שִׁבְעָ֤ה אֲנָשִׁים֙ מִבָּנָ֔יו וְהוֹקַעֲנֻ֖ם

"let seven men from his sons be given to us, and we will hang them"

The Gibeonites' request to **hang** Saul's descendants was a symbolic action by which they sought to avenge themselves on Saul's family and restore justice for the harm he had done to them. In this culture, **seven** was a number symbolic of completeness. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [let seven men from his sons be given to us, and we will execute them as a just consequence of Saul's crime against us]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 21:6 (#7)

אֲנִֽי־אֶתֵּֽן

"I, I will give"

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [I promise that I will give them to you]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 21:7 (#1)

שְׁבֻעַ֥ת יְהוָ֖ה

"the oath of Yahweh"

The author is using this possessive form to describe an **oath** that David swore to Jonathan by **Yahweh**. If a speaker of your language would not use a possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. This refers to the oath that Jonathan had David swear to him by Yahweh, as described in 1 Samuel 20:14–16, that he would not harm his descendants. Alternate translation: [the oath sworn in the name of Yahweh]

See: Possession

2 Samuel 21:8 (#1)

מִיכַ֔ל

"Michal"

The traditional Hebrew text reads "Michal." The ULT follows that reading. Some other Hebrew manuscripts and some manuscripts of the Septuagint (an ancient Greek translation) read "Merab." That was probably the original reading, since 1 Samuel 18:19 describes how it was Merab who married **Adriel** of Meholah, while the author says in 6:23 that Michal had no children. If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to use the reading that it uses. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to use the reading of the ULT.

See: Textual Variants

2 Samuel 21:9 (#7)

בִּימֵ֣י קָצִ֔יר בָּרִֽאשֹׁנִ֖ים

"in the days of the harvest, in the first {days"

It might seem that the expression **in the days of the harvest, in the first** contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If

so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [in the first days of the harvest]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 21:9 (#9)

בָּרִ֣אשֹׁנִ֔ים

“in the first {days”

The author is using the adjective **first** as a noun to mean a certain kind of day. The ULT shows that by supplying the term **days**. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [in the first part]

See: Nominal Adjectives

2 Samuel 21:9 (#1)

בְּיַ֣ד הַגִּבְעֹנִ֑ים

“into the hand of the Gibeonites”

In this verse, the word **hand** is singular in form, but it refers to all Gibeonites as a group. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use the plural form of “hand.” Alternate translation: [into the hands of the Gibeonites]

See: Collective Nouns

2 Samuel 21:9 (#3)

לִפְנֵ֥י יְהוָ֖ה

“to the face of Yahweh”

Here, **to the face of** represents being in the presence of Yahweh. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in the presence of Yahweh]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 21:9 (#4)

וַיִּפְּל֣וּ שבעתים

“and the seven of them fell”

Here, **fell** represents “died.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and the seven of them died]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 21:9 (#8)

בִּימֵ֣י קָצִ֔יר בָּרִ֖אשֹׁנִֽים

“in the days of the harvest, in the first {days”

Here the term **days** represents a certain time, since time is made up of days. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [at the start of the harvest time]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 21:9 (#10)

בָּרִ֣אשֹׁנִ֔ים

“in the first {days”

If your language would not represent a number in a form such as **first**, you could represent this number in a form that your language would use or with an equivalent term. Alternate translation: [in the starting days]

See: Ordinal Numbers

2 Samuel 21:9 (#5)

והם הֻמְתְּ֥ו

“And they, they were killed”

The author is stating the pronoun **they** separately, even though the verb translated as **they were killed** already includes this meaning. He is doing that in order to introduce background information. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for this same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing that the author is introducing background information. Alternate translation: [Now they were killed]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 21:9 (#2)

בְּיַ֣ד הַגִּבְעֹנִ֑ים

“into the hand of the Gibeonites”

Here, **hand** represents control or custody. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [into the custody of the Gibeonites]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 21:9 (#6)

והם הֻמְתְּ֥ו

“And they, they were killed”

The expression **were killed** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Now the Gibeonites killed them specifically]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 21:10 (#1)

וַתַּטֶּהָ֨ לָּ֜הּ אֶל־הַצּ֗וּר

“and she spread it for herself against a rock”

The author assumes that readers will know that Rizpah spread this sackcloth against a rock to make a shelter for herself while she guarded the bodies of her male relatives. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and she spread it for herself against a rock to make a shelter for herself]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 21:10 (#5)

נִתַּ֤ךְ־מַ֙יִם֙ עֲלֵיהֶ֔ם

“water was poured on them”

The expression **was poured** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it was Yahweh. Alternate translation: [rain fell on them] or [Yahweh poured rain on them]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 21:10 (#2)

מִתְּחִלַּ֥ת קְצִיר

“from the beginning of the harvest”

The author is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and she remained there from the beginning of the harvest]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 21:10 (#6)

לָנ֣וּחַ עֲלֵיהֶ֔ם

“to rest on them”

The implication is that the birds would **rest** or land on the dead bodies because they wanted to feed on them. You could indicate this in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [to feed on them]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 21:10 (#7)

וְאֶת־חַיַּ֥ת הַשָּׂדֶ֖ה לָ֥יְלָה

“or a beast of the field by night”

The author is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [or a beast of the field to feed on them by night]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 21:10 (#3)

עַ֚ד נִתַּ֣ךְ־מַ֔יִם עֲלֵיהֶ֖ם מִן־הַשָּׁמָ֑יִם

“until water was poured on them from the heavens”

Sending rain (**water**) from the sky (**the heavens**) was a symbolic action by which Yahweh showed that justice had been satisfied for the crime of Saul, which had been the cause of the three-year drought and famine. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [until Yahweh sent rain from the sky to show that justice had been satisfied for the crime of Saul]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 21:10 (#4)

נִתַּ֤ךְ־מַ֙יִם֙ עֲלֵיהֶ֔ם

“water was poured on them”

The word that the ULT translates in the singular as **water** (to match the singular verb **was poured**) is actually plural. In this plural form, in contexts such as this, it can mean “rain.” Alternate translation: [until rain was poured on them]

See: Unusual Uses of the Plural

2 Samuel 21:11 (#1)

וַיֻּגַּ֖ד לְדָוִֽד

“And it was declared to David”

The expression **it was declared** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way

that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [And someone declared to David]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 21:12 (#1)

אֲשֶׁר תלום שם הפלשתים

“where the Philistines had hanged them there”

It might seem that the expression **where the Philistines had hanged them there** contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [where the Philistines had hanged them]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 21:13 (#2)

הַמּוּקָעִים

“the hanged ones”

The expression **hanged ones** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the men who had been hanged]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 21:13 (#1)

וַיַּ֥עַל

“And he brought up”

See how you translated the similar expression in 2:1. Alternate translation: [And he brought]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 21:14 (#5)

אַחֲרֵי־כֵן

“after this”

By **this**, the author means that God responded to prayers for the land only after the Gibeonites had been avenged and Saul’s descendants had been properly buried. You could include this information in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [after the Gibeonites had hanged seven of Saul’s descendants]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 21:14 (#1)

אֶת־עַצְמוֹת־שָׁאוּל וְיהוֹנָתָן־בְּנֹו

“the bones of Saul and Jonathan his son”

The author is using **the bones of Saul and Jonathan his son** also to represent the bones of Saul’s male relatives whom the Gibeonites executed. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the bones of Saul and Jonathan his son and the hanged ones]

See: Synecdoche

2 Samuel 21:14 (#2)

וַיַּעֲשׂוּ כֹּכָל אֲשֶׁר־צִוָּה הַמֶּלֶךְ

“And they did all that the king commanded”

The implication is that the servants buried the bones at the king’s command. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [And they did all of this at the command of the king]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 21:14 (#3)

וַיֵּעָתֵר אֱלֹהִים לָאָרֶץ אַחֲרֵי־כֵן

“And God was entreated for the land after this”

The phrase **And God was entreated for the land after that** is a comment about what happened after the story as a result of the events within the story itself. This signals the end of a story. Use the natural form in your language for expressing the conclusion of a story.

See: End of Story

2 Samuel 21:14 (#4)

וַיֵּעָתֵר אֱלֹהִים לָאָרֶץ אַחֲרֵי־כֵן

“And God was entreated for the land after this”

The expression **was entreated** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [And the Israelites were able to entreat God for the land after this]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 21:15 (#1)

וַתְּהִי־עֹוד מִלְחָמָה לַפְּלִשְׁתִּים אֶת־יִשְׂרָאֵל

“Now war was to the Philistines again with Israel”

The author is using this phrase to introduce a new event in the story. Use a word, phrase, or other method in your language that is natural for introducing a new event.

See: Introduction of a New Event

2 Samuel 21:16 (#2)

וּמִשְׁקַל קֵינוֹ שְׁלֹשׁ מֵאוֹת מִשְׁקָל נְחֹשֶׁת

“and the weight of his spear {was} 300 {shekels} of bronze in weight”

It might seem that the expression **300 shekels of bronze in weight** contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [and the weight of his spear was 300 shekels of bronze]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 21:16 (#6)

וַיֹּאמֶר לְהַכּוֹת אֶת־דָּוִד

“and he said to strike David”

See how you translated the similar expression in 10:2. Alternate translation: [and he said to himself, “I will strike David”] or [and he thought he would strike David]

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

2 Samuel 21:16 (#1)

בִּילִידֵי הָרָפָה

“was} among the children of Rapha”

Here, the author is speaking of the **children of Rapha** as if Rapha were actually their physical father. He means they were among the descendants of Rapha, the group of giants called Raphaites. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly, here and in verses 18, 20, and 22. Alternate translation: [was one of the descendants of Rapha] or [was a Raphaite]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 21:16 (#3)

שְׁלֹשׁ מֵאוֹת & נְחֹשֶׁת

“was} 300 {shekels} of bronze”

These 300 **shekels of bronze** equaled about 3 ½ kilograms or nearly 8 pounds. In your translation, you could use the ancient measurement and spell the word “shekel” the way it sounds in your language. You could also use the metric measurement given in the UST or use the measurement that your language and culture customarily use. Alternatively, you could use the ancient measurement and put a modern measurement in parentheses in the text or in a footnote.

See: Biblical Weight

2 Samuel 21:16 (#4)

וְהוּא חָגוּר חֲדָשָׁה

“and he was girded {with} a new {weapon”

The expression **was girded** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and he was bearing a new weapon]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 21:16 (#5)

חֲדָשָׁה

“with} a new {weapon”

The traditional Hebrew text simply says “new.” The ULT seeks to show what that reading might mean. Some versions are more specific and say “a new sword” or “new armor.” The Septuagint (an ancient Greek translation) has a term that means “a club” or “a mace” (a club with an iron coating or head). This suggests that the original text could have named some rare but formidable weapon whose name was not preserved exactly in the traditional text. (The context suggests that Ishbi Benob believed he could kill David because he had such a weapon.) If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to use the reading that it uses. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to use the reading of the ULT.

See: Textual Variants

2 Samuel 21:17 (#1)

וְלֹא תְכַבֶּה אֶת־נֵר יִשְׂרָאֵל

“so you do not extinguish the lamp of Israel”

David’s men are speaking of him as if he were a **lamp** providing light for Israel. They mean that he was Israel’s leader who guided them as a lamp would light the way on a path. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [so you do not die and leave Israel without its leader] or [so you do not end your leadership of Israel]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 21:18 (#1)

בְּגֹ֔וב

“at Gob”

The traditional Hebrew text reads “Gob” here. The ULT follows that reading. However, a place called Gob is otherwise not known. The Septuagint (an ancient Greek translation) reads “Gath.” The parallel passage in 1 Chronicles 20:4 reads “Gezer.” So there is some doubt as to the actual name of this place. If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to use the reading that it uses. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to use the reading of the ULT.

See: Textual Variants

2 Samuel 21:19 (#2)

יַעְרֵ֣י אֹרְגִ֔ים

“Jaare Oregim”

The traditional Hebrew text reads “Jaare Oregim” here. The ULT follows that reading. The parallel passage in 1 Chronicles 20:5 reads “Jair.” That may have been the original reading, since the word “oregim” means “weavers” and occurs later in the verse. It may have accidentally been copied here. If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to use the reading that it uses. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to use the reading of the ULT.

See: Textual Variants

2 Samuel 21:19 (#3)

אֵ֚ת גָּלְיָ֣ת הַגִּתִּ֔י

“Goliath the Gittite”

The traditional Hebrew text reads “Goliath the Gittite” here. The ULT follows that reading. The parallel passage in 1 Chronicles 20:5 reads “the brother of Goliath the Gittite.” That may have been the original reading, since 1 Samuel 17:1–51 describes how it was actually David who killed Goliath the Gittite. If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to use the reading that it uses. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to use the reading of the ULT.

See: Textual Variants

2 Samuel 21:19 (#1)

וַיַּ֨ךְ & אֵ֚ת גָּלְיָ֣ת הַגִּתִּ֔י וְעֵ֖ץ חֲנִיתֹ֑ו כִּמְנֹ֥ור אֹרְגִֽים

“And & struck Goliath the Gittite, and the wood of his spear {was} like the beam of weavers”

If it would be more natural in your language, you may want to put the information about the thickness of **the wood of his spear** before the information that Elhanan struck **Goliath the Gittite**. In some languages, that might help emphasize the strength and courage of Elhanan, which the author wishes to highlight here. Alternate translation: [fought Goliath the Gittite. Even thought the wood of his spear {was} like the beam of weavers, Elhanan struck him]

See: Information Structure

2 Samuel 21:19 (#4)

כִּמְנֹ֥ור אֹרְגִֽים

“was} like the beam of weavers”

A **beam of weavers** was the thick, strong beam on which weavers hung their fabric. If your readers would not be familiar with this, in your translation you could use the name of a similar thing that your readers would recognize, or you could use a general expression. If you have already translated the book of 1 Samuel, see how you translated the similar expression in 1 Samuel 17:7. Alternate translation: [was like the thick, strong beam on which weavers hang their fabric]

See: Translate Unknowns

2 Samuel 21:20 (#3)

שֵׁ֣שׁ וָשֵׁ֔שׁ עֶשְׂרִ֖ים וְאַרְבַּ֣ע מִסְפָּ֑ר

“were} six and six, 24 {in} number”

The author is repeating the information about the number of digits that this **man of stature had**, presenting it in two different forms to emphasize how striking it is. You may find it appropriate to repeat the information in your translation in order to convey that emphasis, even if this would otherwise be extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. Alternate translation: [were 6 and 6, for a total of 24 digits in all]

See: Reduplication

2 Samuel 21:20 (#1)

אִ֣ישׁ מדין

“a man of stature”

The author is using the possessive form to describe a **man** who was characterized by great **stature** or height. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [a very tall man]

See: Possession

2 Samuel 21:20 (#2)

וְאֶצְבְּעֹ֣ת יָדָ֔יו וְאֶצְבְּעֹ֥ת רַגְלָ֖יו שֵׁ֣שׁ וָשֵׁ֑שׁ

“and the digits of his hands and the digits of his feet {were} six and six”

If it would be more natural in your language, you may want to put the number of each type of digit with the name of each body part. Alternate translation: [and he had six fingers on each hand and six toes on each foot]

See: Information Structure

2 Samuel 21:20 (#4)

וְגַם־הוּא֙ יֻלַּ֣ד לְהָרָפָ֔ה

“And he also was born to Rapha”

The expression **was born** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [And he too was a descendant of Rapha]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 21:21 (#1)

יְהוֹנָתָ֖ן בֶּן־שִׁמְעִ֣י אֲחִ֥י דָוִֽד

“Jonathan, the son of Shimeah, the brother of David”

Shimeah, not **Jonathan**, was **the brother of David**. You may have kinship terms that you can use to make this clear in your translation. Alternate translation: [Jonathan son of Shimeah, the nephew of David]

See: Kinship

2 Samuel 21:22 (#4)

בְּיַד־דָּוִ֥ד וּבְיַד֙ עֲבָדָ֔יו

“by the hand of David and by the hand of his servants”

The author is crediting David in part with these victories because he commanded the Israelite soldiers who won them. But he is then crediting the specific **servants** or soldiers who defeated these giant opponents. If the connection between the first part of this phrase and the second part is not clear, you may want to use a different connecting word or phrase to show how the parts relate to one another. Alternate translation: [by the hand of David, and specifically, by the hands of his servants]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

2 Samuel 21:22 (#1)

יֻלְּד֖וּ לְהָרָפָ֑ה בְּגַ֖ת

“were born to Rapha in Gath”

The expression **were born** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [were descendants of Rapha in Gath]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 21:22 (#2)

וַיִּפְּלוּ֙ בְּיַד־דָּוִ֔ד וּבְיַ֖ד עֲבָדָֽיו

“And they fell by the hand of David and by the hand of his servants”

Here, **hand** represents the power and capability of David and his servants to defeat these enemies. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And they fell by the might of David and by the power of his servants]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 21:22 (#3)

וַיִּפְּלוּ֙ בְּיַד־דָּוִ֔ד וּבְיַ֖ד עֲבָדָֽיו

“And they fell by the hand of David and by the hand of his servants”

Here the term **fell** means “died”. Alternate translation: [And they died at the hands of David and his servants] or [And it was David and his servants who killed them]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel - Chapter 22 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter continues the supplemental information about David’s reign as king of Israel that the author provides at the end of the book. It is the third part of that information, a song by David about Yahweh’s deliverance.

Some translations set each line of poetry farther to the right than the rest of the text to make it easier to read. The ULT does this with the words of this song in 22:2–51.

This song is also recorded in the Bible as Psalm 18. That shows that the people of Israel used it in their own worship after David had composed and sung it.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

Hebrew poetry
The verses of this song by David continually present two phrases that mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and it would be good to show this to your readers in many cases by including both phrases in your translation rather than combining them. If you do that, it may be clearer in your language to connect the phrases with a word other than "and" in order to show that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. But you may find that in some cases it is appropriate to combine the two phrases. For example:

- both phrases

22:24 And I have been blameless toward him, and I have kept myself from my iniquity. "And I have been blameless toward him, yes, I have kept myself from my iniquity."

22:22 For I have kept the ways of Yahweh, and I have not been wicked from my God. "For I have kept the ways of Yahweh, no, I have not been wicked from my God."

- combined into one

22:7 In my distress I called {to} Yahweh, and to my God I called "In my distress I called out to Yahweh, my God"

Extended metaphor
In verses 8–15, David describes Yahweh coming to help him as being like the greatest natural forces that people of his culture knew, which were an earthquake (verse 8), a volcano (verse 9), and a thunderstorm (verses 10–15). He describes each of these forces in poetic language. In other words, after stating his topic, which is how Yahweh delivered him (verse 7), David then depicts it with multiple images that communicate multiple ideas. Think about how you might show in your translation that verses 8–15, while describing three different things, all illustrate the same topic.

2 Samuel 22:1 (#3)

מִכַּף כָּל־אֹיְבָיו וּמִכַּף שָׁאוּל

"from the palm of all of his enemies and from the palm of Saul"

Here, **palm** represents power or control. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from the power of all of his enemies and from the power of Saul]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 22:1 (#2)

בְּיוֹם

"on the day"

David is using the term **day** to refer to a specific time. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [at the time when]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 22:1 (#1)

וַיְדַבֵּר דָּוִד לַיהוָה אֶת־דִּבְרֵי הַשִּׁירָה הַזֹּאת

"And David spoke to Yahweh the words of this song"

In this verse, David is introducing the song that follows in the rest of the chapter. Use a word, phrase, or other method in your language that would be natural for introducing a long quotation of someone's writing with the story of that person's life. Alternate translation: [Here are the words to a song that David sang to Yahweh]

See: Introduction of a New Event

2 Samuel 22:2 (#1)

סַלְעִי וּמְצָדָתִי וּמְפַלְטִי

"is} my rock and my stronghold and my deliverer"

This verse says basically the same thing as the previous verse. See the discussion in the Introduction to this chapter of how Hebrew poetry was based on the repetition of words, phrases, and ideas. Decide as a team how you will represent Hebrew poetry in your translation.

See: Parallelism

2 Samuel 22:2 (#2)

יְהוָה סַלְעִי וּמְצָדָתִי

"Yahweh {is} my rock and my stronghold"

The terms **rock** and **stronghold** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [Yahweh is the place where I go for safety]

See: Doublet

2 Samuel 22:2 (#3)

יְהוָה סַלְעִי וּמְצָדָתִי

“Yahweh {is} my rock and my stronghold”

David is speaking here of **Yahweh** as if he were a **rock** and a **stronghold**. He means that Yahweh provides safety and protection for him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Yahweh is the one who keeps me safe]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 22:2 (#4)

וּמְפַלְטִי־לִי

“and my deliverer, mine”

David is saying both **my** and **mine** in order to intensify his expression of the idea that Yahweh is his **deliverer**. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [and my sure deliverer]

See: Reduplication

2 Samuel 22:3 (#6)

וְקֶרֶן יִשְׁעִי

“and the horn of my salvation”

David is speaking of God’s power to save him as if it were a powerful **horn** of an animal. A horn was a symbol of strength in ancient Israelite culture because animals use their horns as weapons. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and the one who saves my by his power]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 22:3 (#1)

אֱלֹהֵי צוּרִי

“God of my rock”

David is using the possessive form to describe **God** as characterized by the quality he represents with the image of a **rock**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [God who is my rock]

See: Possession

2 Samuel 22:3 (#7)

מִשְׂגַּבִּי וּמְנוֹסִי

“my stronghold and my refuge”

The words that the ULT translates as **stronghold** and **refuge** here are not the same words in the original that it translates as “stronghold” in the previous verse and **take refuge** earlier in this verse. Hebrew had more synonyms for these ideas than some other languages may have. It may be necessary for you to use the same words rather than different ones. However, if you do have a variety of terms for these ideas, it would be appropriate to use different words here than were used in the previous ones.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 22:3 (#9)

מִשְׂגַּבִּי וּמְנוֹסִי

“my stronghold and my refuge”

David is speaking of Yahweh as if he were a **stronghold** and **refuge**, places where people could go to be safe from their enemies. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the one who keeps me completely safe]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 22:3 (#10)

מֵחָמָס תּוֹשִׁיעֵנִי

“you save me from violence”

David says in 22:1 that David sang this song “to Yahweh.” Here and later in the song, especially in verses 26–44 and 49–51, David addresses Yahweh directly as “you.” However, in the rest of the song, he speaks of Yahweh in the third person, saying “he,” “him,” and “his.” If it would be more natural in your language, you could use either the second person or the third person consistently throughout the song. The UST models one way to use the second person consistently. If you took the other approach, you could use the third person here and later in the song. Alternate translation: [he saves me from violence]

See: First, Second or Third Person

2 Samuel 22:3 (#2)

אֱלֹהֵי צוּרִי

“God of my rock”

David is speaking of God as if he were a high **rock** that he could climb up to reach safety from danger. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [God who is like a rock to me]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 22:3 (#4)

מָגִנִּי

“my shield”

Here David is speaking of Yahweh as if he were a **shield** that protected him from attack. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my protector]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 22:3 (#5)

וְקֶרֶן יִשְׁעִי

“and the horn of my salvation”

David is using the possessive form to describe a **horn** that is characterized by providing **salvation**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and the horn that saves me]

See: Possession

2 Samuel 22:3 (#8)

מִשְׂגַּבִּי וּמְנוֹסִי

“my stronghold and my refuge”

The terms **stronghold** and **refuge** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [my strong refuge]

See: Doublet

2 Samuel 22:3 (#11)

מֵחָמָס תּוֹשִׁיעֵנִי

“you save me from violence”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **violence**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [you keep violent people from harming me]

See: Abstract Nouns

2 Samuel 22:3 (#3)

אֶחֱסֶה־בּוֹ

“I take refuge in him”

David is speaking of **taking refuge** in God as if God were a place of safety in which he could hide. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I can depend on him to keep me safe]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 22:4 (#1)

מְהֻלָּל אֶקְרָא יְהוָה

“To} the one being praised I call, {to} Yahweh”

The expression **being praised** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [I call to Yahweh, the one whom people praise] or [I call to Yahweh, the one whom I praise]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 22:4 (#2)

וּמֵאוֹיְבַי אִוָּשֵׁעַ

“and I am saved from my enemies”

The expression **I am saved** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and he saves me]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 22:5 (#2)

אֲפָפֻנִי מִשְׁבְּרֵי־מָוֶת

“the waves of death surrounded me”

David is speaking of death as if it were a flood with powerful **waves** that could surround and overwhelm him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I was in danger of being killed and did not know how to escape]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 22:5 (#3)

נַחֲלֵי בְלִיַּעַל יְבַעֲתֻנִי

“the torrents of wickedness terrified me”

David speaks here of **torrents of wickedness** as if wickedness were a flood of rushing water that could overwhelm and destroy him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [a wicked person was pursuing me relentlessly, and that terrified me]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 22:5 (#1)

כִּֽי

“For”

Here the word **For** introduces not a reason but a description of how Yahweh saved David from his enemies. If it would be clearer in your language, you could use a different connecting word. Alternate translation: [You see,] or [Indeed,]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

2 Samuel 22:6 (#2)

חֶבְלֵי שְׁאוֹל סַבְּבֻנִי

“The cords of Sheol surrounded me”

David is speaking as if Sheol or death actually had **cords** that it could use to bind him. This suggests he felt trapped in a situation where he thought he would die. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. You could also use plain language. Alternate translation: [I thought I was bound to die]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 22:6 (#1)

חֶבְלֵי שְׁאוֹל סַבְּבֻנִי

“The cords of Sheol surrounded me”

Here, **Sheol**, the abode of the dead according to Hebrew culture, represents death itself. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [The cords of death surrounded me]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 22:6 (#3)

קִדְּמֻנִי מֹקְשֵׁי־מָֽוֶת

“the snares of death confronted me”

David speaks here of **snares of death** as if death were a hunter that could set traps for people. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. You could also use plain language. Alternate translation: [death had me in its clutches]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 22:7 (#3)

מֵֽהֵיכָלוֹ֙

“from his temple”

By **his temple**, David means God’s temple in heaven. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [from his heavenly temple]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 22:7 (#2)

וַיִּשְׁמַ֥ע & קוֹלִֽי

“And he heard my voice”

See how you translated the similar expression with “listen” in 12:18. Alternate translation: [And he granted my request]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 22:7 (#4)

וְשַׁוְעָתִ֥י בְּאָזְנָֽיו

“and my cry {was} in his ears”

David is using the term **ears** to mean hearing. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and my cry was in his hearing] or [and he heard my cry]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 22:7 (#1)

וַיִּשְׁמַ֥ע & קוֹלִֽי

“And he heard my voice”

Here, **voice** represents what David used his voice to say in his prayer. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [And he heard my prayer]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 22:8 (#5)

מוֹסְדוֹת הַשָּׁמַ֖יִם

“The foundations of the heavens”

David assumes that people listening to this song will recognize, according to the understanding of this culture, that the phrase **the foundations of the heavens** refers to solid places on which the sky rested. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [The bases on which the sky rests]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 22:8 (#3)

וַתִּרְעַשׁ֥שׁ הָאָ֖רֶץ

“Then the earth shook and trembled”

The terms **shook** and **trembled** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [Then the earth shook violently]

See: Doublet

2 Samuel 22:8 (#1)

וַתִּרְעַשׁ֥שׁ הָאָ֖רֶץ מוֹסְדוֹת֙ הַשָּׁמַ֔יִם יִרְגְּע֖וּ וַיִּתְגָּעֲשְׁשׁ֑וּ כִּֽי־חָרָ֖ה לֽוֹ׃

“Then the earth shook and trembled. The foundations of the heavens quaked and shook themselves, because it burned to him”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Then, because it burned to him, the earth shook and trembled. The foundations of the heavens quaked and shook themselves]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

2 Samuel 22:8 (#2)

וַיִּתְגָּעֲשְׁשׁ֑וּ & הָאָ֖רֶץ & וַתִּרְעַשׁ֥שׁ

“Then the earth shook & and shook themselves”

The terms that the ULT translates as **shook** and **shook themselves** represent two different verbs in the original. Hebrew had more synonyms for this idea, which David also expresses with the verbs translated as **trembled** and **quaked**, than some other languages may have. It may be necessary for you to use the same words rather than different ones. However, if you do have a variety of terms for this, it would be appropriate to use different words for **shook** and **shook themselves**.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 22:8 (#4)

וַתִּרְעַשׁ֥שׁ הָאָ֖רֶץ

“Then the earth shook and trembled”

David is speaking as if the **earth** were actually a person who could shake and tremble with fear. This expresses how powerfully God responded to David’s prayer. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Then it was as though a violent earthquake occurred]

See: Personification

2 Samuel 22:8 (#6)

יִרְגְּע֖וּ וַיִּתְגָּעֲשְׁשׁ֑וּ

“quaked and shook themselves”

The terms **quaked** and **shook themselves** mean similar things. David is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [quaked mightily]

See: Doublet

2 Samuel 22:8 (#7)

חָרָ֖ה לֽוֹ׃

“it burned to him”

See how you translated the similar expression in 6:8. Alternate translation: [he became very angry]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 22:9 (#1)

עָלָ֣ה עָשָׁ֣ן בְּאַפּ֔וֹ וְאֵ֥שׁ מִפִּ֖יו תֹּאכֵ֑ל גֶּחָלִ֖ים בָּעֲרָ֥ו מִמֶּֽנּוּ

“Smoke went up from his nose, and fire from his mouth devoured. Coals from him burned”

David is saying that when Yahweh came to help him, Yahweh’s power was so great that it was like a volcano. A volcano is an opening in the earth through which gases, smoke-like ash, and very hot, liquid rock come out. The rock can cool and build up over time to form a hill or mountain. David is describing the opening at the top of a volcano, from which **Smoke** and **fire** and **Coals** come out, as if it were the **nose** and **mouth** of the volcano. If your readers would be familiar with what a volcano is, you could express in your translation how David is using a volcano as an image to describe Yahweh’s power. If your readers would not be familiar with what a volcano is, you could

describe in more general terms how Yahweh's power is like fire and smoke.

See: Translate Unknowns

2 Samuel 22:9 (#2)

תֹּאכֵֽל

"devoured"

David is speaking of the fire that comes from a volcano, which represents God here, as if it were a wild animal that **devoured** its prey. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and fire from his mouth completely destroyed everything] or [and fire from his mouth consumed everything]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 22:10 (#1)

וַיֵּ֣ט שָׁמַ֔יִם וַיֵּ֖רֶד וַעֲרָפֶ֥ל תַּחַ֖ת רַגְלָֽיו

"And he lowered the heavens, and he came down, and a dark cloud {was} under his feet"

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [And he came standing on a dark cloud, and thus he lowered the heavens]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

2 Samuel 22:11 (#1)

וַיִּרְכַּ֣ב עַל־כְּרוּב֮ וַיָּעֹ֒ף

"And he rode on a cherub, and he flew"

The phrase **rode and flew** expresses a single idea. The word **flew** tells more about how he **rode**. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning in a different way. Alternate translation: [And he flew by riding on a cherub]

See: Hendiadys

2 Samuel 22:11 (#3)

וַיֵּרָ֖א עַל־כַּנְפֵ֥י־רֽוּחַ

"He was seen on the wings of the wind"

The expression **was seen** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [He appeared on the wings of the wind]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 22:11 (#4)

וַיֵּרָ֖א עַל־כַּנְפֵ֥י־רֽוּחַ

"He was seen on the wings of the wind"

David is speaking as if the wind actually had **wings** and that it could fly through the sky carrying Yahweh. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [It appeared as if the wind were a great bird that was carrying him]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 22:11 (#2)

וַיִּרְכַּ֣ב עַל־כְּרוּב֮ וַיָּעֹ֒ף

"And he rode on a cherub, and he flew"

David is speaking as if God were actually riding on a **cherub** and flying through the sky. This is part of a poetic description of God's power and swift action to help David. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And he came very quickly]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 22:12 (#1)

וַיָּ֤שֶׁת חֹ֙שֶׁךְ

"And he set darkness"

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context here if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [And he set darkness as his shelter]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 22:12 (#3)

חֲשֵׁרַת־מַ֑יִם עָבֵ֖י שְׁחָקִֽים

"were} a gathering of waters, clouds of the skies"

The phrases **a gathering of waters** and **clouds of the skies** mean similar things. David is using the two phrases together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [were rainclouds thick with water] or [were clouds that had collected water]

See: Doublet

2 Samuel 22:12 (#2)

וַיָּ֫שֶׁת חֹ֥שֶׁךְ

“And he set darkness”

David is speaking as if the darkness were actually **set** like a physical object that could be arranged in place. He means that God caused darkness to surround himself. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [It was as if he were dwelling within the darkness of the storm]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 22:13 (#2)

בָּעֲרוּ גַּחֲלֵי־אֵֽשׁ

“coals of fire burned”

Since David says that these **coals of fire** came **From** this **brightness**, he does not mean that they **burned** in place where they were. He means that they came burning forth. Within the image of a thunderstorm, he is referring to flashes of lightning. Alternate translation: [streaks of flame came out]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 22:13 (#1)

נֶגְדּ֖וֹ

“before him”

Here, **before him** represents being in God’s presence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in his presence]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 22:15 (#2)

וַיְפִיצֵ֑ם & ויהמם

“and he scattered them & and he panicked them”

The pronoun **them** refers in each instance to David’s enemies. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [and he scattered my enemies ... and he panicked those enemies]

See: Pronouns

2 Samuel 22:15 (#3)

בָּרָ֖ק

“lightning”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [yes, he sent out lightning]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 22:15 (#1)

וַיִּשְׁלַ֥ח חִצִּ֖ים וַיְפִיצֵ֑ם בָּרָ֖ק ויהמם

“And he sent out arrows, and he scattered them, lightning, and he panicked them”

Here David is using an image within an image. Within the image of a thunderstorm that represents Yahweh coming powerfully to help him, David speaks of lightning bolts as if they were **arrows**. You might be able to clarify this by combining the two parts of this verse, which mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [And he sent out lightning bolts like arrows and panicked them so that they scattered]

See: Parallelism

2 Samuel 22:16 (#1)

וַיֵּרָא֞וּ אֲפִ֣יקֵי יָ֗ם יִגָּלְל֛וּ מֹסְדֹ֥ות תֵּבֵ֖ל בְּגַעֲרַ֣ת יְהוָ֑ה מִנִּשְׁמַ֖ת רִ֥וחַ אַפֹּֽו

“And the channels of the sea were seen, the foundations of the world were uncovered, at the rebuke of Yahweh, from the blast of the breath of his nose”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [And at the rebuke of Yahweh, from the blast of the breath of his nose, the channels of the sea were seen, the foundations of the world were uncovered]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

2 Samuel 22:16 (#2)

וַיֵּרָא֞וּ אֲפִ֣יקֵי יָ֗ם יִגָּלְל֛וּ מֹסְדֹ֥ות תֵּבֵ֖ל

“And the channels of the sea were seen, the foundations of the world were uncovered”

The expressions **were seen** and **were uncovered** are passive verbal forms. If your language would not use those forms, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [And the channels of the sea became visible; ground no longer covered the foundations of the world]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 22:17 (#2)

מִמָּרוֹם

“from the height”

Here, **height** represents “heaven” as God’s dwelling place. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [from heaven]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 22:17 (#3)

מִמַּיִם רַבִּים

“out of many waters”

Here, **many waters** represents the sea, since the sea contains much water. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [out of the sea]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 22:17 (#1)

יִשְׁלַח

“He stretched out”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [He stretched out his hand]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 22:17 (#4)

מִמַּיִם רַבִּים

“out of many waters”

Here, **many waters**, meaning the sea, represents deep trouble or dangerous situations. David uses this image because he had earlier described his enemies as dangerous flood waters. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [out of great trouble]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 22:18 (#1)

יַצִּילֵנִי מֵאֹיְבִי עָזּוֹ מִשֹּׂנְאַי כִּי אָמְצוּ מִמֶּנִּי

“He delivered me from my strong enemy, from the ones hating me, for they were stronger than me”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Because they were stronger than me, he delivered me from my strong enemy, from the ones hating me]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

2 Samuel 22:19 (#1)

בְּיוֹם אֵידִי

“on the day of my calamity”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **calamity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [on a day that would have been disastrous for me]

See: Abstract Nouns

2 Samuel 22:20 (#1)

וַיֹּצִיאֵנִי לַמֶּרְחָב אֹתִי

“And he brought me out to an open space”

Here David is speaking of being rescued as if he had been squeezed into a narrow space and God brought him out to an **open space**. The image suggests that David had been in a dangerous situation with no way to escape, but God enabled him to escape. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And he set me free from danger] or [And he rescued me from my desperate situation]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 22:20 (#2)

יְחַלְּצֵנִי כִּי־חָפֵץ בִּי

“He delivered me because he delighted in me”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase **delivered me** describes. Alternate translation: [Because he delighted in me, he delivered me]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

2 Samuel 22:21 (#3)

יָשִׁיב לִי

“he has given back to me”

David is using **he has returned to me** as a common expression of his culture to mean “he has treated me in the same way.” If this phrase does not have that

meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he has treated me in the same way]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 22:21 (#1)

כְּצִדְקָתִ֔י

“according to my righteousness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way, here and in verse 25. Alternate translation: [according to the way I had been righteous]

See: Abstract Nouns

2 Samuel 22:21 (#2)

כְּבֹ֥ר יָדַ֖י

“According to the cleanness of my hands”

David is speaking of his actions as if they were his **hands**, which could be physically clean or dirty. He means that his behavior has been morally pure. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly, here and in verse 25. Alternate translation: [According to the innocence of my actions]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 22:22 (#2)

שָׁמַ֙רְתִּי֙ דַּרְכֵ֣י יְהוָ֔ה

“I have kept the ways of Yahweh”

David is speaking of how a person lives as if that were a way or path that the person was walking along. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I have lived as Yahweh commands] or [I have obeyed Yahweh’s commands]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 22:22 (#3)

וְלֹ֥א רָשַׁ֖עְתִּי מֵאֱלֹהָֽי

“and I have not been wicked from my God”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context, specifically in the next verse, if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and I have not been so wicked as to turn away from my God]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 22:22 (#1)

כִּֽי

“For”

Here the word **For** introduces not a reason but an explanation. If the connection between this statement and the previous one is not clear, you may want to use a different connecting word to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. The meaning is similar in verses 23, 29, 30, and 32. Alternate translation: [After all,]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

2 Samuel 22:23 (#2)

כָּל־מִשְׁפָּטָ֖ו לְנֶגְדִּ֑י

“all of his judgments {are} before me”

David is speaking of **judgments** as if they were objects that could be physically placed in front of him. This means that he constantly remembers and thinks about God’s laws. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I am always mindful of his judgments]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 22:23 (#3)

וְחֻקֹּתָ֖יו לֹא־אָסִ֥יר מִמֶּֽנִּי

“and his statutes, I have not turned away from them”

David is speaking of disobeying God’s **statutes** as if they were objects that he could physically turn away from. He is describing refusing to obey God’s commands. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and I have not disobeyed his statutes]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 22:23 (#1)

כִּֽי

“For”

Here the word **For** introduces not a reason but an explanation of why Yahweh has rewarded David according to his righteousness. If it would be clearer in your language, you could use a word that introduces an explanation. Alternate translation: [Indeed]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

2 Samuel 22:24 (#1)

מֵעֲוֹנִי

“from my iniquity”

David is using the possessive form to mean sin that he could have committed. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [from any iniquity that I might have committed]

See: Possession

2 Samuel 22:25 (#1)

לְנֶגֶד עֵינָיו

“before his eyes”

Here, **before his eyes** represents how God sees and evaluates people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [in his judgment] or [by his standards]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 22:26 (#2)

עִם־חָסִיד

“With the faithful”

David is using the adjective **faithful** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [To people who are faithful]

See: Nominal Adjectives

2 Samuel 22:26 (#3)

גִּבּוֹר תָּמִים

“the mighty blameless”

The phrase **mighty blameless** expresses a single idea. The word **mighty** expresses to what degree these people are **blameless**. If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this meaning in a different way. Alternate translation: [the mightily blameless] or [the entirely innocent]

See: Hendiadys

2 Samuel 22:26 (#4)

גִּבּוֹר תָּמִים

“the mighty blameless”

David is using the adjective **blameless** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [people who are mightily blameless] or [people who are entirely innocent]

See: Nominal Adjectives

2 Samuel 22:26 (#1)

עִם־חָסִיד תִּתְחַסָּד

“With the faithful you show yourself faithful”

Review whether you decided in 22:3 to use the second person or third person consistently throughout this song, or whether you chose to use both as they appear in the original text, as shown in the ULT here by the shift from “his” in the previous verse to **you**.

See: First, Second or Third Person

2 Samuel 22:27 (#2)

עִקֵּשׁ

“the crooked”

Here David is speaking of people who deliberately do what is wrong as if they were physically **crooked** or bent. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [with those who do evil] or [with those who are dishonest]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 22:27 (#1)

נָבָר

“the purified”

The expression **the purified** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [those who purify themselves] or [those who keep themselves pure]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 22:28 (#2)

וְעֵינֶיךָ עַל

“but your eyes {are} against”

David is using **eyes against** to represent God’s attention and opposition. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression

from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [but you oppose]

See: Synecdoche

2 Samuel 22:28 (#1)

וְאֶת־עַ֣ם עָנִ֔י תּוֹשִׁ֖יעַ וְעֵינֶ֣יךָ עַל־רָמִ֔ים תַּשְׁפִּ֖יל

“And you save a lowly people, but your eyes {are} against the ones being high, you bring {them} down”

Here David is speaking as if oppressed people were **lowly**, that is, in a physically low place, and as if proud people were physically **high** and Yahweh brought them **down** to a lower place. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And you save people who are being oppressed, but your eyes are against proud people, you humble them]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 22:29 (#1)

אַתָּ֤ה נִ֙ירִ֙י יְהוָ֔ה וַיהוָ֖ה יַגִּ֥יהַּ חָשְׁכִּֽי

“you {are} my lamp, Yahweh, and Yahweh lightens my darkness”

Here David is speaking as if Yahweh were actually a **lamp** that gives him light in his **darkness**. This image is rich in meaning. Among the meanings that come out in this context is that Yahweh helps him understand what he should do when he would otherwise be confused or uncertain. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you enable me to recognize what I should do when I could not understand that myself]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 22:30 (#1)

אָרֻ֥ץ גְּד֖וּד

“I run {after} a troop”

This could mean: (1) that David is saying that by God’s help, he can pursue and overtake a **troop**. He may be recalling how he and his men were able to overtake the Amalekite “troop” (1 Samuel 30:8) that had raided Ziklag and rescue their families and possessions. Alternate translation: [I can pursue and overtake a raiding band]; (2) that David is saying that by God’s help, he can directly attack and disperse an opposing group of soldiers. Alternate translation: [I can run through a troop] or [I can attack and disperse an opposing troop]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 22:30 (#2)

אֲדַלֶּג־שֽׁוּר

“I leap {over} a wall”

David is speaking of successfully leading troops to capture a fortified city as if he and they would **leap** over its walls. He may be recalling how he and his soldiers were able to capture the stronghold of Zion in Jerusalem (5:6–9). If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I can surmount the walls of a fortified city]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 22:31 (#1)

תָּמִ֥ים דַּרְכּ֖וֹ

“his way {is} perfect”

Here David is speaking of how God acts and directs others as if it were a **way** or path that he was walking along. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [everything he does is faultless] or [he always acts righteously]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 22:31 (#2)

אִמְרַ֣ת יְהוָ֔ה

“The word of Yahweh”

Here, **word of Yahweh** represents what Yahweh says by using words. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [What Yahweh says]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 22:31 (#3)

צְרוּפָ֑ה

“is refined”

The expression **is refined** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [is pure]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 22:31 (#4)

מָגֵן הוּא לְכֹל הַחֹסִים בּוֹ

“He {is} a shield to all of the ones taking refuge in him”

David is speaking as if God were actually a **shield** behind which people took **refuge**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He protects everyone who trusts him]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 22:32 (#2)

צצַוּר

“is} a rock”

David speaks of God here as if God were a **rock**. This means that God provides safety and protection, like a large rock that people can hide behind or stand on for safety. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [provides safety]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 22:32 (#1)

כִּֽי מִי־אֵ֣ל מִבַּלְעֲדֵ֣י יְהוָ֔ה וּמִ֥י צ֖וּר מִבַּלְעֲדֵ֥י אֱלֹהֵֽינוּ

“For who {is} God except Yahweh? And who {is} a rock except our God”

David is using the question form for emphasis. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate these questions as statements or as exclamations. Alternate translation: [For Yahweh is the only God! And our God is the only rock!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 22:33 (#1)

מָעוּזִּ֥י חָ֖יִל

“is} my fortress of strength”

David is using the possessive form to describe a **fortress** that is characterized by **strength**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [is my strong fortress]

See: Possession

2 Samuel 22:33 (#2)

מָעוּזִּ֥י חָ֖יִל

“is} my fortress of strength”

Here David is speaking as if God were actually a **fortress of strength**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [keeps me entirely safe]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 22:33 (#3)

וַיַּתֵּ֥ר תָּמִ֖ים דַּרְכּֽוֹ

“and he makes my way perfect”

This could mean: (1) that God makes the **way** on which a person travels **perfect**, that is, free from obstacles. Alternate translation: [and he removes all the obstacles in my path] or [and he enables me to live the life he has chosen for me without hindrance]; (2) that David is speaking of how a person lives as if that were a **way** or path that the person was walking along. Alternate translation: [and he enables me to live in just the way that he wants people to live]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 22:34 (#3)

וְעַ֥ל בָּמוֹתַ֖י יַעֲמִדֵֽנִי

“and he makes me stand on my high places”

David may be using this possessive form, referring to these as **my** high places, because he is recalling how he had to hide among cliffs when Saul was trying to kill him. It may be more natural in your language to express this meaning with a different form. Alternate translation: [and he keeps me from falling from any high places where I have to go]

See: Possession

2 Samuel 22:34 (#1)

מְשַׁוֶּ֥ה רגליו כָּאַיָּלוֹת

“making my feet like a deer”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [making my feet like the feet of a deer]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 22:34 (#2)

מְשַׁוֶּ֥ה רגליו כָּאַיָּלוֹת

“making my feet like a deer”

Here David is comparing his ability to move quickly and surely with the way a deer moves in difficult terrain. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [making my feet secure] or [keeping me from stumbling]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 22:35 (#1)

מְלַמֵּד יָדַי לַמִּלְחָמָה

“training my hands for war”

David is using his **hands** to represent all of him in the act of fighting in battle. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [training me for war]

See: Synecdoche

2 Samuel 22:36 (#1)

וַתִּתֶּן־לִ֣י מָגֵ֔ן יִשְׁעֶ֖ךָ

“And you give to me the shield of your salvation”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [And the shield you provide for me saves me]

See: Abstract Nouns

2 Samuel 22:36 (#2)

וַתִּתֶּן־לִ֣י מָגֵ֔ן יִשְׁעֶ֖ךָ

“And you give to me the shield of your salvation”

Here David is speaking of God’s power to save him as if it were a **shield** that could protect him from physical attacks. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you protect me by saving me]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 22:36 (#3)

וַעֲנֹתְךָ

“and your answer”

By **your answer**, David means God’s response to his prayers requesting help. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and your answer to my prayers]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 22:37 (#1)

תַּרְחִ֥יב צַעֲדִ֖י תַּחְתָּ֑נִי

“You enlarge my step under me”

Here, David’s **step** represents the place where he would step. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [You enlarge the place where I step under me]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 22:37 (#2)

תַּרְחִ֥יב צַעֲדִ֖י תַּחְתָּ֑נִי

“You enlarge my step under me”

David is speaking as if God had made the area where he needed to walk more spacious. This represents having freedom to move and act without being constrained by enemies. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. You could also use plain language. Alternate translation: [You give me room to maneuver]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 22:39 (#3)

וָאֶפְלְלֵ֑ם

“but they fall”

The implication is that David’s enemies fall and remain dead. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [but they fall down dead]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 22:39 (#1)

וָאֲכַלֵּ֑ם

“And I devour them”

Here David is speaking of destroying his enemies as if he were a wild animal that could **devour** them. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And I completely destroy them]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 22:39 (#2)

וְלֹ֣א יְקוּמ֔וּן וָיִפְּלְל֖וּ תַּחַ֥ת רַגְלָֽי

“and they do not arise, but they fall under my feet”

David is describing one event before describing another event that preceded it. If it would be helpful your language, you may wish to relate these events in the order in which they happened, as in the UST. Alternate translation: [and they fall under my feet and do not arise]

See: Order of Events

2 Samuel 22:40 (#1)

וַתְּזָרְרֵנִי חַיִל

“And you gird me {with} valor”

Here David is speaking of valor as if it were a piece of clothing with which God **girds** him, like a belt or piece of armor. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And you make me valiant]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 22:40 (#2)

תַּכְרִיעַ קָמַי תַּחְתָּנָי

“you make the ones rising up under me bow down”

David means that people who try to rebel against him ultimately **bow down** as a symbolic action by which they show renewed submission to his authority. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [you make the ones rising up under me submit humbly to my authority]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 22:40 (#3)

קָמַי תַּחְתָּנָי

“the ones rising up under me”

David is using **the ones rising up under me** as a common expression of his culture to mean “those who rebel against my rule.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the ones revolting against my rule]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 22:41 (#3)

מְשַׂנְאָי

“the ones hating me”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [you give to me the ones hating me]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 22:41 (#2)

עֹרֶף

“the back of {their} neck”

In this verse, the word **back** is singular in form, but it refers to all the enemies as a group. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use plural forms of “back” and “neck.” Alternate translation: [the backs of their necks]

See: Collective Nouns

2 Samuel 22:41 (#1)

תַּתָּה לִּי עֹרֶף

“you give to me the back of {their} neck”

David is describing a symbolic action in which victorious soldiers would make defeated enemies lie face down on the ground and then step on their necks to demonstrate their complete triumph (as in Joshua 10:24, for example). If it would be helpful to your readers, you could express the meaning plainly in your translation. Alternate translation: [you enable me to step in complete triumph on the backs of their necks]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 22:42 (#1)

אֶל־יְהוָה

“to Yahweh”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [they call to Yahweh]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 22:42 (#2)

וְלֹא עָנָם

“but he does not answer them”

By **he does not answer them**, David means that Yahweh does not help his enemies as they have asked. (The meaning of **answer** in this context is similar to the meaning of “listen” in 12:18.) You could indicate

this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [but he does not do what they ask]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 22:43 (#1)

וְאֶשְׁחָקֵם כַּעֲפַר־אָרֶץ

“And I beat them like the dust of the earth”

The point of this comparison is that just as the **dust of the earth** consists of tiny pieces, so, in this image, David **beat** his enemies so thoroughly that they broke into small pieces. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [And I beat them into small pieces like the dust of the earth]

See: Simile

2 Samuel 22:43 (#3)

כְּטִיט־חוּצוֹת אֲדַקֵּקֵם אֶרְקָעֵם

“Like the mud of the streets, I pulverize them, I stomp them”

Here David is speaking of his enemies as if they were **mud** that he could crush and trample. This metaphor emphasizes his complete victory over them. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I completely crushed my enemies and trampled them down] or [I utterly defeated my enemies, destroying them completely]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 22:43 (#2)

וְאֶשְׁחָקֵם כַּעֲפַר־אָרֶץ

“And I beat them like the dust of the earth”

David speaks here of defeating his enemies as if he had actually beaten them into small pieces. This compares his total victory over his enemies to the way that dust can be completely scattered. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And I completely destroyed them] or [And I scattered them completely]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 22:44 (#1)

לְרֹאשׁ גּוֹיִם

“as the head of nations”

Here David is speaking of his leadership role as if he were the **head** of a body. Just as the head directs the rest of the body, David ruled over other nations. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [as the ruler of nations] or [to govern the nations]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 22:45 (#3)

לִשְׁמוֹעַ אׇזֶן

“At the hearing of an ear”

David is using one part of a person, the **ear** to represent entire people in the act of hearing. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [When they hear]

See: Synecdoche

2 Samuel 22:45 (#1)

בְּנֵי נֵכָר

“Sons of the foreigner”

David is not referring to a specific **foreigner**. He means foreigners in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Sons of foreigners]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

2 Samuel 22:45 (#4)

לִשְׁמוֹעַ אׇזֶן

“At the hearing of an ear”

David means that these people hear specifically about him. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [When they hear about me]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 22:45 (#5)

יִשָּׁמְעוּ לִי

“they hear me”

By **they hear me**, David means that they obey him. (The meaning of **hear** in this context is similar to the meaning of “listen” in 12:18.) You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [they obey me]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 22:45 (#2)

בְּנֵי נֵכָר

“Sons of the foreigner”

In certain contexts, biblical authors and characters use the common expression of their culture **Sons of** to indicate that a person has a certain characteristic. In this case, these people have the characteristic of being foreigners or people from other nations. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an equivalent expression from your language or state the meaning plainly, here and in the next verse. Alternate translation: [Foreigners]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 22:46 (#1)

יִבֹּלוּ

“fade away”

Here David is speaking of foreign armies as if they were plants that **fade away** and lose their vitality. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [lose strength]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 22:46 (#2)

בְּנֵי נֵכָר

“Sons of the foreigner”

In certain contexts, biblical authors and characters use the expression **son of** to indicate that a person has the characteristic of something. In this case, the people whom David is describing have the characteristic of being soldiers of foreign countries that are resisting his rule. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an equivalent expression from your language or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Foreign soldiers]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 22:47 (#2)

וּבָרוּךְ צוּרִי

“And blessed {be} my rock”

The expression **blessed be** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [And I bless my rock]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 22:47 (#1)

חַי־יְהוָה

“Yahweh {is} alive”

David is using a phrase that expresses a strong feeling, joy. There may be an equivalent word or phrase in your language that you can use in your translation to convey this feeling. If not, you could say what David was feeling, or you could say what made him joyful. Alternate translation: [I rejoice that Yahweh is alive] or [How wonderful that Yahweh lives]

See: Exclamations

2 Samuel 22:47 (#7)

אֱלֹהֵי צוּר יִשְׁעִי

“the God of the rock of my salvation”

David is speaking of God as if he were a large rock or cliff where David could find safety from his enemies. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the God who saves me by keeping me safe]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 22:47 (#3)

צוּרִי

“my rock”

See how you translated the similar expression in 22:32. Alternate translation: [the one who keeps me safe]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 22:47 (#6)

אֱלֹהֵי צוּר יִשְׁעִי

“the God of the rock of my salvation”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the God who is the rock that saves me]

See: Abstract Nouns

2 Samuel 22:47 (#4)

וְיָרֹם אֱלֹהֵי צוּר יִשְׁעִי

“and may the God of the rock of my salvation be exalted”

The expression **be exalted** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that

is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and I exalt the God of the rock of my salvation]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 22:47 (#5)

אֱלֹהֵי צוּר יִשְׁעִי

“the God of the rock of my salvation”

David is using the possessive form to describe **God** as characterized by being the **rock** of his **salvation**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the God who is the rock of my salvation]

See: Possession

2 Samuel 22:48 (#1)

וּמוֹרִיד עַמִּים תַּחְתָּנִי

“and bringing down peoples under me”

Here David is speaking of conquering peoples as if they were being brought **down** physically under his feet. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and defeating peoples before me]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 22:49 (#2)

וּמִקָּמַי תְּרוֹמְמֵנִי

“And from the ones arising {against} me, you lift me up”

Here David is speaking of his enemies as if they were physically **arising** upward to attack him, and he speaks of God as physically **lifting** him up above them. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And you make me prevail over those who attack me] or [And you protect me from those who oppose me]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 22:49 (#3)

מֵאִישׁ חֲמָסִים

“from a man of violences”

David is not referring to a specific **man of violence**. He means violent people in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [from violent men]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

2 Samuel 22:49 (#1)

וּמוֹצִיאִי מֵאֹיְבָי

“and bringing me out from my enemies”

By **bringing me out from my enemies**, David means escaping from being confined or restrained by his enemies. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and bringing me out from the confinement of my enemies]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 22:49 (#4)

חֲמָסִים

“violences”

Here David is using the plural **violences** where he could have used the singular form. This suggests that he is using the plural form to emphasize the severity and continuity of the violence that this **man** commits or attempts. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use the singular and express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [great violence]

See: Unusual Uses of the Plural

2 Samuel 22:50 (#1)

וּלְשִׁמְךָ אֲזַמֵּר

“and I sing praise to your name”

Here, **name** represents Yahweh himself, in light of his fame and reputation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and I sing praise to you] or [and I sing praise to you, Yahweh]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 22:51 (#3)

לִמְשִׁיחוֹ

“to his anointed”

The expression **his anointed** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [to the one he anointed]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 22:51 (#4)

וּלְזַרְעֽוֹ

“and to his seed”

Here David is speaking of his offspring as if they were actually **seed**. Just as a seed can grow into a plant that produces more seeds, David’s descendants would continue to come from his family line. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and to his descendants]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 22:51 (#1)

מגדיל יְשׁוּעֹ֣ות מַלְכּ֔וֹ

“the one magnifying the salvation of his king”

Jewish scribes instructed synagogue readers to say “a tower of salvation to his king” when they got to this phrase. That could have been the original reading. (There is a difference of only one letter between these readings in Hebrew.) If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to use the reading that it uses. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to use the reading of the ULT.

See: Textual Variants

2 Samuel 22:51 (#2)

מגדיל יְשׁוּעֹ֣ות מַלְכּ֔וֹ

“the one magnifying the salvation of his king”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the one saving his king by great deeds]

See: Abstract Nouns

2 Samuel - Chapter 23 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter continues the supplemental information about David’s reign as king of Israel that the author provides at the end of the book. It presents the fourth and fifth parts of that information, a song that presents David’s last words and a description of his greatest warriors.

Some translations set each line of poetry farther to the right than the rest of the text to make it easier to read. The ULT does this with the poetry in 23:2–7.

2 Samuel 23:8–39 is a list of the famous people in David’s army along with some of the special deeds some of them did. Consider how you have been presenting the lists in 2 Samuel in your translation and how you might present the list in verses 24–29 similarly. You may choose to put one name, rather than two, on each line.

2 Samuel 23:1 (#2)

הַגֶּ֖בֶר הֻקַם עָ֑ל

“the man raised {to} height”

The expression **raised** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the man whom God raised to height]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 23:1 (#3)

הַגֶּ֖בֶר הֻקַם עָ֑ל

“the man raised {to} height”

The author is speaking of David’s position of authority as if it were a **height**. He means that God gave David great power and honor. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the man whom God put in an important position]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 23:1 (#6)

וּנְעִ֥ים זְמִרוֹת֙ יִשְׂרָאֵ֔ל

“and the delightful {one} of the songs of Israel”

The author is using the possessive form to describe **songs** that people in **Israel** heard and sang. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and the one in whose songs the Israelites delighted]

See: Possession

2 Samuel 23:1 (#1)

נְאֻ֣ם דָּוִ֔ד בֶּן־יִשַׁ֖י וּנְאֻ֣ם הַגֶּ֖בֶר הֻקַם עָ֑ל

“An oracle of David the son of Jesse, and an oracle of the man raised {to} height”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and it would be good to show this to your readers by

including both phrases in your translation rather than combining them. It may be clearer in your language to connect the phrases with a word other than **and** in order to show that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Review from your work on chapter 22 how you decided as a team to represent Hebrew poetry in your translation. Alternate translation: [An oracle of David the son of Jesse, yes, an oracle of the man raised to height] or [An oracle of David the son of Jesse, who was a man raised to height]

See: Parallelism

2 Samuel 23:1 (#4)

מְשִׁ֣יחַ אֱלֹהֵ֣י יַעֲקֹ֔ב

“the anointed of the God of Jacob”

The expression **the anointed of the God of Jacob** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the one whom the God of Jacob anointed]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 23:1 (#5)

אֱלֹהֵ֣י יַעֲקֹ֔ב

“the God of Jacob”

The author is using the possessive form to describe **the God of Jacob** that is characterized by **Jacob**, meaning this is the God who chose Jacob and his descendants and who made covenant promises to them. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the God with whom the descendants of Jacob are in a covenant relationship]

See: Possession

2 Samuel 23:2 (#1)

רַ֚ח יְהוָ֣ה דִּבֶּר־בִּ֔י וּמִלָּת֖וֹ עַל־לְשׁוֹנִֽי

“The Spirit of Yahweh spoke by me, and his word {was} on my tongue”

These two clauses say basically the same thing as the previous verse. See the discussion in the Introduction to chapter 22 of how Hebrew poetry was based on the repetition of words, phrases, and ideas. Recall how you decided as a team represent Hebrew poetry in your translation. Alternate translation: [The Spirit of Yahweh spoke by me, yes, his word was on my tongue] or [The Spirit of Yahweh gave me the words to speak for him]

See: Parallelism

2 Samuel 23:2 (#2)

וּמִלָּת֖וֹ עַל־לְשׁוֹנִֽי

“and his word {was} on my tongue”

David is using the term **word** to represent what he said by using words. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and I spoke his word]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 23:2 (#3)

וּמִלָּת֖וֹ עַל־לְשׁוֹנִֽי

“and his word {was} on my tongue”

David is using his **tongue** to represent all of himself in the act of speaking. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and I spoke what he wanted me to say]

See: Synecdoche

2 Samuel 23:3 (#1)

צ֣וּר יִשְׂרָאֵ֔ל

“the Rock of Israel”

See how you translated the similar expression in 22:2. Alternate translation: [the Protector of Israel]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 23:3 (#3)

בָּאָדָֽם

“over man”

Here the masculine term **man** has a generic sense that includes both men and women. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use language in your translation that is clearly inclusive of both men and women. Alternate translation: [over people]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

2 Samuel 23:3 (#2)

דֹּבֵ֣ר & צַדִּ֔יק

“said, ‘A righteous one”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a

quotation. Alternate translation: [said that a righteous one]

See: Quotes within Quotes

2 Samuel 23:4 (#1)

וּכְאוֹר בֹּ֖קֶר

“and {is} like the light of morning”

The point of this comparison is that just as **the light of morning** is beneficial and brings blessing, so does a righteous ruler. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [and is a source of blessing, like the light of morning]

See: Simile

2 Samuel 23:4 (#2)

מִנֹּ֥גַהּ

“from brightness”

Here, **brightness** represents sunshine or sunlight. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [from sunshine]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 23:5 (#3)

בֵּיתִ֔י

“my house”

As in 1:12 and similar contexts, **house** here means all the people descended from a particular person. It envisions them as if they were one household living together. In this specific context, David is using the term **house** to mean his dynasty, his royal line of descendants who would rule after him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my royal dynasty]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 23:5 (#4)

כִּי֩ & שָׂ֨שָׂם

“For he has made”

Here the word **For** introduces not a reason but an explanation. Use a connecting word or phrase that would indicate this in your language. Alternate translation: [I say this because he has made]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

2 Samuel 23:5 (#7)

כָּל־יְשׁוּעָ֥ה וְכָל־חֵ֖פֶץ כִּי־לֹ֥א יַצְמִֽיחַ

“all my salvation and every desire, surely will he not make {it} sprout”

David is using the question form to emphasize that God will certainly do what he is describing. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [he will certainly make sprout all my salvation and every desire!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 23:5 (#9)

כָּל־יְשׁוּעָ֥ה וְכָל־חֵ֖פֶץ כִּי־לֹ֥א יַצְמִֽיחַ

“all my salvation and every desire, surely will he not make {it} sprout”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **salvation** and **desire**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [he will certainly save me completely and give me everything that I desire]

See: Abstract Nouns

2 Samuel 23:5 (#2)

לֹא־כֵ֣ן בֵּיתִ֔י עִם־אֵ֖ל

“is} not my house thus with God”

David is using the question form to make a strong statement about how God has blessed his family. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [that is the way my house is with God!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 23:5 (#5)

עֲרוּכָ֥ה בַכֹּ֛ל וּשְׁמֻרָ֖ה

“ordered in everything and secured”

The expressions **ordered** and **secured** are passive verbal forms. If your language would not use those forms, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and he has ordered it in everything and secured it]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 23:5 (#6)

כִּי־כָל־יִשְׁעִי

“For all my salvation”

Here the word **For** introduces not a reason but an explanation. Use a connecting word or phrase that would indicate this in your language. Alternate translation: [Indeed, all my salvation]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

2 Samuel 23:5 (#8)

כָּל־יִשְׁעִי וְכָל־חֵפֶץ כִּי־לֹא יַצְמִיחַ

“all my salvation and every desire, surely will he not make {it} sprout”

Here David is speaking of his salvation and desire as if they were plants that God would cause to grow. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he will certainly bring about all my salvation and every desire]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 23:5 (#1)

כִּי־לֹא־כֵן

“For {is} not & thus”

Here the word **For** introduces not a reason but an explanation. Alternate translation: [After all, is not]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

2 Samuel 23:6 (#4)

לֹא & יִקָּחוּ

“they do not take”

Here the author is using the pronoun **they** in a general sense, not to refer to specific people. Use an expression for this that would be natural in your language. Alternate translation: [one does not take] or [people do not take]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 23:6 (#3)

מֻנָּד & כִּי־לֹא בְיָד יִקָּחוּ

“thrown away because they do not take in the hand”

The expression **thrown away** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [that people throw away because it hurts to hold it in their hands]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 23:6 (#1)

וּבְלִיַּעַל

“But the wicked”

The author is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [But wicked people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

2 Samuel 23:6 (#2)

כְּקוֹץ

“will be} like a thorn”

The point of this comparison is that just as **thorns** are worthless and thrown away, so are the **wicked**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [will be rejected like a thorn]

See: Simile

2 Samuel 23:7 (#4)

שָׂרֹוף יִשָּׂרְפוּ

“And burning, they will be burned”

The author is repeating forms of the verb **burned** in order to intensify his expression of the idea that it conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [And they will surely be burned]

See: Reduplication

2 Samuel 23:7 (#6)

בַּשֶּׁבֶת

“in place”

The author is using **in place** as a common expression of his culture to mean “where they are, without moving them.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate

translation: [on the spot] or [without carrying them away]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 23:7 (#1)

וְאִישׁ֩ יִגַּ֨ע בָּהֶ֜ם יִמָּלֵ֗א בַּרְזֶ֛ל וְעֵ֥ץ חֲנִ֖ית

“But the man {who} touches them will be filled {with} iron or the wood of a spear”

The expression **will be filled** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [But the man who touches them will fill his hand with iron or the wood of a spear]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 23:7 (#3)

וְעֵ֥ץ חֲנִֽית

“or the wood of a spear”

Here, **wood of a spear** represents the shaft or handle of a spear. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [or the shaft of a spear]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 23:7 (#2)

וְאִישׁ֩ יִגַּ֨ע בָּהֶ֜ם יִמָּלֵ֗א בַּרְזֶ֛ל וְעֵ֥ץ חֲנִ֖ית

“But the man {who} touches them will be filled {with} iron or the wood of a spear”

The author is using **filled with iron or the wood of a spear** as a common expression of his culture to mean “will need to use an iron tool or spear shaft to handle them.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [But a man will only touch them with an iron tool or spear shaft that he is holding]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 23:7 (#5)

שָׂרֹ֥וף יִשָּׂרְפ֖וּ

“And burning, they will be burned”

The expression **burning, they will be burned** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [And people will surely burn them]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 23:8 (#2)

הַשָּׁלִשִׁ֑י

“the Three”

The author is using the adjective **Three** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the three greatest warrior champions]

See: Nominal Adjectives

2 Samuel 23:8 (#1)

רֹ֣אשׁ

“was} the head of”

The author is using the image of the **head** to represent leadership. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [was the leader of]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 23:8 (#3)

הֽוּא עֲדִינֹ֣ו העצנו

“He”

The author is using **lifting his spear** as a common expression of his culture to mean “fighting.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He was fighting]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 23:8 (#4)

חָלַ֥ל בְּפַ֖עַם אחד

“slain at one time”

The author is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [whom he all slew at one time]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 23:9 (#2)

בְּחָרְפָּם בַּפְּלִשְׁתִּים נֶאֱסְפוּ

“When they taunted the Philistines, they had gathered themselves”

The pronoun **they** refers to the Israelite soldiers, while the pronoun **themselves** refers to the Philistines. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [When the Israelite soldiers taunted the Philistines, who had gathered themselves]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 23:9 (#4)

בְּחָרְפָּם בַּפְּלִשְׁתִּים

“When they taunted the Philistines”

The author is using taunting **the Philistines**, the first thing that the Israelites did in this battle, to represent everything they did in the entire battle. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [When they fought the Philistines]

See: Synecdoche

2 Samuel 23:9 (#3)

שָׁ֫שָׁם

“there”

The author assumes that his readers will know that by **there**, he means Pas Dammim, a place where the Israelites and Philistines frequently fought battles. The parallel passage in 1 Chronicles 11:13 states the name of this place explicitly, and you could do the same in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [at Pas Dammim]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 23:9 (#5)

וַיַּעֲלוּ֙ אַנְשֵׁ֣י יִשְׂרָאֵ֔ל

“and the men of Israel went up”

By **went up**, the author means the Israelite soldiers retreated to higher ground away from the battle. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and the men of Israel retreated to higher ground]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 23:9 (#1)

ואחרו אֶלְעָזָר֙ בֶּן־דֹּדִ֣י בֶן־אֲחֹחִ֔י בִּשְׁלֹשָׁ֖ה הַגִּבֹּרִ֑ים עִם־דָּוִ֖ד

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: ואחרו אֶלְעָזָר֙ בֶּן־דֹּדִ֣י בֶן־אֲחֹחִ֔י בִּשְׁלֹשָׁ֖ה הַגִּבֹּרִ֑ים עִם־דָּוִ֖ד”

If it would be more natural in your language, you may want to put the information about **among the three warriors with David** with the phrase about Eleazar’s genealogy. Alternate translation: [And after him among the three warriors with David was Eleazar the son of Dodo, the son of Ahohi]

See: Information Structure

2 Samuel 23:10 (#1)

הַהֽוּא קָ֖ם

“he, he arose”

See how you translated the similar expression “you, you know” in 17:20. Alternate translation: [for his part, he arose]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 23:10 (#5)

וַיַּ֤עַשׂ יְהוָה֙ תְּשׁוּעָ֣ה גְדוֹלָ֔ה

“And Yahweh did great salvation”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way, here and in verse 12. Alternate translation: [And Yahweh powerfully saved the Israelites]

See: Abstract Nouns

2 Samuel 23:10 (#4)

יָגְעָ֥ה יָד֖וֹ

“his hand tired”

The author seems to be using he word **hand** in its first instance to represent the power of a person. (In the second instance, it refers to Eleazar’s actual hand.) If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he had used all of his strength]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 23:10 (#2)

הַהֽוּא קָ֖ם וַיַּ֥ךְ

“he, he arose and struck”

See how you translated the similar expression in 2:14. Alternate translation: [he himself took action and slew]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 23:10 (#3)

וַיַּךְ בַּפְּלִשְׁתִּים

“and struck the Philistines”

By **struck the Philistines**, the author means that Eleazar killed Philistine soldiers. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. See the discussion of the term “struck” in the Introduction to 2 Samuel. Alternate translation: [and killed Philistine soldiers]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 23:11 (#1)

וַתְּהִי־שָׁשָּׁם חֶלְקַת הַשָּׂדֶה מְלֵאָה עֲדָשִׁים

“and a portion of the field there was full {of} lentils”

The author is using the phrase **full of lentils** as a common expression of his culture to mean that there were lentils that had been planted and had grown up and ripened in this part of the field of battle. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and the lentils that had been planted in a portion of the field there had grown up and ripened]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 23:11 (#2)

מִפְּנֵי פְּלִשְׁתִּים

“from the face of the Philistines”

The author is using the **face** of the Philistines to represent running their presence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [from the presence of the Philistines] or [to get away from the Philistines]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 23:12 (#1)

וַיַּצִּיבֶלָּה וַיַּךְ אֶת־פְּלִשְׁתִּים

“and he delivered it, and he struck the Philistines”

The author is describing one event before describing another event that preceded it. If it would be helpful your language, you may wish to relate these events in the order in which they happened. Alternate translation: [and he struck the Philistines, and he delivered it]

See: Order of Events

2 Samuel 23:12 (#2)

וַיַּךְ אֶת־פְּלִשְׁתִּים

“and he struck the Philistines”

By **struck**, the author means in this context that he killed Philistine soldiers in battle. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. See the discussion of the term “struck” in the Introduction to 2 Samuel. Alternate translation: [and he killed the Philistines]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 23:13 (#1)

רֹאשׁ

“head”

The author is using the image of the **head** to mean a leader or chief. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [chief]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 23:13 (#2)

וַיֵּרְדוּ

“And & went down”

See how you translated the similar expression in 2:1. Alternate translation: [And ... went]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 23:13 (#3)

אֶל־קָצִירׇ

“to the harvest”

The traditional Hebrew text reads “the harvest.” The ULT follows that reading. The parallel passage in 1 Chronicles 11:15 reads “the rock.” That may have been the original reading, since it suits the grammar and context better and involves a difference of only one letter. If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to use the reading that it uses. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to use the reading of the ULT.

See: Textual Variants

2 Samuel 23:14 (#1)

וְדָוִד אָז בַּמְּצוּדָה וּמַצַּב פְּלִשְׁתִּים אָז בֵּבֵית לָחֶם

“And David {was} then in the stronghold, and a garrison of the Philistines {was} then {in} Bethlehem”

It might seem that saying “then” in both parts of this verse would be extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you could say “then” in only one part of the verse, wherever it would be more natural in your language to say that.

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 23:15 (#1)

וַיִּתְאַוֶּה דָּוִד

“And David desired”

Since what David says in the rest of the verse indicates what he **desired**, you do not need to explain that here at the beginning of the verse by saying something such as, “And David desired to have something to drink.”

See: When to Keep Information Implicit

2 Samuel 23:15 (#2)

מִמִּי יַשְׁקֵנִי מַיִם מִבּוֹר בֵּית־לֶחֶם אֲשֶׁר בַּשָּׁעַר

“Who will give me water to drink from the well of Bethlehem that {is} at the gate”

David is using the question form to express his strong desire for water from the well. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [I wish that someone would give me water to drink from the well of Bethlehem that {is} at the gate!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 23:15 (#3)

מַיִם

“water”

The term for **water** is always plural in Hebrew. Different languages may need to use a singular form in certain contexts, as the ULT does here and elsewhere. If your language would use a plural form in these contexts, it would be appropriate to do that in your translation.

See: Unusual Uses of the Plural

2 Samuel 23:16 (#1)

וַיַּסֵּךְ אֹתָם לַיהוָה

“and he poured it out to Yahweh”

The pouring out of the water was a symbolic action by which David showed that this water, obtained at great risk by his men, was too precious to drink, and it deserved to be offered to Yahweh instead. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the significance of this action in the text of your translation or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [and he offered it as a sacrifice to Yahweh] or [and he poured it out on the ground as an offering to Yahweh]

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 23:17 (#1)

חָלִילָה֨ לִּ֜י

“Profane to me”

See how you translated the similar expression in 20:20. Alternate translation: [Far be it from me]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 23:17 (#4)

הֲדַ֣ם הָֽאֲנָשִׁים֮ הַהֹלְכִים֒ בְּנַפְשׁוֹתָ֣ם

“the blood of the men having gone with their lives”

David is speaking as if the water that the men brought were actually their **blood**. He means that the water represents the danger into which these men put their lives to get it for him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [this water that I am pouring out, since the blood of these men could just as easily have been poured out when they risked their lives to get it]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 23:17 (#5)

אֵ֚אֶלֶּה עָשׂ֣וּ שְׁלֹשֶׁת֔ הַגִּבֹּרִֽים

“These {things} the three warriors did”

The author is offering a summary of the stories he has just related. This signals the end of this section about these **three warriors**. Use a natural way in your language to offer a summary that concludes a section. Alternate translation: [Those are some of the things that David’s three mighty warriors did for him] or [So ends the account of what these three warriors did]

See: End of Story

2 Samuel 23:17 (#3)

הֲדַ֣ם הָֽאֲנָשִׁים֮ הַהֹלְכִים֒ בְּנַפְשׁוֹתָ֣ם

“the blood of the men having gone with their lives”

David is using **having gone with their lives** as a common expression of his culture to mean "who risked their lives." If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the blood of the men who risked their lives to get it]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 23:17 (#2)

הֲדַ֣ם הָֽאֲנָשִׁים֮ הַהֹלְכִ֣ים בְּנַפְשׁוֹתָ֒ם

"the blood of the men having gone with their lives"

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [from drinking the blood of the men having gone with their lives]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 23:18 (#6)

חָלָֽל

"slain"

See how you translated the similar expression in 23:8. Alternate translation: [whom he slew]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 23:18 (#7)

וְלוֹ־שֵׁ֥שֶׁם בַּשְּׁלֹשָֽׁה

"And to him {was} a name among the Three"

Here, **name** represents reputation or honor. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language, here and in verse 22. Alternate translation: [And he had as great a reputation as the Three]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 23:18 (#2)

צְרוּיָ֖ה

"Zeruiah"

The word **Zeruiah** is the name of a woman, David's older sister. See how you translated her name in 2:13.

See: How to Translate Names

2 Samuel 23:18 (#5)

וְה֣וּא֩ עוֹרֵ֨ר אֶת־חֲנִיתֹ֜ו

"and he was lifting his spear"

See how you translated the similar expression in 23:8. Alternate translation: [and he was fighting]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 23:18 (#1)

וַאֲבִישַׁ֣י אֲחִ֣י ׀ יוֹאָ֗ב בֶּן־צְרוּיָ֔ה

"And Abishai, the brother of Joab, the son of Zeruiah"

The author is identifying **Abishai** as the **brother of Joab** and the **son of Zeruiah**. (Joab was also the son of Zeruiah, but the author is making clear that Zeruiah was the mother of Abishai. She could have been the mother of Joab without being the mother of Abishai.) Abishai was Joab's younger brother. Your language may have its own terms or expressions for these relationships. Alternate translation: [And Abishai, who was the brother of Joab and the son of Zeruiah]

See: Kinship

2 Samuel 23:18 (#4)

הָה֥וּא רֹ֖אשׁ

"he {was} the head of"

The author is using the image of the **head** to represent a leader or commander. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he was the commander]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 23:18 (#3)

בַּשְּׁלֹשָׁ֑ה & השלשי

"the three & among the Three"

The author seems to be describing two different groups of three warriors. The ULT distinguishes between them by treating the word **Three** as a title (uppercase) when it describes the great warriors of the first rank, Josheb Basshebeth, Eleazar, and Shammah (23:8–12), and by treating the word **three** as a description (lowercase) when it describes the great warriors of the second rank, Abishai, Benaiah, and another unnamed warrior (23:13–23). Your language may have a convention of its own that you could use to distinguish between these groups, or you could use descriptive phrases, as the UST does. Some versions express the interpretation that Abishai was the commander of

the Three, that is, the great warriors of the first rank. Other versions follow some ancient manuscripts and say that Abishai was the commander of the Thirty, the warriors listed in 23:24–39. If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to use the reading that it uses. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to use the reading of the ULT.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 23:19 (#1)

מִן־הַשְּׁלֹשָׁה֙ הֲכִבֵּ֣ד נִכְבָּ֔ד

“Is it not} that he was the most honored of the three”

The author is using the question form for emphasis to affirm that Abishai was indeed the most honored of the three. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [He was certainly the most honored of the three.]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 23:19 (#2)

מִן־הַשְּׁלֹשָׁה֙ הֲכִבֵּ֣ד נִכְבָּ֔ד

“Is it not} that he was the most honored of the three”

The expression **he was the most honored** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [People certainly honored him the most of the three]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 23:19 (#3)

וְעַד־הַשְּׁלֹשָׁ֖ה לֹא־בָ֑א

“But he did not come to the Three”

Here, **come to** represents joining or achieving the same level of status as the Three. The verse means that although Abishai was a great warrior and was highly honored, he did not achieve membership in or equal status with the Three. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly, here and in verse 23. Alternate translation: [But he did not join the ranks of the Three] or [But he did achieve the same exploits and reputation as the Three]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 23:20 (#5)

אֲרִאֵ֣ל

“Ariel of”

While the term **Ariel** is singular in the original, since the author is referring to **two** such people, it may be more natural in your language to use a plural form. Alternate translation: [Ariels]

See: Unusual Uses of the Plural

2 Samuel 23:20 (#3)

הַה֣וּא הִכָּ֔ה & וְ֠הוּא יָרַ֞ד

“He, he struck & And he, he went down”

The author is stating the pronoun **he** separately in each of these instances, even though the verbs translated as **he struck** and **he went down** already include this meaning. He is doing that to confirm Benaiah’s exclusive personal role in accomplishing these feats. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for this same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing that the author is confirming Benaiah’s exclusive personal role. It may not be necessary to represent the separately stated pronoun explicitly. Alternate translation: [He single-handedly struck ... And he went down alone]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 23:20 (#1)

בֶּן־אִ֥ישׁ־חַ֛י

“was} a son of a man of valor”

In certain contexts, biblical authors and characters use the expression **son of** to indicate that a person has the characteristic of something. In this case, the author is saying that Benaiah has the characteristic of **valor**. See how you translated the similar expression in 12:5. Alternate translation: [was characterized by being a man of valor]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 23:20 (#2)

רַב־פְּעָלִ֖ים

“many deeds”

The author is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [a doer of many great deeds]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 23:20 (#6)

וּבְנָיָ֣הוּ בֶן־יְהוֹיָדָ֗ע בֶּן־אִ֤ישׁ־חַי֙ רַב־פְּעָלִ֔ים מִקַּבְצְאֵ֑ל

“And Benaiah, the son of Jehoiada, {was} a son of a man of valor, many deeds, from Kabzeel”

If it would be more natural in your language, you may want to put the information that **Benaiah** was **from Kabzeel** with the information that his father was **Jehoiada**. Alternate translation: [And Benaiah, the son of Jehoiada, from Kabzeel, was a son of a man of valor, many deeds]

See: Information Structure

2 Samuel 23:20 (#4)

אֵ֚ת שְׁנֵ֣י אֲרִיאֵ֔ל מוֹאָ֖ב

“the two Ariel of Moab”

Interpreters do not understand exactly what the term **Ariel** means. However, many interpreters believe that it may be describing warrior champions as lion-like, that is, strong and fierce. Alternate translation: [two mighty champions of Moab] or [two fierce warrior heroes of Moab]

See: Translate Unknowns

2 Samuel 23:21 (#1)

אשר מַרְאֶֽה

“a man of appearance”

The author is using **a man of appearance** as a common expression of his culture to mean a giant. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [a man who was a terror to behold] or [a giant]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 23:21 (#2)

וַיֵּ֥רֶד אֵלָ֖יו

“and he went down against him”

The author seems to mean that Benaiah **went down** from the Israelite battle lines on a safe height, and he went into a valley to fight this **man of Egypt** in single combat between the battle lines. Alternate translation: [and he went into a valley to fight him in single combat]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 23:23 (#1)

מִן־הַשְּׁלֹשִׁ֖ים נִכְבָּ֑ד

“More than the Thirty, he was honored”

The expression **he was honored** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [People honored him more than the Thirty]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 23:24 (#1)

עֲשָׂה־אֵ֥ל אֶחִֽי־יוֹאָ֖ב בַּשְּׁלֹשִֽׁים

“Asahel the brother of Joab {was} among the Thirty”

If it would be more natural in your language, you may want to put the information about **Asahel the brother of Joab** with the statement that he was among **the Thirty**. Alternate translation: [Among the Thirty was Asahel the brother of Joab]

See: Information Structure

2 Samuel 23:32 (#1)

בְּנֵ֣י יָשֵׁ֔ן יְהוֹנָתָֽן

“the sons of Jashen, Jonathan”

It is possible that here the author is using the plural term **sons** to introduce a single individual, as in Genesis 46:23, “And the sons of Dan, Hushim.” Alternate translation: [Jonathan the son of Jashen]

See: Kinship

2 Samuel 23:33 (#1)

שַׁמָּה֙ הַֽהֲרָרִ֔י

“Shammah the Hararite”

Since the author lists **Shammah the Hararite** as one of the Three greatest warriors in 23:11–12, his name seems out of place in this list of the Thirty. Some interpreters suggest that the explanation is that the Jonathan mentioned in the previous verse was his son. Some versions accordingly read, at the end of the previous verse and the beginning of this one, “Jonathan the son of Shammah the Hararite.” The reading in 1 Chronicles 11:34 suggests this as a possible reading. If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to use the reading that it uses. If a translation of the Bible does not exist in your region, you may wish to use the reading of the ULT.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 23:39 (#1)

שְׁלֹשִׁ֥ים וְשִׁבְעָֽה

“37”

The total of **37** warriors seems to be the sum of the thirty-one listed in 23:24–39, described as the Thirty, and those said to be greater than these Thirty, that is, the Three described in 23:11–12 and the three described in (23:13–23) (although one of them is not named). To help your readers see how this total reflects the names the author provides, you may wish to translate “Thirty” in 23:24 as a title, as the ULT does, rather than as a number (“30”).

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel - Chapter 24 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter concludes the supplemental information about David’s reign as king of Israel that the author provides at the end of the book. It presents the sixth and last part of that information, a description of how David counted the men in his kingdom who were able to serve as soldiers, how Yahweh punished Israel with a plague as a result, and how Yahweh mercifully ended the plague.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

“into the hand of man, do not let me fall”

Yahweh sends the prophet Gad to David to tell him that he must choose among three punishments for counting the fighting men of Israel. There could be famine in Israel for seven years, the Israelites could be defeated by their enemies for three months, or there could be a plague for three days. David chooses the plague, saying, “Please, let us fall into the hand of Yahweh, for his mercies are many, but into the hand of man, do not let me fall.” Gad understands from this that David is choosing the plague, and he returns that answer to Yahweh, since the plague is what happens. It is clear that having a plague would be to come under the power of Yahweh and that being defeated by enemies would be to come under the power of man. But how would a famine similarly constitute coming under the power of man? The explanation seems to be that if there were famine in Israel, the Israelites would be dependent on foreign nations for food, and those nations might take advantage of their helplessness to oppress them. Some Israelites might move to other countries in search of food, and they would be vulnerable there as foreigners. If it would be helpful to your readers, you might explain this in a footnote.

2 Samuel 24:1 (#1)

וַיִּֽחַר־אַ֥ף יְהוָ֖ה לְחָרָ֣ה בְּיִשְׂרָאֵ֑ל

“And the nose of Yahweh added to burn against Israel”

When the author says that **the nose of Yahweh added to burn**, he is using two common expressions of his culture See how you translated the expressions “nose” and “burn” in 6:7 and the expression “added” in 3:34. Alternate translation: [And Yahweh became angry with Israel again] or [And Yahweh continued to be angry with Israel]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 24:1 (#2)

לֵאמֹ֔ר לֵ֖ךְ מְנֵ֣ה אֶת־יִשְׂרָאֵ֔ל וְאֶת־יְהוּדָֽה

“saying, “Go, count Israel and Judah”

It seems unlikely that this is a direct quotation of something that Yahweh said, since Yahweh would not command someone to do something and then punish that person for doing it. This could mean: (1) that the author is summarizing here what he quotes David more fully as saying in the next verse. Alternate translation: [so that David said, “Go, count Israel and Judah]; (2) that the author is depicting Yahweh as having said something in order to convey the idea that Yahweh led that person to do that thing. This would be similar to 16:10, where David says of Shimei, “If he curses because Yahweh has said to him, ‘Curse David,’” meaning, “If he curses because Yahweh has led him to curse me.” Alternate translation: [leading him to go and count Israel and Judah]

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

2 Samuel 24:2 (#1)

הַחַ֣יִל אֲשֶׁר־אִתּ֑וֹ

“the army that {was} with him”

This seems to be a reference to the corps of soldiers stationed at the court who always remained on active military duty, that is, to David’s permanent army. The author describes these troops in 15:18 and 20:7, and he says in 8:16 that Joab commanded them. David wanted to know how many further men were eligible for military service, that is, how great were his reserves. Alternate translation: [his standing army]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 24:2 (#3)

אֶת־הָעָם

“the people”

By **the people**, in this context David means the men who could serve in his army. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [the fighting men]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 24:2 (#2)

מִדָּן וְעַד־בְּאֵר שָׁבַע

“from Dan and to Beersheba”

To decide how to translate this expression here and in verse 15, see how you translated it in 3:10. Alternate translation: [throughout the entire territory of Israel]

See: Merism

2 Samuel 24:3 (#2)

וְעֵינֵי אֲדֹנִי־הַמֶּלֶךְ רֹאֹת

“and may the eyes of my lord the king be seeing”

Joab is using David’s **eyes** to represent all of him in the act of seeing. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and may my lord the king see this with his own eyes]

See: Synecdoche

2 Samuel 24:3 (#4)

וַאדֹנִי הַמֶּלֶךְ לָמָּה חָפֵץ בַּדָּבָר הַזֶּה

“But my lord the king, why does he delight in this matter”

Joab is using **delight in this matter** as a common expression of his culture to mean “want to do this.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [But why does my lord the king want to do this?]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 24:3 (#5)

וַאדֹנִי הַמֶּלֶךְ לָמָּה חָפֵץ בַּדָּבָר הַזֶּה

“But my lord the king, why does he delight in this matter”

Joab is using the question form to politely express his disapproval of David’s plan to count the people. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [But I do not understand why my lord the king wants to do this.] or [But my lord the king should not want to do this!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 24:3 (#3)

וְעֵינֵי אֲדֹנִי־הַמֶּלֶךְ רֹאֹת

“and may the eyes of my lord the king be seeing”

Even though Joab is addressing David directly, he is speaking of him in the third person as **my lord the king** to show respect. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a respectful form in the second person. Alternate translation: [and may you, my lord the king, see this with your own eyes]

See: First, Second or Third Person

2 Samuel 24:3 (#1)

אֶל־הָעָם כָּהֵם ׀ וְכָהֵם֒ מֵאָה פְּעָמִים

“to the people like them and like them a hundred times”

Joab is using **like them and like them** as a common expression of his culture to mean “such as they already are.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [a hundred times more people than there already are]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 24:4 (#2)

וַיֶּחֱזַק דְּבַר־הַמֶּלֶךְ֮ אֶל־יוֹאָב֒ וְעַל֙ שָׂרֵ֣י הֶחָ֔יִל

“But the word of the king prevailed against Joab and over the commanders of the army”

The author is speaking of this **word** as if it had been a living thing that **prevailed** in a contest against Joab and the commanders. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the king’s command was stronger than Joab’s objections and those of the army commanders]

See: Personification

2 Samuel 24:4 (#1)

וַיֶּחֱזַק דְּבַר־הַמֶּלֶךְ אֶל־יוֹאָב וְעַל שָׂרֵי הֶחָיִל

“But the word of the king prevailed against Joab and over the commanders of the army”

Here, **the word of the king** represents what King David said by using words. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [But what the king said prevailed against Joab and over the commanders of the army]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 24:4 (#3)

לִפְנֵי הַמֶּלֶךְ

“to the face of the king”

Here, **to the face of** represents being in the presence of a person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [from the presence of the king]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 24:5 (#1)

הַגָּד וְאֶל־יַעְזֵר

“Gad and to Jazer”

The author is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and then they went to Gad and to Jazer]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 24:6 (#1)

וְסָבִיב אֶל־צִידוֹן

“and around to Sidon”

The author is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and then they went around to Sidon]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 24:9 (#2)

שֹׁלֵף חָרֶב

“drawing the sword”

The author is using this phrase, **drawing the sword**, to mean soldiers, by association with the way that soldiers at this time drew swords in order to fight battles. Alternate translation: [who could serve as soldiers]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 24:9 (#3)

וְאִישׁ יְהוּדָה חֲמֵשׁ־מֵאוֹת אֶלֶף אִישׁ

“and the men of Judah {were} 500,000 men”

It might seem that this expression contains extra information that would not be natural to express in your language. If so, you could shorten it. Alternate translation: [and the men of Judah were 500,000]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 24:9 (#1)

אִישׁ־חַיִל

“men of valor”

The phrase **men of valor** refers to men who had the qualities of strength and courage. If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **valor**, you could express this idea with words that describe men who are brave and strong in battle. Alternate translation: [valiant men] or [strong men]

See: Abstract Nouns

2 Samuel 24:10 (#3)

אֶת־עֲוֹן עַבְדְּךָ

“the iniquity of your servant”

David is speaking of himself in the third person as **your servant** to show humility. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in a humble form in the first person. Alternate translation: [the iniquity that I, your servant, have committed]

See: First, Second or Third Person

2 Samuel 24:10 (#4)

כִּי

“for”

Here the word **for** introduces not a reason but an elaboration. David is using it to characterize his previous statement about having sinned greatly. Alternate translation: [indeed]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

2 Samuel 24:10 (#2)

אַחֲרֵי־כֵ֣ן סָפַ֔ר אֶת־הָעָ֖ם

“after this, he had counted the people”

As the rest of this expression shows, the pronoun **this** refers to David’s action of counting the people of Israel. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [after this action of counting the people]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 24:10 (#1)

וַיַּ֤ךְ לֵב־דָּוִד֙ אֹתֽוֹ

“But the heart of David struck him”

Here, the **heart** represents a person’s thoughts, feelings, and conscience. When the author says that David’s heart **struck** him, he means that David came to feel guilty about what he had done. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [But David’s conscience troubled him] or [But David felt guilty]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 24:11 (#2)

וּדְבַר־יְהוָ֖ה הָיָ֣ה אֶל־גָּ֑ד

“and the word of Yahweh was to Gad”

See how you translated the similar expression in 7:4. Alternate translation: [and Yahweh spoke a message to Gad]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 24:11 (#1)

וַיָּ֤קָם דָּוִד֙ בַּבֹּ֔קֶר & וּדְבַר־יְהוָ֖ה הָיָ֣ה אֶל־גָּ֑ד

“And David arose in the morning, and the word of Yahweh was to Gad”

The words that the ULT translates as **And ... and** indicates that the word of Yahweh came to Gad at the same time as when David **arose in the morning**. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could describe the time relationship more explicitly. Alternate translation: [When David arose in the morning, the word of Yahweh came to Gad]

See: Connect — Simultaneous Time Relationship

2 Samuel 24:12 (#2)

הָלֹ֗וךְ וְדִבַּרְתָּ֙ אֶל־דָּוִ֜ד כֹּ֣ה אָמַ֣ר יְהוָ֗ה שָׁלֹ֤שׁ אָנֹכִי֙ נוֹטֶ֣ה עָלֶ֔יךָ בְּחַר־לְךָ֖ אַחַ֣ת־מֵהֶ֑ם וְאֶֽעֱשֶׂה־לָּֽךְ

“Go, and you shall say to David, ‘Thus says Yahweh, “Three I am lifting over you. Choose for yourself one from them, and I will do {it} to you”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [Go and tell David that I say that I am lifting three over him and that he is to choose one from them for himself and I will do it to him]

See: Quotes within Quotes

2 Samuel 24:12 (#3)

שָׁלֹ֤שׁ

“Three”

Yahweh is using the adjective **Three** as a noun to mean three things or options. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [Three things]

See: Nominal Adjectives

2 Samuel 24:12 (#1)

הָלֹ֗וךְ וְדִבַּרְתָּ֙ אֶל־דָּוִ֜ד כֹּ֣ה אָמַ֣ר יְהוָ֗ה שָׁלֹ֤שׁ אָנֹכִי֙ נוֹטֶ֣ה עָלֶ֔יךָ בְּחַר־לְךָ֖ אַחַ֣ת־מֵהֶ֑ם וְאֶֽעֱשֶׂה־לָּֽךְ

“Go, and you shall say to David, ‘Thus says Yahweh, “Three I am lifting over you. Choose for yourself one from them, and I will do {it} to you”

There are three levels of quotation here. Yahweh is speaking (level 1) and quoting what he wants Gad to say (level 2), which is that he, Yahweh, has a message for David. Yahweh then presents this message to David as a direct quotation (level 3). Use the appropriate punctuation in your language to mark these levels of quotation. Alternatively, you could translate this so that there are not second-level and third-level quotations (see the Quotes within Quotes note).

See: Quote Markings

2 Samuel 24:12 (#4)

אָנֹכִי֙ נוֹטֶ֣ה עָלֶ֔יךָ

“I am lifting over you”

Yahweh is speaking of the three choices of punishment as if they were objects he could **lift** and hold over David. This is a metaphor that indicates that Yahweh is presenting these choices to David and has authority over how they will be carried out. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly.

Alternate translation: [I am laying out for you] or [I am presenting for you to consider]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 24:13 (#2)

לִפְנֵי־צָרֶיךָ וְהוּא רֹדְפֶךָ

“to the face of your enemies and he is pursuing you”

Here, **to the face of** represents David being in front of his enemies. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [n front of your enemies and he is pursuing you]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 24:13 (#3)

לִפְנֵי־צָרֶיךָ וְהוּא רֹדְפֶךָ

“to the face of your enemies and he is pursuing you”

Since the word **enemies** is plural, it may be more natural in your language to refer back to it with a plural pronoun. Alternate translation: [in front of your enemies while they pursue you]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 24:13 (#1)

וַיַּגֶּד־לוֹ

“and he declared to him”

The implication is that Gad declared to David the three choices that Yahweh had given him, as stated in the previous verse. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and he declared to him what Yahweh had said]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

2 Samuel 24:13 (#4)

דַּע וּרְאֵה

“know and see”

Gad is using **know and see** as a common expression of his culture to mean “consider thoughtfully.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [consider thoughtfully]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 24:13 (#5)

מָה־אָשִׁיב & דָּבָר

“what word I shall return”

Gad is speaking of a message or reply as if it were a **word** that was an object he could carry back to Yahweh. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [what answer I shall give]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 24:14 (#1)

נִפְּלָה & בְיַד־יְהוָה כִּי־רַבִּים רחמו

“let us fall into the hand of Yahweh, for his mercies {are} many”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since **his mercies are many** gives the reason why David says **let us fall into the hand of Yahweh**. Alternate translation: [since the mercies of Yahweh are many, let us fall into his hand]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

2 Samuel 24:14 (#2)

נִפְּלָה & בְיַד־יְהוָה

“let us fall into the hand of Yahweh”

Here, **hand** represents the capability of a person. In this case, it refers to Yahweh’s power to punish and his ability to show mercy. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [let Yahweh be the one to punish us]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 24:14 (#3)

אַל־אֶפֹּלָה

“do not let me fall”

In this verse David uses the first-person singular pronoun **me** when asking God not to let him fall into human hands, even though he had just used “us” when speaking about falling into God’s hands. If it would be clearer in your language, you could use plural pronouns consistently, since David is speaking on behalf of all Israel. Alternate translation: [do not let us fall]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 24:15 (#1)

עֵ֣ת מוֹעֵ֑ד

“the time of appointment”

The author is using the possessive form to describe a **time** that is characterized by its having been appointed. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the appointed time]

See: Possession

2 Samuel 24:15 (#2)

אִ֔ישׁ

“men”

Here the masculine term **men** has a generic sense that includes both men and women. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use language in your translation that is clearly inclusive of both men and women. Alternate translation: [people]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

2 Samuel 24:16 (#1)

וַיִּשְׁלַ֤ח יָדוֹ֙ הַמַּלְאָ֔ךְ

“And the angel stretched out his hand”

The author could be using the same expression that occurs earlier in the book, in 1:14 and 18:12, to mean that the angel was preparing to use violence (in the form of this plague) against the people of the city of Jerusalem. When Yahweh tells him to **lower** his **hand**, that could mean that he is not to afflict the people with the plague. However, since David sees the angel, it seems more likely that the angel actually had reached out and upward with his hand and that Yahweh told him to put his hand back down and not use it to cause the plague. So you may choose to translate this literally.

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 24:16 (#2)

הַמַּלְאָ֔ךְ

“the angel”

The term **the angel** refers to the angel whom God sent to bring a plague on Israel. You could identify this **angel** more fully in that way here. However, this angel is identified in verse 17 as “the striker among the people.” Because this information appears in the following verse, you may not find a need to explain about the angel further here.

See: When to Keep Information Implicit

2 Samuel 24:17 (#2)

אָנֹכִ֤י חָטָ֙אתִי֙ וְאָנֹכִ֣י הֶעֱוֵ֔יתִי

“I, I have sinned, and I, I have committed iniquity”

David is stating the pronoun **I** separately in each of these instances, even though the verbs translated as **I have sinned** and **I have committed iniquity** already include this meaning. He is doing that acknowledge his personal responsibility for sinning by taking a census of the Israelite soldiers. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for this same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing that the David is acknowledging his personal responsibility. It may not be necessary to represent the separately stated pronoun explicitly. Alternate translation: [I was the one who sinned, yes, I was the one who committed iniquity]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

2 Samuel 24:17 (#1)

הִנֵּ֤ה

“Behold”

See how you translated the similar expression in 1:2. Alternate translation: [Listen]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 24:17 (#3)

אָנֹכִ֤י חָטָ֙אתִי֙ וְאָנֹכִ֣י הֶעֱוֵ֔יתִי

“I, I have sinned, and I, I have committed iniquity”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [I myself have greatly sinned]

See: Parallelism

2 Samuel 24:17 (#5)

וְאֵ֖לֶּה הַצֹּ֑אן

“But these sheep”

David is speaking of his subjects as if they were **sheep**. He means that they are innocent and defenseless, like sheep who depend on their shepherd to protect them.

If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [But these innocent people]

See: Metaphor

2 Samuel 24:17 (#4)

וְאֵאֶלֶּה הַצֹּאן מֶה עָשׂוּ

“But these sheep, what have they done”

David is using the question form to emphasize that the people of Israel were innocent and had done nothing wrong. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [But these sheep have done nothing wrong!]

See: Rhetorical Question

2 Samuel 24:17 (#6)

תְּהִי & יָדְךָ בִּי וּבְבֵית אָבִי

“let your hand be against me and against the house of my father”

Here, **hand** represents God’s power to punish. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [use your power to punish me and the house of my father]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 24:18 (#1)

עֲלֵה

“Go up”

See how you translated the similar expression in 2:1. Alternate translation: [Go]

See: Making Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information Explicit

2 Samuel 24:19 (#1)

כִּדְבַר־גָּד

“according to the word of Gad”

Here, **word** represents what Gad said to David. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [according to what Gad had said to him]

See: Metonymy

2 Samuel 24:20 (#1)

וַיִּשְׁתַּחוּ לַמֶּלֶךְ אַפָּיו אָרְצָה

“and he prostrated himself to the king, his nose to the ground”

See how you translated the similar expression in 14:4.

See: Symbolic Action

2 Samuel 24:21 (#1)

מַדּוּעַ בָּא אֲדֹנִי־הַמֶּלֶךְ אֶל־עַבְדּוֹ

“Why has my lord the king come to his servant”

Araunah is speaking of David in the third person as **my lord the king** to show respect, and he is speaking of himself in the third person as David’s **servant** to show humility. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate these expressions with a respectful form in the second person and in a humble form in the first person. Alternate translation: [Why have you, my lord the king, come to me, your servant]

See: First, Second or Third Person

2 Samuel 24:21 (#3)

וְתֵעָצַר הַמַּגֵּפָה

“that the plague may be restrained”

The expression **the plague may be restrained** is a passive verbal form. If your language would not use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [that Yahweh may restrain the plague]

See: Active or Passive

2 Samuel 24:21 (#2)

לִקְנוֹת

“To buy”

David is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [I have come to buy]

See: Ellipsis

2 Samuel 24:22 (#1)

הַטּוֹב בעינו

“the good in his eyes”

Araunah is using the common expression of his culture **the good in his eyes** to mean "whatever seems good to him" or "whatever he chooses." If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [whatever he sees fit]

See: Idiom

2 Samuel 24:24 (#1)

קָנֹנוֹ אֶקְנֶנָּה

"buying, I will buy {it"

David is repeating forms of the verb **buy** in order to intensify his expression of the idea that it conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [I will certainly buy it]

See: Reduplication

2 Samuel 24:24 (#2)

שְׁקָלִֽים חֲמִשִּׁים

"50 shekels"

These **50 shekels** of silver weighed about 570 grams or 1.25 pounds. In your translation, you could use the ancient measurement and spell the word "shekel" the way it sounds in your language. You could also use the metric measurement given in the UST or use the measurement that your language and culture customarily use. Alternatively, you could use the ancient measurement and put a modern measurement in parentheses in the text or in a footnote. Alternate translation: [570 grams of silver] or [50 pieces of silver weighing about one and a quarter pounds]

See: Biblical Weight

2 Samuel 24:25 (#1)

לַיהוָ֔ה & וַיֵּעָתֵ֖ר לָאָ֑רֶץ וַתֵּעָצַ֥ר הַמַּגֵּפָ֖ה מֵעַ֥ל יִשְׂרָאֵֽל

"for Yahweh & And & was entreated for the land, and the plague was restrained from against Israel"

The expression **was entreated** and **was restrained** are passive verbal forms. If your language would not use those forms, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [And thus David entreated Yahweh for the land, and Yahweh restrained the plague from against Israel]

See: Active or Passive